

Introduction

Purpose

“What is a human being?” is a question that psychology continues to ask today with the same fascination, immediacy, and urgency that animated philosophers centuries ago. Who are we really, how do we engage the rest of the world, and how do we come to know what we know and that we know?

During the 20th century, developmental theorists and researchers have offered a powerful response to these questions, which goes to the heart of epistemological and educational issues. The response of constructivist developmental theory generally is that persons move through qualitatively different ways of knowing who they are, how the world works, and how they know what they know.

During the early epochs of a person's life, the transformations from one way of knowing to another are experienced by the vast majority of people, but the changes are neither deliberate nor conscious at the time. During the college years and later in adulthood, a small minority of people continues to develop still more complex, qualitatively different ways of knowing themselves and the world. At this point, the changes are increasingly more voluntary, deliberate, and conscious, generated in part by the explicit asking of these very questions, and the conscious observation of how one responds to them.

There is great controversy whether such later stages of self-development even exist. This controversy arises because few people undergo these changes, mature adults have been studied far less than children and adolescents, and asking these questions explicitly generates a critique of commonly accepted views of what it means to be a mature adult. Paradoxically, these rarer perspectives on life produce types of knowledge that are incomprehensible to those who have not themselves asked the necessary epistemological questions and experienced the self-transformations occurring in this inquiry process.

However, if these relatively rare persons who do undertake the deliberate inquiry into how we create, maintain, and transform meaning are, in effect, uncovering a valid perspective on who we might become, how we could interact with the world, and how we come to know this, then they can help us understand the normative direction and potential of human learning and development. The very possibility that this might be so makes documenting this process with increasing accuracy significant.

Purpose of the Study

This study will attempt to create better theory at these less understood levels of adult development. The research has two separate but related goals. It will test whether the highest stage in a widely used ego development theory reflects what we currently know about high-end development and self-understanding. Moreover, it will test whether the existing measurement tool, a specific sentence completion test, adequately describes this area of development. By charting and validating the characteristics and rare qualities of individuals at the highest ego stages, this study hopes to make a substantive contribution to the field of positive adult development. Indeed, it hopes to answer the age-old question of the nature of humanity from the perspective of constructivist developmental psychology.

Early pioneers in postulating and documenting adult mental development beyond early adulthood into mature age used the psychological concept of “ego” as the underlying principle in personality organization that develops and generates coherent meaning throughout life. The ego is said to orchestrate how we perceive inner and outer reality and to coordinate affect, thought, and action.

Conventional ego development theory describes stages of human mental development from childhood to adulthood, which occur mostly unconsciously and as a result of maturation and pervasive cultural conditioning. Conventional stages describe forms of meaning making that seem required for adults to function in the roles of modern societies.

Postconventional ego development, on the other hand, describes the rarer stages of meaning making in which some adults begin to deliberately and consciously wrestle with culturally programmed responses to life. They begin to examine previously taken-for-granted assumptions and explore the fundamental questions about knowing and reality.

The sentence completion test is a measure that is meant to assess people's level of ego development or their ego stage. The theory currently describes three conventional adult stages and three stages beyond these. Two of the postconventional ego stages, the Individualistic and the Autonomous, are fairly well researched and recognized by many other theoreticians, albeit the stages are given different names. The most highly developed ego stage, the Integrated, on the other hand, is rarely described in the literature and ill-defined by the original framework developers' own admission. It attempts to portray self-actualized persons who have permanent, objective, and integrated, yet highly complex self-identities. Because of the emphasis on permanence and stability, the theory cannot account for people who develop a dynamic, fluid self-experience and who question the very assumption of the permanent self and object world. Such themes do appear on sentence completion tests and originally prompted this research into the upper end of ego development theory.

This research focuses on how people's meaning making develops after they have reached the penultimate or Autonomous stage. It constitutes a needed step in a research effort begun decades ago to study mature ego development in response to perceived problems at the high-end of the theory and the measurement instrument.

Overall, the goal of this study is to put the previously suggested reinterpretation of high-end ego development theory and measurement to the test. First, it will explore whether defining postautonomous ego development differently from the original framework allows one to understand high-stage sentence completions and protocols that the original theory cannot explain. Second, it will test empirically whether others can reliably score postautonomous completions to the test with a set of newly created postautonomous scoring categories.

This testing will be accomplished in several steps. First, it will explore the notion that postconventional ego development is characterized by an increasing awareness of the constructed nature of knowledge as well as a concomitant, step-wise deconstruction of the assumptions underlying conventional views of reality and the self. It will assess to what extent other sources in the developmental literature use similar notions to describe mature cognition. It will especially examine theories that postulate postautonomous perspectives in constructivist developmental theory and in transpersonal psychology to analyze what agreement exists between the thematic categories for identifying postautonomous ego stages and the characteristics given in these theories. In effect, it will be seeking to show the content validity of these categories. In the process of examining others' conceptions of high stage development, it will also expand and enhance the definition and description of the categories.

Second, it will test empirically whether these categories are helpful for scoring highest stage sentence completions and protocols by subjecting them to a thorough multiple analysis by others. The database used consisted of 1100 relatively rare postautonomous sentence completions and 476 whole high-end protocols systematically culled from over 4400 protocols in 17 years of scoring tests. The size of this database of high-end material allowed the data to be divided into several subsets for different kinds of analysis. What is more, it provided the database for the kind of analysis that the original framework developers felt could not be done.

To begin, it will ascertain to what degree an expert rater will concur that high-stage responses from a random set of late-conventional responses and above are hard to score with the existing manual. The expert rater will next use the new categories to determine whether they make a difference in the outcome. The rater will also

provide feedback about the clarity and completeness of the proposed categories and help optimize the category descriptions through dialogue.

Following that, a team of general raters will score randomly selected data from both data sets (individual completions and whole protocols) as a reliability test. It will report interrater agreement and Cronbach's alpha coefficient. If the outcome warrants, it will determine new cut-off numbers for rating postautonomous protocols.

Finally, it will discuss both the theoretical and empirical results of this study, outline threats to validity, and suggest further research directions.

It is hoped that this research will make several useful contributions to psychology: (a) It will make clear the underlying logic of postconventional adult development including two stages beyond the Autonomous stage. (b) It will provide a concise set of scoring categories for distinguishing between the two proposed postautonomous stages as well as for scoring high-end protocols and sentence completions.

It seems important for educational psychology to have a model of adult ego development consistent with late 20th century conceptions of advanced cognitive growth and integration. Such a model may help us to distinguish and recognize similarities among the mature qualities and reality perspectives found across cultures. In addition, the new thematic distinctions for analyzing high-stage material could be useful to researchers who study mature development in other disciplines.

Last, this research—by exploring the border area between personal and transpersonal development—might move forward an integration of Eastern and Western conceptions of human growth.

The Gift of Wonderful Ideas

Rare indeed are the moments when one is given a vision, an insight, or a fabulous idea that transforms one's outlook on life in an instant of recognition. There are moments that stand out especially and are reported here because they were pivotal in mental growth and eventually led to the topic of this research. The first great idea was encountered during adolescence, and the second during a course in adult development in mid-thirties.

During adolescence, a language teacher lectured on philosophical thoughts. The teacher was explaining what the philosopher meant when answering the question "What is man?" by responding: "He is nothing compared to infinity and an infinity compared to nothingness." This teacher helped to understand the ideas by translating them into analogous mathematical equations:

1 = person; 0 = nothingness; ∞ = infinity.

Compared to the infinite, man is nothing: $1 / \infty = 0$

Compared to nothingness, man is an infinity: $1 / 0 = \infty$

The Study of Human Beings

Introduction to the Human Condition

Despairing about the many contradictions in personal experience, one might resonate with a description of the human condition that places human experience at a fulcrum, vacillating between greatness and unworthiness. This perspective finds comfort in the idea that humans have the courage to face their paradoxical position in nature and embrace their destiny. This realization often serves as a momentous psychological breakthrough,

relating the self-absorbed search for a meaningful interpretation of personal experience to humanity's broader quest for self-understanding.

An interdisciplinary approach to learning—linking ideas in literature to abstract symbol manipulation in mathematics, and interconnecting philology, philosophy, literature, and mathematics—can help individuals grasp the subtler connections and ambiguities of life. This approach guides restless minds to consider personal experience within broader human and historical contexts, inspiring further study in fields like linguistics and semantics, the study of the meanings of words.

Ego Development Theory

Ego development theory offers a coherent explanation of human behavior, helping individuals map their own perceptions, reactions, feelings, and thoughts. Its emphasis on subtle differences in language aligns well with the study of semantics. The theory is based on the notion that language is constitutive of reality. It posits that what we say and how we say it indicates how we frame reality. Through our utterances, we reveal what we know that we know and notice, as well as what we choose to ignore or unconsciously leave out. Most interestingly, it can also reveal what does not appear on our mental screen at all, illuminating what is not in our conception of the world and what we do not know we do not know.

This theory integrates many strands of psychology into a coherent approach that makes both rational and intuitive sense. Becoming skilled at scoring sentence completion tests (SCT) reveals that some high-stage responses, although meaningful, do not fit the standard theory or manuals. This discrepancy prompts the systematic collection of high-end protocols and responses to understand why it exists and how to make sense of it. Some theorists have grave doubts that one can make better theory at the upper end, and some recent manuals practically eliminate the highest, integrated stage.

Advocating the constructivist developmental perspective as a meaningful approach to answering the question of “what is human?” and being an expert scorer of the measurement instrument are central to this inquiry. The goal is to test conjectures about high-stage ego development and how to measure it.

The Study of Human Beings

The basic questions of how we are similar as a species, and how we as individuals and groups differ from each other, continue to be explored in many disciplines of science (biology, anthropology, sociology, philosophy, medicine, and psychology). Within psychology, the questions of similarity and difference have been addressed in many subdisciplines (evolutionary, abnormal, personality, and developmental). The developmental subdiscipline, in turn, has been approached from different angles (such as biological, cognitive, constructivist, and psychopathological).

Whether there are human universals and, if so, what aspects of being human would come under this rubric are among the most debated questions throughout history, with different emphasis placed on either similarities or differences. One area in which universals have been sought throughout Western history is in the mental sphere. Early philosophers identified the concepts of identity, difference, change, and stability as basic categories of mind. Later philosophers expanded the list, trying to define the building blocks of conceptual space, adding categories such as time, place, quantity, quality, and causality.

Three other universals are proposed as essential to understanding human development:

1. Humans have a need for orientation and coherent meaning.
2. Humans tend towards both increasing differentiation (individuation) and greater integration (communion).

3. All humans partake in the language habit.

The Need for Orientation and Coherent Meaning

From cannibalistic burial rituals to the unschooled mind's everyday theories about why a thrown penny returns to the ground, to the most sophisticated postmodern arguments about why we have no leg to stand on in looking for universals in meaning making, all are attempts at explaining the world and locating ourselves within a larger context. The fundamental need for structuring and explaining experience is undeniably and universally human, no matter what shape it takes. Asserting that there is no viable position from which to judge is, itself, a definite position.

Meaning making is seen a priori as an innate, defining characteristic of human beings. At the same time, researching ego development explores the many ways human beings differ in how they make sense of their experience. Understanding what matters to individuals—what they are able to perceive and conceive of, what is outside their awareness, and how conscious they are of their own meaning-making activity and its limits—is a central question.

The Balance Between Autonomy and Homonymy

The second universal is the human need to fulfill the double propensity towards autonomy (differentiation, independence, mastery) and homonymy (integration, participation, belonging). Human development can be conceptualized as the balance between these two opposite needs, negotiated differently by different people. This motion can be described in terms of what one can take as object and what one is subject to at each stage, or in terms of what one is separating from and what one is integrating toward. The balance between autonomy and homonymy is negotiated differently among individuals within a culture and at different junctures in life. Whole cultures also differ in how they allocate more value to either individualism or connection. Yet, the need to relate and to individuate is universal.

The Capacity for Language

The capacity for language, or symbolic representation of experience, is a third universal human characteristic. There is no known culture today without a language. Natural language use and symbol use are prerequisites for participating in human social life and are essential to survival. The measurement tool for ego development is directly based on the assumed relationship between language and meaning system. Test manuals use subtle distinctions in verbal expression to infer differences in how people construe reality.

Understanding the nature and function of language, as well as its innate roots, is paramount in understanding ego development theory and its measurement instrument. A mindful appreciation of the place of language in our experience is an important clue to mature ego development, because language permeates all facets of life and intellectual inquiry. Knowing how language influences what we notice or ignore, what we hold dear or abhor, and what we take for real or deem outside the limits of relevant possibilities, adds an important dimension to our understanding of ourselves and the human condition.

The Centrality of Language in Ego Development Theory and Measurement

Language is so habitual an aspect of our behavior that we tend to forget how complex it is and how it structures our awareness. Language should be understood in the broadest sense, as symbolic codification or representation of experience in all its varied forms, including gestural, oral, written, and sign language; figurative

representations; logic, mathematical, and other abstract codes. Without symbolic representation, today's global reality of instant information exchange could not exist.

All systems of notation or symbolic representation are shorthand for transmitting knowledge and experience among people. To be understood, there must be some consensus on how a symbol relates to the thing symbolized, and this knowledge must be shared. Natural language is the prototypical system of symbolization. Only natural language is universally used to talk about, analyze, reflect upon, and communicate about itself, and about all other symbol systems, as well as about experiences from nonsymbolically mediated states of mind.

The view of language presented here integrates ideas from general semantics, the sociology of knowledge, anthropology, and nativist approaches. While some linguists support the notion that language is an inborn faculty, sociologists elaborate on the human context necessary to activate language and its power in shaping our understanding of reality.

Human babies lack the necessary biological means to survive after birth without a nurturing human environment. The period during which children develop minimal self-sufficiency through interactions with others is also the period during which the "self" is formed. Thus, the individual self cannot be understood apart from the particular social and linguistic contexts in which it was shaped. Children are molded to become members of their group from the day they are born through relentless modeling of behavior and language. What is to be considered important and real in everyday life is always transmitted through language and has coercive power over the child. The child internalizes the world of significant others as the only existent and conceivable world.

For example, a toddler calling a cat a "doggie" is subtly corrected until they learn to distinguish dogs from other four-legged animals. By about age five, children acquire a complex linguistic system adequate to manipulate abstract concepts, such as time and emotions, and to use symbolic sound codifications to interact with others not present. They will also correct a younger sibling who exhibits the dog-cat confusion. By this time, labels appear to children as inherent in the nature of things. Any notion of their conventionality or arbitrariness is lost.

Each culture divides the original, unstructured continuum in different ways according to its specific needs, development, imagination, and context. With every speech act, the members of a language community mutually reinforce the shared conceptual map or worldview for each other. By the time we are in school, we are so deeply habituated into language that we cannot imagine life without it. We generally can remember neither our own preverbal existence nor how we acquired our mother tongue. For most people, the language habit remains unconscious and automatic throughout their lives.

We use language to accomplish a wealth of transactions, from the practical to the fantastic, from the ordinary to the sublime. We use language to identify concrete objects and events around us and to tell the stories of our group and of ourselves. At all times, we use a shared language to assure ourselves and each other of the reality and meaningfulness of our existence. Human existence without language seems utterly unimaginable.

Language is likely the most powerful means by which we are socialized into a specific overarching view of reality. Its social function is to serve as shorthand for transmitting knowledge and experience among its speakers and from generation to generation. For this endeavor to work, there must be some consensus among speakers of how a construct or symbol relates to the thing it symbolizes, and this relationship must be learned for participation in any social group.

Fortunately, the language habit is innate. As long as children's potential for language is activated through regular exposure and training at the maturationally appropriate age, they acquire a specific language and hence will structure experience via its grammar and concepts. Developing more sophisticated language then becomes a central basis for continuing development within a given speech community. The cognitive growth that accompanies children's physical maturation can be described as a process of continuous acquisition of finer and finer symbolic representations, elaborations, and distinctions. This also includes organizing existing

concepts into higher orders of abstraction. The more evolved and mature, the more territories of experience become available for symbolic representation and cognitive manipulation.

Just as different cultures segment the continuum in different ways, so different individuals perceive a slightly different segment of the stimuli continuum, depending on the microstructure of their specific bodies (including genetic variables) and their maturational development. They accept stimuli for processing both according to their innate general human makeup, their unique personal constitution, and according to the linguistic screens and limitations imposed on them by their culture.

It seems reasonable to conclude that in order to grow into adults, human beings are initially dependent on a culturally accepted orientation and definition of what is real in life. Once a coherent view of reality is absorbed, it is constitutive of experience and filters out rivaling possibilities. We carry around in our heads a conceptual map of the world, a guidebook to rightness and wrongness, ugliness and beauty, value and worthlessness. Such mental maps seem indispensable because they provide us with rules and scripts for action, and explanations of why things are the way they are. Moreover, they often rationalize, justify, and sometimes even sanctify our existence.

Becoming aware of one's acculturation marks a turning point in development. Once individuals understand that they are interpreters of reality, that they contribute their own meaning to external and internal facts, and that their insight may differ markedly from generally held definitions of what things mean, their explanatory universe has changed dramatically. They have become aware of the inevitability of cultural conditioning and programming. In a step beyond, people can become aware of the deeper bias inherent in the construction and reification of the object world via language. This may include an ever-growing awareness of the processes and mechanisms of thinking and meaning-making themselves.

The experience of the artificiality of such concepts as the "ego" occurs at the most differentiated stages of development. Once one can entertain the idea that the universe is one interconnected whole without boundaries, one has to face one's intrinsic tendency to organize experience—one's need to make cosmos out of chaos—by attributing order and relevance to it. Seeking a way of experiencing and meaning making that is direct, without the filter of language, can become a central existential quest. Ego-development theory, if it is to be a viable explanatory principle, must be able to account for this extraordinary phenomenon.

Language as verbal behavior is a crucial aspect of sentence completion tests. It is indisputable that, by the time we are adults, employing symbolic representations is such an automatic aspect of our behavior that we completely depend on doing so for making sense of the world. Concepts are used as tools to solidify our world and ourselves. If a world of nameable things exists, then 'I' as one of the nameable things exist as well. A pernicious feature of the modern Western configuration of sense of self is that it tends to obscure its historical origins and its interpretation-dependent nature. Thus it perpetuates the illusion that we have selves as we have eyes, hearts, or livers, and makes it very hard to question this notion.

Western psychologists are only now beginning to look into the costs associated with our near total reliance on language as a medium. A view heard increasingly often is that we create symbolic systems of meaning and then forget that they are our creations, and also that language poses a unique problem of analysis by its being both the object and the agent of its study.

There seems to be a growing interdisciplinary consensus that the maps and theories we make about reality by rational means are always reductionist and partial. They can never grasp the whole, intricate unity of the living universe of which we are an inextricable part. The very existence of multiple, sometimes conflicting maps and scientific explanations of human nature helps to point out the relative position and limitation of each of them.

No matter how much we learn and know about the intricate workings of our body-minds through objective, modern science, our existence as biological organisms is impermanent. Our edifices of knowledge are

impermanent. They are but intimations of a deeper reality that may not ever be fully accessed empirically and by merely rational means. The reality outside the cave is the real territory, and we must be warned about confusing our conceptual maps with the reality outside. Language is arguably the chief means by which we create such conceptual maps of reality. These maps, in turn, serve as a powerful tool to create a sense of permanence and identity and, by the same token, to ward off our fears of impermanence and insignificance. Being cognizant of this possibility creates an ineluctable dilemma.

Fascination with how we interpret our experience, how we make sense of these existential dilemmas, and how much awareness we have about our own meaning making naturally leads towards constructivist developmental psychology, a branch of psychology that elevates meaning making and the differences among people in this vital activity to a central position.

Positive Lifespan Development

There are differences in emphasis even within a meaning-centered psychology. Much psychological research in the last century has focused on human suffering and what causes people to fail at making adequate sense of their lives. Only more recently has there been a resurgence of interest into what makes some people navigate the straits of life with skill, success, and grace.

The types and severity of psychopathology, including the failure to create a coherent sense of self, have been classified and described in diagnostic manuals. While psychiatry's aim is mainly to help those with severe pathologies to live more tolerable and safe lives, helping people create more adaptive narratives for their experience has been the domain of much psychotherapy.

On the other hand, we can also focus on what innate proclivities, favorable circumstances, and external supports enhance the capacity of individuals to synthesize a self-supporting story from the myriad, constantly changing challenges and demands of life and to live a life full of vigor and forward motion. The synthetic function of the ego inspires the study of positive adult development, resilience, and wisdom. Narrative coherence may be more important than actual historical truth in people's ability to find meaning in life. The relationship between objective science and the humanities—and even religion—may be analogous: the story we tell about the meaning of a given scientific fact perhaps weighs more heavily for our survival than its absolute truth.

Within the last decade, there has been a growing trend among objective, empirical scientists to advocate a more integrative, cross-disciplinary approach toward the major questions in life, including the question of human nature. Evolution as a scientific explanatory principle has been described as the grandest myth about the universe there ever was, bringing narration and meaning making back into the hard sciences as a basic aspect of human activity.

Experts in Eastern spiritual traditions also articulate a need to bridge science and religion. The objective methods of science for discovering truth and the religious function of generating meaning based on subjective, inner awareness are not only compatible, but complementary. There is an urge for reconciliation among science, the humanities, and religion, an integration that honors all their methods of data collection, analysis, and verification.

Yet long before modern science rediscovered the centrality of a coherent narrative, the peoples of the world created myths about the universe and how they fit into it. These myths inevitably explain where human beings come from (origin), who they are (in relation to the rest of creation), why they are the way they are (nature), why they are here (purpose), and where they are going hereafter. The ancients also had stories about the meaning of the human lifespan.

Types of Lifespan Theory

The practice of dividing the human lifespan into several phases according to age is as old as the riddle posed by the Sphinx to Oedipus: “What goes first on four legs, then on two, and then on three?” “Man,” Oedipus rejoined, thereby describing the simplest theory of lifespan development. Yet noticing the changes in locomotion is but one way of describing the visible changes. Today we are likely to have a more complex, psychological interpretation of the riddle. We associate the crawler with early dependency and animal-like instinctual behavior, the two-legged being with real personhood, higher mental functions, free will and control, and the three-legged creature negatively, with the decline of these capacities, as well as positively, with turning inward and greater wisdom.

Psychological theories on what develops and how growth occurs, especially in children, have proliferated. This is naturally so because the changes are much more visible during the growing-up years. Once one is grown, the changes and adaptations are subtler and become noticeable only after longer stretches of time. However, interest in the adult lifespan has reawakened and, as a result, there are several branches of psychology that specifically deal with positive adult development. There are three types of theories most relevant to this inquiry.

Statistical means have allowed researchers to reduce the seemingly endless ways of characterizing human behavior into a relatively small number of dimensions or factors. Of these more scientific trait theories, the five-factor model is probably the most rigorously tested. The Five-Factor Model purports that five factors—Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness, and Conscientiousness, derived from factor analysis—are sufficient to account for most personality differences in adulthood.

Some researchers feel that their five-factor model and ego development theory—and the respective methods—ought to be complementary. It stands to reason that given a particular ego stage, some important differences among subjects might be explained by personality traits, and conversely, that individuals with similar personality profiles might still differ significantly based on how they frame their experience (ego development). The ego has been described as “the master trait,” second only to intelligence in accounting for human variability. Indeed, it seems that differences in the ego construct are more predictive of behavior in a wider variety of circumstances than differences in other proposed personality traits.

To characterize the ego as a trait, however, is peculiar and may be a result of initial attempts to distinguish this approach from the more common type and trait classifications. Most developmental theorists would not characterize the ego as a trait, but as a psychic organizing function or the synthetic principle in meaning making. The psychological construct of the “ego” is at the core of creating and maintaining a coherent world view. The ego is defined as the autonomous drive towards meaning making. The ego represents the striving of human beings to understand themselves and the world they live in by fitting new experiences into their current meaning system. Overall, the ego labors mightily to create and maintain coherence and vigorously defends against dissonant stimuli. Yet, with increasing ego development, immature defenses give way to more mature ones.

When the ego fails in its mandate to create meaning, humans suffer anxiety, which is the dread of non-being or a basic sense of meaninglessness. Thus the ego is at the very core of meaning making, constantly integrating and absorbing experience and classifying and finding order in everything that touches the individual both externally and internally.

Stage Theory

Historically, stage models of mental growth or genetic epistemology were proposed early on. The “genetic” or developmental approach outlined how children’s reasoning about moral situations changes in foreseeable ways

from early childhood through adolescence. These insights were developed by carefully exploring how children of increasing age made sense of their experience in many domains. Children were given practical problems to solve, their actions were watched, and they were asked for explanations of why they did what they did. At other times, they were presented with everyday natural phenomena and concepts, and probed for what they meant by what they said. Responses and observations were recorded and analyzed for common patterns and recurring shifts in different age groups.

Based on the evidence gathered, it was concluded that children's reasoning was not merely an incorrect version of adult thought, but that it was coherent and meaningful in its own right. Reasoning changed in terms of quality over time, and the changes were predictable and deducible from children's actions and explanations. Four major stages of increasing differentiation and integration in the formation of adult cognition were described. This theory covers the first two tiers of the development of meaning making and reasoning. In large strokes, children's thought develops sequentially from sensory-motor to magical thinking through concrete and abstract thought to formal reasoning. The highest form of cognitive integration observed was called formal operations.

As children grow up, they gradually learn to think more abstractly about their experiences. They learn to connect thoughts, feelings, and wishes to specific actions and from such actions to their consequences. That is, people learn to understand time in a linear fashion. Events follow each other in a sequence from past to present to future and are viewed as a causal chain. In the West, reality is treated as an assemblage of various types of permanent, well-defined objects with inherent properties. These are arranged in closed systems, clearly separated as distinct entities from each other and from the observer. Elaborate procedures and heuristics (the scientific arsenal of methods) are employed to experiment with, measure, analyze, and figure out the laws that govern their behavior. If something does not work according to expectations, the problem space is "reduced" into its component parts (independent variables). Then the culprit variable is isolated, so that a solution can be found by using an appropriate existing procedure or by devising a new one based on established scientific principles. There is even an "objective, scientific" writing style which effectively mirrors the separation (or obscures the relationship) between experimenter-observer and that which is being experimented on and observed.

It was projected that people reach formal operations by early adulthood. This stage was seen as the prototype of mature reasoning, necessary for the functioning of modern society. Indeed, formal operations figure prominently in the ideology and education of the West. Adults with this mind frame, also referred to as the modern mind, think of themselves as separate, independent selves, in control of and responsible for their actions. They make decisions based on rational analysis and are actively engaged in orchestrating and controlling the movement of their lives. It is no exaggeration to say that people with a formal operations worldview quite often look at life itself as a task to be accomplished or a technical problem to be solved. In response to this need, there is a wealth of information available about how to solve any problem or achieve any goal. Guides to the five ways of stopping smoking or the twelve steps to enlightenment are readily available.

In general, whenever we encounter a new phenomenon, we describe and categorize it and try to fit it into our existing explanations. If it does not fit, we create explanations for its "deviant" behavior that make it fit into our existing way of knowing. The formal operational reasoner is excellent at finding explanations for any state of affairs. In addition, they can predict what is likely to happen next and manipulate the components to achieve specific outcomes, extrapolating from the known. Conscious analysis of causes and consequences, deliberate choice of methods, and rational decision-making are hallmarks of meaning making at the formal operational or Conscientious stage.

The human actor in this drama sees himself as a clearly separate self-contained system and other human beings as such systems in their own right. In the positive case, this assures every one a kind of integrity and

independence; in the less favorable circumstance, it reduces individuals to objects themselves, isolated and at the mercy of being objectified by others.

The fascinating aspect of formal operations is that it trusts that a rational, scientific approach will be adequate to answer all questions, and that what appears as a mystery now, will turn out to be explainable eventually. This positivistic, progressive stance has produced the industrial revolution and evolved into the current global technology, which has solved many dire problems of humanity and created technological wonders unimaginable fifty years ago.

Methods

One major methodological contribution to developmental psychology is recording responses to the same set of stimuli from many subjects at different ages in order to (a) find common patterns, (b) define these patterns, and next © test their predictive power in describing behavior. This approach uses responses to verbal stimuli from many individuals, looks for distinctive patterns, and attempts to order them in a meaningful way along a developmental continuum from lesser to greater complexity, coherence, and higher order integration.

It was also pointed out early on that people as organisms do not merely react to the environment, but that they seek out experiences, actively experiment with them, and interpret them: that is, they construct their meaning. These ideas, exemplary studies, and empirical method were pivotal in spawning the constructive developmental approach in psychology and what is sometimes referred to as the study of positive adult development.

In addition, there was cognizance of the fundamental role of language in the construction of meaning and mastery of life. Specifically, it was observed that the external object world is constructed early in development and then (mis)taken as preexisting and external. When language and thought begin, the neonate is for all practical purposes but one element or entity among others in a universe that he has gradually constructed for himself, and which, hereafter he will experience as external to himself.

However, the construction of the external object world is only the beginning of the “conquering” of reality through symbolic representation. Once in motion, the process of reification or objectification continues unconsciously and covers more and more abstract aspects of experience. Determining the level of awareness people have in regards to the function of language in meaning making may itself be one of the indices of their level of cognitive development. Because the insight into the constitutive role of language in reality perception is such a pivotal aspect of the interpretation of development based on evidence from late-stage sentence completions, the main ideas relevant to such a perspective are summarized below.

Social Construction of Reality

The idea that language is constitutive of experience is especially elaborated in the literature on the social construction of reality. It also emphasizes the child's mastery of the object world through the acquisition of language. Studies show that linguistic classifying of experience is a universal aspect of human nature. Mental growth can be described as the continuous acquisition of subtler distinctions among concepts, their clustering into complex matrices, and their ordering into hierarchical systems of meaning.

Every culture transmits its own basic assumptions about reality and the relationship between humans and their environment through its language, symbols, and behavioral patterns. Therefore, the acquisition of a language seems absolutely necessary for cognitive growth beyond the infant state to occur. In order to become adult participants in life, children must learn the specific notions about reality of their group, starting from the initial concrete distinctions to the more general and varying types of relationships, role functions, and abstract theories available in the larger society. What is most interesting is that the constructed nature of everyday reality remains

hidden from consciousness for most people throughout their lives. The reality created by one's language is taken for granted as the only existent and conceivable world.

By the time children go to school, they can deal with ordinary experience in the summary fashion we all use: They respond to the ever-changing sensory information in terms of the predictable characteristics and properties of the physical world as transmitted to them through the concepts and grammar of their culture. Moreover, once we have internalized these notions about how the world is, we cannot conceive of it in any other way. It is self-evident that the world is as we perceive it. Specific labels appear as inherent in the nature of things and thus become automatic, objective, and permanent. Any notion that the distinctions among things may be arbitrary and that they have been "learned" is veiled by the overwhelming reinforcement of everyday experience. Thus for most people, the language they use indeed mirrors the reality they perceive as existing independent of their descriptions. In other words, to them, the map is the territory, and they come by this notion naturally in the course of growing up in their respective cultures.

Summary of Stage Theory

The worldview of formal operations is referred to as Newtonian, as scientific and, with positivistic overtones, as a progressive or "modern" stance. People know reality in other words, a different epistemology, or a different worldview. Central to this model is the claim that the stage sequence is unidirectional and that the stages constitute hierarchical integrations. Development is unidirectional because the sequence of stages is posited to be the same for all people. It evolves from the least differentiated to ever more differentiated ways of knowing and relating to the world. It moves from simple to complex in regard to all possible contents. It is hierarchical because each subsequent stage constitutes a transformation of the previous way of interpreting reality.

A new stage integrates the material or content of the previous one as a special case, that is, as an element into its more inclusive meaning system. Each stage is thus a part/whole. It is a whole in its own right, as well as part of a bigger, more expansive system of understanding. This involves "orders of consciousness," or the increasing ability to take as object that which one previously could only construe and experience subjectively. What we were unconsciously embedded in or subject to at one stage, becomes an object that we can consciously organize and reflect upon at the next higher stage. In the most global sense, development can be described as the gradual unfolding of people's capacity to embrace ever-vaster mental horizons and to plumb ever-greater depths of the heart.

Postconventional Development Theory

Postconventional Constructivist Models of Human Development

Beginning with the late Sixties, several developmental theorists started to challenge the highest stage of previous models. Looking at formal operations as a step in development rather than its terminus, they suggested that positive development and cognitive differentiation beyond formal operations could occur throughout life. They claimed that (a) mental development does not necessarily stop upon becoming an adult—although it often does—and that (b) formal operations is not the final or the highest order integration possible. Based on their research with adults, they claimed that some people continue to transform their views of reality throughout the lifespan into even more complex and inclusive matrices of reasoning and understanding than those reflected in formal operations. Because these theories expanded the invariant hierarchical sequence upwards, they are sometimes called post-Piagetian, even though the terms postformal or postconventional are more often used.

Postformal theories emphasize contextual and process-oriented forms of knowing, and increasingly turn attention to people's inner life. They explore meaning making not only in terms of its mechanics, but also in terms of its human valence and experience. Some theories distinguish between understanding what is merely rationally defensible and logically consistent from what is perceived as meaningful or wise in mature living. To underline this distinction, the term "postformal" is restricted to theories of cognition that describe more complex, higher-order forms of logical analysis and reasoning, and the term "postconventional" is favored for theories that also deal with issues of meaning, value, and experiential salience.

Some psychologists, of course, take issue with the concept of stage-like development beyond formal operations. Some object to any attempts at revising the original paradigm, claiming that all postformal variants of stage theory are mistaken in principle since the original framework of genetic epistemology is based on a logical empiricist or positivist philosophy of science. This model overemphasizes logic and rational thought, and thus the theory is not adequate to account for development, which is an organic process. Specifically, it is argued that biological processes, like most other fundamental ones, need to be inserted within an extralogical framework of metaphysical concepts and principles (being, becoming, potential, and so on).

In response, it can be argued that logical positivism, rather than being a "type" of theory, can be regarded as a necessary, but not a final "stage" in the development of the theory of science, just as formal operational reasoning is a necessary, but not final equilibration in the development of human understanding. The original theory is accurately described as overemphasizing rational thought, but the possibility of post-Piagetian theories is not mistaken. The method has proven productive beyond its original use. What characterizes postconventional development is precisely that the positivistic worldview of formal operations is superseded by a more organismic, systemic view of reality.

Research over the last twenty years on how mature adults organize experience has made plausible the existence of worldviews that reintegrate nonphysical or psychic aspects (being, becoming, potential) into the logic of psychology. Constructivist theories of adult development describe just how people reintegrate the formerly split-off affective, somatic, intuitive, and nonrational aspects of experience into their meaning making at the postconventional stages.

Overview of Postconventional Constructivist Developmental Models of Human Development

The capacity for symbolic representation of reality and the clustering and hierarchical ordering of concepts (i.e., the propensity for classification) seem to be universal characteristics of human beings. It is this focus on the active interpretation of reality or construction of meaning that is the bedrock of the constructivist perspective. We perceive, organize, judge, and synthesize input from all sources that reach our awareness in order to orient ourselves and create coherent meaning in life. In addition, constructivist developmental theories argue that we tend to coordinate the many inputs into larger systems of meaning that are internally consistent, and that we do so through a series of increasingly complex and exhaustive reinterpretations of what constitutes reality.

What is most important in selecting a context for exploring the nature of postautonomous ego development is that constructivist developmental theories make useful distinctions and predictions not possible in other branches of psychology. They can explain why people develop contextual, process-oriented, and dialectical forms of knowing that integrate affect, intuition, and rational thought. In particular, they can account for the phenomena of increasing self-awareness and awareness of the process of meaning making itself that some people develop. Neither psychodynamic, ego psychology, information processing, phasic, or trait explanations of adulthood have much to say about these aspects of experience which seem to become of central concern to meaning makers at the postconventional stages of development.

General Description of Adult Development

The orthogenetic principle for the field of developmental psychology states as a “law” that wherever development occurs it proceeds from a state of relative globality and lack of differentiation to a state of increasing differentiation, articulation, and hierarchic integration. Mental growth, in the most general way, can thus be described as a process of continuous differentiation and elaboration as well as of higher order abstraction and integration.

Sequentiality is a fundamental aspect of constructivist developmental theory. People can understand thinking at their own level or at levels below their own, but not at levels above their own. The more developed a person is, the more realms of experience become available for symbolic representation and cognitive manipulation, that is, the broader the range of experience that can be integrated and made sense of. Thus, fewer and fewer aspects of experience remain hidden, denied, or split off from conscious awareness.

Developmental theories share a belief that the need for meaning and communication drives people to integrate into their existing conceptual frames of reference every difference that enters their awareness, by either labeling it or filtering it out. The defense mechanism by which people screen out phenomena that do not fit their preexisting worldviews is called “selective inattention.”

On the other hand, people can also learn to accommodate discrepant stimuli by adapting in two distinct ways. Most growth in adulthood seems to occur within a given stage, i.e., laterally, or by adding more information to what one already knows. The current way of viewing reality is refined, enriched, and modified to include more diverse domains, more contexts and detail, and to establish more connections among them. The higher the stage, the more room for such horizontal expansion seems to exist. On rare occasions, a transformation or vertical change occurs in response to persistent discrepancies that cannot be accommodated through horizontal integration or defensive mechanisms. In that case, the whole previous meaning system may be transformed and restructured into a new, more expansive and inclusive theory. In one way or another, constructivist developmental theory makes a fundamental distinction between horizontal growth, which adds new information or content to the existing worldview, and vertical growth, which transforms or reorganizes the current meaning system into a higher order integration.

Thus, constructivist developmental theory posits that the more evolved and differentiated individuals become, the more elements from more diverse sources and at higher orders of synthesis, they can simultaneously process and integrate into a coherent system of meaning. Such sources of input range from registering multiple channels of sensory information, to others’ feelings, behaviors and interactions, to being alert to one’s own behavior, reasoning, primary process and secondary ideation, perceptions, emotions, motivations, biases, dreams, intuitions, bodily states, and altered states of consciousness. Interindividual sources in the form of the group mind, or archetypal intimations, are also included as possible input at subtle levels of meaning making, while these sources can be organized into four territories of experience and foci of attention.

Another way of looking at the developmental progression is to state that the greater the differentiation, the greater distance from the objects of attention one has, or the greater one’s perspective on experience. At the most advanced levels, whole systems of human behavior and thought—for instance, moral reasoning, physics as a discipline, or language as an automatic habit—are taken as objects of reflection. Individuals can become simultaneously aware of the most concrete and the most ephemeral aspects of their experience. They can recognize the immediate and the infinite in both temporal and spatial terms.

At this point, it may be useful to introduce a figurative model which summarizes current thought about the overall course of development from its early, undifferentiated modes to the most mature and rare ways of meaning making observed. The overall growth trajectory is divided into four tiers: a preconventional, a conventional, a postconventional, and a postpostconventional or ego-transcendent one. Available statistical

research places about 10% of adults in the first, 80% in the second, and 10% in the third and fourth tiers. Using such a model allows one to indicate and compare how much of the overall range of the adult development trajectory each theory covers and how many subdivisions at the third tier it postulates.

1. The preconventional tier describes stages of meaning making that most people traverse before age twelve, i.e., they are more characteristic of children and are therefore considered immature, or lacking the complexity required for successful functioning and integration into modern society.
2. The conventional tier represents the stages most commonly found in adolescents and adults. These are the stages most representative of the conventions (the practices, beliefs, norms, and values) of what it means to be an adult in a given culture, hence the label conventional. This is also, therefore, the tier in which differences in local socialization most likely play the biggest role in individuals' differing self-perceptions, both within and across cultures.
3. The postconventional tier, also referred to as postformal or post-Piagetian, has only recently emerged as a viable lens for viewing the psychology of adulthood in Western psychology.
4. A fourth tier, the postpostconventional, metarational, or transcendent one, is even more rarely described by developmental psychologists in the West as part of the full potential of human development. Since this study is limited to the third tier of development, especially its upper-end, or the postautonomous level, a detailed understanding of the fourth tier is not necessary. The fourth tier is relevant to this inquiry, however, inasmuch as it covers the postautonomous level of the trajectory.

The postconventional tier is divided into two levels representing two distinct mindsets: the general systems stage, and a unitive stage. This distinction allows one to classify theories that postulate postconventional stages in theories may differ by whether they focus on stage characteristics.

Adult Meaning Making and Ego Development Theory

Theoretical Differences in Adult Development

Theories of adult development vary significantly in their focus and methodology. Some frameworks chart movement through stages dynamically, while others adopt a more static approach. Furthermore, theories differ in whether they are primarily data-driven or theory-driven, and whether their empirical foundations rely on interview data or psychometric testing.

Researchers have investigated numerous separate aspects of adult meaning making. Some focus on the mechanics and underlying laws of problem-solving, utilizing specific, narrowly defined cognitive tasks similar to classic practical beaker and balance beam experiments. Others explore reasoning within specific domains, such as moral development, conceptions of the good life, or the domain of faith. Additional research has examined the transition from adolescent to adult thinking, describing intellectual development in college-age populations or the emergence of relativistic thought. In response to earlier studies that relied heavily on male subject populations and were thus open to critiques of gender bias, subsequent research traced development in adult women to test how gender influences developmental trajectories. Finally, some theories focus on the evolving

self and its overarching attempt to orchestrate meaning across domains, charting individuals' evolving sense of self or identity as a complex, multidimensional response to personal and cultural factors.

Most of these theories, however, avoid considering adult development beyond the rational, representational realm of cognition. This reluctance may stem from the fact that experience and expertise in transcendent realms become increasingly rare among researchers themselves. Additionally, propositions regarding postrepresentational cognition are difficult to test using standard scientific methods and are therefore challenging to evaluate from the purview of mainstream psychology.

In contrast, the field of transpersonal developmental psychology has attempted to build full-spectrum theories of human development that follow the trajectory from birth through conventional and postconventional stages into the postsymbolic realm and stages of higher consciousness. Rigorous methodologies have been formulated for testing transcendent phenomena, detailing techniques for data collection, empirical evidence, and verification. These transpersonal theorists are particularly relevant because they are more likely than most researchers of postconventional development to include the highest levels of development and the transition to postrepresentational cognition in their models.

Domain Relationships and the Unified vs. Stranded Debate

Theories also differ in how they view the relationships among different domains of development. To account for the unevenness observed in individual cases, some proponents of constructivist developmental theory allow for a general coherence among domains theoretically, but insist that unevenness occurs frequently in real life and must be accounted for within the theory. Based on observations of adolescents and young adults in counseling environments, some researchers have described specific moves that account for this variability, such as “retreat, escape, and temporizing,” while others use concepts like “encapsulation” for the unevenness observed in clients. The issue of whether different dimensions of the self develop more or less in tandem, or whether they can follow significantly different trajectories, remains a critical debate. Comprehensive and complex accounts of the relationship among domains (strands) and waves (major transformational moves) of development have been articulated in integral theories.

Overall, the question of whether development is unified or consists of many strands is still debated, with evidence supporting both positions. The unified position posits that stages are structured wholes forming a single coherent system of logic. Some theories subsume several dimensions of a person under ego development—including impulse control, character development, interpersonal style, conscious preoccupations, and cognitive style—and understand them as developing more or less together. Depending on whether the focus is on micro- or macro-development, one may observe both phases of inconsistent performance and phases with more stage-like, coherent, or consolidated performance patterns. What researchers choose to pay most attention to is often a matter of personal affinity and largely determines what they are apt to find. A richer and more verisimilar understanding of human nature can likely be gleaned only from a tapestry of approaches and perspectives.

By using the concept of the ego as the central processing unit that orchestrates and aims at coherent meaning, it can be demonstrated how concepts of the self and reality evolve together such that a sequence of clearly observable stages of increasing differentiation and integration can be drawn, making the underlying logic visible. At the same time, development must be understood as a gradual and ongoing process with periods of more or less stability, since ego stages are qualitatively different points along a more or less hypothetical continuum. The stages themselves are most visible when comparing large numbers of adults or people at very different stages. Ego stages offer a powerful way of characterizing differences among people.

While the course of development naturally abounds with possibilities for pathology and less-than-optimal negotiation of the multiple demands on the self, it seems undeniable that most individuals try to organize experience into some coherent, unified view of reality. Even in the most severe psychopathologies, one can often discern the striving of the ego to cohere in the first place or to maintain a semblance of coherence. Thus, a focus on positive or ideal adult development and meaning making as a central, synthesizing activity of the self is particularly valuable.

Critiques of Early Cognitive Stage Theories

Numerous arguments against early cognitive stage theories have been mounted, questioning the cross-cultural universality of the stages, the ages at which people can solve laboratory problems, and the locus of control, which was predominantly placed within the individual. Given current knowledge, it is reasonable to challenge many specifics of these foundational theories. For example, early theorists both underestimated and overestimated the ages at which individuals reach defined stages because much of the theory was based on laboratory tasks. They underestimated them because children who are coached can solve certain problems earlier than surmised. On the other hand, full formal operations rarely occur as early as suggested (age 12), and many adults do not develop them at all. However, the approach of basing theory on careful experimentation, observation, and interviewing—that is, on empirical evidence—remains a powerful avenue for expanding knowledge about the human condition.

Ego Development Theory and Sentence Completion Testing

Ego development theory and its associated sentence completion measuring instrument form the basis for assessing stages of character development. This approach constituted a breakthrough in cognitive developmental psychology and measurement when it first appeared for three major reasons: it used adult women as a sample population at a time when research and conclusions about adult development were customarily drawn from studying males; it was thoroughly grounded in empirical evidence; and it introduced a novel argument for determining a person's stage of development.

The sentence completion test serves as a vehicle to deduce people's overall frame of reference, or mental map, from their verbal productions. It is fascinating that 36 brief sentence completions can provide a fair idea of the greatest concerns and challenges for a given developmental personality type. It remains astonishing that one can comprehend another in important ways by knowing their developmental stage, and that one can predict their behavior across a number of dimensions. This includes preferences for relating to others, ways of adjudicating in cases of conflict or doubt, and main preoccupations and concerns. Empirical evidence for the predictive power of the instrument comes from extensive research and pilot studies.

Characteristics of the Test

The sentence completion test assesses a person's ego stage or character development. It is perhaps the most widely used standardized developmental measuring instrument for adults. Its psychometric properties, reliability, and validity have been thoroughly explored by numerous researchers.

The test usually contains 36 sentence stems or sentence beginnings displayed on two pages in numerical order with space for test-takers to enter their responses. They are instructed to complete the set of 36 stems in any way they wish. Thus, it is a semi-projective test, inviting test-takers to impose their own way of structuring reality on the material presented. A salient aspect of semi-projective sentence completion tests is that each sentence stem provides both the framework for the response and a unit by which to compare all responses from many

individuals given to that stem. Unlike fully projective tests, the stems limit to some degree what a plausible completion can look like.

The test can be administered in groups, which is likely the most effective method, requiring at most half an hour. It can also be given verbally to people for whom writing may be a challenge, and by telephone when group or mail administration is not possible, with the researcher noting responses verbatim. Non-group administration inevitably introduces some error. Administrators and raters are held to strict adherence to recommended procedures, and problems with non-traditional uses are explicitly detailed.

The recommended 36-item form contains the same stems for both men and women and is constructed so it can be given in two psychometrically equivalent halves for pre/post-test research designs. Many other forms exist, including variations for different target populations, some combining different items or varying their order. The current form aims to provide a variety of themes and optimal sequencing, containing the statistically most discriminating items.

The stems refer to everyday life and were chosen to appeal to and elicit responses from the widest possible range of adults. Examples include:

- “A man’s job -”
- “I am -”
- “If my mother -”

These stems tap into how people construe coherent meaning, calling on subjects to project their own way of making sense of experience. The semantic choice (differentiation of content and specific language) and sentence structure are said to reveal the underlying frame of reference or ego stage. The test assumes that language is interpretable, meaningful behavior that mirrors people’s ways of responding to life, or even that language is constitutive of reality. This aligns with the notion that no expression of psychic life is arbitrary, lawless, or trifling. If spoken and written language is behavior, differences in verbal expression are interpretable as differences in psychic life or meaning making.

The Role of Language and Rater Interpretation

The semantic and structural distinctions required to separate similar responses into different stages according to their level of differentiation were tacitly assumed skills, even though participants were not trained linguists. Part of the appeal of the original manuals was the skillfully sequenced sets. For instance, completions to the stem “When people are helpless -”:

- “I try to help them”
- “I want to help them”
- “I feel a need to help”

These responses give a clear sense of increasing stimulus-response delay and self-reflection, and were used as examples for three consecutive conventional stages. Students taught how language can zero in on a subject’s probable underlying frame of reference can readily sort such sequences intuitively, gaining a sense of the construct of the evolving self. This supports the face validity of the theory and the claim that adequate understanding of the theoretical construct requires knowledge of the scoring system.

However, this approach carries dangers. Researcher bias or limitation can powerfully influence the initial sorting of responses with similar content into different stages, even with consensus among research team members. Using exacting psychometrics afterward to ensure that classes of responses are consonant with the overall

rating of a protocol cannot entirely remove the problem due to the circularity of the process; it cannot discover shared rater limitation.

Sentence Completions as Verbal Behavior

The test is fundamentally based on the notion that meaning is created and communicated through language, and that choice of content and structure models one's conception of reality. The test provides enough glimpses into such choices to give an overall sense of how things cohere for a person.

In comparing structured and projective tests, it has been noted that in structured tests, investigators project their own frame of reference rather than tapping the subjects', which is what reveals ego level. In unstructured tests, one cannot control what the subject will choose to reveal. While testers become adept at interpreting minimal signs, there is always the chance a person will conceal all or respond in a way that conceals their usual ego level.

Concealment and preexisting psychopathology are issues raters must be aware of. Signs of serious disturbance are not necessarily easily detected, though expert raters can often pick up telling incongruities. What can be said with certainty is that the ego level displayed is one an individual has mastered and can employ in a test situation. In most cases, lower responses are not due to concealment but to limitations in the subject. Individuals functioning at lower stage levels will simplify verbal stimuli to a form they can understand and handle. Misreading or not understanding stems indicates low ego level, as some stems require a conventional conception of reality. For example, "Crime and delinquency could be halted if -" is hard for lower-level subjects to understand because it pulls for hypothetical reasoning.

In contrast, postformal individuals commonly choose to respond to some items at lower levels than they are capable of—most often at conventional stages—because doing so is functionally adequate. This flexibility is a sign of higher development. Lower stage responses can also be a form of acting out or avoidance of emotionally loaded stems for subjects at all levels.

Overall, the test measures performance rather than competence. We cannot tell what a participant might have said under other circumstances. Thus, one can assert that a person seems capable of appreciating the world at least at a specific level under test conditions.

Furthermore, there are intrinsic difficulties in assigning behavioral signs to any developmental level. A sign appearing at one level in a tentative version appears at higher levels in increasingly clear and elaborated versions. A thought appearing at one level as a cliché appears in a deeper, more convincing, and more complex version at higher levels. Thus, a manual using verbal signs is valued for its explicit logic and plausibility manifest behind the sequencing of model responses and categories. The primary questions are: "Given a particular ego level, what is the probability of showing this sign?" and conversely, "Given a particular replicated response, what is the probability that the subject comes from a given level?"

Since the highest stages are characterized by originality, spontaneity, and freedom from stereotypy, behavioral signs are difficult to find. Replicated responses are not expected at these levels. It is a weakness of the statistical approach that it works best where there is sufficient data; the end of a qualitative scale escapes its power. The fundamental problem of psychometrics is transforming qualitative data onto a quantitative scale, and identifying the entities worth measuring.

Manual Construction and Scoring Rules

The manuals grew from an exemplar manual—which just listed responses given for each stage and was not useful for rating new material—to a categorized manual, which separated responses into categories with titles indicating the common element. The published manual is a rationalized category manual, attempting to justify

every scoring decision theoretically and empirically. It offers an overview of each stem, a theoretical rationale for category placement, and cross-references for similar content placed at different stages.

Final placement of a category was based on an internal consistency method. If a group of responses rated at a given stage turned out to come predominantly from protocols rated at a different stage, the group was reassigned to the more frequent stage in the next version. The final product has many instances where face validity is striking, but also placements whose logic in terms of a consistent theory of ego evolution is not evident. This is expected when statistical techniques override placement by insightful researchers, especially for rarer, non-replicated completions. Empirical test construction methods rest on replicated responses, which is difficult for free-response tests given human variability.

The manual consists of separate scoring sections for each stem, containing lists of representative content categories with actual completions as examples. Trained raters assign an ego stage to each response by matching the completion with a listed category title. Five rules govern the process:

1. Matching (tried first).
- 2-4. Rules for scoring compound completions (which may contain elements at the same or different stages).
2. Rules for other eventualities (missing or incomprehensible responses).

Verbatim matches occur mostly at the low end of the scale and through the conventional tier. Beyond that, the length and complexity of responses require the use of Rules 2-4. Skilled reliance on scoring rules becomes increasingly important as responses become more complex and unique with increasing ego development.

The number of recognized stages changed over time, from an initial four to nine, to as many as ten or eleven, and currently eight. Whichever way the continuum is parsed, each consecutive stage represents a coherent, predictable, and recognizable way people differ. The instrument types people according to their ego level, making stage theories quasi-typologies, though they differ because stages follow an invariant sequence.

A final rating of an entire protocol (Total Protocol Rating or TPR) is based on the cumulative distribution characteristics of the individual scores. These distributions are compared to predetermined cut-off numbers (ogives) that distinguish between adjacent stages, and a stage score is assigned according to a specified algorithm. Ideally, a scorer reads the entire protocol to assess whether the mechanically derived score warrants rating the complete protocol at that stage.

The TPR reflects a person's most ego-syntonic and habitual frame of reference, or their "center of gravity." People tend to respond optimally in domains where they are highly motivated. By definition, an ego stage is the view of reality a person most routinely and automatically uses in everyday situations. While there is spread around the center of gravity, one cannot fully understand reasoning beyond one's own. Upward scatter is interpreted as intimations of more complex meaning making, though not sufficiently numerous to show a shift into the adjacent higher level.

Ego Development Theory Structure

The ego development theory ranges over three tiers: preconventional, conventional, and postconventional. Unlike domain-specific stage theories, it describes a basic or overarching aspect of personality development including cognitive, affective, and behavioral aspects.

The theory uses the ego as the underlying principle in personality organization. The organization or synthetic function is not just something the ego does; it is what the ego is. The ego strives for coherent meaning and orchestrates how reality is perceived. The failure of the ego to integrate is meaninglessness. The fundamental

characteristics of the ego are that it is a process, a structure, social in origin, functioning as a whole, and guided by purpose and meaning.

To claim an underlying construct develops, one must show its movement from stage to stage and its changing properties. The theory attempts to account for transformational changes in perspective by proposing a sequence of ego stages. These stages form an invariant sequence and represent hierarchical integrations of greater complexity, cognitive differentiation, and integration. A higher stage transforms the previous way of looking at reality, offering a broader, deeper, more integrated perspective.

However, the theory has been critiqued for lacking a rigorous, coherent definition of the ego construct and the logic underlying successive stages. It lacks an explicit logic of what makes one position higher or more mature than another, making it difficult to justify a sequence of hierarchical stages.

Problems with the Manual and Theory

The most distinctive feature of the theory and instrument is that the theory evolved out of the measurement instrument. The manual is based on years of cumulative experimentation, with observations from successive studies influencing the conceptualization of the theory itself.

Developmental theory heavily derived from empirical evidence and based on a probabilistic rationale is prone to specific problems. It cannot readily account for data from the extremes of the scale (due to lack of evidence) or novel data. It is strongest in the middle range where data is adequate. The reliance on statistical conclusions without known rationale, permitting data to decide, is seen by some as less arbitrary, but it leaves questions about whether other approaches could have produced similar results.

The lack of theoretical logic is evident in the manual's categories. Identical completions to very similar stimuli can be listed at two different stages. Explaining almost the same stimulus-response sequence one way for one stem and differently for another raises questions about overall coherence. The stage descriptions are often like sketches or snapshots, making little attempt to be comprehensive or explain the movement from one stage to the next.

High-End Problems and Proposed Revisions

Rating high-end protocols presents a significant challenge because the theory and manuals do not clearly distinguish between the two highest stages (Autonomous and Integrated). The Integrated stage often does not seem to be a transformation of the previous stage, but merely an elaboration or original combination of material from lower stages. Most examples of the ultimate stage do not contain content or structure different from the penultimate Autonomous stage.

However, a handful of examples at the Integrated stage seem genuinely different in tenor, content, and structure, warranting consideration as a "postautonomous" stage. For example, a response to the stem "I am -":

- "I am - finally, in the long run, mostly unfathomable, but I enjoy the process of trying to fathom."

This response reflects a fluid, deconstructed self-view, enjoying the process without concern for a definable outcome or the desire for objectivity common at prior stages. It requires a transformation and awareness of one's own mental processes not documented earlier. Yet, there was no general ego development theory to account for this awareness. The manuals highlight "the search for identity" as the characteristic of the Integrated stage, but this response abdicates that search in favor of witnessing the ongoing process of self-becoming.

To address these limitations, systematic collection of rare "postautonomous" responses led to proposed revisions. Postconventional ego development can be characterized by an increasing awareness of the

constructed nature of knowledge and a step-wise deconstruction of assumptions undergirding conventional views of reality. The search for an objective, nondistorted view of reality is superseded by an understanding of the futility of such a goal. Attention turns to how meaning is continuously reconstructed and how all constructs are artifacts of linguistic codification.

Other examples of such responses to “I am -” include:

- “- which is pretty wondrous to me all by itself as it unfolds”
- “- alive, trundling along, making sense as best as can, diversifying & expanding while consolidating & contracting”

Analysis of these responses led to the proposal of two distinct new stages with several categories each. For example, criteria for the Construct-aware stage look for signs that subjects are cognitively aware of the constructed nature of “labeled” reality and concerned with ambiguities and paradoxes inherent in constructing meaning. The experience of alert, detached witnessing of one’s changing self-identifications is a criterion for the more integrated Universal or Unitive stage.

Unlike existing stem-specific categories, these proposed postautonomous categories are at a higher level of abstraction and apply across all stems, reflecting stage-specific themes. This approach allows for a theoretically coherent and plausible explanation of the data. At the Construct-aware stage, individuals recognize the pattern of forming coherent maps of reality by consecutive approximations and the underlying human need for permanence that drives reification. At the Universal/Unitive stage, people understand the fundamental instability and illusion of the permanent object world more deeply, integrating this awareness into a new mode of living and a more sober appraisal of the purpose of rational behavior and language.

The Second Edition Revisions

The 1996 Second Edition of the manual was intended as the final, authoritative version. It introduced a single-volume, “unisex” format based on data from both males and females, with examples reflecting current public attitudes. Recalibrating stems referring to women brought them into line with contemporary social realities, acknowledging that the social expression of development varies across cultures and times.

However, several changes present challenges:

1. **Stage Relabeling:** Stages were relabeled E2 to E9, truncating the number of levels from ten or eleven down to eight. While eliminating labeling inconsistencies, this poses a serious transposing challenge for longitudinal studies with great potential for clerical error.
2. **Introduction of Themes:** Themes were introduced to guide raters, effectively adding an extra step in the decision tree. Since it is not systematically carried through, it is not necessarily more efficient.
3. **Altered Ogive Rules:** The rules for assigning Total Protocol Ratings became less stringent for obtaining a postconventional rating, requiring only six ratings beyond the highest conventional stage (E6). Borderline ogives were eliminated.
4. **Combinatorial Categories:** New “combinatorial” categories at the postconventional tier invite mechanical application, overruling the rule that compound responses must generate a higher level of conceptual complexity. A response with several E6 elements might be rated E8 merely because of the combination, confounding conceptual complexity with the assembly of ideas and weakening demands for postconventional ratings.

5. **Dropped Stages:** Stages that raters had difficulty rating or that were ill-defined were dropped to streamline the instrument.

Relying primarily on data and psychometrics runs the risk of ignoring vital aspects of the overall underlying pattern. When a stage makes theoretical sense and can be explained as a distinctive position in the developmental sequence, it ought to be included whether or not it draws many responses. Data-driven theory is only as good as the data it is based on.

Development Theory and the Challenges of High-End Stages

A fundamental purpose of development theory is to provide a plausible model of how adults differ from each other in a systematic fashion. It should explain how they develop increasingly complex maps of meaning, what they choose to focus on or deal with at each stage, and how they reason their positions. Thus, combining data with interpretation and insight is essential for producing predictive and useful theory. Nonetheless, the framework developers seem to weigh the frequency of stage assignments and expedience increasingly more heavily than theoretical consistency in their latest version of the manual and theory. By renaming and renumbering the stages, some of the confusion resulting from earlier modifications was avoided on the one hand, but on the other, the theory as a whole became weaker. This move was intended to make the task of learning how to score easier for novice raters, but it puts practicality above the integrity and coherence of the theory.

High-End Problems Persisting in the Second Edition

Because the placement of examples in the manual is based on probabilistic considerations, the manual is good at distinguishing among adults at the most common stages. It is less so for the extremes at either side of the distribution curve. It is weak at the lower end because examples are few and the test requires that respondents be minimally verbal to respond to the stimuli. However, this is not a grave problem for the low-end because responding inappropriately and misunderstanding the stimulus items are in part signs for low ego development. The paucity in numbers and distinctions of the examples mirrors the impoverished and confused thought of low ego stages.

The problem at the upper end, however, is very different and more serious. The next section cites many more of the framework developers' pronouncements verbatim than other sections because it is at the high-end of the scale that their explanations are least consistent, perceptive, and defensible.

Lack of Clarity and Sparse Examples

In 1993, the framework developers asserted that:

More problematic than (...) is description of the highest stage. There bias is all. I try to be vague [? ?] about the highest stage, and I discourage our raters from assigning the highest score (integrated), because I find the rules are almost always misinterpreted, even by our most reliable and conscientious collaborators (...). It is also the level on which there is least agreement with other similar stage conceptions (p. 59).

The framework developers continue to cite lack of “agreement” (p. 7) and “lack of data” (p. 6) as the main reasons for the vagueness of the Integrated stage. As a practical matter, the Second Edition offers considerably fewer postautonomous examples than previous versions. It contains only 18 examples in the introductory chapters and the scoring section combined. Thus, 30 out of 36 stems currently provide no examples for the Integrated stage. As for the manual, the framework developers acknowledge that the few examples actually listed may not be very helpful to raters in scoring higher stages. They remark that:

because replicated responses are rare at E8 (Autonomous) and nonexistent at E9 (I-6; Integrated), this chapter [Manifestations of ego level in sentence completions] is about as helpful as the item manuals for those levels (p. 9).

One begins to wonder why the Integrated stage has not been dropped altogether from the manual as other stages have, given its theoretical fuzziness and the lack of empirical support.

The Problem of Identity

As in earlier versions, the sole discriminating characteristic for the Integrated stage is given as the “search for identity.”

The one new category at E9 is the search for identity. Clichés about “who I am” or being oneself do not qualify, only responses that on other grounds would be classed at least as E8. The problem of identity appears in terms of reconciliation of roles, striving for autonomy, individuality and self-fulfillment, and recognizing other people's need for theirs” (p. 25)

All of the above concerns are also listed as characteristic of the Autonomous self. Moreover, concerns with identity (self-assessment) appear at all stages and at all levels of differentiation since ego as underlying construct is said to reveal the current synthesis of “who I am.” Identity therefore appears at level E8 for instance in “A man's job - search for identity” and in “For a woman a career is - a means of achieving identity” as category titles. To clarify the distinction between the search for identity at E8 and E9, the framework developers declare that, at E8 “people express their respect for other people's need for autonomy,” but “the problem of identity appears only in general or cliché form; full appreciation of identity as a problem is present at E9” (p.23).

What they understand a “full appreciation of identity as a problem” to mean must be deduced from two examples at their Integrated stage E9 in the “Manifestation ...” chapter.

My mother and I - get along, but I need to get away to develop myself, I praise her because she is a woman, and a person. I am a person but not yet a woman.

When a child will not join in group activities - it may be because he feels no identity with the group, is too self-conscious, or has no real interest in the activity. (p.25)

Though the first completion is touching, it only expresses an insight that is most likely from an Individualistic (E7) perspective. It could possibly be rated at E8 for the quality of “admiration” that is clearly expressed. The girl tries to find her identity as a woman within the context of and in contradistinction to a special significant other. The second response should be rated at E7 according to scoring Rule 2 because it combines lower material in an interesting way that seems overall more complex than its parts taken alone. Neither of these responses seems to warrant a postautonomous rating since they give no indication of a frame of reference that is qualitatively different from and more integrated than an Autonomous one.

One is tempted to interpret the first response above as a “full appreciation of identity as a problem,” or “the search for identity as a problem,” but this clearly is not what the framework developers have in mind. In their framework, the most evolved persons are aiming for a clear enduring self-sense that—although it may be emotionally rich and cognitively complex—is based on an “objective” appraisal of oneself in the world. There is no indication anywhere in their writing that they have considered how the expression “search for identity” itself inherently frames their reality as assuming that (a) a permanent objective identity can be found and (b) that finding one is a desirable goal. The “problem of identity” for the framework developers is how to best accomplish the endeavor or at least approximate it. The possibility of questioning the meaning of such a search is not entertained.

Lack of Distinction Between the Autonomous and the Integrated Stage

Because they have not provided useful guidance, distinctions, and examples in the past for rating the Integrated level, the framework developers find that:

There are major differences among qualified raters both as to the description of this level and application of the description in particular cases (p. 7).

They therefore suggest that for practical purposes their highest rating, the Integrated stage, be eliminated (p. 24), or collapsed with the Autonomous stage because of its rarity. It accounts for “probably less than 1%” (p.6) of SCT protocols from an urban population. Even if one agreed with their interpretation of what constitutes the “highest” stage of ego development, it is not clear that statistical rarity alone warrants ignoring the possible theoretical distinctions that the study of these rarer views might produce. The framework developers are justified, of course, from an actuarial perspective. Most research projects with adults have predominantly conventional subjects, so that distinctions at the high-end are unnecessary for scoring them. To know what characterizes most people in an adult population is important for many reasons, but is it more important than to know what the overall trajectory of development might be and to understand what characterizes those at the high-end of the scale as the framework developers assert? One wonders what happened to their earlier recognition that: “theoretical insights” at the “growing tips of theory” are possible only by retaining “rare, unreplicated responses” (p. 14).

Furthermore, it is a curious aspect of an otherwise admirably concise and objective writing style throughout their work as well as in the Second Edition that the framework developers feel compelled to attribute “questionable” motives to high-end writers of long, complex responses as well as to those who would want to understand and rate such material:

Protocols with a very large number of long responses, even if they are mostly rated E8 or E9, are not comparable with those on which the manual is based. They may have been written to display that their authors know the “right” answers, or to teach lessons to whoever reads the test. In any case, they appear to be addressed to a different directive than simply completing sentences. (p. 25)

For some people that may be the case, but for others that directive may be ego-syntonic, in the service of expressing their deepest concerns as they experience them, or, in the framework developers’ words, addressing “life’s universal problems” (p. 32). The struggle to express in words the complexity of one’s understanding in response to a simple test situation is just one of those “universal problems” that does seem to appear frequently in postautonomous protocols. Rather than dismissing it, it deserves to be investigated. What has changed in the way postautonomous subjects understand themselves? Why do they talk explicitly about their struggles with

complexity issues whereas subjects at earlier stages ignore them? These are the types of questions that guide one in discovering recurring themes in high-end responses and that differentiate high-stage protocols from earlier ones in a unique, qualitatively distinctive way.

In addition, the framework developers also suspect those who are particularly interested in the higher stages of merely seeking self-affirmation or of downright strangeness.

The highest stages are fascinating in part because they embody much of what each of us aspires to or believes that he or she has achieved (p.1).

Many professional colleagues are enthralled with studying the highest possible levels (p. 87).

Even if people of the highest ego level became psychologists, would they really want to spend their time scoring SCTs? (p. 59).

The response to the question is, why not? A Buddhist might observe that every activity that is done with one's full-presence of mind and heart is an expression of being. Any job is as important or unimportant as any other. There is no difference. Thus, the framework developers tend to dismiss questions of meaning making which might be essential concerns in life for some individuals, and they devalue anybody's interest in these matters. Granted, few people give responses that fall into the postautonomous range, but their completions promise to be especially illuminating in mapping out a more full-bodied theory of mature ego development. The above remarks seem part of the framework developers' overall adherence to a linear, analytic model of science, one that declares anything that can't be readily measured as outside the realm of scientific purview or meaningful inquiry and therefore of little value.

No New Theory in Spite of Whole Field of Research

The Second Edition along with the technical companion volume consists of a defense of previous methodological moves as well as of current strategies. It shows no evidence that the overall theory of ego development has been reexamined since its first publication. The most recent cite in the Second Edition is a 1968 work on intellectual development. Other than the framework developers' own publications, there is no consideration of any work done by later authors. Most significantly, the Second Edition doesn't even mention other relevant work in the field of adult development.

This insistence on keeping ego development separate and distinct from other movements in the field is also peculiar to the framework developers, and perhaps expresses the zeitgeist. Their ego development theory as it stands, cannot adequately allow for the evolution and transformation of its own system even as it can acknowledge dynamism and movement as an important element in growth. Thus, it would be a fascinating task for a psychobiographer to assess in which way ego development theory is a child of its specific progenitor and of her historical-intellectual context and why it may be at odds with the current postconventional research arena and a more postmodern scientific paradigm. Although tongue-in-cheek, the framework developers' phrase, "the obdurate vagary of human beings always escaping our labels," (p. 57) summarizes in a nutshell their sentiments towards the extraordinary and the unac-"countable".

Given the substantial evidence of the limits of both the theory at the upper-end and the inadequacy of the Second Edition as a scoring tool for postautonomous development, it seems that a test of the proposed revisions is appropriate.

Summary of Revisions of Ego Development Theory

This section, which summarizes prior work in ego development theory, is subdivided into three parts. First, it highlights four salient aspects of the overall conception of ego development which systematizes and extends ego development theory. Among them, it will mention 'the expanding perspective on the self' as the underlying construct that develops throughout the stages. Second, it will point out a distinctive pattern that emerged from examining the whole sequence of stages in large numbers of SCTs. It proposes that ego stages alternate in their overall emphasis and balance between stages of differentiation and stages of integration (separateness and connectedness). This pattern is introduced here because it originally guided the hypothesis for an intermediate stage of differentiation between the integrated Autonomous and "integrated" Integrated stage. Third, it will sketch the overall cognitive dynamics in postconventional ego development and present two new stages, the Construct-aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9) and the Unitive stage 6 (C10) as part of the whole trajectory of expanding perspectives. It is suggested that these be used in lieu of the Integrated stage E9 (I-6) when dealing with high-end samples. For reasons of comparison and distinction, an abstract of the Autonomous stage 5 (E8) is also included in this section.

Ego Development Theory

Definition of Terms Used

Key terms are defined noting the similarities and differences between these definitions and other researchers'. First, the critical term "ego": Some aspects of the use of the term ego and "self" seem similar to the superego (e.g. the development of impulse control, managing affective states, and conflict resolution). However, the term "ego" is used here to denote the underlying principle in personality organization that strives for coherent meaning and orchestrates how we perceive reality. "Ego development is the term for the common element in the stage sequence and the corresponding dimension of individual differences" (p. 6).

The term self is used interchangeably with person and individual whereas by ego, it refers to two main dimensions: ego as process and ego as representation. The function of the ego as process is to organize, synthesize and integrate experience from both external and internal sources and to mediate among them. The ego is the central processing unit within the rational, personal, symbol-mediated realm of experience. The ego as representation (the I and the me as one's identity) can be understood as the result of this effort at integration. The created identity thus changes with the changing levels of integration. Interestingly, rare high-end SCTs seem to reflect the possibility of becoming a witness to both the ego's efforts at processing and to the changing results of the process of "identity formation."

The fundamental arbitrariness and limits of defining and reifying experience were introduced earlier and will be taken up again as a separate theme in the validation study.

A Multidimensional Psychological System

Ego development theory describes the ego as an overarching, multifaceted construct. Human development has been described as emerging from a synthesis of doing, being, and thinking, although this general pattern would be qualified by adding that the balances among the dimensions are likely to shift along the growth path. Following this, ego development theory can be usefully described as a psychological system with at least three different, but interrelated dimensions that coexist at all times. The affective dimension deals with emotions and the experience of being in this world. The cognitive dimension addresses the question of how a person learns, reasons, and knows about himself or herself and the world. The operative dimension looks at what people see as the purpose of life, what needs they act upon, and what ends they are moving towards. These three

dimensions of experience have correlates in all human cultures and represent ontological, epistemological and teleological concerns.

It is maintained that the stage descriptions “emphasize the affective and motivational aspects of personality growth, such as impulse control, conscious preoccupations, interpersonal orientation, and character development” (p. 5). Current researchers have different views of what special weight should be given to cognitive style or cognitive complexity as an aspect of the concept of ego development. Since the perspective on the ‘self’ has been chosen as the element that develops, it appears that the cognitive aspect drives the others in this approach. It can be argued that this is more likely an artifact of the lens chosen than an aspect of development itself.

The Linguistic Foundation

Another crucial aspect of ego development theory and measurement is its linguistic foundation. It seems indisputable today that the capacity for symbolic representation is innate in human beings and that its activation is indispensable for growth to occur. For verbal projective tests to be useful, one has to assume that there is a “probabilistic” relationship between that which is experienced and expressed and the signs used for doing so.

As discussed previously in the section on the centrality of language, ego-development theory postulates (a) that the content and the structure of people’s language reveals their conceptual frame of reference, and (b) that their underlying cognitive structure can be deduced from a matrix of linguistic signs. Most importantly, it assumes that individuals function at the level that explains the world best to themselves in areas that are relevant to their lives.

The analysis of a person’s use of language in the SCT for both its conceptual content and its structure provides the researcher with a set of clues to the person’s underlying self-theory and Weltanschauung. This is so because language is internalized so completely and at such an early age that it acts as an unconscious filter for a vast number of stimuli. We can therefore evaluate what the conscious sphere of people is likely to be from what they spontaneously choose to express on an SCT, and often, more saliently, by what is missing because it is outside their conceptual framework. Some material may be filtered out defensively because it is threatening to one’s current self-system. But more often, distinctions don’t appear because they don’t register at all in that person’s range of awareness. By definition, an ego stage is that frame of reference that a person most automatically and routinely uses in everyday situations.

If we accept the premise that one’s language subtly mirrors one’s conceptual or ego stage, the question arises whether ego development theory can be shown to follow a regular order of expanding views of reality. The ‘Perspectives on the self’ is an attempt at elucidating the movement through the stages. ‘Perspectives on the self’ can be used as the consistent element from which to view the whole sequence of ego development. This movement from a simple, undifferentiated self-state to ever more complex self-identifications follows the overall move described as part of the orthogenetic principle. The level of perspective increases at each stage (quantitative aspect of change) and, in turn, greater perspective allows for a different understanding of what is looked at (qualitative nature of change) (p.117).

In 1984, the theory was critiqued qua developmental stage theory for lacking an underlying structural logic. A distinction was introduced between “hard” and “soft” stage models. What hard structural stages gain, it was written, “is precision in their articulation of a structural logic of stages that will survive the ever-changing growth of psychological knowledge about the self, its functions and development” (p. 384).

In response to this critique, it is suggested that the evolving ‘perspective on the self’ demonstrates the inner logic of ego development from the Symbiotic stage through the proposed postautonomous stages. It is argued

that spelling out the structure of an underlying regularly expanding self-perspective moves ego development theory from a “soft” stage theory to one more akin to a “hard” stage type according to the distinction.

These ‘evolving perspectives on the self’ are similar to orders of consciousness in that they distinguish between what is subject (and thus hidden from view, or unavailable for consideration and negotiation) and what can be taken as object, “looked at,” or dealt with at each stage of ego development. Thus, the ‘perspective on the self’ actually provides a logic or scaffold that underlies the ego stages. Unlike the previous construct, (1) it explains the dynamic unfolding of the self; (2) provides a test of whether a stage is qualitatively different from a previous one, and (3) serves as a predictor.

By structuring ego development theory via a unifying construct that can be shown to expand regularly, one of the problems with the theory is eliminated. As it stands now, this version of the theory explains both the strengths and the limits of each meaning-making stage and anticipates the specific issues that adults are likely to have to negotiate at the next level in their development. It predicts what content and processes they will be able to notice, perceive, act and reflect upon, organize, and synthesize at the current stage that they did not perceive before. That kind of mental growth is best conceptualized as “making what was subject into object so that we can ‘have it’ rather than ‘be had’ by it” (p.34).

This reconceptualization of ego development theory fleshes out the descriptions of the qualitatively different points on the continuum provided by the framework developers. It explains how people form systems of coherent meaning and how they move from one interpretation of reality to the next by tracking the changes between the stages. Looking for regularities in the whole sequence of ego stages, is one way to systematize the theory.

The Alternating Pattern Between Stages of Differentiation and Integration

According to developmental tenets, when individuals grow beyond the confines of a particular stage, they may redefine themselves within the new frame of reference of the next stage. After carefully studying many SCT protocols as well as the theory and scoring manuals, it appeared that these redefinitions seem to alternate in a regular fashion between stages of differentiation and integration. The continuous renegotiation of the balance between differentiation and assimilation, or the “double trend towards autonomy” (differentiation, separation, mastery, independence) “and homonomy” (integration, participation, relatedness, connection) throughout development has been commented on as a fundamental tendency in human beings.

According to developmental principles, ego stages can be thought of as organic wholes, as relatively stable balances within which adults stay settled for long periods of time, often for a lifetime. It is for this reason that the positions of differentiation in ego development theory can be considered “stages,” or relatively permanent positions, rather than transitional phases between more enduring stages. This model describes a logical sequence of ten such stages of differentiation and integration, which range over three tiers of the four tier developmental model. The stages represent stable hypothetical equilibria along the continuum. Other models, on the other hand, only consider the integrated points on the continuum as qualitatively different stages proper.

The pattern of the alternating stages of differentiation and integration can be summarized as follows. Individuals at the earliest two stages in ego development theory are too undifferentiated for the separation of the double trend toward autonomy and homonomy to emerge fully. Beginning with the Self-protective stage, however, one can distinguish between stages that favor separation and those that emphasize relatedness.

The Rule-oriented, Self-aware, Individualistic, and Construct-aware Stages (A3, $\frac{3}{4}$ (E5), $\frac{4}{5}$ (E7), and $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9)) are oppositional stages or stages of differentiation. People at these stages emphasize their difference and uniqueness in relation to the previous stage. In each case, they are beholden to that former way of meaning making by explicitly setting themselves apart from it while they are, at the same time, able to observe it from a

new level of perspective. They tend to stress the boundaries, the distinctions, and the differences to the previous way of perceiving themselves and the world. They also tend to affirm their independence although, depending on the stage, at different levels of cognitive complexity and abstraction. Because their basic need for relatedness is not fulfilled, they generally express more negative affect and more tension than persons at the even stages 3 (E4), 4 (E6), 5 (E8), and 6 (C10).

Alternating Stages of Differentiation and Integration

On one hand, ego development theory at the postconventional tier deals with people's ability to represent the self and reality with increasing accuracy, objectivity, and non-self-defensiveness. From one ego stage to the next, people become more individuated and more complex according to the pattern of continuing differentiation-integration begun in infancy. They can draw multiple kinds of distinctions and connections among stimuli from ever more diverse sources and meaningfully integrate them into a coherent frame of reference for themselves. Overall, this movement describes the increasing mental flexibility and personal maturity evidenced at the postconventional stages.

The second movement, in contrast, is best described as a step-wise deconstruction of the clear-cut subject-object boundaries that were established in the process of forming the adult, independent, rational self and the permanent object world. This process of deconstruction of the subject/object separation seems to happen in two steps, which are elaborated below.

The Systems Level of Postconventional Development

At the systems level, individuals begin to realize that they interpret what things mean and that their interpretations are both culturally determined and influenced by personal experience. What something means depends on one's relative position in regard to it. This change is generally referred to as a systems view of reality. Although the objects themselves are still viewed as permanent, what they mean is now seen as constructed. Variables are seen as inevitably interdependent rather than independent, causality experienced as cyclical rather than linear, and boundaries of objects as open and flexible rather than closed depending on one's definition of what is to be considered within a system or outside. At the Individualistic stage $\frac{4}{5}$ (E7), the importance of context and point of view first enters as a crucial element into people's thinking and understanding. A main concern of this stage is to lay bare the assumptions embedded in the conventions absorbed at earlier stages. Stage $\frac{4}{5}$ (E7) represents systematic operations in the General Stage Model. The Autonomous stage 5 (E8) expands cognition to metasystematic operations as it actively integrates different frameworks or subpersonalities into a coherent new self-theory that coordinates different even contradictory subidentities into a core self.

The Postautonomous Level of Postformal Development

At the second level of postconventional development individuals come to realize that all objects are human-made constructs, especially such abstract constructs as the ego, three-dimensional space and time. All are based on a reification of the underlying phenomenological flux and on layers upon layers of symbolic abstraction. Even the concept of a concrete object such as "an ordinary chair" is an enormous simplification of actual experience: No two people's mental picture of a chair is the same and no two chairs in the world are identical. The concept we usually have in our minds is only one of many layers of possible ways of knowing a chair. Entirely different descriptions would come from a chemist or a carpenter.

As described earlier in this chapter, the framework developers posit one postautonomous stage, the Integrated stage E9 (I-6), for development beyond the Autonomous stage. To systematize the theory and eliminate the

acknowledged vagueness of stage E9, two stages were introduced to replace it: the Construct-aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9) and the Unitive stage 6 (C10). These were based equally on high-end SCT data and conceived of by extrapolating from the existing pattern of alternating differentiation and integration of the previous sequence in ego development theory.

In general, people at the postautonomous level tend to experience and view reality as an undifferentiated phenomenological continuum, as Unity consciousness, the creative Ground, “das All,” the Tao, or whatever other terms human beings have coined to express their intimation of the underlying unity. Some of the anticipated concerns of men and women at these two highest stages of ego development are (a) to deal with the fundamental paradoxes in human nature, (b) to grapple with one’s need to make order out of chaos by abstraction, classification and reification, © to face one’s unavoidable automatic mental habits, and (d) to realize that “biases” are universally embedded in the way we create meaning via language.

Since the proposed revisions of ego development theory and measurement at the postautonomous level are being tested, earlier ego stages below the Autonomous stage are not discussed.

Below, an overview of postconventional ego development is first given in order to provide a framework for the individual higher stages. A summary of the Autonomous stage and a more extensive description of the two stages following it in the scheme are then provided. The Autonomous stage is included in order to highlight how postautonomous stages differ from it.

The Autonomous, the Construct-Aware and the Unitive Stages

The Autonomous Stage: Stage 5 (E8)

Persons at the Autonomous stage realize that they may notice different conflicting aspects of themselves at different times but, unlike persons at stage $\frac{4}{5}$ (E7) who may despair about ever knowing who they really are, Autonomous individuals become able to “own” more of the contradictory parts of themselves. They can integrate previously compartmentalized sub-identities of the self into a coherent new whole or core identity. The crucial new element is generativity, the commitment to generate a meaningful life for oneself through self-determination, self-actualization, and self-definition—the hallmarks of an Autonomous person. A strong, integrated ego with mostly mature defenses is the basis for such commitments as well as the experience of being part of a meaningful community of similarly committed and principled people.

Autonomous individuals have much insight into themselves and into others. They therefore tend to believe that human beings can be known even across cultural boundaries because, according to their experience, underneath people are essentially alike. Because Autonomous persons have found a relative balance between inner and outer, body and mind, thought and feelings, they generally display high self-esteem on SCTs. They are convinced that higher development is better and closer to truth. They are therefore often invested in helping others to grow. Higher is believed to be better because the more differentiated and the more autonomous persons become, the more they can claim that they have a nondistorted (true) and realistic view of themselves and the world.

The Autonomous or Strategist Stage 5 (E8)

- **Life purpose:** Realm: Society, others with similar values, like-principled.
- **Time frame:** own “history, lifetime”
- **Cognition:** metasystematic operations, general systems view, internalized

- **Preoccupations:** own development, self-actualization, self-fulfillment; process, holistic view, body-mind integration (centaur)
- **Positive equilibration:** well-being, high self-esteem, autonomous, tolerant, insightful, growth-oriented; committed to universal principles
- **Truth:** can be approximated, higher stage is better since not all arguments and positions are of equal quality. Higher is thus more adequate to deal with complexity.

The Construct-Aware Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9)

Construct-aware adults start to wonder about the meaningfulness of more and more complex thought structures and integrations such as can be imagined with a fifth or nth person perspective. They start to realize the automatic nature of human map making in the representational domain and understand the logical loops and recursions that one can get into when trying to be as accurate as possible within the language-mediated realm. They are becoming aware of the absurdities to which unbridled complexity and logical arguments can lead. Some writers are wizards at creating such complex, nestled absurdities. An example from a collection of poems is given here to illustrate how self-perspective taking can be carried to the extreme.

Jack sees Jill can't see Jill can't see and that Jill can't see Jack can see and see he sees what Jill can't see she can't. Jack tries to get Jill to realize that there may be something she can't see she can't see. (p. 68)

Jill thinks Jill sees it and can see that Jack thinks Jill thinks she sees it but Jack thinks Jill can't see she can't. Jill thinks Jack can't see he can't see what he thinks he can, and that he can't see (therefore) that she sees what he thinks he sees but doesn't. (p. 82)

Adults at the Construct-aware stage realize that the "ego" has functioned both as an integrator for all stimuli (process of meaning making) and as a central point of reference (product of permanent self and object world). Once they realize this fundamental egocentricity, it may be felt as a constraint to further growth. Postautonomous persons often reject the self-centeredness and self-importance of the previous stage as they realize their relative personal insignificance in terms of the totality of human experience. They yearn to transcend their own ever-watchful, conscious egos. From past encounters they have come to know of a state of being (peak experience) which is fundamentally different from all previous ways of knowing. It seems to contain the answer to their yearnings.

During peak experiences one is no longer the center of one's world construction as at prior stages, but just a witness to oneself as an experiencing being. The paradox of being a rational, separate individual locus of consciousness while also feeling interconnected and part of a deeper, non-individualized, all-pervasive consciousness, is one of the existential conflicts of the Construct-aware stage. It exemplifies the tension of the polar opposites residing in the human breast that has been pondered over when exploring human nature.

Construct-aware adults sometimes struggle to find a balance between feeling their unique self-experience and concomitant sense of importance in life, and seeing themselves just as a minute speck in the eternal scheme of things. They are keenly aware of the paradox, but incapable of finding a position from which it can be synthesized. They live with great inner tensions. They may become preoccupied with notions of noncontrol, tolerance and acceptance as they find themselves trapped in desiring to be free from desire, and intolerant of intolerance. People at earlier stages do not register such intractable paradoxes or double binds and therefore are not expressing them on their SCTs.

At the Autonomous stage 5, individuals think of themselves as separate individuals with the mission to individuate or actualize themselves. They routinely think, feel, assess, label, coordinate and interpret experience

from what seems to be a stable, enduring core self. Individuals at the Construct-aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$ develop a more critical stance towards these automatic processes. They begin to understand that much of their mental habits are “programmed” and automatic. They realize, for instance, that concepts and their definitions are based on arbitrary conventions that make reality appear fixed and static in ways it never is.

Once the fluidity of experience is realized, the ego can no longer unconsciously organize coherent meaning from experience, but becomes aware of itself as an organizer and as a temporary, though necessary and useful construct. This stage is therefore sometimes referred to as Ego-aware as well as Construct-aware. Only after a stable, autonomous self-sense is present, can adults become fully aware of the human activity of meaning making through the arbitrary delineation, objectification and labeling of reality without losing their footing. Now concepts can be seen for what they are: as illusions—as effective but nevertheless arbitrary maps.

On the one hand, Construct-aware adults know empirically and intuitively that there is no clear subject/object separation, no either/or, yet they are stymied by trying to transcend this state of affairs. At the Autonomous stage 5 (E8), the identification with polar opposites is still sequential (on waking I am cross, but after tea I am more civil) or context-dependent (I seem to be patient with Peter, and driven at work). Now any dichotomies are integrated, and non-defensively appreciated as two sides of the same coin (I am both cross and civil at the same time), because each concept only exists through the other. Construct-aware individuals understand this to be true mostly on a rational level, however, and a desire to identify themselves generally with the positive side of the paradox can be heard in their SCTs.

As people become able to perceive and process more information from more and more diverse sources, they become increasingly aware of how complex all phenomena and relationships among them are. Starting at the Autonomous stage, people try to describe this experience through ever more complex matrices of abstract thought, reflection and interpretation. The sudden increase at the Construct-aware stage of responses that fit the higher complexity rule (Rule 2) for compound sentences is probably a result of this intensified search for accuracy and a defense against a budding sense of reality’s elusiveness.

At the Construct-aware stage, people show a heightened awareness that the mental habits of thinking, expecting, defending and fearing are problematic in themselves. While the Autonomous ego effectively, but unconsciously, coordinated its rich experience to support a balanced self-sense, the postautonomous ego is no longer sure that it is—and wants to be—in control. It sees itself trapped by automatic mental habits which, on a deeper level, it has found inadequate. How does this realization bear on one’s self-understanding?

The framework developers offer no examples or explanations for this kind of cognitive insight into linguistic conditioning and mental habits. At their stages E8 (I-5) and E9 (I-6) persons take for granted that proper reflection and rational analysis will eventually lead them to discover the underlying true self. To the contrary, it is argued that at the postautonomous level, rational thought is no longer accepted as a given, but becomes itself an object of intense questioning and exploration.

Some Construct-aware adults know that there are no unproblematic formulations for describing one’s self-experience. For one, trying to define oneself is felt to be self-limiting. Secondly, the previous sense of an enduring, underlying core self is now seen as each individual’s personal and temporary self-narrative or guiding fiction in need of constant revision. Such insights constitute a new level of cognitive differentiation beyond the Autonomous stage, which are not recognized as a possibility in the theory. At the Construct-aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9), the previous way of self-understanding is actively rejected and a new kind of self-knowledge sought.

At this juncture, people become entranced by the inner world and the workings of their minds and start to watch the intricate proceedings with great curiosity and absorption. Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9) persons don’t just think about thinking; that feat is possible earlier in development. Now they want to understand the mechanics of how they think and interpret reality while they are doing so. More importantly, they realize how impossible it is for them not

to think and analyze at every waking moment. Thus, the question of identity changes from a question with a possible answer to a question about such questioning itself. The question "who am I truly and fundamentally?" (the search for identity) changes to "what is the meaning behind the experience of continually yearning for a more accurate self-definition?" To some adults the paradox of trying to find out the nature of thought by using thought becomes obvious. Others realize (a) the historical process of creating a coherent self-identity through successive approximations and (b) the futility of ever getting at the source through further intensive self-analysis.

Ego-aware individuals intellectually recognize the pattern of forming self-identities by consecutive approximations driven by the underlying human need for certitude and stability. At the integration following the Construct-aware stage, the essential instability of self-representations is both experienced and acknowledged on a deeper level. The ability to abstain from automatically trying to explain everything characterizes self-understanding at the Unitive stage.

Postautonomous individuals may also wonder about their own hubris, their tendency for overvaluing the second half of the equation. They may become disheartened about the depth of their ego attachment and the seeming impossibility to go beyond it through effort and vigilance. Moreover, they realize that learning and knowing more about themselves and about reality in the rational mode does not lead to greater insight and wisdom for themselves. Nevertheless, because they know that striving for more self-knowledge is part of the human condition, they truly appreciate others' need to make sense of their lives within their own means. They therefore have a deeper tolerance for others' solutions to life without being blind to their obvious shortcomings or ignoring the profound differences among people as those at the Autonomous stage tend to do. Sometimes they express a sense of envy at the simplicity or innocence (not-knowing) of those less aware because the burden of knowledge and insight may weigh heavily on them.

Nonetheless, as Construct-aware adults they are capable of arriving at a positive equilibration within these fundamental conflicts: They fulfill their perceived or chosen destiny independently and courageously in full realization of their basic despair and aloneness. They may learn to embrace their fate (karma) whole-heartedly.

Since postautonomous adults are, by definition, already autonomous and familiar with the possibility of self-deception and defensive maneuvers, they do not need to deny the value of the concept of the self and of rational behavior once they recognize their limitations. Instead, human mental activity and language are acknowledged as critical tools for human adaptation and interaction, but no longer unexamined and taken for granted as they were earlier. In the representational realm, we humans always create paradoxes. By labeling, comparing, measuring, analyzing, and predicting, attention is inevitably taken away from what really is, to what we presume there is.

When individuals realize that their sense of a coherent self has been built on a partial, filtered perception of reality, they naturally desire to experience the underlying, unfiltered reality. They want to be liberated from the bondage of rational thought and the pseudo-grounding afforded by the representational self. They wish to be free from restricting self-definitions. They desire to see life afresh, without the preconceived ideas and mental behaviors that were supported by the social-linguistic environment and perfected through acculturation and lifelong habit. But they also become aware of how difficult it is to transcend one's unconscious and ingrained habits of the mind especially since a predisposition for mental behavior appears to be hardwired.

Construct-aware adults seem to realize that their self-identity is always and only a temporary construct. Hence, they become less invested in the idea of an individual ego that serves the unconscious function of creating a stable self-identity. They see through the mental habits of analyzing, comparing, measuring, and labeling as a means to reify and map experience. They understand the need for a different approach to knowing, one that responds to the immediate, unfiltered experience of what is. This new way of knowing requires an attitude of complete openness: One that is free from wishing for any particular outcome, and free from the automatic habits

of representational thought. Paradoxically, the very desire for freedom from any particular idea of how the world should be, keeps one fettered within that frame of reference. A genuine and radical openness—an openness that is completely detached from any desired outcome—is the essence of a different mode of experience. In short, the next step requires that one's yearning for a stable self-identity be let go and that one's accustomed way of growing, knowing and learning be fundamentally transformed.

The Unitive Stage 6 (C10)

The Unitive stage represents such an entirely new way of perceiving human existence and consciousness. The previous way of viewing reality almost exclusively through the lens of one's separate personhood is transformed. The new paradigm is multiperspectival and universal. Unitive individuals experience themselves and others as part of ongoing humanity, embedded in the creative ground, fulfilling their evolutionary, karmic or divine destiny depending on their orientation towards the ultimate.

An autonomous, well-integrated ego is the prerequisite for the development to unitive forms of self-cognition. It has been said concisely: "You have to be some-body before you can be no-body" (p.11).

Autonomous/Integrated individuals see themselves and are usually experienced by others as "somebody." They show high self-esteem. Construct-aware individuals become aware of the anthropocentric self-importance of the earlier stance. They may feel torn between high and low self-esteem. As this paradox has been expressed, "[Man] is nothing compared to infinity, and an infinity compared to nothingness." Construct-aware individuals feel competent and powerful when comparing their highly developed mental capacities and their ability to understand the complexities of life with those of most others. But, at peak moments, when they see through the illusion of the stable, independent self and the dysfunctional, unconscious aspects of rational behavior, they may feel annihilated, that is "like nothing." The drama is the more salient, because at the Construct-aware stage individuals have achieved a measure of ego-maturity that many outside observers would tend to admire. However, Construct-aware subjects know that they are fettered within deep-rooted mental habits that prevent them from developing the different kind of self-experience and way of knowing that they yearn for. Struggling valiantly to relinquish control, desire, and attachments, they inevitably fail. For the essence of the new way of understanding are effortlessness, non-control, non-attachment, and radical openness.

Unlike people at previous stages, the Unitive person no longer feels a need to reach after fact and reason. "Objective" self-knowledge no longer satisfies the need for constancy as it does for the highest stages in the theory. Instead, unfiltered experience or the perception of ongoing process, rhythm and flux provide inner stability and affirmation.

The self-sense of the Unitive stage is fluid, "undulating," based on people's trust in the intrinsic value and processes of life. For those at the Unitive stage, one can truly speak of a different, higher stage integration according to the axioms of cognitive-development theory. It also requires a new vocabulary to describe the experience, a feature that was considered as a possible sign of a distinctive stage (p. 11). At the unitive stage, a whole logical/psychological system (the rational, representational domain in human development) has become the content—an element or object in a higher-order, postrepresentational integration.

In Unitive self-experience, individuals see through the function of the ego to objectify and reify the self by defining (delimiting) it. They experience the self in its moment to moment transformation and therefore consciously decline to satisfy the implicit demand for objective self-identification. They understand that the striving for individual permanence is an impossible and unnecessary dream in the face of their experience of the continuous change in states of awareness.

They also see the ego with its striving for independence and for permanent, objective identity as just one way among others of how one is conscious of being. Thus, the representational self has been deconstructed and given way to a whole new mode of perception.

In contrast to the Construct-aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9), adults at the Unitive stage have replaced habitual, conscious mental processing by immersing themselves in the immediate, ongoing flow of experience. They can consistently maintain an awareness of their passing thoughts, feelings, behavior, perceptions and states of alertness. They

The Unitive Stage

At this level of development, individuals function primarily as non-judgmental witnesses to their own ongoing process of becoming. They observe the various roles they play in life as secondary to their core state of being.

This stage is characterized by a timeless, infinite frame of reference where the primary preoccupation is a non-controlling, conscious witnessing of the flux of experience and mental states. The positive equilibrium achieved here involves an accepting, unassuming presence—a full empathetic ability to be with whatever arises without ego-defending or interfering. Truth is experienced as immanent; it is the experiential reality of interconnectedness and non-separateness, where existence is understood as changing states of awareness within a timeless spirit.

Their openness to ongoing experience, combined with a conscious refusal to reify and codify that experience, makes this stage fundamentally and structurally different from all previous stages of ego development. Furthermore, people with this fluid, transcendent sense of self appear free from the anxiety accompanying the “not-knowing” that characterizes earlier stages. Rational awareness or consciousness is no longer perceived as a shackle, but simply as another phenomenon that moves between foreground and background depending on momentary focus.

By this stage, individuals no longer consciously attempt to overcome rational mental habits. Instead, they have relaxed enough to remain open to naked experience and mental activities as they unfold. The paradox of feeling both related to others and entirely separate and unique is now integrated. These feelings are experienced as changing perceptions and equal manifestations of being, without undue tension.

At this level of integration, adults can observe themselves and other beings simultaneously from multiple points of view, shifting focus effortlessly among various objects of attention and states of awareness. They appear to operate within a cosmic time frame that embraces all of history as well as the future. They feel deeply embedded in the processes of nature: birth, growth, death, joy, and pain are all viewed as natural occurrences—patterns of change within the flux of time.

Open Boundaries and Attunement

Persons at this stage transcend narrow ego-boundaries. They possess open boundaries and exhibit “attunement awareness,” which is an explicit immersion in the ongoing, indeterminate process of being. Truth is seen as immanent in the universe and can be apprehended through this ready, open-process stance, but it cannot be grasped by effort or purely rational means.

Crucially, from this unitive perspective, higher developmental stages are not viewed as “better” than lower ones. All stages are recognized as necessary parts of an interconnected reality and an overall evolutionary process where everything is exactly as it should be.

These thinkers also accept themselves “as is” in a non-controlling manner. Regardless of how great their achievements might be, they remain aware that these are merely a drop in the vast pool of ongoing human

endeavors. Furthermore, no matter how often they may fall short, they do not dwell on their failings but simply move on into the next moment.

The reality they relate to most profoundly is the undifferentiated phenomenological continuum, the creative ground, or unified consciousness. Every object, word, thought, and theory is recognized as a human construct—a way of separating out and creating boundaries where none inherently exist and where none need to exist.

The quest for meaning and connection is understood as an essential aspect of the human condition. Individuals at this stage feel interconnected with others because they understand and share that fundamental condition. Due to this unitive ability, they are highly tolerant and compassionate, feeling an affinity with all expressions of life. They respect the essence in others and therefore do not need them to be different than they are. They can appreciate the absolute perfection of the simplest organism and marvel at the beauty, power, and diversity manifest in creation.

For these individuals, peak experiences no longer possess an out-of-this-world quality; rather, they have become a habitual way of being and experiencing. The present is experienced as the space where past and future interpenetrate. Total openness releases them to be in tune with truth and beauty, allowing for visionary experiences—the ability to comprehend things holistically rather than solely through the filter of the rational mind.

Expressed differently, individuals at this stage can access reality directly and “immediately,” as well as through symbolic representation. The key difference is their constant awareness of both modes. While individuals at the preceding stage do experience unitive awareness spontaneously, they do so only sporadically or when deliberately invited through meditation or other consciousness-altering practices. Because of their ability to concentrate on their own internal processes, such “flow” states may happen more frequently than at conventional stages. While access to the numinous and altered states of consciousness is possible from all stages through various gateways, individuals at this unitive stage begin to sustain the perspective as a consistent home base.

The concepts of this stage can be refined to eventually become part of one unified field containing all possible supertheories, theories, paradigms, systems, and elements at whatever order of abstraction and complexity, both within and beyond human perception and imagination. This unified field is the source and end-state beyond which no further development or more all-encompassing field exists. It is the uniquely human naming process that pulls out (abstracts) from this unified field continuum that which is inherently not separable or distinct.

The assessment framework can only discover signs of a beginning unitive frame of mind; it cannot “measure” it in the same way it measures preunitive stages, because the framework itself is based on language. Individuals identified at this stage are likely to have inklings of this kind of knowing—an initial familiarity, rather than the most profound awareness possible. The path from early to fully realized unity is acknowledged as a long and arduous one.

Summary of Post-Autonomous Stages

The portraits of the hypothesized post-autonomous stages were drawn from theoretical considerations and empirical responses. The guiding questions for analyzing these responses were: What view of reality would prompt a person to make these statements? Given the knowledge of the evolving self and the autonomous stage, what would a transformation fulfilling strict higher-stage criteria look like? Is it possible for the pattern of increasing differentiation-integration in the rational domain to reach a logical limit beyond which further transformations no longer matter? What would a transformation of the entire constructivist developmental pattern look like?

The proposal to add two new stages—a construct-aware stage and a unitive stage—to the upper end of the developmental theory answers these questions. Self-identifications at these two stages are structurally different from previously established highest stages, and from each other. In each case, the dominant structure of awareness of the lower stage becomes an element in the next stage.

First, individuals become conscious of their own development. They can look back and describe the transformations of their self-understanding over time by becoming aware of the mechanics by which they construct meaning and reality. In a step beyond that, they become able to transcend the symbolic realm and immerse themselves in the fluid, non-evaluative mode of unfiltered experience.

With the postulation of the construct-aware stage as a missing link, the inner logic of the developmental theory can be mapped from the earliest stages to the unitive stage. The evolving perspective on the self demonstrates one possible underlying logic for this development. Additionally, increasing awareness of the power and dangers of language plays an important role in post-autonomous understanding. Only at this level do adults fully understand that every concept and theory is based on an arbitrary but useful anthropocentric segmentation of the underlying unified field or creative ground. Thus, describing individuals' growing awareness of the reification process in meaning-making offers an additional way to characterize developmental differences.

Each of the two new stages hierarchically integrates the previous way of meaning-making. The construct-aware stage represents the highest observed self-view in the rational, symbolically mediated realm of cognition. The unitive stage, with its fluid, deconstructed self-view, appears to sit at the threshold of the realm of post-symbolic, metaphysical, or transpersonal consciousness.

Overall Patterns in Development

Development can be described in terms of two patterns: the regularly expanding perspective on the self, and the continuous renegotiation of the balance between differentiation and integration at each successive stage.

An overall shift from increasing differentiation to increasing integration marks the transition from conventional to post-conventional stages. The first two tiers of development consist of a movement away from symbiotic union toward increasing differentiation and separation of the self. The post-conventional stages show an overall trend of assimilation and integration toward a new conscious embeddedness in, or union with, an ultimate reality.

During the early tiers, the budding self learns to know, define, and establish itself through ever-finer segmentations of the originally undifferentiated inner and outer world. The acquisition of the third-person perspective enables people to see themselves for the first time as fully separate persons; they become self-conscious. By extrapolation, they also become aware of others as selves with unique, separate personhood.

Simultaneously, the unconscious linguistic mechanism of reification—which automatically transforms learned concepts into objects existing in the world independently of the observer—is most pronounced at these middle stages. “Objectivity” (the denial of subject-object interrelationship) is a necessary condition for the abstract reasoning and scientific, rational analysis that becomes fully developed at the conscientious stage.

The pattern of increasing differentiation from newborn symbiosis to adult abstract, analytic, logical functioning may be superseded by a movement toward greater deobjectification and reassimilation at the post-conventional stages, culminating in the openness and self-transcendent awareness of the unitive stage.

The change from a linear paradigm (perspective) to a concept of field (vision) between the construct-aware and unitive stages is a striking characteristic of this conception of development. The pattern up to the construct-aware stage can be visualized as a growing branch structure, with the self at the center and layers of increasing ramifications at the periphery.

In general, human beings navigate life by searching for ever-more adequate representations of who they are and what the world looks like. The shift to the unitive stage represents a quantum leap in experience and outlook, discontinuous from the previous pattern of gradually reframing and expanding one's perspective. An unbounded neural network or a field that contains within itself many theories and models of possible definitions of self and reality better represents the multidirectional, multiperspectival, and non-egocentric mode of those functioning at the highest stage. The transformation from the linear expanding rational paradigm to the transcendent view can be likened to the change from an earthbound perspective to one from a spaceship in orbit, contemplating earth as a tiny part of the cosmic panorama.

Conclusion on Theoretical Structure

By introducing the construct of the “perspective on the self,” the developmental theory can be seen as akin to a hard structural theory. This perspective can be logically mapped and figuratively represented throughout the scale, fulfilling the structural demands for a stage theory: the stages follow a hierarchical sequence, and the same construct is used to show its transformation throughout the sequence.

Replacing the previously established highest stage with the construct-aware and unitive stages provides greater understanding of development at the post-autonomous level. The construct-aware stage serves as the missing link in a genetic epistemology covering the personal realm of experience. The sequence follows a pattern where each stage logically subsumes the previous stage as an element in its new meaning structure.

Increasing awareness of the constructed nature of reality characterizes the post-conventional stages. In its most ambitious expression, the theory postulates that development may lead naturally and logically to intimations of ego-transcendence.

However, there have been few signs in the assessment completions that people develop beyond a preliminary though explicit awareness and tolerance for uncensored perceptual input. The unitive stage cannot be defined more clearly from the gathered evidence, as the instrument is inadequate for distinguishing between the wisdom of mature integration and authentic transcendence as defined in theories of higher consciousness. Thus, the unitive stage is best considered a threshold position between the personal and transpersonal tiers.

Developing through the full range of stages and concomitant transformations may be regarded as an inevitable, legitimate, and non-meditative path through the gates of rationality onto the path of higher, post-symbolic consciousness. The radical openness to unfiltered witnessing, the absence of anxiety in the face of “not-knowing,” and a fluid self-understanding provide evidence for this hypothesis.

Several factors suggest the unitive stage is a gateway for a whole new cycle of possible stages. Empirically, adults at this stage have a beginning understanding of the transcendent realm. Awareness of the desire for unity, embeddedness, or permanence is sometimes experienced as a source of disequilibrium or subtle attachment. Other limitations are inherent in Western notions of time and space, and distinctions between waking reality and other consciousness states. Whether a person has fully transcended ordinary consciousness cannot be determined within the constraints of the sentence completion assessment; only through in-depth interviewing and physiological tests could one ascertain how consistently these individuals embody a witnessing awareness that remains alert throughout sleep and waking reality.

The developmental theory has no terminus; it is open to further revision and refinement. This view is consistent with the semantic argument that all thoughts and theories are constructs—useful maps for orientation, but alterable to fit new insights. However, the theory does have a terminus if one looks at the increasing perspective on the self and takes it to its logical conclusion: development ends at the point where the process becomes aware of its own need for self-perpetuation through self-representation—when it becomes transparent to itself.

Evidence makes it plausible that adults can become conscious of these inner processes and mental habits. Some reveal their recognition of the limits of the rational mode of understanding. Even though conscious of what is happening, they may or may not experience the letting go that is the prerequisite for a transcendent, immediate experience of what is.

Scoring Categories: Construct-Aware Stage

The scoring categories were developed from a database of over 1,900 protocols, isolating responses that showed greater complexity, demonstrated insights into the limitations of thought or self-perception, or evidenced awareness of the constructed nature of reality. The analysis involved asking what central theme or preoccupation was present, what beliefs were questioned, the complexity of sentence structure, and what kind of experience and view of reality would make the response possible.

There are four categories for the construct-aware stage.

Category 1: Complex Matrix

The first category is structural. Persons at this stage feel compelled to give responses that objectively mirror the complexity of their reality perception.

Description: Complex matrix of possibilities, reasons, feelings and contrasts, often rational, abstract, distanced in an effort to accurately describe the complexity of reality as perceived.

These completions are often several lines long, employing various stylistic devices and punctuation marks to reflect the perceived complex matrix of experience and handle nestled arguments.

Examples:

- “When I am with x woman—how can I generalize? Sometimes I am over-whelmed, sometimes bored; sometimes incredibly aware of a sexual electricity, often times primarily involved in business dealings; sometimes arguing, sometimes enjoying her company and sometimes wishing I were somewhere else.”
- “A good father—accepts the individuality and limitations of his children, recognizes that they too have problems, and manages to be sympathetic at a distance.”
- “A wife should—develop herself according to a fairly sure list of priorities which will enable her to prepare for her own future as one in which she will be respected and loved for the real good she has done in her life and the lives of those dependent on her.”
- “A woman should always—be as true to her principles & ideals as she can be if she is to avoid tremendous incongruence—of course she can’t do that, and there are no objective shoulds—we all do whatever we can/must.”

With increasing understanding, people feel a greater need to express themselves comprehensively, often writing in margins or using tiny script to convey their internal complexity.

Category 2: Immediacy and Conflict

Description: Immediacy, experiencing and expressing conflict, paradox and contradictions non-defensively, without needing to resolve them.

This category captures the ability to express the actual thoughts and feelings of a person as they occur. Unlike earlier stages that put problems into a good light, here conflict and contradictions are expressed directly without

apology or hindsight.

Examples:

- “Crime and delinquency could be halted—oh fuck it cant be halted; it can possibly be ameliorated, and the question seems trivial as I sit here in a country where terrorists are killing whole villages and leveling homes with bulldozers, and (...) army officers are possibly raping (...) women—anger and despair are responses to these realities, and to crime and delinquency too.”
- “When people are helpless—they particularly need our compassion but may well find precisely this the greatest burden of their helplessness.”
- “If my mother—could not be so frightened of the dark things in life (death, sorrow) she might feel less pain, or at least pain that she could get a handle on (or pain her daughter could watch her deal with more to her daughter’s comfort.)”

Category 3: Paradoxes and Thought Processes

Description: Aware of existential and psychological paradoxes, thinking about own thinking process and habits, aware of loops, recursions and logical paradoxes as inherent in any symbol system (not as instances) stream of consciousness, free associations, comments on various levels of own awareness or experienced lack thereof.

This category covers aspects of conscious awareness from states of mind to the inevitable incongruities discovered in reasoning. Although the limits of rational thought are experienced, the hope and need for explanations remains evident.

Examples:

- “At times he worried about—anything and at times he worried about nothing, and the worry was in his mind not in its object.”
- “I am—sensitive, honest, striving to always love others, reflective, sometimes to the point of being unable to get out of endless loops, striving to take responsibility for myself individually as well as trying to improve the world.”
- “I feel sorry—for all of those who cant understand or accept those different from themselves; and for myself when I must include myself in this group.”
- “A man should always—look for the larger implications than just his own point of view, particularly when he is most sure of the absolute rightness of that point of view.”
- “The thing I like about myself—my concern to be honest with myself, a claim that may itself be a delusion.”

Category 4: Constructed Nature of Reality

Description: Explicit awareness of perceptions, definitions, labeling, assumptions, frame of reference, paradigms and structure in meaning making. Aware of the constructed nature of self and reality.

People at this stage realize that labels and definitions are arbitrary conventions that make reality appear fixed and static. They recognize that words have neither a single nor an objective meaning, nor a separate definition independent of the relations of equivalence and contrast among them. They realize definitions are not fixed, are constructed over time, and exist only against the backdrop of other words.

Examples:

- “A man’s job—is traditionally been the role of ‘breadwinner’, but such simplistic labeling ignores an almost infinite number of possibilities, limited only by that man’s conceptual model of himself and his world.”
- “I feel sorry—(meaning remorseful) is often confused with ‘I feel sorry’ (meaning sympathy)—both important to feel, to speak, and to clarify.”
- “I am—a confusing complex of contradictions—both good/bad, assured/self-doubting, aloof/warm at the same time. There are no easy formulations to the way I am.”

When respondents mention how they construct meaning, they show awareness of the constructed nature of everyday reality. They can imagine multiple realities, not just multiple interpretations of the same reality.

Further Examples:

- “When they talked about sex, I—compared the way they viewed it (sex) with the way I viewed it. Did they see it as Beautiful? Normal? Base? It was a reflection on their view of the world.”
- “Rules are—artificial constructs that we sometimes use to explain (away) reality or to control (the flow of) events—and as our creation, they may thus exist, change, or not exist as we wish I need [sic].”
- “Education—means, to me, at this moment, an unfolding process of coming to make sense of the world.”

At this stage, polar opposites reside within the individual, and which side is focused on is understood as a matter of framing reality, not reality itself.

Example of framing:

- “The worst thing about being a woman—is accepting your position as a woman and an individual, but once found ceases to be the worst and becomes the best.”

The idea of underlying unity is understood on a rational level, and the evaluative mode prevails. The frustrated desire to explain reality while aware of the illusion of order explains the tension often found in these protocols.

Scoring Categories: Unitive Stage

There are five categories for the unitive stage. Once adults see through their need for logical coherence and explainable order as means to perpetuate their sense of self-permanence, a palpable affective shift occurs. Freedom from excessive categorizing allows a new freedom towards being and witnessing.

Category 1: Wide Range and Positive Affect

Description: Wide range of thought on human relationships (self not as center) often with unique, positive affect and gratitude.

This new way of knowing is characterized by a sense of admiration for the marvelous way life already is, at every moment, in all its expressions.

Examples:

- “Raising a family—has been and is a wonderful experience. The fact of growth, progress, evolution is right there before your eyes in a very intimate way.”
- “I feel sorry—for those who have not learned how to appreciate the good & bad experiences in life & look forward to each day of life with the feeling that it is wonderful to be alive.”

- “When I was younger—I didn’t know so much about this world, therefore I didn’t grieve about its problems so much and didn’t appreciate and wonder at its marvels.”
- “The thing I like about myself—is the way I have developed a keen sense of humor—gift of my mother—while simultaneously maintaining a philosophical perspective of my relative position in the universe, obviously a gift from my father.”
- “If my mother—has one abiding hope, it is that her children continue to grow toward grace and perfection.”

Category 2: Tolerance and Acceptance

Description: High tolerance, acceptance of self and world “as is,” openness to life, change, process, rhythm, self in flux.

This category speaks to the freedom from judging and the experience of life as flux, where nothing stays still.

Examples:

- “The thing I like about myself—... a very good question, one I’m trying to answer every day! My adaptability, my ability to accept (and even embrace) change.”
- “My conscience bothers me if—upon reflection, I find that I wasn’t open to all the possibilities of a situation—if I did not see the full reality, not feel the flow and therefore tried to control the outcome.”
- “Sometimes he wished that—he always remembered that life is always this wonderful even when the more underlying challenging events of his life temporarily shade the permanent foundation of happiness and growing fulfillment that are his reality.”
- “Raising a family—can break your heart and be wonderful too. One sometimes learns almost too late to accept and love and not try to change.”

Category 3: Universal Connectedness

Description: Universal connectedness; profound expression of self as part of larger world, humankind, history, ongoing creation.

This describes a sense of connection that goes beyond the personal realm (family, race, nation) and becomes trans-personal, embedded in historical times or a reality outside individual embodied existence.

Examples:

- “Women are lucky—they have always shaped children through the ages, and therefore the world.”
- “A man feels good when—he acts in a responsible, caring manner towards the world and himself, accepting good and bad as part of the whole.”
- “Being with other people—is awkward at times, pleasant at others, transcendent when we glimpse beyond the shifting surface to the depths of a common humanity.”

Category 4: Fundamental Reflections

Description: Fundamental feelings, thoughts and reflections about human existence, faith, life, death, joy and suffering, conscience and consciousness, mystery of being etc.

Responses here address themes at their most fundamental level of meaning, requiring cognitive complexity to articulate.

Examples:

- “Usually he felt that sex—had been removed from its relation to love and life, & used as a medium to promote sales, & he felt deeply resentful of it & its contribution to the dehumanization of people.”
- “Women are lucky because—as a broad generality, they seem to be more in touch with the realities and eternal verities of life.”
- “Being with other people—is the very substance of life itself. It may be invigorating, simulating, wearing or frustrating—but is rarely boring. The range of human behavior and interaction is endlessly intriguing.”
- “The worst thing about being a woman—is struggling to make our voice heard in the world—our values expressed + realized in action, our power felt and celebrated.”
- “The thing I like about myself—all of myself at different times. My ability to appreciate pain and see humanness in the world's destructiveness.”
- “When people are helpless—I'm ambivalent. I think maybe the idea of being helpless is one of the most horrifying to all of us on a fundamental level.”

Category 5: Unitive Thought and Metaphor

Description: Instance of unitive thought or metaphor: shifting focus effortlessly between near and far, mundane and sublime, temporal and eternal, serious and ridiculous, individuated and transcendent self as well as fluid transition between different states of consciousness.

This represents the ability to simultaneously perceive the particularity and universality of a fact—seeing it as here and now, yet also eternal. Persons at this stage can take multiple points of view and shift focus instantly.

Examples:

- “At times she worried about—the fate of the world—would this little blue marble, suspended in space, ultimately self-destruct?”
- “I am—someone and everyone, special and ordinary, one tiny part of vast cosmic system who has the potential to make a difference.”
- “When I am criticized—praise and blame are alike & indifferent to me - as a revelation of what I am, but valuable as a revelation of another's feeling.”
- “I am—at times a question mark, at times just a period, but many times an exciting exclamation mark.”
- “At times she worried about—money, health, the state of the world, and whether her son needed new shoes right now.”
- “Usually he felt that sex—was anything from a dirty game to a lofty expression of a beautiful relationship depending on who 'he' is.”

This category differs from the complex matrix category by exemplifying the ability to shift focus effortlessly among many perspectives, rather than offering panoramic surveys from a single vantage point.

Chapter 3: Postautonomous Ego Development: Its Nature

Section 1: Methods

Introduction

Having finished with the preliminaries, the focus now shifts to the actual studies that form the center of this research. So far, the need for conceptualizing postautonomous ego development differently from the framework developers has been established. Ego development theory was located within the broader context of adult lifespan development literature, especially constructivist developmental theories. Problems at the upper end of the original ego development theory and its measurement instrument were pointed out in some detail. As potential solutions to these problems, an alternative interpretation of ego development theory and a modification of the instrument at the high end were described. It was suggested that the amorphous Integrated stage might be profitably replaced by two stages, a Construct-aware stage and a Unitive stage. With the introduction of this refinement at the upper end of the scale, the goal was to systematize ego development theory and to clarify the psychologic behind the transformations of meaning making that seem to occur after the Autonomous stage.

Both the theoretical and the measuring problems with the original highest stage appear to have been carried over into the recent Second Edition of the manual. Thus, it seems fitting at this point to test the plausibility of the proposed alternative interpretation of high-end ego development empirically and ascertain the content validity of the suggested scoring categories for measuring postautonomous ego development. The reliability of the coding categories will be tested in the next chapter.

To organize the reporting of these several studies, they are divided into two chapters reflecting the different overall approaches. This chapter describes the qualitative approaches used to probe the content validity of the proposed high-end stage distinctions and scoring categories and then discusses the outcomes of the inquiry. The subsequent chapter maps the multiple quantitative ways in which measurement issues were explored and tested, and reports those results.

In the current chapter, the hypothesis that postconventional ego development is characterized by an increasing awareness of the constructed nature of reality as well as a concomitant, step-wise deconstruction of the assumptions underlying conventional views of reality and the self is first tested. To accomplish the first goal, selected sources in the postconventional and transpersonal psychology literature are analyzed. How these texts characterize postconventional development overall, and postautonomous development in particular, is investigated. Second, the specific agreement that exists between the characteristics given in these theories for postautonomous development and the thematic categories for identifying high-end ego stages introduced in the previous chapter is traced. In effect, the goal is to demonstrate the content validity of these themes by posing the following research questions and exploring each in a different way:

1. To what extent does the conception of postautonomous ego development seem consistent with the conceptions of mature development in the current literature about the mature self, particularly in postconventional constructivist and transpersonal psychology?
2. In addition, how well do the proposed scoring categories for identifying the two postautonomous ego stages concur with the specific attributes given for postautonomous development in the chosen literature?

To answer these questions, current notions about postconventional development will first be summarized. Next, the rationale and the resulting criteria by which the theories for the qualitative analysis were chosen will be specified. Section three of this chapter contains the summaries of the selected theories addressing aspects relevant to the inquiry into the overall conceptualization of postautonomous development and discusses their significance. Fourth, to answer the second question, these sources are analyzed for the presence of the specific content themes that are used in the proposed scoring categories for postautonomous sentence completions. Finally, the result of this second inquiry will be reported and its implications discussed.

General Proposed Features of Postconventional Ego Development

It may be helpful here to recall the two different dynamics that can account for the trends observed at the postconventional tier. Postconventional development can be looked at from two seemingly contradictory perspectives. On one hand, postconventional development continues the pattern of alternating stages of differentiation and integration toward greater complexity that can accommodate the ever-expanding experiential universe of the self. Thus, one's knowledge of reality becomes broader, deeper, and more adequate as fewer and fewer of the discrepant stimuli need to be fended off in order to preserve the integrity of the current meaning system. Increasing complexity and differentiation are the hallmark of this dynamic. On the other hand, postconventional development can be explained as a stepwise deconstruction of the previously unconsciously constructed permanent object world. It is suggested that these two lenses are complementary and necessary for describing different aspects of postconventional development.

There is another important difference between the two trends. While the layers of cognitive abstraction can be logically extended to the *n*th degree or *ad infinitum* (or *ad absurdum*), there is no additional benefit in meaning beyond a certain point as cognitive complexity alone does not account for deeper insight into the human condition. As one researcher remarked:

Abstractions are already so far removed from actions in the real world that further developmental levels might well be not merely useless, but maladaptive.

On the other hand, the second dynamic looks at meaning making itself from a metaperspective and thus it can account for the awakening of wisdom in relation to cognitive complexity.

Increasing Cognitive Complexity

In some form or other, all postconventional theories posit a systems stage or a dialectical form of thought. Unlike formal operations, which treat parts of systems as separate, the systems approach takes into account the interdependence of parts within a system and the interdependence between a system and its context. There is also a branch of science called "systems theory" which deals with phenomena from a systems perspective. However, a distinction is made between systems theory and a systems view because the latter considers aspects of meaning in addition to the structure and mechanics of complex interacting systems.

A systems view allows people to recognize their own cultural conditioning and participation in interpreting reality. Things mean what they do because of our experience with them in given personal, cultural, and historical contexts. In a systems view, researchers cannot be "objective," but are always participants in what is observed. Moreover, the whole system is considered to be greater than the sum of its component parts. In human affairs, systems thinkers look at relationships rather than isolated individuals and aim for plausible interpretations rather than objective truth and certainty. They do not merely rely on the ever-increasing arsenal of conventional scientific methods, but describe and investigate the means by which they arrive at their hypotheses (heuristics). There are two main types of systems theories. Whereas theories that take a dialectical approach seem to focus

more on the processes by which knowledge is being transformed and acquired, theories that postulate a systems view take the interdependence of variables as a starting point and focus on the nature and the outcome of the proposed transformations.

Most theories with a systems view concentrate on the first postconventional level. They postulate that the self is not an isolated entity but part of a system. It is socially constructed and in a dynamic relationship to its contexts. In the fields of sociology and anthropology, a systems view is now commonly seen as more adequate in describing the self than is looking at separate individuals. The narrative focus in literature and therapy also stresses a self-conception that is constantly reconstructed in language acts and social interactions. One researcher makes a powerful argument against the notion that we can ever gain a non-distorted, non-fictionalized view of ourselves. He points to the continuing tension between the modern tenets of a knowable, objective reality and the subjective enterprise of human meaning making as a fundamental problem of our times.

In the more organismic, interdependent notions of the self, boundaries are less rigidly drawn between subject and object. Although most adult developmental theories allow for more dialectical, context-sensitive interpretations of reality in adulthood, they still consider the search for a stable, unified self-identity as the goal of individuation, one that can integrate many of the subtler tensions and inconsistencies that become apparent with greater cognitive complexity. As pointed out before, the framework developers, especially, see the attainment of an objective, integrated identity as the goal of development. They equate their hypothesized highest stage vaguely with a set of characteristics introduced to describe self-actualizing persons.

Stepwise Deconstruction of Permanent Self-Identity (Object Permanence)

Evidence from the sentence completion tests indicates that for some adults the search for an integrated, enduring self-identity is superseded by a more immediate, fluid and process-oriented self-view. It seems that the systemic view can give way to a completely flexible, non-reified notion of self in a rare transformation beyond the systems view of reality. In one interpretation of the fifth order of consciousness, for instance, adults at the interindividual stage are described as having such a process-oriented experience of the self. Few additional Western constructivist developmental psychologists have tried to conceptualize the frame of mind of individuals who go beyond a systems view. This broader epistemology allows people to see through their tendency to reify reality and the self and to feel most alive and genuine in an indeterminate process of witnessing, and ultimately of being.

In contrast, transpersonal psychology has long advocated a dereified, dematerialized view of reality as the goal of development. Several researchers have all put forth theories that the permanent self is an illusion. Both Buddhism and Vedic schools of human development argue that the separate, independent ego can be transcended in favor of an immediate, direct experience of a higher Self.

Summary

It is suggested here that describing postconventional development in terms of a stepwise deconstruction of the constructed aspects of our symbolically mediated views of reality leads to a more comprehensive understanding of mature development than looking at increasing structural complexity only. In this view, postconventional development outlines the disidentification from the culturally supported fiction of the separation between knower and known. It has been argued elsewhere that seeing through one's cultural and linguistic conditioning is a logical outcome of paying attention to the processes of meaning making that can lead one closer and closer to the transcendent realm of intuitive, non-representational ways of knowing.

Becoming aware of how we automatically acquire our different cultural programs for interpreting reality seems to be a first step towards mature insight. Beyond that, becoming aware of how cultures, in general, depend on

natural language to create their respective realities seems to be an additional and important step towards the eventual transcendence of the symbolic mode of reality perception.

At least in theory, the decoupling from one's automatic and exclusive symbolic mediation of experience allows one to reconnect with the underlying reality in a fuller and more direct way. This different way of apperception has been explored in the field of transpersonal developmental psychology. A common theme among transpersonalists who try to describe the metarational realm of higher stages of consciousness is the paradox of having to communicate the "ineffable" of the subtlest inner experiences through the filter of language.

Choosing Relevant Theories

Having given a general background for how postconventional adult development is generally approached, the criteria by which the developmental literature for this research was chosen are now stipulated. Choosing a small number of representative theories that were likely to inform the inquiry seemed reasonable since looking in the most likely places for confirmation or disconfirmation of one's ideas or hypotheses is more efficient and effective. If one wants to catch a rare tropical fish, it is best to start in the tropics in an area where similar fish have already been caught. Thus, the review is not meant to be comprehensive and may pass over a number of theorists or theories that also speak to the questions.

As argued earlier, only a constructivist developmental approach is likely to view human development in terms of a stage-like progression in which each stage supercedes its predecessors and subsumes the former way of generating coherent meaning into a larger, more comprehensive perspective. Thus, it is to these theories one must turn if one is interested in exploring meaning making in its most complex manifestations.

Constructivist developmental theory holds that development is unidirectional. Persons progress from lower to higher without skipping any stages. Each stage builds on the foundation of the prior stage and becomes the basis for the next transformation. The stages are not just unidirectional, they are also hierarchical as each stage subsumes earlier development under its new, overarching system. In addition, if we look at how many adults reside at each of these stages regardless of the number of stages postulated, the distributions tend to be bell-like. There are considerably more individuals in the middle stages than at either of the extremes. Based on numbers collected from many research projects, most adults (about 80%) reside in the second tier of development whereas no more than 10% to 15% are estimated to inhabit the third tier. Neither the Subject-Object Instrument nor the sentence completion test, however, can distinguish between very advanced self-development in the personal realm and achievement of ego-transcendent insights. Since the stages develop in sequence and take time to traverse, it is assumed that the most mature stages are rarely reached before mid- or late adulthood—if at all.

It matters whether one focuses on development within the personal realm (the first three tiers of development) or whether one conceives of development beyond the personal realm (tier four). In the first case, one is satisfied if one can formulate a reasonable trajectory for the development from the infant's undifferentiated being to the insights articulated in the voices of society's most thoughtful and mature representatives. In the second case, only the postulation of an ultimate non-personal Self seems to do justice to the depth of realization possible. The "wisdom of the ego" seems a mere shadow on the wall compared to the wisdom or the witnessing capacity of the transpersonal Self. Precisely because such transpersonal theories see the personal realm itself as a less developed form of knowing than the transcendent perspective, they have likely articulated the limits of such lesser understanding more clearly than those who cannot stand outside of it.

Thus, theories which posit no development beyond the second tier in adulthood or theories that are based on college age students are unlikely to contain material for this inquiry. Theories that restrict their postconventional development to a systems view are probably also unproductive. One theory addressing women's ways of knowing is an example of this type of theory. It addresses the need of knowers to understand their own

contribution to interpreting reality, but it does not question the underlying assumptions of the meaning-making process itself.

Because the interest was in broad differences in the ways people organize their understanding of life, domain-specific theories were also omitted. This includes theories of moral development in spite of their groundbreaking influence in shaping the field of postconventional psychology and their postulation of stages of “postprincipled” moral reasoning.

Ego development is a personality theory that encompasses many of the domains that others have studied separately. Thus, the first general selection criterion—the construct of self or ego as an overarching principle in development (or non-domain specificity)—was chosen for optimal comparability with the original ego development theory.

The second criterion—postautonomous content—excludes all those theories in the field of postconventional development which focus on describing either the transition from conventional to postconventional development or those who are dealing with systems-type meaning making only. Some material that came from theories about human growth that are not strictly stage theories, such as schemas of dialectical thinking, was also included. Nonetheless, these were chosen because they show sensitivity to the questions raised. The third criterion is a focus on meaning rather than reasoning alone, although level of awareness regarding one’s reasoning habits can be in the service of deeper understanding.

To answer question one, it was first examined whether the overall hypothesis about the postconventional tier of ego development is supported by other researchers writing about stages of advanced human development. In particular, it was verified whether others observe that people become increasingly aware of the constructed nature of reality and as a result start to question and deconstruct their formerly held assumptions about the permanent object world and the construct of an enduring self. The theories of a group of constructivist developmental researchers were analyzed. How each theorist conceptualizes postconventional development overall and describes his/her highest stages was examined. In particular, it was noted what themes and forms of reasoning they believe occur after systems thinking has been incorporated.

Because psychologies spanning all four tiers of development are more likely to have a well-defined perspective on the postautonomous segment of the developmental continuum, representatives from two different transpersonal perspectives were also turned to. The goal was to see how they depict mature personal development and to what degree the concern with the illusion of the constructed nature of reality is shared between them. Therefore, how these theories define self development at the high-end of the third tier in the personal realm and to what extent the categories matched their accounts of the nature of advanced ego development was analyzed.

Although spiritual or ego-transcendent aspects of development figure prominently in these transpersonal theories, ego-transcendent stages per se were not looked at because they are outside the scope of this thesis. Thus the basic strategy was to establish the content validity of the postautonomous stage distinctions and categories by anchoring them in the above literature on the mature self and by evaluating to what extent the way of conceiving of postconventional ego development differently from the framework developers is akin to other current views of mature development in both constructivist developmental and transpersonal psychology.

A conceptualization of postconventional ego development as a deconstruction of the formerly constructed permanent self is problematic if there is little consensus among the selected authors as to what the most mature self-views in the personal realm look like. The notions about postautonomous development can be readily proven false if there is evidence that individuals at earlier ego stages are capable of making the kinds of distinctions at the required level of complexity that, it is suggested, are reserved for the most advanced meaning makers.

In summary, whether the notions of postautonomous ego development are plausible will be explored by concentrating on theories that (1) posit an ego or self as a “general” organizing principle across domains, (2) investigate reality conceptions beyond the general systems stage, or show signs of postautonomous concerns, and (3) focus on understanding rather than reasoning alone.

Section 2: Review of Theories with Postautonomous Elements

Postconventional Theories

The following is a selective and more detailed review of the authors whose writings were examined for both their overall view of postconventional development as well as for specific themes and signs that characterize possible postautonomous development. Each of these theories was evaluated along the following parameters. First, how does it parse postconventional development into stages, what is its overall view of postconventional development and what main distinctions does it make to assess postconventionality? Second, how much is it itself aware of the distance between the level of formal abstraction in which the theory is expressed and the underlying reality it attempts to describe?

To highlight the distinction made earlier between postconventional and postformal models, the review will begin with a general model of hierarchical complexity. While the postconventional models explore issues of epistemology and meaning, this model focuses on structural aspects of higher cognition.

(1) The Metasystematic and the Crossparadigmatic Stages in the General Model of Hierarchical Complexity

In 1984, a general stage model of development was first introduced. It was intended to unify the budding field of postformal psychology by providing a rigorous theoretical scaffold for the many then emerging strands of postformal (neo-Piagetian) adult development theory. Although the general stage model has not gained the discipline-wide acceptance that was hoped for, it does serve as a guidepost for other theories in terms of structural rigor.

This model is the quintessential postformal model since it describes logical operations and relies on mathematics to describe its findings. Although not a theory of the development of the self, it is non-domain specific, it posits two stages beyond a systems view, and it covers some postautonomous concerns. Even though its focus is on reasoning rather than meaning, it is included here because of its claim of being a metatheory, superordinate to all others in the postconventional field.

By setting up clearly delineated, hierarchically ordered problems or tasks, the model was operationalized and systematized to be internally consistent and follow the same logic of differentiation across the entire developmental sequence. People are rated to be at the highest stage at which they can successfully solve stage-specific cognitive tasks. The relationships among the stages are expressed in formal mathematical terms. Thus, the output of the processes of one stage become the input for the processes of the next stage in a much more precise and systematic way than is possible in more qualitative theories.

The current model and its scoring system claim to be a universal system that can score anything since it can be applied to “almost any text or discourse in any domain.” According to the developers, the stage sequence is grounded in the hierarchical complexity criteria of mathematical models, information science (signal detection theory), and analytical behaviorism. “Hierarchical complexity” refers to the number of recursions that the coordinating actions must perform on a set of primary elements in a task. The tasks are uniquely defined for each stage and follow each other in a strictly sequential order. A statistical method is used to assess the

coherence of responses at any order of complexity and the degree to which transitions between orders of complexity appear to be stage-like or discontinuous.

Overall, the model postulates four stages beyond formal operations. Two represent systems views of reality (systematic; metasystematic) and two represent postsystems views (paradigmatic; crossparadigmatic).

The systematic stage allows one to see and describe the properties and transformation within a system; the metasystematic stage deals with relating whole systems to each other, culminating in the formulation of a metasystem or framework for coordinating several systems. The crossparadigmatic stage, finally, coordinates or unifies whole paradigms or frameworks of knowledge into a superordinate field. The latter two take the forms of “super-metasystems and fields.”

Examples given for the highest two stages are taken from the history of science. The scoring system rates those scientists highest who created new fields of inquiry by crossing previously separate scientific paradigms into new wholes. One scientist is given as an example—along with others—as a representative of the crossparadigmatic stage. According to the researchers, this scientist belongs to the crossparadigmatic group because he created the new field of the “limits of knowing” by integrating mathematics and epistemology.

The disconnect between theories of the growth of cognitive-logical sophistication and theories concerned with the individual's living understanding of reality as described by ego development theory, is evident here. One wonders how these personalities would have fared on a sentence completion test or in a subject/object interview. In light of what is known about these scientists' lives from the many biographies about them, it is doubtful they were particularly insightful about reality, other people, and their own inner workings. It is clear that crossparadigmatic achievement in science does not necessarily translate into mature ego development.

Unless the developers can show that their structural analysis can pick up the subtleties of a deconstructed, fluid view of reality in which the rational, symbol-mediated realm is considered a useful subset, but not the end-all of making sense of things, they can hardly claim their system can be applied to “almost any text or discourse in any domain.” At the very least, one would want the exceptions in “almost” more clearly spelled out.

If we are interested in what it means to be a human being, we want to be able to account for how different people make sense of experience on a lived level. The quality of insight cannot be assessed by an analytical model like this one. If we want to specify and assess the formal properties and the logical consistency of stage theories, then this model fulfills a useful role.

This model was introduced here for two reasons. On the surface, it fits the selection criteria. It was also intended to emphasize one of the difficulties in choosing theories. Despite its claims that it can rate anything, the scoring system is unlikely to do justice to the kind of thought that characterizes the Unitive stage. The model is reminiscent of concerns of people at the Construct-aware stage because it favors complexity and aims at rigor and logical consistency. It is unlike Construct-aware thinking, however, because it remains unaware of its own unquestioned attitude towards the means by which it makes its arguments. It never inquires into the adequacy of formal mathematical notation and statistical analysis as means to describe aspects of experience. They are simply taken for granted. Map and territory are considered commensurate. Because the model does not question the limits of the means by which it makes its claims, it cannot serve for the second part of this chapter which seeks to validate the thematic content of the postautonomous categories in theories with postautonomous content.

Thus, the focus turns next to the framework developers whose theory is concerned with meaning and therefore offers an opportunity to clarify some of the contrasts.

(2) The Autonomous and the Integrated Ego Stages in Ego Development Theory

The original ego development theory and its measuring instrument, the sentence completion test, have already been introduced in abundant detail. To repeat, the ego development theory fulfills the criteria stipulated earlier for relevance to this thesis. Ego development is a constructivist developmental stage theory. It is non-domain specific because it posits the multifaceted construct of ego as the central processing and synthesizing faculty. It focuses on the changing meaning at each subsequent stage, and it includes a stage beyond the Autonomous, the Integrated stage. Thus, it is really postautonomous, reaching into the second level of the third tier of development.

Ego development theory seems to resonate with many people, especially its description of the phenomenon of the search for identity and the many changing forms it takes. It has a quality of verisimilitude or closeness to life which a theory like the general model of hierarchical complexity lacks though it may be more rigorously defined and theoretically coherent.

The current conception of the final stage has been analyzed in much detail. According to the framework developers' own assessment, it is ill-defined, and there is no consensus as how to rate it even among experienced raters. As a consequence, there are very few examples given for this stage and several of these are simply combinations of content and reasoning that is available at earlier stages. Nonetheless, some of the examples given in the manuals do fit the criteria for a higher stage rating. To make this point, several concrete examples from the manuals were included in the previous section in which the scoring categories were discussed. Below, the portions of the theoretical characterization of the Integrated stage that call for more attention according to the proposed categories are indicated with italics:

Characteristics of Autonomous responses that are prominent at the Integrated stage, usually in combination, are existential humor and a feeling for paradox, respect for others' autonomy, search for self-fulfillment, value for justice and idealism, opposition to prejudice, coping with inner conflict, reconciliation of role conflicts, appreciation of sex in context of mutuality, and *(1) reconciliation to one's destiny*. Some form of conceptual complexity is always present, whether in terms of conflict, contradiction, alternative construction of situations, or subtler complexities (such as the idea of potential for development or of *(2) intolerance of prejudice*). Responses at this level are often vivid, touching, or poetic. Many unite the specific and the general, and *(3) concern for inner life (presented as differentiated self-perceptions)* and outer life (usually relationships with others). Generally, responses combine two or more thoughts that would separately be rated at the Autonomous stage.

(1) Only the themes of "reconciliation to one's destiny," and the ability to "unite the specific and the general" are part of the categories for the Unitive stage which were independently derived from a different data set than the Integrated stage features.

(2) Although, at first glance, the theme of "intolerance of prejudice" seems to fit a construct-aware category which identifies the awareness of inevitable paradox as a sign of postautonomous development, there is no sign that the framework developers are actually aware of the internal contradiction that a recognition of one's intolerance for intolerance (prejudice against prejudice) generates as the following example for the Integrated stage indicates:

I feel sorry—for the disadvantaged, particularly the negro to the point I am outraged and intolerant of prejudiced people.

It seems that they simply mean that expressing one's distaste for prejudice can be a sign of Integrated development although issues of social justice begin to appear at the conventional stages.

(3) "Concern for inner life (presented as differentiated self-perceptions)" could be a salient indicator if it was made clear in which way this concern is addressed differently at the Autonomous and the Integrated stages. The examples given in the new edition do not allow such distinctions. The example above about a person's outrage at inequities does not show any deeper or additional self-perception than is possible at the Autonomous stage. The same is true of the next case:

The thing I like about myself is—that I let my "child" out; that I don't waste time judging the individuals I meet; and that I think independently and creatively.

This kind of relishing of one's independence from conventionality is symptomatic of the Individualistic stage. However, does it show concern for inner life and differentiated self-perception? The rush to non-judgment "I don't waste time" seems to describe a person who is not very aware of her own tendencies. Seeing oneself as a system of "fixed" subpersonalities (child, parent, etc.) in the vein of transactional analysis occurs as early as the Conscientious level. An integrated rating seems unjustifiable on psychological grounds. Based on the complexity rule, an Autonomous rating would be considered at best.

The only unique characteristic given for the Integrated stage is "the problem of identity." It was initially assumed that this meant that postautonomous individuals actually questioned their preoccupation with identity because of the phrasing. However, there is no evidence in the sentence completions that any other definition of self was ever considered than that of a durable category or objective self-identity. "The problem of identity," therefore, merely refers to a heightened awareness that one has not, as of yet, gained that desired, mature, balanced, non-defensive self-identification one envisions as the Integrated example below demonstrates:

My mother and I—get along, but I need to get away to develop myself. I praise her because she is a woman, and a person. I am a person but not yet a woman.

This young woman has a clear idea what it means for her to be a woman. She will presumably recognize and be satisfied when she reaches that goal. Yet evidence from the sentence completion test attests that individuals can develop a perspective on their own meaning making that allows them to realize that self and reality are being continuously reconstructed in an "illusive" effort to attain an objective, coherent "unified" self-view.

As already mentioned, the original theory cannot account for people who become interested in a dynamic, fluid self-experience. Nor can it explain responses that show that an individual is attracted to modes of reasoning that draw energy and insight from the very irreconcilability of polarities and ambiguities. Such themes do appear on sentence completion test protocols and seem to be recognized as features of advanced development in other theories.

It is possible that the kind of postautonomous responses that were observed did not appear in any of the samples from which the original ego development theory and the instrument were constructed because of their rarity. Lack of data at the extremes is an inherent source of error for empirically-driven developmental theories, which can only be as comprehensive as their data. In addition, the researchers' own limited awareness (rater bias) is addressed as another possible reason for not recognizing existing nuances and cognitive differentiations:

To the extent that ego development is a hierarchical variable, the difficulty we have of understanding, describing and judging the highest stage is plausible. In principle, a person does not fully understand the

relevant thinking of people much above his or her own.

Whatever the reasons, and they are likely multiple, the original ego development theory fails to make coherent distinctions beyond the Autonomous stage. The Integrated stage does not constitute a qualitative transformation of earlier forms of meaning making. For the most part, the rationale given for including a response at the Integrated stage is unclear or unconvincing. In the previous section, the few cases in which examples for the Integrated stage do seem to capture criteria that parallel the post-autonomous distinctions were noted.

(3) Dialectical Thinking as a Metasystematic Form of Cognitive Organization

Although a full-scale development theory is not offered, a complex matrix of what are called schemata or movements in thought was devised to describe mature ways of reasoning. According to this framework, “the dialectical schemata framework” is “a cognitive psychological conception of dialectical thinking.”

The schemas range from the end of tier two (formal operations) through most of tier three although no endpoint is given. It is argued that dialectical thought as a whole, especially the meta-formal aspects of it, constitutes a metasystematic form of understanding reality since it is concerned with the relationships among variables. The schemata are non-domain specific and describe how people differ in their reasoning about a broad topic. However, meaning making is central to this intellectual enterprise:

Dialectical thinking can be understood as efforts at comprehension relying on application of an implicit model of dialectic, developmental transformation via constitutive and interactive relationships, to the phenomenal world.

Rather than proposing a stage sequence, dialectical thought is organized into 24 general moves-in-thought or cognitive schemata. These schemata are drawn from recorded interviews with college age students and their professors. They thus include the voices of mature adults. The schemata are classified into motion-oriented, form-oriented, relationship-oriented ones, plus a higher-order group that integrates the other three by “describing relationships among forms, and transformations through forms, as well as the process of form construction.”

These schemas address eight out of the nine scoring criteria or postautonomous concerns as defined. Infinite regress in logical arguments and awareness of the constructed nature of knowledge are two of the most common issues that came up in the interviews.

Dialectical thought is differentiated from other types of postformal thought by focusing on the organizing principle or “process by which structured wholes, forms, or systems, evolve and change.” Dialectic is defined as a transformation (= movement through forms) in which the relationship between the notion of form and the notion of movement are central, that is the relationship itself “has a role in making the parties what they are.” This is illustrated with the definition of the concept ‘road’: “If no vehicles traveled on the road, it would not be a road. (...) Thus, its being a road depends on its particular relationship to vehicles.”

This is a fine example of the kind of awareness emerging at the Construct-aware stage. It shows an understanding that concepts are interrelated, depending on each other for their existence and focuses specifically on the complex problem of definitions.

The following are some of the schemas that address the issues of greater complexity and of the constructed nature of reality. Both schema 4 and schema 15, for instance, deal with definitions. They make explicit that the meaning of any assertion, concept or object of reflection depends on all of the things to which the assertion, concept, or the object is related to and differentiated against (including their background and negations).

Schema 7 points out problems with objectifying or reification, that is, of treating as separate and static, entities that are part of interrelated, dynamic processes. It speaks to our tendency to see named objects as external givens rather than as constructs. It is further suggested that people who are aware of this pattern can avoid objectification and reification by:

using language in such a way that one is likely to maintain awareness of motion, process, or constitutive relations in general, and of the processes of human activity and mental abstraction or construction in particular. This is difficult in the English language, since the use of the nominative case, which is required by the grammar, carries connotations which often result in all of the effects described ... above. (...) One can often detect an effort to avoid hypostatization by the awkwardness of the language entailed.

Schema 6 deals with the practical, actively-constructed nature of knowledge and its function as a map of “uncharted complexity” and thus clearly speaks to the map-territory issue. It is classified as a motion-oriented schema because people can become self-consciously aware of how thinking about their thinking influences the course of their thinking. Thus, thought can become “aware of the possibilities for change or motion within itself.”

Among the meta-formal schemata, 16, 17, 18 and 23 refer to contradiction and paradox as means to transforming (transcending) established mindsets by challenging the person conscious of them to a “developmental resolution as a transformation to greater complexity.” The basic rhythm of thesis-antithesis-synthesis of schema 1 is, of course, the same whether applied to single instances or to whole systems of thought, which is the case for the meta-formal schemata.

Unlike the framework developers, it is realized that:

(...) disequilibrium is valued over any particular form of equilibrium, since it provides a source of transformation which is capable of freeing one from the limits with which any particular form of equilibrium is viewed as necessarily associated.

This preference for uncertainty reflects the attitude of the person who is conscious of the paradox of living in language. The very awareness of the inherent tension points beyond it. Thus living in paradox feels freeing and vital compared to any kind of closure which is seen as limiting and deadly by the construct-aware person.

Though all dialectic schemata have been located in the general realm of postformal thought, the hunch is that they could be shown to be typical of several different stages, some emerging as byproducts of formal operations, others becoming salient only towards the end of differentiation in the postformal realm. In summary, some schemata described seem to parallel the criteria found to characterize postautonomous protocols. Overall, the schemas become more complex with higher list numbers. At the same time, dialectical thinking includes a deconstruction of formerly held static and rigid understandings of events, and reinterprets them as context-dependent, interactive, multiply determined. Dialectical analyses “draw attention to the limits of the context in which formal analyses are applicable.”

In this formulation, the general model of hierarchical complexity would not be dialectical because it does not draw attention to the limits of the context in which its analyses are applicable. Becoming aware of the limits of the means by which one formerly made sense of experience is a feature of postautonomous psychological differentiation. In addition, empirical evidence showed that professors tended to use dialectical schemas in general more often than their students do. They also employed more of the more advanced schemas, while graduate students, in turn, used more dialectal schemas than their undergraduate peers. Thus, as predicted, the more advanced schemata (i.e. those most in line with postautonomous insights) seem to occur with greater life experience and at an older age. They show not only greater cognitive complexity, they also indicate an

increasing awareness of the constructed nature of reality, and of our tendency to reify what is in flux. Thus, these observations support the contention that the mental moves that created earlier truths are deconstructed at later stages of development.

(4) The Interindividual Stage

The theory of the evolving self is probably the one theory most similar to the original ego development theory overall, in that the self as a meaning maker is accompanied from its beginnings to its most mature expressions. It postulates that the “subject-object relationship” is the “general underlying principle... which organizes” how one makes sense of cognitive, affective, interpersonal and intrapersonal experience differently at each of the five epistemological positions described. Unlike the original theory, however, there is much more willingness to account for and describe not only the stages themselves, but to portray convincingly how people develop from one stage to the next. The emphasis on the victory of each stage over the previous way of meaning making, and the inevitable price for development that must be paid, gives the works of the two theories a very different feel.

This theory is more psychologically nuanced and comprehensive than the original ego development theory for the following reasons: It addresses both the ontological question of what it means to exist in this world and the epistemological question of how we make sense of our existence. It explains how we construct meaning by embracing ever more of our external and internal experience. It empathetically portrays the changes in positive experience, motivating concerns, and difficulties at different stages while it explains these changes using the subject-object transformation as the underlying cognitive mechanism. For the latter, a descriptive itinerary is provided of how meaning evolves “according to regular principles of stability and change” or “in which the output of the processes of one stage become the input for the processes of the next stage.” Humans seem to evolve via a continuous dialectic between related opposites of all kinds: between self and other, between preservation and expansion, differentiation and integration, individuation and participation towards greater overall flexibility and coherence between the organism and the surround.

In its first formulation, an overall theory of ways of knowing or orders of consciousness is outlined that describes five such orders: two preconventional, two conventional and one postconventional. Each of these constitutes a higher order integration.

The framework developer’s model incorporates the previous perspective as a component within a new, broader outlook. The proposed stages focus on relatively stable periods of meaning organization within the continuous process of development. The overall progression alternates between favoring relative independence and relative inclusion, similar to patterns observed in other models of ego development. Of the five proposed stages of consciousness, the final stage, termed the Interindividual or fifth order of consciousness, is broadly postconventional. Thus, the theory spans the first three tiers of development. The term “interindividual” chosen for this final stage suggests relevance to the concept of deconstruction, as “inter” implies “between,” hinting at a permeability of boundaries.

In many respects, this theory shares similarities with other comprehensive models of ego development. Both describe the evolving self from birth to mature adulthood and attempt to provide a comprehensive sequence of stages. Recognizing that the self is multi-faceted, these theories address not only cognition but also affect and action, describing their differentiation and integration through dynamic interaction. Despite covering similar ground, the theories differ in significant ways. The instrument used to measure the orders of consciousness not only assesses the five theoretically defined stages but also identifies four transition steps between each stage. These steps are evaluated impressionistically along a continuum, ranging from initial differentiation from the old

stage to shifting toward a new organizational structure. Consequently, an individual can be assessed as being at a specific stage or at one of four intermediate positions.

The postconventional territory examined in this framework aligns approximately with the highest stages and positions in other developmental schemes. Despite being conceptualized as a single stage, the theory contains components that can be considered postautonomous.

In a subsequent publication, the framework developer introduces the concept of two distinct positions between the fourth and fifth orders of consciousness: a deconstructive form of postmodernism and a subsequent reconstructive form. The antimodernist position is described as a phase of differentiation prior to integration, characterized by energy devoted to maintaining a valuable disjunction and articulating the rationale for doing so. This antimodern position parallels the oppositional stance found in other individualistic stages. It explicitly rejects the tenets of the preceding stage, which is characterized by well-guarded boundaries. While it excels at exposing the discrepancies and limitations of the previous mindset, it lacks the capacity to integrate them into a new, coherent whole.

The theory posits that approximately ten percent of adults may develop beyond conventional views of reality to an interindividual or trans-systemic order of comprehension, transitioning from a modern to a postmodern view of reality. In developmental terms, at least a postsystemic perspective is required for an individual to view universal human behaviors, such as meaning-making, as objects of reflection. Individuals at this stage realize that the logical power of any system is flawed and incomplete when viewed from the outside. They understand that every system or “way of knowing” is inherently decisive, including some elements while excluding others. Consequently, every way of knowing is simultaneously a way of not knowing. Each discipline is recognized as an ideology that offers explanatory power but inevitably advantages certain perspectives while disadvantaging others.

The realization that “each way of knowing is a way of not knowing” captures the essence of postautonomous meaning-making, addressing several aspects of construct-awareness simultaneously. It acknowledges the dynamic interrelationship between foreground and background, or between polar opposites. It accepts the relative nature and inherent limitations of any intellectual discipline. Postautonomous awareness focuses not on the content of knowledge, but on the process of how sense is made of the world.

When individuals examine their own process of observation, they realize that what appears clear and distinct can change simply by shifting focus across the visual field. The focal area becomes prominent, while the unfocused area becomes dim and indistinct. This highlights the subjective, deliberate, and directed nature of attention, thoughts, and reactions, as well as the inherent cost of any choices made. This cost involves a lack of clarity, or even blindness, in areas outside the focus of attention.

The framework developer explicitly addresses issues of boundaries, polar opposites, and the continuous process of reconstruction, valuing the ongoing challenge to absolutes and boundaries. A key question is whether one assumes the a priori existence of separate elements and systems—a formal-operational view of reality—or focuses on the process by which knowledge about reality is generated. At the fifth order of consciousness, individuals realize that any abstraction, whether a single element or a complex theory, is always a partial representation of the whole, existing only in relation to what the human perceiver has differentiated it from.

As meaning-makers, humans inevitably seek an overarching theory that encompasses all potentialities, providing certainty and closure. It is not until the fifth order of consciousness that individuals become capable of reflecting on their need for meaning and order, and their active involvement in creating these through continuous recreations or more encompassing theories.

Regarding the interdependent nature of polar opposites (any concept and its negation), the theory addresses this postautonomous concern by discussing the dualistic equivalency between the absolute ideology of the institutional self and the absolute antiabsolutism of the deconstructive postmodern stance. Absolutism and antiabsolutism form a dualistic pair, much like dualism and non-dualism. The framework points to a superordinate possibility beyond dualistic splitting, where the tendency to split is internalized as an expression of one's own partialness and incompleteness.

According to the theory, it is this awareness of partialness, continuously extended to larger contexts, that drives the human endeavor of meaning-making toward wholeness and the transcending of boundaries. Similar to other perspectives, the theory maintains that individuals with a reconstructive mindset find vitality in dismantling every new conceptual boundary that enters awareness, viewing closure and fixed boundaries as restrictive. It can be assumed that individuals with this insight have developed a fully postautonomous stance toward experience. While one might argue that the purpose of reconstruction—creating increasingly better theories—is to eventually arrive at a complete theory, a truly reconstructive view would likely associate such a final “victory” with stagnation or death. As long as life continues, the process of reconstruction must also continue.

The framework developer is acutely aware of the reifying tendency embedded in language, which often frames reality as static, separate things rather than ongoing, indeterminate processes. This is highlighted by pointing out the dual meaning of the word “meaning” as both “making sense” and “mattering or being of consequence.” This distinction summarizes the core of the theory in both its epistemological and ontological dimensions.

It is more difficult to locate within this theory the movement from an initial relativistic reaction against cultural conditioning to the more profound doubt characteristic of the construct-aware stage. Based on sentence completion data, it appears that some individuals develop a balanced stage between the absolute relativism of the antimodern position and the postautonomous stance anchored in the dialectical process of continuous construction, deconstruction, and reconstruction. At this intermediate integration, individuals recognize that the antimodern stance is a reaction to the rigid boundaries of formal operations, but they do not yet fully grasp the fleeting nature of all reality construction. Instead, they resolve the resulting uncertainty through reasoned choices and commitments, reminiscent of concepts like “developing commitments” or principled moral reasoning.

Individuals at this reconstructive equilibrium believe they must and can generate and live by their own overarching theory, principles, and self-created identity. Unlike earlier stages, this stable self-system is metasystematic, allowing for multiple connections, nonlinear causality, and feedback from other systems in creating its version of reality. It provides a new, self-guided inner stability and relative certainty. The autonomous self represents such an intermediate balance. Individuals at this stage consciously strive to form a stable core self by integrating new awareness while steadfastly holding onto a belief in “the” self and aspiring to actualize it.

However, individuals at this intermediate equilibrium cannot yet relinquish the notion of an overarching self-system. They cannot fully examine the processes of meaning creation or the universal temptation to objectify reality by actively defining it. They are still searching for a coherent identity. While they may accept the philosophical premise that life is fundamentally motion, they remain seduced by language into experiencing themselves and the world as static entities that move. In the terms of the theory, they still believe in their “somethingness,” albeit in a sophisticated, dynamic way. This “something” represents a well-articulated, complex, committed, and relatively tolerant self that is aware of its interdependence with other selves.

Unlike other models where the highest stages remain at this intermediate balance, this theory postulates that individuals at the interindividual order of consciousness can become aware of their reifying tendencies. Furthermore, the most advanced individuals are expected to relish and draw vitality from the awareness of the partialness of all views and interpretations of reality. Thus, the theory supports the proposition that advanced

development includes both complexification and the continuous deconstruction of prior assumptions at increasingly deeper levels of recognition.

Unfortunately, the theory and its associated measurement instrument do not provide actual examples of the highest, interindividual stage. However, two hypothetical examples constructed by the test makers, rated close to but below the highest stage, exhibit characteristics of postautonomous awareness. The first example involves a reflection on what it means to be helpful:

"No matter how exciting my ideas are, my holding them so dearly actually deadens my vitality; it drains the juice that makes me alive, even the me who invents the ideas to begin with."

The researchers interpret this self-reflection as indicative of a unitive conception of reality, suggesting that life is viewed as a continuous flow of experiencing and participating. Being stuck is seen as falling out of this flow, and the goal is to return to it. While the test makers conceive of a way of knowing that remains in flux, the hypothetical test taker is still struggling to remain in motion, remaining "loyal to the beach." In postautonomous terms, this represents a typical construct-aware struggle: having intimations of a fluid way of being but still being drawn to the safety of the familiar self, accompanied by a yearning to remain in the flow.

The second hypothetical example is even closer to the posited interindividual stage:

"I almost have to keep from letting myself get too involved with my first take on things because, whatever actual merit it may have, I'm in danger of making it into the truth. And I also have a tendency not to want to see some other whole way I'm actually operating or feeling, because I might get pulled into making that the truth."

In this example, the speaker is fully conscious of her absolutizing tendencies and remarks on her own mental habits. By attempting to counteract the first tendency, she realizes she creates a new stumbling block.

The concept of variables as constructs leads to the notion of illusion. All human-made distinctions are part of reality but do not encompass all of reality. Ordinary waking reality is seen as an illusion because individuals mistakenly believe their identifications and distinctions are reality itself.

Another theorist specifically addresses the shared boundaries of polar opposites, noting that one cannot delineate "good" without simultaneously delineating "evil." This highlights the interdependent nature of basic dichotomies and the automatic dualistic splitting that occurs when naming the world. From a top-down perspective, reality is viewed as neither one nor many, neither infinite nor finite, neither whole nor part; everything is interconnected. This represents the final deconstruction of the permanent object world and the concomitant release of the concept of a permanent self, characteristic of the unitive stage. While individuals at systems stages can investigate the content and cultural assumptions guiding their beliefs, those at unitary stages become aware of the underlying process of meaning-making itself.

The portrayal of the unitary stage as one where individuals become fully conscious of the constructed nature of objects and their boundaries, and recognize the essential unity of the universe, goes further than many other adult development theories in deconstructing the formal-operational view of reality and illustrating the limits of reasoning based on rational, symbol-mediated knowing.

In summarizing the analysis of non-domain-specific models of adult development, two different explanations of postconventional development emerge. The first characterizes it in terms of increasingly complex and differentiated hierarchical systems. The second posits a simultaneous, step-wise deconstruction of formal operational concepts. While some theories describe development primarily as increasing complexity, differentiation, and integration at higher levels of abstraction, others specify the increasing ability to see through the meaning-making process itself as the most salient aspect of postconventional development.

Some models, while examining the ability to reflect on whole fields of thought, take the object world created by language for granted and do not examine the premises of symbolic logic used to develop their abstract models.

Other theories are also complexifying, describing the capacity to integrate more dimensions of experience, comparing advanced stages to self-actualizing persons. However, these characterizations often do not progress beyond a systems view of reality, and their measurement instruments may not account for the possibility that individuals can become aware of the constructed nature of reality.

Conversely, other models clearly consider both the increasing complexity of thought and the increasing awareness of the constructed nature of reality as essential aspects of mature growth. The trans-systematic ability to reflect on whole internally consistent systems of thought and dialectical reasoning are key features. While these advanced stages are more complex and differentiated, their most salient features are the awareness of reifying tendencies and the underlying unity and flux of experience. Some models advocate for greater integration of outer and inner territories of experience, describing a transcognitive awareness similar to a witnessing stance, focused on the moment but characterized by relentless questioning.

The necessity of deconstructing the conventional view of reality, with its linear and analytical tenets, is explicitly addressed by some theorists. A unitary view of reality is defined as preeminent, where reasoning and symbolic representation are seen as specific forms of a more integrated, metaphysical apperception of reality. This deconstruction process involves two steps: first, realizing that objects have shared boundaries, causality is cyclical, and cultural conditioning exists; second, realizing the fundamental unity of reality, the illusion of boundaries, and the reifying aspects of language. This top-down approach, akin to Eastern philosophy, describes reality as an undifferentiated whole, viewing systems theory and formal operational thought as increasing concretizations and distortions of reality.

It is noted that theorists focused on psychometrics or quantitative analysis tend to overemphasize the structural, measurable aspects of development at the expense of qualitative, content-related aspects. Consequently, they may overlook the possibility that the very means of argumentation and measurement can be questioned at advanced levels of cognitive insight. This limitation is predictable from a constructivist perspective, as a scientist's choice of topic, theory, and methodology reflects their own conception of reality. As one perspective notes, a theory is primarily a way of looking at the world, not a form of knowledge of how the world actually is.

Turning to transpersonal, four-tier models of development that span all tiers, these models provide insights into postconventional and postautonomous development. One such model, derived from Vedic psychology and introduced to the West, proposes a fully developed, four-tier model of consciousness. The fourth, non-ego-centered, postsymbolic tier is considered structurally and functionally higher than the third tier, being more adaptive, stable, accurate, and comprehensive. These higher states are viewed as a natural continuation of human development.

According to this theory, underlying all development is an abstract, silent, completely unified field of consciousness, the self-sufficient source of all mental processes. This transcendent self is non-domain specific, postautonomous, and meaning-providing. All representational processes (perception, thought, feeling, intuition) are seen as fluctuations or concrete manifestations of this underlying field. While they coexist at all times, stages above an individual's current developmental level may be too subtle to register in conscious awareness.

This theory also emphasizes the role of language in meaning-making, distinguishing between presymbolic, symbolic, and postsymbolic modes of knowing. The shift from preverbal to verbal processing is seen as monumental, paralleling the shift from personal, representational knowing to transcendent, postconceptual processing. A parallel is drawn between the conditioning required for language acquisition and the systematic training needed for postlanguage technologies to acquire fourth-tier, ego-transcendent ways of knowing. This aligns with the observation that individuals at advanced stages begin to realize how deeply they are conditioned into symbolic thought and how difficult it is to transcend it. Shared symbol systems draw awareness away from direct experience toward a filtered, culturally specific version of reality.

The model proposes a hierarchical sequence of increasingly abstract, functionally integrated faculties or “intrinsic levels of mind.” These latent capacities unfold progressively, paralleling ordinary developmental stages and extending to transcendent stages. The levels are structured from gross to subtle: sensori-motor faculties, desire (early representations), the thinking mind (concrete), and the discriminating intellect (abstract and formal operations) cover the first two conventional tiers. The third tier includes two levels: feeling/intuition and ego.

At the first postconventional level, feeling and intuition reenter meaning-making as valuable sources of information for assessing the whole organism. No longer split off from reason, feeling enriches experience and supports decision-making. This level is more flexible and relational than intellect alone, involving subtler, rapid, holistic, intuitive modes of functioning less dominated by linguistic expression and sequential formal reasoning. This parallels open-system, context-sensitive, conflict-tolerant stages in other models.

The ego, as a level of mind, occupies the most advanced position in the personal representational realm and is developmentally closest to the transcendental self. It is defined as the most refined value of life, the experienter that understands, feels, and thinks. The thinking faculty is the mind; the understanding and discriminating faculty is the intellect; the feeling faculty is the heart. This conception aligns with views of the ego as the faculty that synthesizes experience into a coherent whole, allowing for detached reflection or mature wisdom. However, the ego remains localized and limited by its inability to know itself directly, a struggle evidenced in advanced developmental assessments.

The goal of associated practices is to allow the self to unfold naturally toward its source in transcendent consciousness by freeing the individual from stress and entrenched habitual patterns. Self-actualization is considered a waypoint on the route to higher consciousness. The theory emphasizes that the capacity for higher forms of consciousness is innate but emerges only through exposure to and practice in postrepresentational ways of knowing. Continued practice fosters further differentiation within the postsymbolic realm. Cognitive growth is accompanied by the continuing differentiation of language and thought in the symbolic realm and the progressively deeper reintegration of knower and known in the postsymbolic realm.

This perspective supports the interpretation that postconventional development involves increasing awareness of the limits of rational, language-mediated meaning-making. Unlike conceptions that view the search for an objective, integrated self as the goal of development, postautonomous development leads to the discovery of the illusion of such an endeavor and the necessity for an entirely different mode of knowing. Longitudinal research indicates that individuals engaged in specific meditative practices achieve postconventional stages at significantly higher rates, supporting the hypothesis that development results from the experience of deeper, more complete levels of subjective existence.

Another comprehensive model traces the evolution of consciousness through cultural history, concluding that reality is hierarchical, composed of successively higher levels of reality (or decreasing illusion), ranging from the material plane to ultimate spiritual realization. This grand theory seeks to integrate all other explanations, positing that the universe begins and ends with spirit as the ultimate ground. It includes the concept of involution, where spirit manifests in grosser forms before returning to itself through evolution. Evolution is seen as reflecting a deep structure immanent at both phylogenetic and ontogenetic levels.

This complex model outlines nine levels of individual consciousness across three major divisions (body, mind, and spirit). Recognizing language as crucial in the ascendance of mind over body, it views numerical subdivisions as convenient mapping tools rather than inherent realities. The first five structures cover the conventional tiers, the sixth stage (vision-logic) represents the third tier, and the final three structures comprise contemplative or transpersonal development.

The model distinguishes between enduring structures (like linguistic competence and cognitive capacity) and transitional structures (like self-identity and moral stages), which are replaced as development progresses. At

the core is a self-system responsible for mediating, organizing, and navigating experience. The self-system does not follow an invariant sequence, though specific lines like self-identity may unfold in a stage-like fashion. Vision-logic, representing the postconventional tier, integrates aspects of experience into networks of relationships or interrelated systems. Termed “panoramic logic,” it apprehends how ideas influence each other as an integral whole. This stage covers several advanced developmental positions, including aspects of systems thinking and unitary thought. The model further argues for a union of science and religion, elaborating on the “linguistic turn” as a key ingredient of postrational development.

The Realization of the Language Habit

The realization that our maps are not the territory, no matter what level of differentiation and complexity we achieve in mapping our understanding of the world, is a crucial insight. It addresses the understanding that words mean what they mean only within the totality of all other words in an interrelated web of meaning. The discovery of the power and problem of the language habit is a spontaneous and profoundly captivating aspect of the Construct-aware stage. On the other hand, people seem to realize earlier at the Individualist and Autonomous stages that they are part of a vast background of cultural signs, and that in many cases they have no clue as to where it all came from. Overall, both cultural and linguistic conditioning becomes visible at the third tier of development. In other words, it is suggested that during vision-logic the previously taken for granted way of meaning making gets deconstructed and its limitations self-consciously explored and exposed.

Another aspect of vision-logic is its acceptance of contextualism, diversity and multiple perspectives as the means for opening up the rigid boundaries and self-contained, monological truths of the formal-operational self. Vision-logic emphasizes adding up all the perspectives, privileging none, and thus attempts to grasp the integral, the whole, the multiple contexts that endlessly disclose the cosmos, not in a rigid or absolutist fashion, but in a fluidly holonic and multidimensional tapestry.

The discovery of the fundamental partialness of our views at the third tier of development is reiterated, but vision-logic is explicitly seen as part of the bigger trend by which spirit rediscovers itself. Vision-logic is considered the most awake of the stages of the awakening mind in the personal realm and forms a link to the transpersonal, fourth tier of spirit. That other Unitive concepts are also part of vision-logic is evident from the description of the “existential level” and its stage-specific pathologies. The “Centaur” (animal body and human mind in one) represents the self-stage of vision-logic. The Cartesian body/mind split of the previous stage is healed, as boundaries are softened and data from all available sources, not just pure reason, are employed to navigate life. The major concerns of the existential or Centaur self are listed as: “personal autonomy and integration; authenticity; and self-actualization.” Associated affects are: a concern for overall meaning in life (or-being-in-the world); a grappling with personal mortality and finitude and finding a courage-to-be in the face of lonely and unexpected death. Where the formal mind begins to conceive of life’s possibilities and take flight in this new-found freedom, the existential mind (via vision-logic) adds up the possibilities and finds this: personal life is “a brief spark in the cosmic void.” How the existential self handles the new potentials of autonomy and self-actualization, and how it grapples with the problems of finitude, mortality, and apparent meaninglessness - these are the central factors in F-6 pathology.

The courage-to-be despite one’s awareness of mortality and finitude, as well as the courage to create coherent meaning in the face of the elusiveness of representations, these are the qualities particular to the postautonomous ego differentiation. Only at the existential level are they expressed with such clarity and poignancy. Adults at the system level of thought tend to relish the powers afforded by this new way of thinking

which releases creativity and gives more freedom to roam than formal operations. They embody the first equation in the Pascalian paradox: “I am an infinity compared to nothingness.”

It is at the Construct-aware ego stage that the opposite side “I am a nothing compared to infinity” starts to resonate at a profound level. When personal life is seen “as a brief spark in the cosmic void,” then the person is ripe for existential despair and anxiety as well as for a new, and different kind of integration. It is the Unitive ego stage, which allows the conjoining of both sides of the Pascalian paradox without undue tension and without the need for experience to be different than it is.

In summary, the conceptualization of postconventional development as a step-wise deconstruction of formerly held truths is supported. Features of vision-logic include both cultural and linguistic conditioning. It is suggested that contextualism and cultural relativism can be understood at the first level of postconventional development, while the discovery of our universal linguistic habituation is more characteristic of the postautonomous level. Most importantly, vision-logic is part of the Great “Nest” of Being. It adds higher cognition and affect (feeling and intuition in the Vedic formulation) as well as insights from body and non-waking realities to the tools of the earlier, merely rational mind. At its most advanced, vision-logic opens the door into the spiritual, transpersonal, non-egoic, non-representational realm of being.

Discussion of High-End Developmental Theories

Postconventional development can be looked at from two seemingly contradictory perspectives. First, postconventional development continues the pattern of alternating stages of differentiation and integration toward greater and greater hierarchical complexity accommodating an ever-expanding experiential universe. At the same time, postconventional development can be understood as a stepwise deconstruction of the previously unconsciously constructed permanent object world with its closed boundaries, linear causality and subject/object separation. Both views provide useful lenses into aspects of postconventional personality development, but only the latter is adequate to describe the insights of people at the most advanced ego stages as seen on rare sentence completion tests (SCTs).

Eight selected sources, six constructivist developmental and two transpersonal, were examined to find out how they accounted for the postconventional terrain in general and for the stages beyond a systems view in particular. Four of these models also have their own measuring instrument. The evidence from investigating these eight sources revealed that two constructivist models do not include the notion of the gradual deconstruction of the conventionally acquired mindset as part of their understanding of highest stage development. They do not do so, however, for different reasons.

The General Model of Hierarchical Complexity

The General Model of Hierarchical Complexity (GMHC) looks exclusively at cognitive development. It focuses on the structure of the underlying logic and argumentation evident in the material that is evaluated as to stage. Some of their studies of systems level performance are based on subjects’ ability to translate their own comprehension of the material into abstract symbols, for instance, in the Four Stories Problem. For their highest stage, the crossparadigmatic, only anecdotal or historical evidence is offered.

Nonetheless, some parallels exist. One of the criteria for a person to be rated at the Construct-aware stage is the ability to look at one’s own life and self-identity as a continuous pattern of identification, disidentification and re-identification at more complex and integrated levels, that is, to recognize that identity formation as a

psychological endeavor is based on the paradigm of consecutive approximations or as a historical, evolutionary process. The similarity here is to the conception of crossparadigmatic stage insofar as some people can take a perspective on the whole field of “development” by relating, for instance, ontogenetic (personality), phylogenetic (species), and cultural evolution (ideas).

On the other hand, the GMHC would fail to explain an unwillingness to “structure” experience because the rational need to explain everything has been transcended. Individuals at the Autonomous stage tend to see life in terms of integrating multiple self-systems into one self-actualized self while those at the Construct-aware stage notice the range of transformations that they have moved through and the likelihood of continuing transformations. Finally, people at the Unitive stage understand the non-necessity of striving for such identifications in the first place. They understand the limits inherent in arriving at an adequate self-theory based on the reification of experience. It is suggested that GMHC cannot adjudicate such instances of insight because it is entirely grounded in the rational, personal mindset, unaware of the constraints of its own reasoning.

Instead, the GMHC deals with the abstract formulations of underlying mental operations at ever more inclusive orders of complexity. Little empirical evidence outside of the history of science of paradigmatic or crossparadigmatic cognition is given. Even though Gödel is cited as an exemplar of their crossparadigmatic stage, the GMHC has yet to show any signs of awareness that there is a difference between reality and its description via symbolic representation and mathematical abstraction, and between knower and that which is known. Ironically, it was Gödel who argued that the problems of definition cannot be solved even within the most carefully constructed symbol systems. Thus, the mathematical and statistical rigor that is being used in support of the claims of the GMHC is not adequate to do justice to the broadly defined psychological phenomenon of adult development that the GMHC claims to explain.

It is declared that “if the field of endeavor represents the most complex element of epistemology for which there is any empirical evidence, then crossparadigmatic operations represent the present terminus of genetic epistemology.” In other words, their systematizing seems to have reached a limit because of the present (meaning current) lack of evidence. However, they do not recognize that this limit is inherent in their approach which relies on structural evidence and rational analysis. Since the GMHC values cognitive complexity over insight, it cannot conceive of metarational modes of apperception that could integrate an understanding of the limits of symbolic analysis.

The Loevinger Model

The translation of a qualitative phenomenon (how different people make various meaning of the same task) into a quantitative result in ways that maximizes output and efficiency and minimizes rater bias is part of the overall appeal of this model and instrument. By using a semi-projective sentence completion test and a rationalized manual, some of the problems of other measures including the GMHC are avoided. First, the test is the same for all respondents; second, responses are spontaneous and not probed; third, rater bias is less likely because of the matching procedure; and fourth, rating can be accomplished without the rater himself or herself being a complex reasoner. This is decidedly not the case for rating postconventional material with the GMHC scoring instrument.

On the other hand, the creation of rationalized manuals is very much dependent on the insights of those who originally interpreted and “rationalized” the sentence completions as well as the quality of the data used. As for the theory, it seems to reflect the theoreticians’ own take on reality. It is imbedded in a modern, scientific view of reality that can only take a limited perspective on its own means of meaning making. Thus, at the high end of the scale, probabilistic considerations are used to defend placement choices rather than theoretical coherence, soundness, and plausibility. Reflecting both of these issues, the theory as well as the Second Edition is more

effective for dealing with the lower two tier of ego development, but problematic at the third tier. The theory is least adequate at the postautonomous level because it only gives the fuzziest notions of what such meaning making would look like. The criteria given for the ultimate stage do not distinguish it from earlier stages, and, of greater theoretical concern, they cannot account for “deconstructed” views of reality.

Other Theories

The theories of the four other constructivist developmental psychologists investigated clearly indicate that the hallmarks of the highest forms of self-development and understanding include greater complexity and higher order integrations as well as an increasing realization of the underlying mechanics of meaning making in the rational realm. All four posit that people can become aware of reification or objectification. These are the means by which we make lasting and solid what in actual experience is fleeting and insubstantial. In contrast, the concern for “finding” an objective, well-balanced and integrated identity is put as the most unique sign for the highest stage whereas “losing” one’s need for identity seeking is more characteristic of postautonomous insight according to the other observers of mature views of reality and self development.

All four authors also count as markers of high-end development an awareness that paradox is inevitable, that polar opposites are defined through each other, and that language is a filter that stands between the experiencer and lived experience, or between knower and known. As people gain understanding of these mental habits while they occur, they begin to relate to them in a more conscious way. Whereas they are critical and often frustrated with their own automatic rational behavior at the Construct-aware stage, they can gain a detached perspective on it at the Unitive stage.

There are no clear dividing lines between one stage and the next except in the abstract model. This is only a problem from a traditional scientific point of view, which demands comparability of test samples. Here, it is taken as further support that, in the end, such divisions are arbitrary and based on the needs, purposes and methods of their creators.

Thus, one third tier stage is postulated, but given multiple attributes which include early postconventional as well as mature postconventional characteristics. Currently, the interpretation seems to be the most elaborate third tier self-theory with four theoretically defined steps between conventional and transpersonal development. Four postconventional cognitive differentiation-integrations across domains are also posited, but they focus predominantly on the higher complexity aspect of advanced reasoning. By ignoring the constructed nature of the means by which they create their arguments, that is by dismissing the possibility of the bankruptcy of the whole complexifying endeavor, they stop at the highest level for which there is some structural evidence.

Only theories that acknowledge both increasing complexity and increasing awareness of the constructed nature of reality carry in themselves the seed for a different, altogether new paradigm of cognition. The shift from the unconscious, preverbal world of the infant to the world negotiated through language is as monumental a transformation as the shift from the personal, representational realm of consciousness to the transpersonal, postrepresentational.

Testing Content Validity of the Scoring Categories

Following the general evaluation of the theoretical terrain of postautonomous development, the proposed criteria for identifying high-stage protocols were tested empirically. There were two reasons for this step. First, it was necessary to verify whether the proposed categories were sufficient for describing postautonomous

development. Second, this move seemed useful in light of potentially creating a compendium to the Second Edition for rating postconventional protocols.

Therefore, it was examined in detail how the categories compared to the characteristics articulated in the writings of the relevant authors analyzed in the previous section in their respective descriptions of the postautonomous terrain. One theory was replaced with another that also fulfilled the selection criteria.

The choice of these texts was based on the likelihood that they addressed postautonomous issues. Thus, the theoretical framework chapters as well as the specific part of the writings in which the selected authors dealt with their respective postconventional-postautonomous stages were looked at. Although read carefully, the aim was not at catching every instance of correspondence. Thus, there may be some not noticed or noted down. Here the attempt is only to ascertain whether the thematic categories are indeed part of the repertoire of describing higher stages of development by others, not to find all instances of their occurrence. However, novel characteristics that had not appeared in the database were looked for.

To structure the task, the themes from the existing category descriptions were used as a guiding framework. So far, the nine thematic categories appear to be necessary and sufficient to identify the unique characteristics of the two proposed postautonomous ego stages and to distinguish between them and earlier stages. As mentioned before, the categories are stage-specific and could prove to be useful for identifying postautonomous material outside the narrow context of sentence completions.

At this stage of the project, the aim was to test whether concrete corroboration of the proposed criteria could be found rather than the more general conceptual parallels and differences investigated in the previous section. The numbers of pages consulted for each author are given in Table 3.4. These refer to their treatment of the postconventional/postautonomous area of development only, not the complete works. The following questions were put to each text:

Do the proposed scoring criteria actually appear as postautonomous characteristics in the works of the theoreticians examined for their general views on postconventional and postautonomous development? Do these authors list any characteristics missed? Comparatively, how often are specific categories mentioned?

First, it was wanted to find out whether the themes of the scoring categories actually appeared in the targeted texts. Second, it was needed to make sure that salient postautonomous themes or concerns had not been left out because they did not appear on the SCTs of the data collection from which the categories were empirically derived. Clearly with rare empirical data, there is little confidence at the outset that the evidence will cover most types of responses that would be relevant for creating a comprehensive stage characterization. Therefore, this analysis of the targeted texts also included reading them for potentially new subthemes or entirely new categories. Third, knowing which of the existing categories are mentioned most often among the other thinkers in this field would give some additional weight to their relative importance. The question whether to keep a rare category for the sake of comprehensiveness or whether to list only those that appear a minimal percentage of the time is a further consideration in manual construction.

It is a rare benefit of empirical work that it occasionally produces insights unlikely to occur in a more theoretical context. Construct-aware category C9 (5/6v) was derived from analyzing hundreds of postconventional SCT responses. The sometimes exceedingly complex completions in postautonomous protocols tipped off to the Construct-aware individuals' struggle with complexity issues. Thus in this specific instance, it is the unique, complex structure of a response that identifies it as Construct-aware rather than the content which is more salient in other categories. It is anticipated that the expression of complexity may be part of the description of high-end development in other theories, but not its specific structural markers that are most striking in sentence completions.

To accomplish the test of the adequacy of the scoring categories, the steps below were followed.

Method

1. The current category descriptions are umbrella types - that is, they are highly condensed summaries of the observed characteristics pertaining to a given master characteristic. To facilitate and fine-tune analysis, the compact categories were broken down into several component subthemes.
2. A multi-column table was devised for recording the topics, themes and subthemes to be tested. The grid represents a category by author matrix. Empty cells were included to have room to modify existing text and to add new themes. See Table 3.3 for a schematic representation of the grid.
3. Next, the selected texts were read and any postautonomous characteristics they mentioned were flagged. The amount of text analyzed differed for different authors. Some material were chapters on postconventional development in theoretical works, others were summary articles on third tier development.
4. Whenever a match was found between a theme on the y-axis of the grid and a target text, it was entered into the corresponding stage, category and subtheme cell, color-coded according to the author and work. Each item was identified by author, text and page number. Where possible, the distinctions between the criteria for the Construct-aware and the Unitive stage were maintained. Since authors vary in the number of distinctions they make at the high end of their scales, it was planned to note where a feature seemed postautonomous but a clear stage distinction was not possible.
5. Finally, the tabulated frequency of correspondences was summarized and the outcome analyzed for patterns. The summary of the tally by category is given below as well as a discussion of the evidence.

Table 3.3 Schematic Grid for Tallying Postautonomous Categories

Scoring categories divided into subthemes, indicators	Relevant postautonomous adult development literature	Transpersonal Psychology
$\frac{5}{6}$ Definition of category and subthemes	Author 1	Author 2 Etc.
$\frac{5}{6}$, 1 Subtheme 1	Text 1, p. 18	
Subtheme 2		Text 2, p. xx
Subtheme 3 Etc.		
$\frac{5}{6}$, 3 Theme	Text 1, p. 348	Text 2, p. 10
New subthemes from texts????		

Results and Discussion of Text Analysis

The actual searching of relevant text for the presence of the proposed categories and for finding new features that might be useful in characterizing postautonomous responses did not produce radically new descriptors. 1398 pages of potentially relevant text surfaced 264 instances of criteria for describing postautonomous development. Many of the subtheme cells stayed empty. Therefore, the discussion will be at the level of category themes only. In short, these are as follows:

Construct-aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9)

- Complex matrix (non linear list); abstract, structural signs
- Evaluation of multilayered intrapsychic and interpersonal dynamics
- Exploration and evaluation of habits of the mind; paradox, infinite regress; attention to process, attention to attention
- Reference to the constructed nature of reality; the language habit; definitions and frames of reference

Unitive stage C10 (6)

- 6.1 Explicit gratitude for other beings and life in their whole complexity
- 6.2 Acceptance of change, process, world and people as they are
- 6.3 Non-trivial expression of universal connectedness
- 6.4 Fundamental thoughts and feelings about the human condition
- 6.5 Unitive ability, embracing polar opposites and multiple perspectives

It was difficult to place an item into a Construct-aware or a Unitive category. However, 2 instances were found where the Ironist stage is described which partially overlap with the Unitive stage and partially lie outside its parameters. Given the lesser frequency of adults at the Unitive stage, it is natural that there were fewer mentions at the Unitive stage overall.

All nine categories were represented across the texts, but not every author recognized the same categories as indicative for the most advanced kind of development. The two Construct-aware categories with the most hits were 9x which refers to the questioning and evaluating of the habits of the mind, and 9y which makes reference to the constructed nature of reality and its active framing.

Only one author mentioned the complexity category 9v as an indicator of dialectical thought. Unitive ability (10z), the second category with structural indicators was recognized twice by one author, once by another and once by a third as symptomatic of advanced development.

Two authors had eight out of the nine categories represented, while another described seven of them. Thus, the categories do seem to capture elements of postautonomous behavior that are evident to others combining that territory. One author produced the most evidence overall: This seems understandable since his 24 detailed schemas are based on actual excerpts from interview material. As evaluation criteria, the schemas are conceptually closer to scoring categories than the general personality descriptions offered by the other authors.

Table 3.4 Content Category Analysis

		Construct-aware Stage Categories 5/6 (C9)				Unitive Stage Categories 6 (C10)					
Author	# Pages	1/v	2/w	3/x	4/y	1/v	2/w	3/x	4/y	5/z	Sums
Author 1	351	0	4	15	16	1	4	6	2	1	49
Author 2	342	2	13	20	50	1	6	6	6	0	104
Author 3	27	0	0	2	5	0	2	2	4	0	15
Author 4	176	0	5	16	8	0	5	7	4	2	47
Author 5	43	0	1	0	11	0	0	2	0	0	14
Author 6	338	0	0	8	10	1	6	0	0	1	26
Author 7	81	0	0	4	0	2	1	1	0	1	9
Sums	1398	2	23	65	100	5	24	25	16	4	264

The Construct-aware category (9y) was mentioned by six out of seven theoreticians, and gathered 38% of the responses. This rubric deals with the constructed nature of reality and includes seeing symbolic representation of reality as a potential “problem” because it “reifies” experience and acts as a screen between reality and reality as perceived by the human observer. Since this seems to be the most easily recognized index of postautonomous development having named the whole stage by this characteristic seems appropriate. 25% of the correspondences came from category (9x) which pays attention to the process of meaning making and to thought habits, such as the recognition of inevitable paradox and infinite regress in logic as well as to issues of conscious attention. 23 instances of category (9w) were found, which describes individuals with an explicit and subtle recognition of the complex interdependence of intrapersonal and interpersonal dynamics.

The Unitive characteristics were presented by three authors as more mature than the other criteria mentioned in the personal realm. The two most common categories for the Unitive stage were (10w) and (10x). Category 10w refers to the letting go of evaluative behavior and being able to witness whatever transpires in the moment. At the Unitive stage, the pleasure principle no longer seems to hold. All experience becomes both meaningful and not meaningful, or neither (non-dual perception). The “unitive” connection across all possible boundaries (geography, time, race, intelligence etc.) is typical of stage 10x and was also recognized as a relevant marker by all seven authors.

The selected literature also contained a few instances of meaningful postautonomous distinctions and subthemes that had not yet been adequately articulated. These were entered as a new subtheme in the relevant umbrella category. There were no entirely “new” categories in this selected sample. After the numerical comparison was completed the umbrella descriptions for the categories were amended to better reflect the characteristics recorded on the list. Their refinement is an important subtext of this study as will be more evident in the next chapter. It is an ongoing effort geared toward simplifying the praxis of actual high-stage scoring.

Footnotes and References

An indication that one cannot yet stand outside and look at the method as a tool. It constitutes the situation where one “is had by one’s methods, rather than having them.”

This tendency is also known as negentropy, a distinctive property of all living organisms.

In an attempt to find a suitable metaphor for the kind of learning that adults are engaged in at the third, postconventional tier, the term “the honor curriculum” was chosen. Perhaps this is not an ideal description because those who are at this order of consciousness probably view reality the way they do because they can do no other, thus “honor” has little to do with their behavior. Indeed, every stage is “honorable” in that it lives at the order it has mastered. Victories would be acknowledged and celebrated wherever they occur on the growth trajectory.

Closer to a transcendent experience yet: The realized Witness Self knows that it is whole already, always.

Since it is asserted that “differentiation always precedes integration”, the whole stage sequence could perhaps be systematically reformulated to include the positions of greatest stable differentiation between the integrations in the theory. The modal for adults is between the Interpersonal and the Institutional stage.

The abstract synonyms for the act of definition themselves “define, delineate, delimit, demarcate, determine, circumscribe, frame” all contain the notion of boundary. A concept can only be formed by segmenting a previously undivided continuum into several interdependent entities.

In the present day climate of antbehaviorism, the fact that language acquisition is largely conditioned is not often recognized. However, this is another place where a conceptual synthesis between schools of thought (“behaviorism” and constructivist developmental theory) might become feasible.

Some critics find fault with many of the concrete details of the effort at synthesis. However, the inevitable price in accuracy to be paid for grand “orienting generalizations or conclusions” is acknowledged. As one is disposed to explore the beauty and intricacies of spirit manifested in the detail, the counterpoint of the vast and integrative vision is particularly appreciated.

The addition of a third, intuited witness-self or anterior self to the dyad of the proximate self (I) and distal self (me) is found as especially meaningful, illuminating and promising for future research in the spiritual line of development.

An alternative, and less successful attempt at a grand integration is offered. The difference is mainly that it remains subtly unaware of its treatment of the cosmos as an “it” rather than a “thou” or the eternal “I”.

Gödel “proved” that all symbol systems are self-referential and produce non-contradictory propositions only within their own axiomatic confines. Any analysis of them from an outside frame of reference will produce inconsistencies or “undecidable propositions”.

Examples of how the General Hierarchical Complexity Scoring System (GHCSS) Handout can be applied across domains show both the powerful and the limiting aspects of the system. The example material is from

probed interview studies. The highest examples shown are rated at the metasystematic level 5b. One study is on the moral climate in universities. Some of the text strings rated at 5b might be rated at the Construct-aware ego stage because of the awareness of paradox and contradiction among propositions (C9x) and because of the complexity (nestling) of thoughts (C9v).

On the other hand, an example given for 5b from a life experience interview would be rated lower at E6 or E7 if the higher complexity rule is applied to combinations of conventional elements. The privileging of structure/complexity over actual meaning is also the main critique of the Second Edition. Looking only at the structure of reasoning, hides the fact that it is the rater who assigns “the level of abstractness” to an element produced by the interviewee. It is a matter of definition.

Let me give a concrete example for a 5b rating:

DO YOU FEEL YOU ARE SATISFIED WITH YOUR CLOSE RELATIONSHIP? “Difficult to give a “Yes” or “No.” Probably the best answer is in some ways. On the positive side, “s. o.” [my significant other] relationship has lasted > 6 years; on the negative side, I don’t feel as though I am consistently able to maintain the level of intimacy I would like, primarily because of my work schedule.”

The content and concerns of this response are entirely conventional. Responsibility is placed on technicalities (my schedule). The subject lives in the formal operational world of sharp self-other distinctions and reified objects (intimacy is a clearly defined thing of which one can have more or less). All of these would be signs of a conventional view of reality. Whether “significant other” is interpreted to mean “the concrete significant other I have” or “significant others that are part of relationships in general” depends on the rater. Combined with a precise number of years, it would tend to be seen here as a concrete reference. The issue in all of this is to point out that all scoring systems that are based on text interpretation are vulnerable to rater bias. Each concept can be assigned several different levels of “abstractness” depending on the context and aim of the interpreters.

Postautonomous Ego Development: Its Measurement

Section 1: General Methods

Outline

As has been shown in the previous chapter, parallels with others’ views of postautonomous development can be readily established on a theoretical plane. Both constructivist developmental theorists and researchers studying Eastern paths to maturity suggest that people can develop a stance towards reality that goes beyond the Western rational confines towards ego-transcendence. As individuals recognize ever more profoundly the traps and “unreality” of the world woven with words at the Construct-aware stage, some eventually integrate that understanding into a new, metarational worldview at the Unitive stage. It is astonishing that such sentiments towards experience occur on SCTs at all. However, can the presence of the two proposed advanced ego stages be actually measured by empirical means?

Chapter 4 documents the multiple ways in which measurement issues were explored and tested. The first section describes the overall research design, sampling procedures, data collection and description. Each of the three sections that follow is devoted to a specific set of research questions: The second section addresses individual response agreement and category refinement issues. The third section deals with the central issue of

measuring interrater agreement for whole protocols. The fourth section discusses how cut-off numbers for assigning high-end ego scores were determined and addresses general psychometric issues. Each section describes the methods used to answer the research questions, and reports and discusses the results of the respective studies.

To explore the viability of measuring postautonomous development, the following three sets of questions were posed:

1. How would an experienced scorer rate a random set of postconventional responses with the Second Edition? Which ones would they flag as hard-to-score? What reasons would they give for any difficulties? If they were given the criteria for scoring, would there be any difference in the results? What refinements of the category descriptions could be made through mutual discussion and feedback?
2. What levels of interrater agreement could be achieved for both individual sentence completions and total protocol ratings when novice raters use the category descriptions, stage distinctions and scoring procedure?
3. To what extent does using these new scoring categories and stage distinctions alter the distribution characteristics of postautonomous protocols? Do these warrant a revision of the cut-off numbers at the high end, and if so, what would be the best way to translate the observed distribution patterns into numerical guidelines for scoring postautonomous protocols?

This chapter begins by describing some technical aspects of administering the long-term project of data gathering and entry. For a summary of the two previous waves of data use, the reader is referred to Chapter 2. There, the earlier modification of the theory was described and a set of scoring categories for rating postautonomous protocols that have been used since 1987, but never empirically tested for reliability, was introduced.

The Sample

When looking for rare fish, checking other people's nets is an efficient way to catch interesting specimens. However, this approach also introduces many difficulties as people fish in different waters, use differently gauged nets and sort their catches by different properties.

A long-term, large-scale effort was necessary to find enough rare postautonomous data, both individual responses and total protocols, to analyze them for salient patterns. From 1980 to July 1997, 4420 SCT protocols (consisting of over 130,000 items) from 185 different projects were scored. These projects involved subjects that came from all walks of life (including prisoners, priests, professional managers, undergraduate and graduate students, professors, accountants, administrators and artists, young delinquents and senior executives). Their ages ranged from adolescence to mature adulthood (range 16 to 82). Projects originated from across America, Canada, Australia and the United Kingdom. It is an opportunistic sample with no subsample being systematically representative of any population. The size of the overall sample, the broad age range of the subjects, and the wide geographic provenance make this a very productive sample nonetheless.

The 4420 protocols were scored between 1980 and 1997 and yielded 1100 individual responses (0.8%) that seemed to fall into the postautonomous range. These are the responses that were complex and meaningful, but did not sufficiently fit existing ego development theory, or match the stage or category descriptions of the Autonomous and Integrated stages. Copies of 476 (about one in ten) mostly postconventional protocols were also retained for further analysis.

Throughout the data collection, two tallies were generated for each project. First, the scores from each protocol were entered into an individual, two-part scoring sheet. It contained the individual ratings, alternative scores and

comments as well as summary statistics: These include simple and cumulative item distributions, ogive score, total weighted score (TWS), total protocol rating (TPR) and percentage of responses at the conventional stages.

Figure 4.1 Sampling Procedure

- **Original Data from which Dissertation Sample was Drawn:** 4420 SCT Protocols (~130,000 completions) scored from 1980 to 1997
- **Dissertation Sample:**
 - 228 24-items Form 81-items only (87+ protocols)
 - 41 36-items <85
 - 187 36-items All forms E5-C10
- **Final Samples for Reliability Studies:**
 - 145 individual completions to refine high-end categories
 - 60 Protocols for Interrater Agreement Study
 - 476 mostly postconventional protocols (10.8%)

Also noted were SES and final comments about any unusual observations made on reading the whole protocol. Second, each set of individual scoring sheets was summarized in a master tally. It contained the stage distributions for each protocol as well as the automatic ogives, total weighted scores and final total protocol ratings. Where available, data on gender, age, levels of education, professional occupation, and comments on the ratings were included.

Both individual and project tallies were regularly shared with the respective project administrators as part of the scoring contract to allow the clients to perform independent replication and reliability studies. Each time a project was worked on, the project leader was asked for permission to retain copies of either individual postautonomous completions or entire high-end protocols. In addition, a few other protocols were selected mainly for teaching purposes. To guarantee anonymity, the original identification number and salient project information were kept in a separate file. To insure anonymity further, it was promised not to use and make public more than a few lines from any one protocol.

Rewritten Content

The remaining 61 protocols were excluded from this project because they originated from protocols with 15 items or fewer, or they were below the stage $\frac{3}{4}$ level.

Problems with this approach

As noted in the description of the manuals in Chapter 2, there is an unfortunate proliferation of protocol forms, item combinations, and manuals. Over the years, the framework developers have produced unpublished adjunct manuals for items specific to girls and boys, items specific to men, and preliminary manuals in preparation for the revision. Although the recommended length of a protocol is 36 items, forms with 12, 18, 24, 27, 36, and 44 items have been encountered. The 1970 manual likely began the trend of experimentation by offering six different test forms for different subject groups and 48 different stems. In addition, items that appear

on all the forms are sequenced differently from form to form. Thus, researchers often order the stems to suit their own purposes and add a few items of their own liking. Sometimes these additional items have poor manuals or no published manuals at all.

Partially to remedy this situation, the framework developers introduced a definite 36-item version to replace all previous forms in 1981. Unfortunately, this move did not stop other researchers from using their own forms and, as a result, 55 different stems have been scored and tracked over the years. To manage them, a master list for all stems was created in 1985. Items 1-36 are those from the 1981 form, the same ones used in the Second Edition. Items 37-55 represent stems used in old manuals or in other projects for which manuals exist. Therefore, both the master list number and its actual location number in the sequence of the particular form for each stem and response pair were entered.

The raters

Whenever one deals with postconventional stages, the issue of rater bias (limitation) becomes even more relevant than for ordinary samples. According to the framework developers, the logic of ego theory dictates that only those with a relatively high ego level can become good raters of high-level protocols. The chief access to a person's ego level is precisely that it limits what he or she can conceive and perceive; that limitation holds for raters as well as for subjects.

Thus, it was anticipated that one of the problems with testing high-end material would be to find skilled raters who could learn how to rate and identify (to perceive) the proposed postautonomous stage and category distinctions. There was special concern about the ability of the experienced rater to be able to "speculate about and conceive" of high-end development on his/her own. A person was needed who could evaluate the new scoring manual and who could compare the usefulness of its high-end scoring categories with the proposed ones. This was important since it was hoped to benefit from the experienced rater's insights into the theory for revising and fine-tuning the high-end scoring categories.

Finding raters for this project was indeed very difficult. In March of 1998, a conference on ego development was attended in celebration of a prominent researcher's eightieth birthday. The hope for leads to possible raters was unsuccessful. Only after several more months of looking was an expert rater finally found, a woman who had been trained in 1980 and whose own protocol had been rated at the high end years earlier. This seasoned scorer rated two sets of individual responses twice. Discussions about her rating experience were taped in three two-hour and one one-hour meetings over a six-month period.

Finding raters who could commit to scoring 60 whole protocols proved to be even more difficult. After several months of searching unsuccessfully for raters, a group had to be trained over the summer. A flyer was distributed and advertised on an email system inviting readers to forward the message to whomever they thought might be interested in scoring. The email quickly resulted in nine responses. These volunteers were interviewed to explain the project and needs and answer their questions. Five individuals signed a preliminary contract which stipulated what was offered in terms of training and potential employment and the trainees' responsibility in terms of attending training sessions, doing homework and participating in the project if chosen based on the result of a test at the end of the training series. When all was said and done, the actual scoring task was completed by two participants.

Rater Training

The training workshop was held on three Saturdays in May and June of 1998. It included short lectures, many handouts, and intensive discussion of the actual process of scoring and protocol rating. Participants were

instructed in the theory of ego development and high-end individuation. As homework, they scored the self-training items and half of the practice protocols in the Second Edition. They then practiced scoring during the sessions, first with individual items, then with whole protocols. They needed to learn how to use not only the Second Edition but also the old manuals since the interrater agreement study contained several stems no longer carried in the current manual. Furthermore, in the second session, the proposed postautonomous stages and scoring categories were introduced. The ensuing discussions on theory and measurement issues were intense and inspiring as all participants got caught up in the intricacies and beauty of making fine semantic distinctions, matching the responses with examples in the manuals and connecting the response characteristics to differences in people's ego development.

As if scoring of high-stage material alone was not difficult enough, participants had to learn to manage multiple scoring systems. They dealt gracefully with the hardship of having to translate the numeric stage names from the old manuals instantly into the differing numeric names of the Second Edition. The participants suggested renaming the proposed stages $\frac{5}{6}$ and 6 to C9 and C10 to avoid confusion with the framework developer's stage E6 (Conscientious) from the Second Edition and to distinguish between her highest stage E9 and the revisions. This advice was incorporated in the original reporting to make discussion and comparisons easier for the trainees. It still left the problem of the actual scoring with different manuals. Although complicating matters, this is typical of what can happen with a widely used measure that has had many forms and that has gone through a radical renaming of its components late in the game.

Three women completed all three training sessions and scored two 36-item protocols as a readiness test. All three did well enough and agreed to continue in the project. Though satisfactory overall, the respective tests showed systematic scoring errors. Thus, individual sessions were scheduled to work on the specific problems of each scorer and to deepen her understanding of high-end distinctions before starting on the interrater agreement study proper. The final research team of newly trained raters consisted of three women: a director-level university administrator, a management consultant specializing in transformative learning, and a non-native speaker of English interested in the psychology of creative writers.

With this background information in place, the actual studies that were designed to test empirically the proposed "enhancements" to the scoring method at the postautonomous level of ego development are now discussed.

SECTION 2: TEST OF INTERRATER AGREEMENT FOR INDIVIDUAL COMPLETIONS

Methods

To begin, it was ascertained to what degree an experienced rater would concur that high-stage responses from a random set of late-conventional responses and above 4 to 6 are hard to score with the established method.

1. How would an experienced scorer rate a random set of postconventional responses with the Second Edition? Which ones would s/he flag as hard-to-score? What reasons would s/he give for any difficulties? If given the proposed criteria for scoring, would there be any difference in the results? What refinements of the category descriptions could be made through mutual discussion and feedback?

To test the claim that high-end completions are hard-to-score with the Second Edition, an experienced rater was employed. The process proceeded in a bootstrapping fashion, alternating between (a) independent scoring tests that resulted in reportable numbers for interrater agreement and (b) tape-recorded explorative

conversations about the expert rater's reaction to the scoring experience to further understanding of possible problems and to hone the high-end category descriptions.

Two sets of individual responses matched for stem and stage, Set A and Set B, totaling 145 responses, were prepared. The final sets contained only stems that (a) were in the Second Edition, (b) came from the 12 stems with the most responses, and (c) were higher than stage 3. In an attempt to be rigorous in creating a sample that was both random and matched, an "elaborate" process was gone through. Though practiced even with high-end protocols, the experienced rater had not yet worked with the Second Edition. Since the actual matching procedure has not changed from the old manuals to the Second Edition, it was assumed that the transition from one to the other would be easy. Set A of the individual responses was meant to serve as a learning experience for her in using the Second Edition, set B as an actual test of the usefulness of the proposed categories in improving ratings of high-stage material. A series of separate, reportable rounds of scoring and subsequent taped dialogues about them were proceeded with.

Step 1: The experienced rater scored the 73 items of Set A independently with the Second Edition according to the instructions and "caveats" for rating high-stage completions and protocols. The rater was also invited to indicate on the scoring sheet when and for which reasons she found any completion hard-to-score. It was predicted that disagreements would increase with increasing ego level and complexity of the responses. Interrater agreement between the initial ratings with the Second Edition and hers was measured and reported as a baseline.

Step 2: Next, a meeting was held to discuss her responses to the Second Edition and her ratings and comments to the completions. She was introduced to the proposed interpretation of postconventional ego development and instructed in the application of the high-stage scoring categories by sharing the respective book chapters and through conversation.

Step 3: The experienced scorer rated Set A once more, this time using both the Second Edition and the proposed scoring categories. Again initial agreement was measured and reported.

Step 4: A second meeting was held to compare results. Instances of disagreement were examined and either resolved through discussion or her feedback was used to modify classification categories and/or improve category descriptions. Differences were considered resolved when it was agreed that the proposed descriptions effectively characterized and differentiated high-end responses both from earlier responses and between the two postautonomous stages. A similar procedure was also followed for step 6.

Step 5: The experienced rater scored the 72 completions of Set B with the Second Edition and the refined postautonomous categories. Initial agreement was assessed and reported including Pearson Correlations to indicate the level of agreement between raters.

Step 6: The results were once more discussed, compared and this time differences compromised. The compromised scores were used for the final round of individual interrater reliability testing which included the novice raters.

Set A of the individual responses was used in the initial training of the new raters to help them gain facility with the Second Edition. Set B was added to their independent scoring task to expand the interrater agreement test for individual completions. The results were compared in pairs for each of the completions with the compromised rating from the experienced rater and the researcher, then reported and analyzed.

Given the small number of data in each set, testing for interrater agreement for individual postautonomous categories seemed unproductive. Since a main feature of such responses is their complexity, many fit more than one category within a given stage. According to the framework developers, "such differences [in assigning a category within a stage] are not considered errors". The overall aim of the manuals including the postautonomous categories is to correctly identify the stage to which a completion belongs. It was reasoned that

if the experienced scorer and the scoring team could use the proposed high-end categories and distinctions to rate individual completions reliably at a given stage, there would be some evidence of their fit and their effectiveness. If agreement remained low, the probable reasons for this outcome were planned to be evaluated. It is not uncommon that several rounds of testing and refining coding categories are needed in a new test instrument to achieve even moderate agreement. Testing the efficacy of the high-end criteria first before scoring whole protocols with them was additionally intended to allow for flexibility in the research design. It might have made sense to stop the empirical testing at this juncture, had the outcome been completely negative, that is, if scoring with these new categories proved less accurate than scoring with the existing method.

Results

The probability values for all correlations reported in the interrater agreement studies both for individual items and for whole protocols were statistically significant at $p < .0001$. Since the probabilities are the same throughout, they will not be shown in the tables and the symbol *** will be used in the text to indicate the level of statistical significance.

Table 4.2 PEARSON CORRELATIONS FOR EXPERIENCED RATERS (R1, R2)

Set B	Round 1	Round 2
Rater	R1*R2	Compromised @ Rcomp
r =	.80	

In the learning phase for the expert rater (R2; Set A, Round 1), there was no appreciable difference between scoring with the categories of the New Edition only (Round 1; $r = .91$) **and scoring for the first time with the addition of the proposed postautonomous categories and stage distinctions (Round 2; $r = .93$).**

This was expected since initial agreement between the experienced rater and the researcher was very high. This does not mean, however, that the Second Edition is as useful alone as scoring with the benefit of the added distinctions of the new scoring categories. While, in Round 1, the experienced rater and the researcher scored 12 and 13 completions respectively at the Integrated stage, they scored 29 and 26 responses from the same item set at the two postautonomous stages after they were introduced (Round 2). This may be an indication that the new categories indeed allow for making distinctions that are not possible with the Second Edition.

Table 4.3 PEARSON CORRELATIONS BETWEEN THE COMPROMISED RATING (Rcomp) AND THE NOVICE RATERS (R3, R4) IN PAIRS

N=72	Set B, Round 2		
Rater	Rcomp*R3	Rcomp*R4	R3*R4
r =	.85	.69	.69

Round 1 of Set B served to give the expert rater further experience with the new categories. It also allowed arrival at a set of compromised scores after differences were discussed. Agreement was reached in all but three cases. These compromised scores (Rcomp) were then used as a basis for comparison with the novice raters (R3, R4). The second set of individual sentence completions (Set B), scored by both the experienced raters and

the novice raters, fared less well than Set A. The scores ranged from $r = .80^{***}$ for the two experienced raters (see Table 4.2) to $r = 0.69^{***}$ for the two trainees paired with the compromised scores.

Agreement within one stage ranged from 69.4% between the experienced raters to 90.3% for Rater 3 and the compromised scores. Rater 3 had a talent for making high-stage distinctions. Rater 4 remained reliable, but more uncertain about the distinctions between the Construct-aware and the Unitive stage. Indeed, she did not rate any responses at the highest stage in Rounds 1 or 2.

Discussion

Because of the random sampling procedure, data Set B was harder to score and contained some very “strange” and very complex responses. These were rated by some scorers using Rule 5 for unscorable responses at the compromise stage 3, and given higher “guess” scores by others. While isolated “odd” completions do occur on protocols occasionally, their impact is negligible in the context of the other items on a protocol. In isolation, however, they may unduly influence the outcome. This may partially explain the lower agreement between outcomes for Set A and Set B. In addition, Rater 4 had some difficulty in picking up the signals for the highest stage as mentioned above.

During discussions with the expert rater about her experience with the Second Edition, she spontaneously expressed her disappointment with it on several occasions. The following comments about stages 5 and the highest stage are from the discussion after the expert rater had used the Second Edition for the first time:

“There were so few criteria in the new manual that I couldn’t justify a particular rating.”

“The new combination rules don’t make any logical sense for my matrix. The new rules conflict with the old ones, which were fine.”

Later she expressed a preference in some instances for coding with the proposed categories because they actually provided themes that capture some of the qualitative difference of responses from the Construct-aware and the Unitive stage:

“Some responses just seemed too ambiguous to interpret without looking at the total protocol. But I am fascinated by your descriptions of the felt experience of these more complex levels. I especially appreciate your portrait of the hope and effort to paint a complete picture, to make lists, as if things are, ultimately, listable-describable and knowable-once and for all. I like the vividness of the contrast you make with what comes after that: a stance more like relinquishment and acceptance, and even pleasure in incompleteness and indescribability.”

Overall, she found it difficult to migrate to the new stage names and considerable effort was spent on entering and translating the scores, and trying to communicate across the confusing labels.

As hoped, the experienced rater had her own conceptions of highest stage ego development. Much of the discussion time was taken up with trying to put into words what the thinking was behind the categories and how distinctions were made among stages 5, $\frac{5}{6}$, and 6. The expert rater, in turn, asked for clarification and challenged some interpretations. Being able to discuss the nuances of the higher stages with a knowledgeable and thoughtful partner is a real pleasure and often more quickly productive than private musings. Initially, the expert rater’s conception of the Unitive stage was more idealistic than the proposed one, and allowed for no signs of doubt or ambivalence. Given the proposed view of development this is an unrealistic, though widely shared view that the framework developers commented on as well:

“Many theorists are tempted to believe that there is an ultimate stage of life that combines all virtues and is a paragon of good adjustment, a state of grace which most of us believe we have achieved or are on the verge of

achieving. We did find some responses by persons at high ego levels that indicated a well-adjusted life or attitude toward life.”

Full-spectrum theories of development based on Eastern traditions have, of course, postulated an ultimate reality of complete union, a state (not a stage) in which distinctions are meaningless. They also postulate intermediate stages beyond the third tier. These ego-transcendent stages are, by definition, of a different nature than the kind of “grace” which the framework developers refer to, and which can be gained in the personal realm through ego development. Even if a subject were at one of the transcendent stages of consciousness, it is unlikely that the subtleties would be picked up by an instrument like the sentence completion test. A probed interview would offer a more effective way to explore the nature of development beyond the personal realm.

As long as people develop, the changes they undergo inevitably pose opportunities for both adjustment and maladjustment as each stage solves some problems (gains new freedoms) and is subject to new limits. What is experienced as a challenge at each stage, is likely to change with the changing reality perception. In fact, there exists a carefully elaborated literature on the difficulties and pathologies of the stages at the fourth, transpersonal tier of development. In the Western mental health field, developmental psychopathology is relatively new and underexplored. As far as is known, nobody has yet done systematic research into what mental difficulties are most prevalent at the third tier of ego development. Suffice it to say in the context of this project, that the postautonomous stages are not conceived of as problem-free or as immune to mental disorders.

In the design of this project, the feedback from the experienced rater was to be the final step in optimizing the category selection and description. However, due to the long delay between meetings, the conversations with the training workshop participants turned out to be as salient and important in sharpening the category descriptions as the feedback from the experienced rater. These descriptions themselves have not changed in substance, but for some categories, a title phrase has been added to highlight the main feature.

While the experienced scorer was familiar with the conception of the Autonomous stage from the earlier manuals and from the theory, the new raters were reluctant to use the stage 5 rating because they could not deduce the stage character from the few examples given for it. In all paired comparisons, the greatest disagreement occurred in relation to stage 5. Indeed, when the contingency tables were examined, R3 and R4 had zero agreement in assigning this stage to individual completions while the compromised Rcomp pairings with both R3 and R4 showed more scatter for rating the Autonomous stage than for any other stage.

The expert scorer, assessing her experience with the Second Edition at the end of her involvement with the project, wrote the following:

“The new manual (...) may make it easier to learn to score simpler protocols. But, this manual reads like ‘WUSCT Lite.’ It’s as if the author wanted to make a neat package, and the messy parts didn’t fit. (...) I found the old manual richer in its presentation of a commonly-found response in the heading, with variations below, so that one could get a general idea of how respondents might understand a stem. The new manual also belies the complexity of the more cognitively complex stages by giving so few examples.”

Conclusion

In response to the research question whether using the proposed category and stage descriptions made a difference to an experienced scorer using them in conjunction with the Second Edition, the answer is not decisive. First, adding the new categories, did not make an appreciable difference statistically. This is not unusual when initial agreement is over 90 percent since there is little room for improvement. On the other hand, there was better agreement for the postautonomous stages than there was for the Autonomous stage. It appears to be the weakest link in the stage sequence that combines the earlier stages with the proposed higher

stages. Moreover, agreement on isolated individual sentence completions is not necessarily a valid indicator for how well the scoring categories will function in assessing ego stage in the context of whole protocols.

In light of these considerations, there was enough agreement between raters on the first try to progress to the next phase and test the revised high-end scoring categories with a set of full-length protocols as planned.

SECTION 3: TEST OF INTERRATER AGREEMENT FOR SIXTY 36-ITEM HIGH-END PROTOCOLS

The first study showed that scoring individual, out-of-context, high-end sentence completions can be done with satisfactory results using the proposed postautonomous scoring categories. Naturally, high-end responses take on their full significance only in the context of a whole protocol. Thus, the next step involved testing to what degree the raters would agree in scoring whole protocols.

1. What levels of interrater agreement can be achieved in total protocol ratings when trained raters use the revised category descriptions, stage distinctions and scoring procedure?

Sample

A selective sample was necessary in order to test the postautonomous categories empirically. Despite the years of effort to find high-end protocols, the numbers are still very small. Since the framework developers' requirements for inclusion in their highest stage are softer, a few protocols that came from other researchers that used the "standard" cut-off numbers did not qualify as postautonomous protocols for this sample.

To test protocol interrater agreement, the 187 out of 231 36-item protocols that had rated in the upper-half of the scale with the old manuals based on more rigorous cut-off numbers were selected. They were transcribed into a consistent format into tables including word counts for each protocol and both the consecutive and the master list item numbers were noted.

Since the goal was to use about 12 protocols from each of the five stages, every third protocol from the stage 4, every fourth of $\frac{4}{5}$, every other from $\frac{5}{6}$ and almost all from the rare 6 group among the 36-item protocols were picked. Originally, analysis by gender was not a specific goal. However, by chance, the resulting groups were almost evenly matched for gender so that such a comparison became an option.

Table 4.4 SAMPLE (N=60) STRATIFIED FOR OLD TPR

Current Stage names	4	$\frac{4}{5}$	5	$\frac{5}{6}$	6	Total
Distn N=187	47	57	44	26	12	
Goal by stage	12	12	12	12	12	60
Actual distribution by old TPR	12	14	12	13	9	60
F/m ratio	$\frac{5}{7}$	$\frac{8}{6}$	$\frac{7}{5}$	$\frac{4}{9}$	$\frac{7}{2}$	$\frac{31}{29}$

Next the 60 protocols were sorted into four batches of 15 protocols each, making sure that each batch contained some protocols from each stage in random order. According to standard procedure, all the completions of each batch were then combined and sorted by stem to insure that the initial rating of individual completions was out of context. Since these protocols came from many different 36-item forms, 54 out of the 55

items on the master list appeared among them and thus the sequence for each stem was naturally scrambled. When the completions all come from the same protocol form, one has to randomize the order of items for a given stem additionally to avoid context bias. This was a rare occasion where having data from many forms turned out to be a small benefit.

As soon as the batches were ready in the summer of 1998, and before giving them to the team, they were rated with the Second Edition and the results entered into a spreadsheet. A comparison with the old ratings can thus be reported. While doing so, the support materials for the assistants were prepared. This step helped appreciate just how taxing a task they had agreed to accomplish.

The raters used the Second Edition for all stems that it included. They also relied on their copies of old manuals for the ten stems with the most occurrences no longer part of the Second Edition. The rest of the stems—at most three per protocol—for which they had no manuals at all had to be rated based on their knowledge of the theory only. This is admissible by rating Rule 4 which states:

“In the case of a meaningful response, where there is no appropriate category and Rules 2 and 3 [for compound sentences] do not apply, use the general theory to arrive at a rating.”

Next, each batch of 540 items was sorted in increasing order by stem from the master list. Each response was identified by the batch number as well as its position number on the original protocol to facilitate entry into the scoring sheet at a later stage of the procedure. A log was retained which matched the batch numbers with the original protocol numbers from the protocol list. Throughout this process, only the ID# and the batch numbers were used to safeguard the anonymity of the subjects as well as to protect the raters from any information about the subjects that might influence them.

Scoring

Three raters started the independent scoring effort in August of 1998. After all items of a batch were scored, the participants had to enter each response into the correct cell on the scoring sheets provided. This again was a difficult task since the actual protocols differed considerably in the sequence of items. A test of success was when all 36 cells in a scoring sheet were filled and no duplicates and no empty cells remained. In spite of vigilance, this step was found to be time-consuming and especially prone to clerical error.

The next step for the raters was to calculate the simple and the cumulative response distributions for each protocol and to enter the information in the individual scoring sheet. After that, they determined the automatic preliminary ogive scores and the total weighted score for each protocol.

To arrive at a final TPR, the protocol is read as a whole to check whether the overall content reflects the theoretical characteristics of the probable stage and whether the protocol fulfills the additional requirements for being scored at that stage. For assigning postconventional ogives, more stringent cut-off numbers were used than the framework developers'. The higher the protocol, the more variety of structure and content, depth and complexity is required.

To assign TPRs, the raters also considered the required spread of high-stage categories for highest stage ratings. More detailed information will be given in Section 4 on determining cut-off numbers for high-end TPRs. Finally, the raters filled out a one page summary tally for each batch of 15 protocols.

When a finished batch was received, the item by item results from the individual scoring tallies and the summary information were entered into a spreadsheet. Doing it by batches was of practical advantage as it enabled data entry as it arrived rather than all at once and thus to get a feel how the project was progressing. Two raters finished the assignment within three months. Both scored sixty 36-item protocols and Set B of the individual completions. The third rater opted out after discovering that she did not have the patience for scoring minutiae although she had an affinity for the theory. This reaction can be readily understood by anyone who has

rated protocols. While one needs to be somewhat compulsive to do a thorough matching job and systematic in entering data, a tendency to overanalyze the responses does not lead to improved ratings.

The final worksheet contained the individual scores for each of the 60 protocols, the automatic ogive, the TPR, and the TWS from the two independent raters, the researcher, and the scores from the previous rating with the old manuals. Next the total protocol ratings were compared for percentage agreement and reported both overall and in pairs.

Because of the proliferation of different forms, an item by item comparison was not done. Cronbach's alpha coefficient served as a measure of consistency. Exact agreement as well as agreement within one stage are also good indicators of interrater agreement. These were also calculated and will be reported below. The results from this statistical analysis were to tell how relatively reliable the postautonomous categories and stage distinctions are in scoring high-end protocols and in assigning final scores.

Are stages $\frac{5}{6}$ and 6 really different stages on a continuum?

To test whether the two new stages are both different from each other and higher than the Autonomous stage, the distribution curves for each kind of aggregate TPR type were compared. These distributions were drawn based on the results from scoring the 60 protocols. First, if the distribution moves towards the higher end overall with increasing TPR, there is some indication that the categories can detect the predicted order of the newly defined stages. Second, if there are differences between the different stages, their distribution curves should be discontinuous and have clearly separate peaks.

Results

Sample analysis

The sample consisted of 31 women and 29 men between the ages of 16 and 79. 78% were between the ages of 26 and 65. In general they were highly educated with 34 of them having a Master's degree or higher.

Twenty-two subjects were in the management sector (8 mid managers, 2 supervisors, 6 executives, 2 professors of management, and 3 management consultants, as well as 1 entrepreneur). 25 were students at the time of taking the test at various levels of education. An artist, a priest, a professor of sociology, a military officer, a physicist, a physician, a couple of counselors and teachers were also among the sample. Two individuals were retired. Thus, education and management were heavily represented in this opportunistic sample. On the other hand, subjects for the protocol sample belonged to 45 different projects and came from across the USA, Canada and the UK which introduced some desired variability.

Table 4.5 DEMOGRAPHIC CHARACTERISTICS OF SAMPLE: AGE AND EDUCATION (N=60) (f=31, m=29)

Age	<19	19-25	26-35	36-45	46-65	66+	Unknown
f	3	0	10	14	3	0	1
m	0	1	12	7	8	1	0

Education	<HS	<BS/BA	<Masters	Masters/+	ABD	Ph.D.	Unknown
f	3	6	3	9	1	2	7
m	0	5	5	6	3	7	3

When studying high-stage performance, it is natural that people with more education are more likely to be included. The real surprises were a 17-year-old girl at a Magnet Arts High School, and a 47-year-old entrepreneur with a High School education. Both their protocols scored at the Construct-aware stage. A 26-year-old military officer scored at the Unitive stage. Overall seven out of eight stage 6 protocols came from people aged 26 to 44, the priest's age was unknown. Thus, the average of 33.7 is ten years below the expected age for a Unitive worldview. It had previously been assumed that it would occur only at or beyond middle age.

Except for the priest's, the Unitive protocols all came from graduate students but from different schools. Thus, the intellectual environment is likely to have played a significant role in their views and the ease with which they responded to the simple stimuli with complex utterances. A longitudinal study would be especially interesting in these cases to test whether (a) the participants will settle on a lower ego level in a less supportive and challenging environment after leaving school and/or (b) "graduate school" simply allowed them to be who they were earlier than they might have been in less conducive circumstances, or © other factors played a decisive role.

Interrater agreement

To test interrater agreement the paired Pearson correlations for TPRs for the two raters and the researcher were determined as well as Cronbach's alpha coefficient, which estimates internal-consistency or homogeneity.

Table 4.6 PEARSON CORRELATIONS FOR TPRs BY THREE RATERS (R1, R3, R4) N=60

	Rater 1	Rater 3
Rater 3	.95	
Rater 4	.84	.79

Paired agreement for TPR between the two trained raters and the researcher was high with p values = .0001 for all correlations. Even Rater 4, who had some difficulty making the distinctions at the highest stage, did well. She agreed with the researcher $r = .84$, and with Rater 3, $r = .79$.

Cronbach's alpha coefficient was 0.95 for TPRs and 0.96 for the TWSs. An alpha of .95 shows that others can indeed learn to make the distinctions at the high end of the scale reliably using the new scoring criteria for stages $\frac{5}{6}$ and 6.

The sums of the TPRs for the three raters were clustered tightly at 473, 474, and 469 respectively with corresponding means of 7.9, 7.9, 7.8 and Standard Deviations of 1.30 to 1.38. The average protocol of the sample was almost at the Autonomous stage 5. This was expected as the protocols had been selected based on ratings with the old manuals to fall about evenly into the five highest stages. The actual agreement between the old ratings (dating from 1980-1995) and the ratings of the same protocols with the Second Edition in July of 1998 was high. The Pearson Correlations were $r = .91^{***}$ for TPR and $r = .95^{***}$ for TWS.

A pattern output table, comparing the agreement patterns for three raters on 60 protocols, is another way of showing internal consistency. Complete agreement for all three raters occurred in 26 (43.3%) cases. There was

three-way agreement within one stage in 30 cases (50%). In only four cases was the difference between the highest and the lowest score for a given protocol two stages, and in no instance was disagreement greater than two. Thus there was 93.3% three-way agreement within one stage, a most remarkable outcome for (1) having used stringent cut-off numbers, and (2) for having been achieved with a sample that, by all definitions, was difficult to score.

If looking at total agreement without distinguishing between stages $\frac{5}{6}$ and 6, there was three-way 61.7% total agreement and 100% agreement within 1 stage. That agreement is higher when fewer distinctions are made, stands to reason. Overall, the demonstrated high consistency of agreement among all three raters testifies to the reliability and discriminative power of the distinctions that were introduced.

Sequentiality and discreteness of the new stages

The following numbers and the corresponding graph of the distribution curves for each ego stage (type of TPR) shows how, with increasing ego stage, the percentage of responses at a given stage shifts to the right. With each shift, fewer responses occur at the lower levels and more at increasingly higher ones in a clearly clustered pattern.

Table 4.7 makes vivid the wide range of completions seen in many high-stage protocols. When the distributions for each ego stage type are aggregated as they are here, the effect is even more noticeable. The widest spread occurred at the Autonomous stage where the twelve protocols had completions ranging from 2 to 6. The narrow spread for $\frac{3}{4}$ could be an artifact of the $N=1$, but it also represents a general tendency of the conventional personality to adhere to the narrow parameters of conventionality. Not unusually, one encounters a protocol that is entirely located at the conventional tier.

Table 4.7 FREQUENCY DISTRIBUTION BY TPR: PERCENTAGES OF ITEMS SCORED WITHIN EACH CATEGORY, BY STAGE. (N=2160 item ratings from 60 protocols)

TPR	N	<3	3	$\frac{3}{4}$	4	$\frac{4}{5}$	5	$\frac{5}{6}$	6
6	288	1.0	2.1	10.8	13.9	24.3	30.9	17.0	
$\frac{5}{6}$	540	0.2	1.7	4.4	14.1	23.3	27.4	25.7	3.1
5	432	0.7	4.6	11.3	27.1	27.8	21.3	5.3	1.9
$\frac{4}{5}$	468	0.6	3.4	16.5	43.2	25.9	10.0	0.4	
4	396	1.5	8.8	30.3	44.7	12.1	2.3	0.3	
$\frac{3}{4}$	36	27.8	47.2	16.7	8.3				

As can be seen in Figure 4.2 below, the overall distributions are consistent with predictions as well as the gradual shift of the center of the distributions toward the right with increasing TPR. This reflects the shifting center of meaning making at successively higher ego stages. The graph shows that the distribution curves for the different personality types (ego stages) are clearly discontinuous and distinct from each other as each type of TPR peaks in a different area of the distribution space. The prediction that the distribution patterns for different ego stages are distinct is supported by the evidence.

For a stage theory to be hierarchical, the stages have to be distinct and sequential. Stages 5, $\frac{5}{6}$ and 6 follow each other in a sequential order and are discontinuous according to the percentage frequency distributions for the different groups of TPRs. Therefore, the Construct-aware and the Unitive stage seem to fulfill the stage requirements for being higher order hierarchical integrations.

Discussion

Is such high interrater agreement for TPRs replicable? Unlike scoring average protocols which can be “learned” by following the self-training exercises in the Second Edition and some discussion with other raters, learning to successfully score the high-end categories and stage distinctions requires thorough training, explicit theory and probably, minimally, a Conscientious ego stage. Even with intensive training, the raters tend to make systematic errors in the areas that are beyond their own ken. These can be picked up and addressed in a training situation, but would otherwise remain undetected. In this case, Rater 3 who had a special aptitude for the instrument, initially tended to overuse stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (false positives) while Rater 4 generally missed the signs for 6 (false negatives). In addition, Rater 4 preferred the $\frac{4}{5}$ rating over any other.

Figure 4.2 DISTRIBUTION OF PERCENTAGE ITEM FREQUENCY BY TPR

Problems with identifying the Autonomous stage: Both novice scorers avoided using the 5 rating for the individual completions because they said they found the manual too vague and inconclusive. They reported that they could not deduce the Autonomous personality type from the examples and descriptions given in the Second Edition. This uncertainty is again reflected in the contingency tables for whole protocols: Predictably, some disagreement occurred for assigning the highest, Unitive stage score since it is the most difficult to identify and most apt to reflect rater limitation. Between Rater 1 and Rater 3, there was still more agreement than disagreement (71%).

In contrast, the consistent disagreement for the Autonomous stage, seems more problematic. While Rater 1 and Rater 3 agreed 11 times, but disagreed 4 times, (73%) in assigning stage 5, the agreement for stage 5 between R1*R4 and R3*R4 were 18.8% and 15.8% respectively. For no other stages in the sequence was disagreement greater than agreement. Moreover, there didn't seem to be a pattern in the instances of low agreement. That the greatest rater uncertainty occurred around 5, seems to be a sign that there may be a problem with the New Edition in defining and illustrating the nature of the Autonomous stage.

This situation is partly due to the many new combinatorial categories for the Autonomous stage. The old manual left the assessment to the rater of whether a compound response was multi-part and more complex or merely multi-part by providing clear Scoring Rules for compound sentences. In 1993, the framework developers discussed this issue in the following manner, consistent with the higher complexity requirement:

“One of the toughest problems was how to score responses comprising two or more elements each of which could be scored alone. (...) Where two or more responses contrast in such a way that the combination generates paradox or greater complexity, then the rating is one level higher than for the highest element. The detailed rules parallel the rules of skill theory.”

The Second Edition continues to list the same scoring rules, but then offers many new, combinatorial high-end categories. These simply add several conventional elements together regardless of whether the meaning they create is of a higher complexity than the constituting parts. Recipe-style assignment of postconventional ratings is clearly in conflict with the concept of ego development. It is the qualitative differences that make the difference among stages, not just the number of elements. As the expert rater commented earlier, by retaining the rules and introducing the combinatorial categories, many conflicts have been introduced. Given that all three

scorers found fault with the Second Edition for some of the same reasons enumerated in Chapter 2, the Autonomous stage and the combinatorial categories are an area that perhaps needs to be reconsidered.

Rater bias

Since the distinctions at the postautonomous level are subtle and out of the range of most people's frame of reference, the possibility of rater limitation bias was a private concern at the beginning of this reliability study. Would the novice scorers be able to learn to make the distinctions quite possibly several stages above their own?

The experienced rater's score was known to be high. Thus, it could be anticipated that she would be able to assess high-end distinctions. No such expectations existed for the workshop participants found by email advertising. The more remarkable is the result and the more admirable was the performance of the two assistants. They became proficient in ego development theory as well as in the category and the stage distinctions for the two new postautonomous stages. They learned how to manage two scoring systems (old and new) with conflicting names and rules. Finally, they had to score 60 difficult protocols, and do all this in the short time of six months.

As mentioned in Chapter 2, unlike the established categories, the scoring categories for stages $5\frac{5}{6}$ and 6 are not stem-specific. Instead, they apply across the test to all items. Beginning at the postconventional tier, protocols become increasingly unique, richly varied in thought and emotional texture as well as in sentence structure. Because matches are improbable at this level of abstraction and complexity, it made more sense to extract characteristics for them at the most general level. The framework developers provide only 18 examples for the Integrated stage in the Second Edition, with most stems having no entry. Granted, dealing with both stem-specific and stage-wide categories for scoring high protocols, may be an unorthodox solution, but from the evidence so far, it may be more workable than the minimalist approach used in the Second Edition.

Conclusion

People interested in using the proposed high-stage scoring categories and stage distinctions can learn to use them reliably for scoring high-end tests with appropriate training. Indeed, using the postautonomous distinctions and categories may give more distinct and valid results than using the Second Edition alone for projects with high-end protocols. Especially if postconventional ego development is conceived of as the gradual deconstruction of self-boundaries, consensus of what constitutes the best examples of mature ego development may increase among those exploring this area if the proposed high-stage characteristics are taken into account.

Finally, given the results of the interrater agreement study for rating whole protocols, there is strong evidence to refute the "null hypothesis" that rating high-end completions cannot be done reliably because systematic criteria for assessing postautonomous completions cannot be found.

In this section interrater agreement for sixty high-end protocols was tested, and a positive conclusion was drawn as to (a) the viability of measuring the proposed Construct-aware and the Unitive stages and (b) as to their emergence in the predicted hierarchical sequence.

The remaining step of the measurement chapter is to determine fitting cut-off numbers for assigning total protocol ratings to the two new postautonomous stages.

SECTION 4: DETERMINING CUT-OFF NUMBERS

1. To what extent does using these new scoring categories and stage distinctions alter the distribution characteristics of postautonomous protocols? Do these changes warrant a revision of the cut-off numbers at the high end, and if so, what is a reasonable way to translate the distribution patterns into numerical guidelines for scoring postautonomous protocols?

Again, this step was designed to be explored only if warranted by the outcomes of the previous step. Since the protocol interrater agreement was sound, examining what rationale other than Bayes theorem might be used to determine cut-off numbers for assigning postautonomous ratings to 36-item protocols was proceeded with. It was felt that the numbers needed to be more in tune with people whose “center of gravity” seems to be at these two highest stages.

One of the many ways stage measurements differ is in the algorithm they use to determine what final stage score to give the collected material evidence. No matter what the method—structured interview, multiple choice test, signal detection procedure, or sentence completion tests—human beings tend to give responses at more than one level. By probing or inviting the participants to go deeper, one hopes that they will respond at their highest, most thoughtful level. One thus rates a test at the highest stage that is exhibited if enough evidence at that stage is present and not enough at the next higher level. How many instances are deemed to be “enough” is, of course, the big question, which gets answered by different researchers differently.

The unprobed test tends to elicit responses from a wider range of stages than probed instruments as indicated in Table 4.7. Low tests may be narrowly spread because of their authors’ cognitive limitations, conventional ones are often entirely contained within the conventional tier, but most protocols range over 4 or more stages. Indeed, in the context of a whole high-end protocol, having the freedom to respond spontaneously without hiding one’s occasional raw feelings can be a sign of non-defensiveness rather than impulsivity even though the particular element of the response might be rated at a preconventional stage.

To do justice to the tendency to give responses in a bell-like distribution curve, the ogive method (ogives = cumulative frequency polygons) was developed to determine ego stage using the cumulative distributions of the individual responses as a starting point.

Overall, there is agreement that ogives better reflect the variations in the distributions of real protocols than choosing either the highest level displayed or the most often used (mode) as a criterion for assigning a final score. As has been seen, the higher the stage, the more the center of the distribution curve moves to the right.

On the other hand, the requirement of two highest-stage item scores for a protocol to be rated at the highest stage is found to be too low. According to the criteria, the confidence level for two items is only 0.84. It reaches 0.98 for three items. In experience, people who function at the postautonomous stages respond more frequently with postautonomous responses. It is affirmed that “the most convincing protocols have three or four ratings” at the highest stage.

The postautonomous protocols that were examined showed distributions with significantly more high responses than anticipated. This makes sense if the ego stage of a person is understood to represent his or her core functioning or favored way of dealing with reality. When read as a whole, protocols with only two or three responses at the highest stage simply did not seem to fit the overall feel or expected profile of a person who has developed a postautonomous frame of mind. Even though the percentage of people at stages $\frac{5}{6}$ and 6 is low (< 2%), those who are at them seem to clearly speak from that vantage point. Therefore, it was felt that cutoff numbers needed to be related to the actual number of postautonomous responses observed in postautonomous protocols, rather than merely based on probabilistic calculations.

Postconventional and Postautonomous Ego Development: Theory and Measurement

Methodological Considerations in Stage Assignment

As previously discussed, test creators must inevitably choose the final parameters by which they distinguish among stages in any method of assigning developmental stage scores to sets of empirical evidence. Whether this evidence consists of interview transcripts, behavioral observations, or sentence completions, the final choice of what constitutes evidence and how many pieces of evidence are required to draw a conclusion is a necessary step. This choice is also arbitrary—not in the sense of being random or capricious, but in the sense of being arbitrated, reasoned, and deliberated. It is a matter of choice and not inevitable; it is not the only choice reasonable people could make. Once a scheme is in place, this simple fact often seems to be forgotten. Especially in the realm of wisdom and mature human meaning-making, overly logical and mathematically-derived conclusions seem inadequate. This argument has been made previously in critiquing models of hierarchical complexity. For similar reasons, it is made here regarding the method of assigning final ratings to protocols at the high extreme. The mismatch between method and theory seems problematic.

The Use of Bayes' Theorem

The reasoning for requiring only two responses at the highest stage for rating a protocol at the Integrated stage continues to be based on probabilistic grounds. The method, its costs, and its benefits were evaluated. Bayes' theorem was used to determine how many signs (completions) would be minimally necessary to assert that the protocol having the determined number of signs was likely to be at the extreme stage under consideration. The argument still relies on the low-end, Impulsive stage as a model case. The striking qualitative differences between low and high stages are ignored, and both ends are treated as interchangeable with respect to the statistical method. Below, it is spelled out how such probabilistic reasoning is tied to a concatenation of "ifs" and adjustable percentages for the proportion of protocols with or without the sign and the proportion of probable true and false positives.

According to this reasoning, the probability of correctly identifying a protocol as being at the highest stage is 34% if there is only one sign, and if it is assumed (a) that overall 5% of all responses are at the highest stage and, (b) that on average, false positives occur 5% of the time, and false negatives 50%. That is, with one sign, the confidence that a protocol is at the highest stage is only about $\frac{1}{3}$. If there are two clear and "independent" signs (completions) for the highest stage, the odds of correctly identifying a protocol as being at that stage increase to 84% (which is 34% better than by chance), and if there are three signs, to 98%. Thus, three signs rather than two seem a more adequate choice as a minimal requirement even within this argument.

If the more realistic, empirically based 1% for each of the postautonomous stages is chosen, the probability figures for correctly identifying a high-end protocol change as follows: One sign = 10%, two signs = 50%, three signs = 91%, and four signs = 99%. Thus, two signs would be no better than assigning a high stage by chance. To require minimally four signs for rating a protocol at the Construct-aware or Unitive stages seems a better choice.

The decision to settle on only two signs was presumably made so that at least a few protocols made the cut, given that there were so few high-end protocols and consensus was lacking. The current suggestion of combining the Integrated with the Autonomous stage is reasonable if the projected highest stage is indeed as poorly understood and so rare as to be close to nonexistent.

However, as has been shown, this is no longer the case. The most insightful subjects in the sample seemed to have a clear and coherent voice coming from their postautonomous reality perspectives. If it is held that ego stages reflect the habitual frame of reference of their “owners,” which is for them the most meaningful and coherent explanation for the way things are, one would expect to see a more consistent use of the preferred epistemology even in a test situation.

Having established that the postautonomous stage distinctions and categories have merit in rating high-end protocols, the ranges and averages of Construct-aware and Unitive completions for the protocols in this project were calculated. However, to determine final cut-off numbers for the entire postconventional tier, including the more frequent Individualistic and Autonomous stages, one would want to use the larger database from which this sample was drawn.

Results

The following cut-off numbers were determined by examining the frequency distributions for all protocols at a given higher stage, and then determining the range and averaging the numbers.

Total Protocol Ratings (TPRs) for the Construct-aware and Unitive stages in this study were based on the “a-minimum-of-four” cut-off rule. Thus, the range starts with four. Four signs represent a 99% confidence that the protocol is at the given postautonomous stage based on Bayes’ theorem and the realistic 1 percent occurrence for each of the postautonomous stages in the original large sample.

Given the average number of postautonomous responses of 6.1 at the Unitive stage, and 11.1 at the Construct-aware stage for the Unitive stage, requiring at least four Unitive stage completions at the Construct-aware stage for a Unitive stage rating seems sensible. Combined with the rationale of Bayes’ theorem, this is stringent, but not unduly so. At least four ratings (average 9.3 at the Construct-aware stage) at the Autonomous stage looks appropriate too for a TPR at the Construct-aware stage. The minimally four ratings above the Autonomous stage may be either from the Construct-aware stage alone or distributed between the Construct-aware and Unitive stages. Additional conditions need to be fulfilled as well for a Construct-aware TPR. If ego stage represents a person’s main frame of reference, then fewer than four responses at either the Construct-aware or Unitive stages may be seen as part of the natural spread or variability of developing human beings, not as an indication of their having reached those stages.

Conclusion

Using ogives is an elegant solution to the problem of allocating stage scores as it “respects” the stage spread that characteristically occurs on the unprobed sentence completion test. Moreover, employing Bayes’ theorem for the problem of determining cut-off numbers at the high-end was a creative move at the original time. On the other hand, Bayesian reasoning alone was found to be inappropriate at the upper end given the definition of ego stages as that frame of mind a person most readily employs in everyday situations. Anecdotal evidence from pilot interviews confirms that postautonomous adults really shift their attention away from Autonomous reasoning. They do not wish to go back to the previous, more limited way of being because it no longer seems adequate and satisfying.

In the end, only a good understanding of the processes governing ego development and a secure sense of the differences among different ego stages will result in making ego development scoring with the sentence completion test the successful translation of a qualitative into a corresponding quantitative entity that it is meant to be. But quantitative methods must remain a handmaiden to theory, not lead it. In this view, “measuring” ego development cannot be divorced from the raters’ interpretation much beyond the conventional stages. What a

carefully designed instrument can do is help to make the process leading up to the final rating as systematic and as bias-free as possible.

The revised manual does this passably for the lower stages, but it fails to do justice to the complexity and richness of the third tier of development, especially at the most mature positions. There, the ego becomes aware of its own shenanigans and learns to remain witness to the process of meaning-making rather than to constantly reach for rhyme and reason. Witnessing allows the habits of incessant self-evaluating and automatic categorizing of all other phenomena to be seen for what they are: temporarily successful means of perpetuating the illusion of object permanence.

Discussion and Conclusion

Summary of Thesis and Results

This research explored the rare phenomenon of postautonomous ego development in order to create more adequate theory and measurement of this little-understood area of adult development. The goal was to provide an alternative to the earlier conception of high-end ego development.

In light of two decades of research in the field of advanced adult development and new data from the sentence completion test, it seemed important to reassess both the theory and the instrument at the highest levels of observed ego development. In particular, the oft-repeated contention that postautonomous ego development can be vaguely described at best, and that systematic criteria for assessing it in sentence completions cannot be found, was challenged.

This whole long-term project started out based on some intriguing high-end responses to the sentence completion test. These unique responses did not fit existing ego development theory, nor could they be scored with the manual in a consistent or satisfactory manner. What were merely hunches initially about late-stage development became testable propositions as high-end sentence completions were systematically gathered and analyzed over more than a decade in order to shed some light on this neglected research area of developmental theory.

Overall, this research was conceived as a secondary analysis and testing of propositions about high-end ego development theory and measurement that were published earlier. At the start of this study, a reinterpretation of high-end ego development had been proposed, but not yet validated, in response to perceived problems and limitations of the earlier theory. It was recommended that the Integrated stage be replaced with two stages: a Construct-aware stage and a Unitary (Unitive) stage. These stages were characterized by increasing levels of deconstruction of the concept of a permanent object world (including the search for an enduring and objective self-identity) with increasing understanding of the constructed nature of everyday reality. Moreover, it was posited that, based on sentence completion data, the highest observable stage, the Unitive stage, shared some features with beginning ego-transcendent conceptions of reality as described in the spiritual traditions of the East and in contemporary transpersonal psychology.

The plausibility of such an interpretation of late-stage conceptions of reality was explored in the context of the current literature of postconventional development in both constructivist and transpersonal developmental psychology. For maximum comparability with the Autonomous and Integrated stages, theories were selected that (a) are non-domain specific, (b) investigate reality conceptions beyond the general systems stage, or indicate postautonomous concerns, and © focus on meaning-making and insight into the human condition rather than merely on cognitive complexity and abstract reasoning.

First, it was tested whether a different conceptualization of post-conventional development might be more productive in explaining some of the rare sentence completions that could not be meaningfully interpreted within the earlier psychological framework. The relevant works of authors who address postautonomous human development were analyzed for their explanations of development beyond conventional wisdom and beyond the well-integrated Autonomous ego stage.

In addition, how these researchers characterized people at the postautonomous level of development was investigated, and their attributes were compared with those listed in the scoring categories. There appeared to be a number of salient correspondences among these characterizations. Recognition of the constructed nature of reality and the limits of language, attention to the process of meaning-making in the rational realm—and especially with such concerns as the nature of polar opposites, paradox, and infinite regress—were mentioned as most characteristic of the first postautonomous level. Acceptance of change and process as basic aspects of experience and insight into the unity of the reality underlying all constructed differentiations was seen as the most indicative features of the next stage of the developmental trajectory.

Evidence from others' theories as well as their portrayal of late-stage characteristics verified the merit of the conceptualization of high-end ego development overall. Given the relatively few theorists who discuss the postautonomous developmental sector combined with the differing number of divisions they make at the postconventional tier, the question remains open of just how close the correspondences are. What can be said with some certainty is that this version of ego development theory is more or less convergent with the earlier theory up to the Conscientious stage. At the Conscientious stage, however, the theories start to differ. It is believed that divergent validity for this interpretation has been established since it has been shown that it can accommodate views of reality on sentence completion tests that elude the earlier theory.

Regarding the critique of the sentence completion test for measuring mature ego development, a set of nine scoring categories had been proposed for assessing and distinguishing between the Construct-aware and the Unitive ego stage. These categories were based on a thorough analysis of empirical data from the sentence completion test, but they had not yet been examined for reliability. Therefore, it was tested whether others could understand and reliably use the proposed scoring categories in rating high-end protocols. The high interrater agreement achieved confirmed the usefulness and reliability of the proposed scoring criteria. The overall concordance of results in this study is taken as further validation of the proposed high-end modification of ego development theory and measurement.

The high interrater agreement (Cronbach's alpha of .95 for Total Protocol Rating) would indicate that one can not only document and describe with greater clarity and accuracy how persons at the upper end of ego development create, maintain, and transform their perspectives on reality, but that one can actually measure this process. This research contributes to the present understanding of the nature of late-stage human development. Furthermore, this characterization of postconventional ego development may currently be the most detailed account of the process of mature self-development. It is based on empirical evidence and leads readily from a Western conception of development to Eastern models. It begins to bridge "bottom-up" conceptions of mature development as increasingly complex self-differentiations and integrations with the "top-down" conceptions of the permanent self as a transitional phenomenon that may be recognized as an illusion and potentially transcended.

Discussion

"Measuring" personality and human behavior is difficult in the first place because of the complexity and variability, or the "obdurate vagary" of human beings. Yet, such measuring of psychological phenomena is at the very heart of psychometrics. The lasting contribution to psychology of the earlier framework is in having devised

a novel way “to translate qualitative aspects of behavior to quantitative and to reduce diverse observations to single scores.”

Benefits and Limitations of the Conception of Postautonomous Ego Development

The outcome of this study confirms that envisioning postconventional ego development as a continuation of differentiation and integration at ever higher levels of complexity alone is not sufficient to account for the kinds of reality conceptions that can occur after an Autonomous stage equilibration has been achieved. Such development can be better explained if one starts with the premise that people do not just continue to complexify the way they make sense of reality. Instead, they also become ever more conscious of (a) previously unexamined assumptions, (b) defensive maneuvers to safeguard the psychic status quo, and © the depth of their cultural and linguistic programming.

Researchers in the social sciences now generally agree about some of the problems and constraints of the conventional scientific or modern research paradigm, especially if applied to living organisms. They find that analytic-formal operational reasoning relies too exclusively on the rational faculty while it ignores other essential components of meaning-making such as affect and context. They comment that modern rational science (including psychology) divides subject and object, investigator and problem, knower and known into independent variables to be analyzed and explained separately in its attempt to be “objective.” Instead, they insist that variables are interdependent and that the observer cannot be separated from that which is observed. They therefore suggest a systems view of reality as a more adequate paradigm for studying social phenomena.

In a similar vein, constructivist developmental theorists posit that adults at the first postconventional level of development may also recognize the systemic nature of reality. This new understanding is generally described in the literature as two different, but complementary and coexisting forms of thought. Systems thinking proper focuses more on structure. It answers questions of how parts of a system relate and influence each other, and how different systems are nestled within each other. Within a general systems view of reality, researchers acknowledge the multiple relationships among variables and the existing networks of interpretations.

The dialectical form of postconventional reasoning, on the other hand, emphasizes the process by which we make sense of knowledge and observations. It explains the regular and continuing process of meaning-making through thesis, antithesis, and synthesis; or construction, deconstruction, and reconstruction. Both these forms of systems awareness generate their own limits: The systems thinker can never answer the question of where the boundaries between observed entities are to be drawn as each “entity” is itself a whole and part of a larger whole, one system nestled inside another—ad infinitum. The dialectical thinker eventually begins to wonder whether and at what point the dialectical process might reach its functional limit.

In a differentiation beyond the systems level, people become aware of these quandaries. Postautonomous individuals begin to be fascinated with questions of how their minds work and how they make sense of reality through ever more complex theories, rational maneuvers, and interpretations. They become especially concerned with the many automatic mental habits that they unconsciously metabolized through a lifetime of cultural conditioning. Of these, the language habits of dualistic splitting and reification are probably the most intractable and the last ones to be recognized.

Few theoreticians have ventured into explication of the second level of postconventional development, the postsystems, or postautonomous one. As has been shown, they tend to agree that some form of recognition of the constructed nature of reality and of the inevitable problems created by our dependence on symbolic representations are always present at these more advanced stages of development. An appreciation of inevitable paradox in the rational realm and the complementarity of polar opposites are also often mentioned. Another characteristic of highly evolved people is the depth at which they experience and understand the interdependence of self and others and the complexity of thoughts, experiences, feelings, and memories at play.

Moreover, the more highly evolved an individual, the clearer become the non-distinctiveness of the “permanent object world” and the impermanence of the precious self. Regarding postautonomous descriptors, the transpersonal authors also portray the last phase of personal development as showing increased mind-body-feeling integration and greater awareness of the constructed nature of reality.

People at the postautonomous level reveal on sentence completion tests that they are increasingly concerned about their ingrained behavior patterns. They are keenly aware of the human tendencies to reify and complexify. As social beings habituated into language, they often realize that they share these tendencies with all other human beings. What’s more, they can acknowledge that these tendencies may be a futile attempt at arresting a profound sense of impermanence and insubstantiality. An early harbinger of postmodernism gave exquisite expression to this awakening:

Man’s freedom is a fabricated freedom, and he pays a price for it. He must at all times defend the utter fragility of his delicately constituted fiction, deny its artificiality. (...) It is one of the most remarkable achievements of thought, of self-scrutiny, that the most anxiety-prone animal of all could come to see through himself and discover the fictional nature of his action world.

Anyone who has tried to stop the mind from producing discursive thought knows how fascinating and frustrating this seemingly independent process can be. We cannot help but discern, classify, and label experience. No matter how hard we try, we can rarely just witness life as it unfolds without reacting to and evaluating what we believe is happening.

It is the transpersonal theories and Eastern ways of conceptualizing human nature that offer a viable explanation for this state of human affairs and a perspective beyond the dilemma. Zen Buddhism, for instance, has developed a technique by which students are confronted with their attachment to discursive reasoning. Essential to the Zen koan is “paradox,” i.e., that which is “beyond” “thinking,” and transcends the logical or conceptual. Since the koan eludes solution by means of reasoning, it requires an intuitive leap to another level of comprehension beyond the logical contradictions and the dualistic splitting inherent in the rational, representational mode of knowing.

Individuals who have known this other way of being tell us that the direct experience of reality is ultimately more meaningful and satisfying to them than any previous worldview filtered through the watchful ego. Yet in the same way that infants need years of practice and modeling to learn to see the phenomenal flux as the world of permanent objects according to their particular linguistic surround, so the achievement of Subject permanence seems to be greatly aided by the committed discipleship to a given spiritual path. The steady practice of accessing and experiencing transcendent states of awareness in meditation is understood as a way of unlearning, or deconditioning the prior more limited form of reality apperception via language and rational deliberation. It is a gradual path toward a different, more inclusive and expansive mode of knowing. Subtle distinctions among the meditative approaches, however, exist as to the description of the ego transcendent stages. Only at the proposed ultimate level of being, even the subtlest distinctions are said to disappear and become meaningless. This realization was expressed in the following lines: “All distinctions are mind, by mind, in mind, of mind / No distinctions no mind to distinguish.” Unity realization is also mirrored in the words of an ancient Buddhist precept: “Insight is the ultimate illusion.”

It is wondered what implications it would have for psychology if both the capacity for symbolic representation of experience and for the transcendence of the mediated form of relating and meaning-making were considered as innate, that is, as part of human nature.

Although the Integrated individual is likened to the self-actualizing person, neither the theory nor the instrument, which is meant to illustrate the characteristics of people at a given stage, makes clear how the Integrated self’s

frame of reference differs qualitatively from the Autonomous one. More problematic yet, the theory is silent about the ego becoming aware of its self-perpetuating tendencies and of the possibility of transcending the rational, discursive mindset.

Similar limitations hold for the proponents of purely analytical constructivist models of development. They cannot detect the kind of profound integration that results in the simplicity that is occasionally evident in Unitive protocols. Because they take the representational, symbolically mediated reality as the only kind of reality that exists, they are limited to assessing the structural complexity of rational thought. They cannot detect its fundamental limitations. As a result, purely cognitive approaches tend to privilege intellectual prowess, logical sophistication, complexity, and formal aspects of meaning-making at the expense of deeper insight and wisdom.

Constructivist developmental theories that focus on meaning are not limited in the same way by the method as structural models are. They are, on the other hand, not free from influences of the researcher's own development. Interestingly, it is not necessarily obvious in a given case whether such limitations occur by unconscious researcher bias or by conscious choice. It is assumed that mindfulness would allow some mature people not to have to reveal everything they understand in the service of a continuing dialogue across diverse boundaries.

One of the problems of comparing this conceptualization with other theories containing postautonomous components has been the relatively few distinctions that are being made in general in the third, postconventional tier of development. The Interindividual stage as well as the Centauric self ranges over several of the steps considered distinct in postconventional development. The "unhappiness" expressed in an Individualistic protocol has an entirely different tone (annoyance) than the existential despair sometimes evident in Construct-aware sentence completions. They originate from different perceptions of what is at stake. While the individualist may harbor hopes for potential agreement behind the facade of multiple interpretations, the Construct-aware person is uncertain whether the concept of agreement is even meaningful in human affairs. In turn, their shared dystonic affect is different from the sense of certainty, commitment to affirm order, and high self-esteem typical of Autonomous persons.

Finally, when respondents show enough evidence on their sentence completion tests that they have let go of any concepts of how the world ought to be, and, instead, show an acceptance of experience as it unfolds, they are said to be at the Unitive stage, the last stage detectable with the sentence completion test.

The Unitive stage allows individuals to be with or witness rather than label experience. This capacity for witnessing invites comparison with non-attached, transpersonal modes of being. If people can develop a non-evaluative perspective on their own as a natural outcome of profound self-inquiry in the personal domain, should the Unitive stage be considered to belong to the fourth, ego-transcendent tier of development?

There is no way to tell from the available evidence whether Unitive persons consistently or only occasionally escape the entrapments of the habits of the mind. We cannot know from an instrument like the sentence completion test whether an individual has realized Subject permanence. According to transpersonal literature, higher stages of consciousness have clear physiological correlates that are crucial in assessing whether or not and to what degree a person has achieved ego-transcendence. Such physiological changes can and have been empirically documented, especially in regards to the Transcendental Meditation technique. It is therefore not believed that the sentence completion test is ever likely to offer enough evidence to determine the status of higher consciousness of people at the Unitive ego stage. Nor is the sentence completion test a fitting and useful tool for further exploring and testing adult development at the transition to and at the transpersonal tier.

Thus, insufficient evidence is one of the salient problems of the theory of the Unitive stage. The level of "vagueness" that was originally found needed addressing regarding the Integrated ego stage has now been pushed up a few notches. It is believed that this interpretation offers both a more accurate conceptualization of postautonomous ego development and a more veridical description of the experience of postautonomous

individuals than earlier theory. Yet, it is hoped it will, in turn, be extended again as more is learned. It may also change radically when entirely new perspectives become available. What seems to be a definite advance in psychology is that this particular reconceptualization of high-end ego development provides a productive way of linking insights from conventional Western and transpersonal psychology.

Some quarters inevitably object that normative theories in general and higher stages in particular “unfairly” privilege complexity and insights which have nothing to do with ordinary people’s lives. A model is followed in responding to this challenge. Only a theory that contains in itself the means for detecting its own limitations and partialness while it simultaneously honors the possibility of greater inclusiveness and integration can really do justice to the universal human need for orientation and for relationship to an Ultimate Reality or transcendent value.

Unlike the nihilistic tenor of much postmodern deconstructivism, ego development theory sounds a hopeful note (a spirited no to no) as long as it retains its continuously self-examining, boundary-opening stance. From the perspective of ego development theory, the nihilistic type of postmodern deconstructivism is an understandable reaction to some of the excesses of the modern mindset, but not the final position at which one must inevitably arrive. Postmodern deconstructivism creates just the kind of double bind that becomes painfully obvious only at the Construct-aware stage. It defends its relativistic stance that there are no absolutes—absolutely. Similar to people at the Individualistic stage, proponents of this position cannot yet detect the fallacy of their arguments. From a developmental point of view, absolute relativism or postmodern deconstructivism may be understood as an epistemological step on the way to a relativism that is aware of its own partialness as an ideology.

Given these insights, postconventional development in the personal realm can be described as a step-by-step deconstruction of the modern rational, analytical mindset. Such development includes a conscious uncoupling from the conventions that lead to its acquisition as well as the gradual divestiture of absolutizing tendencies as these are part of the reification paradigm.

In addition, developmental theory that extends beyond the rational domain also offers a response to people’s frustration with the many unexpected and disastrous side effects and long-term dangers of much technology that grew out of the positivistic tenets of modernity. Transpersonal conceptions of human nature as more than material can serve as possible alternatives. Already many people from all walks of life feel drawn to Eastern spirituality and indigenous practices of meaning-making because these promise both connection to an ultimate as well as inner wealth and contentment, more lasting and profound than any material satisfaction.

At the same time, the relationship between people’s ego stage and their readiness for benefiting from the influx of the numinous remains to be explored. The propensity of the ego to usurp the spiritual has been powerfully spoken about. It seems plausible that the higher the ego stage in the personal realm, the less likely transcendent experiences are distorted to enhance the ego. Beginning with the Construct-aware stage, such tendencies would actually be anticipated, unearthed, and “jostled with.”

Scoring with the New Criteria

Training Issues

As reported, collecting relevant data and finding people willing to learn to score a random sample of complex protocols from the upper half of the scale was difficult. The training sessions were encouraging because the debate was vigorous and illuminating. Still, being aware of the caveat that there are major differences among qualified raters for rating the highest stage, the study was designed for all eventualities. Since the novice raters had had little time to digest the theory and to practice scoring beyond the training sessions, modest

performances were anticipated. The very high interrater agreement for rating whole protocols was thus a genuine surprise.

A Cronbach alpha coefficient of .95 for total protocol ratings, and .96 for total weighted scores is considered strong evidence for the consistency of rater agreement. But what does it mean that these novice raters, each independently, achieved interrater reliabilities with this very difficult sample as good or better than those of experienced teams with more average populations?

The first concern is naturally whether such a result could be replicated with a different set of raters. Given that neither of the other raters was known before the training, there was no control over what talent or dedication they brought to the task. Even though one of the novice raters consistently overlooked the subtle distinctions between the Construct-aware and the Unitive stage responses when she was on her own, she did seem to grasp them when supported in training. It is to her credit that she did not use Unitive stage scores where she did not see them since she was well aware of the purpose of this study. In spite of this difficulty, she mastered the theory and the combined instruments sufficiently overall to be able to score very reliably.

Both raters received intensive instruction not only in how to score in general and in how to use the high-end categories, but they also got a thorough dose of the interpretation of ego development. It is positive that self-training alone is not feasible for gaining adequate scoring proficiency with the high-end categories. One probably also needs to have at least a formal operational frame of reference, as well as an interest in character development and semantic nuances to learn to apply them consistently. Doing the self-training homework in the revised manual before and during the workshop in addition to about twenty-five hours of intensive training may be enough for a person to become proficient in both general and high-end scoring. For such a complex measure, this is a very brief period.

There is some sense that enthusiasm, experience, and expertise partially account for the positive outcome. This is, of course, a problem if others are interested in learning to score with the new criteria. Thus, a possible future goal is to operationalize the teaching approach and to create a scoring manual for high-end protocols. There would also be a need to think about how to assure the responsible use of the high-end scoring criteria by others. The liberties people have taken with the original measurement stand as a warning.

Usefulness of the New Categories

When entering the field of developmental psychology, there was some confidence in the ability to draw theory from a careful reading of salient and seemingly reasonable high-stage sentence completions. Every time such a response was encountered, the question was asked: what kind of view of reality would a person have to have in order to make this statement? It was trusted that, with patience, enough evidence could slowly be accumulated to allow for some meaningful generalizations to this question. There was much less confidence initially whether a way could be found to systematically measure these rare, unreplicated responses.

As indicated, it has been argued that improving the measure at the upper end could not be done because of the paucity of data, the uniqueness of the completions, and because of likely researcher bias.

There was faith that, with patience, the first two hurdles could be overcome. In which way the third blinds to alternative interpretations and other problems, is left to others to point out. Comments from researchers concerned with these matters are awaited and welcomed. Especially meaningful would be reactions from those whose meaning-making is being mapped. How well do these categories capture postautonomous people's actual lived experience? Can they relate to the characterization? Does it ring true, false, or partially adequate? How do people identified as being at the same high ego stage actually understand each other, and how do they differ? The unique, non-replicated responses in postautonomous protocols are an indication that people at the

highest stages have much more room to roam and to manifest in different ways than people at earlier, more conventional reality views.

The earlier scoring categories are narrowly defined and differ for each of the 36 sentence stems on the test. They are strictly item-specific and are therefore applicable only within the context of the sentence completion test. In contrast, it has been suggested that the stage-wide, thematic categories for identifying the postautonomous stages may be useful beyond the sentence completion test. While they were empirically derived, they seem to characterize mature human development in general. Employing the categories in an in-depth interview context, for instance, to explore whether highly developed individuals in other cultures hold similar views of reality would be a valuable extension of the developmental inquiry into human nature.

Using the Revised Manual

Unexpected Results

An interesting and unexpected result of this study is that the Autonomous stage seems to be as poorly described in the revised manual and less well documented than in the older manuals as the Integrated stage. The novice raters were not able to deduce the Autonomous personality type from the information and examples given. They were especially confused by the many combinatorial categories. The training group raised many more questions about how to recognize the Autonomous stage than anticipated given experience in training with prior manuals. The expert rater and the novice raters alike complained about the lack of definition and distinctive examples for the Autonomous stage.

That the greatest interrater disagreement occurred in regard to Autonomous ratings in the protocol interrater agreement study seems to corroborate the seriousness of the problem. As the expert rater remarked in summing up her encounter with the revised manual, "What saddens me is that it [the theory] is less clearly stated than in the older manual, so fewer people can take the ball and run with it." Currently, the characterization of the Autonomous stage in the manual is too inconsistent for reliable results. There is little doubt that more consistent and "telling" categories for the Autonomous stage could be created from existing sentence completion test data in the same way that the criteria for the two postautonomous stages were developed.

Research with High-End Protocols

Several additional changes at the third tier of the revised manual make scoring postconventional protocols more unreliable. First, the use of many "recipe" categories has effectively erased the earlier meaningful scoring rules for compound sentence completions. Second, the ogive rules have been further loosened. Now only 6 out of 36 responses need to be beyond the conventional stage for a protocol as a whole to be rated as postconventional. In this view, the distinctions at the postconventional tier have been watered down over time rather than becoming sharper and more explicit.

The concerns can be summarized. First, the new recipe-style, combinatorial categories eliminate the meaningful distinctions made in scoring rules between compound sentence completions that do generate a higher level of complexity and those that do not. In the revised manual, many examples with conventional ideas that do not "generate a higher level of conceptual complexity" are now rated at the postconventional tier disregarding the existing rule and the underlying logic. When such a crucial aspect of developmental theory as the complexity demand for higher ratings is no longer reflected in the measurement methodology, one wonders whether the construct validity of the whole scheme has been diminished.

Furthermore, in several cases, the group of workshop participants could not find reasonable explanations for the placement of other examples in the "rationalized" revised manual. Some responses that can readily be

differentiated from each other by stage are bunched together under one category heading; others are assigned to different stages even though they reflect a very similar frame of reference both semantically and structurally. As a group, there was disagreement with the manual in general, and the combinatorial categories in particular, many more times than was expected from experience with the older manuals.

Second, the bar for protocols to be rated at the postconventional tier has again been lowered in the revised manual. Stricter cut-off numbers are argued for at all postconventional stages for the same reasons that they were opted for at the highest two stages. To say that someone functions at a specific ego stage makes sense only when the evidence from the sentence completion test supports at least some preference or reasonable proportion of responses coming from the target level.

Third, the problem with using Bayes' theorem to determine the minimal number of 'signs' necessary to assign a score at the statistically rare extremes of the scale has been discussed. Both ends of the developmental trajectory are treated as interchangeable concerning the statistical method and thus, the vast qualitative differences between low and high stages are not honored. Simple average frequency distribution counts in protocols that appear to consistently reflect a given postconventional perspective are as good a choice to determine how many responses one might reasonably expect on average at a specific postconventional stage than more complex probabilistic methods.

Fourth, whatever number the test makers decide on for the automatic cut-off rules, they are a starting point, a ballpark estimate of where a protocol is likely to be. They do not take the quality of the whole protocol into account. The sentence completion test is meant to assess people's ego stage, that is, to distinguish among the different types of meaning-making from its earliest to its most mature expression. The higher the protocol, the more unique the responses and the more the subtlest, qualitative differences make the difference between one stage and the next. The diversity of content and sentence structure, the richness and presence of stage-specific themes and concerns, cognitive complexity, style of delivery, relational space and time awareness are essential for assigning an advanced stage score.

Any attempt at making scoring easier, less thoughtful, less dependent on one's in-depth knowledge of the underlying psychological processes is bound to weaken the distinctions that differentiate the stages. The trend of the revised manual to "mechanize" scoring by using combinatorial categories and by relying on automatic ogive rules does a disservice to the intricacies and original power of the conception of ego development. No matter how effectively statistical means are employed to assist in the assignment of a preliminary stage score, the final assessment of postconventional protocols ought to be based on a thorough understanding of developmental theory. The final step of reading a whole protocol and arriving at a Total Protocol Rating by taking into account all the available evidence can simply not be discarded without losing much of the quality that made ego development theory and the original test so powerful and engaging.

As the expert rater observed, "this manual reads like WISC-Lite!" It appears that the test creators introduced some of these changes to make the instrument easier to learn and the results easier to input into an electronic format for analysis as well as more widely accessible and commercially successful. All psychometricians have to make difficult decisions in which practicality, psychometric adequacy, demands from clients, financial concerns, and personal preferences play a role. Because the revised manual reflects even less well than earlier manuals the distinctions among postconventional ego stages, many of the changes that have been introduced are regretted.

Endnotes

1. A preferred list of stems was also devised. Starting in 1984, a 24-item professional form was developed, which is now expanded to 36 items. This was done after busy executives repeatedly complained about the

available forms as too boring (too many family items and sexual matters) and too few items relevant to adult professional lives. "When a child won't join in group activities" was replaced with "when people step out of line at work" and "a good father" with "a good boss." Both of these items have a manual. Especially postconventional individuals readily notice the overall tenor of the test (Freudian legacy) and get annoyed or bored with the repetition and narrow focus.

2. This fixed one problem, only to cause another. There are several major constructivist developmental theories whose numeric stage names approximately paralleled those of the earlier theory. The parallelism is now lost through this relabeling. Especially since this is a cosmetic change, not a revision of the theory itself, it seems that some consideration of other research in the field would have been an important criterion when contemplating major changes. In this revision, the old stage labels are used and the more recent ones are added in parentheses.
3. For this study, only 14-item protocols were used in order to avoid duplication with responses used for whole protocols. First, protocols rated lower than the Conscientious-Conformist stage with the old manuals were deleted, assuming that there would be enough conventional material left given the known distribution of the protocols. 20 protocols were randomly selected and sorted by stage. All responses lower than the Conformist stage were eliminated because testing these was not at issue. Next, 45 responses from the postautonomous individual response data pool were added in order to even out the numbers for the two highest stages for each stem. All of the responses from the protocols and the individual postautonomous response list were combined into one data set of 427 items and sorted by stem and stage. Stems that did not occur in the revised manual were deleted. Among the remaining 36 stems, the twelve with the most responses were chosen, again eliminating the rest. This left a list of 217 items from 12 stems ordered by stage ranging from the Conformist stage to the Unitive stage. From that final list, a grid was created with columns A and B for each item and responses from the list were assigned alternatively to either Set A or B in the order they appeared in such a way that they were spread among the ego levels and evenly matched between Set A and B.
4. A procedure for this step has been published (a downloadable Macro in Excel). It has been found that sentence completions at the high-end of the scale regularly are longer than the maximum length for text strings per cell in Excel. In addition, 55 different stems had to be accounted for. Thus, the macro could not be taken advantage of.
5. Sample ogive argument for the postconventional tier: In order to be rated at the Construct-aware stage, a protocol must have no more than 32 ratings (previously 34) at the Autonomous stage, that is at least 4 ratings (previously 2 ratings) above the Autonomous stage. If the protocol has more than 32 ratings at the Autonomous stage, one checks the next lower stage and so on. In order to be rated at the Autonomous stage, a protocol must have no more than 30 (previously 31) item ratings at the Individualistic stage. In order to be rated at the Individualistic stage, a protocol must have no more than 27 at the Conscientious stage (previously 28, now 30 item ratings).
6. It is one of the disadvantages of using studies from other projects that one can often not feasibly do follow-up studies when interesting questions like this one about a population arise.
7. It is pointed out that the new raters did use scores below the Conformist stage (9 instances) where appropriate. This gives some indication that they were alert to the fluctuations and did not merely rate everything high because they expected "high." To test whether that tendency was present, one Conformist protocol was included in the data set, which had quite a different tenor than the Conscientious ones without

alerting the raters to this fact. One rater recognized that the protocol was at the Conformist stage, the other rated it at the Conscientious stage, but had a very low total weighted score for it.

8. Although disappointment with the revised manual may have influenced the trainees, enthusiasm for the method and theory overall clearly also made them willing to dig deep and learn to argue scoring matters at a level of great sophistication and insight. Overall, there seem to be more examples in the revised manual which are placed at given stages that cannot be “rationalized.” In several cases during the practice exercises in the revised manual, there was agreement as a group, after thorough deliberation, at which stage to rate a response while disagreeing with the revised manual.
9. The revised manual gives 11 examples for the Integrated stage divided among 6 stems: 1, 2, 6, 10, 12, and 33 as well as a few more in the demonstration chapter. This number is down from 49 examples across 25 stems in the old manual.
10. When dealing with shorter protocol forms, one postautonomous completion will make the difference between an Autonomous or an Integrated rating in the revised model. That scorers are reluctant to make such a judgment call is understandable. Thus, all interested parties seem to agree that for projects that may have postconventional protocols, the 36-item test form is to be preferred.
11. Calculations if $P=1\%$, $Q=99\%$, $p_1=50\%$; $p_2=5\%$. How sure are we with 1 sign that a protocol is at the rare Construct-aware stage? $H_p = P(p_1) / [P(p_1) + Q(p_2)] = (0.01)(0.5) / [(0.01)(0.5) + (0.99)(0.05)] = 0.005 / (0.005 + 0.0495) = 0.005 / 0.0545 = 0.09 \sim 10\%$ How sure are we with 2 signs? $H_p = P(p_1)^2 / [P(p_1)^2 + Q(p_2)^2] = (0.01)(0.5)(0.5) / [(0.01)(0.5)(0.5) + (0.99)(0.05)(0.05)] = 0.50 \sim 50\%$ How sure are we with 3 signs? $H_p = P(p_1)^3 / [P(p_1)^3 + Q(p_2)^3] = 0.91 \sim 91\%$ How sure are we with 4 signs? $\sim 99\%$ $P =$ Population at highest stage $Q =$ Population not at highest stage $p_1 =$ estimated true positive $p_2 =$ estimated false positive $P/Q > p_2/p_1 = 0.01/0.99 > 0.05/0.5$ $Q = 99\%$, $p_2 = 5\%$, $P = 1\%$, $p_1 = 50\%$ Earlier calculations if $P = 5\%$, $Q = 95\%$ then 1 sign $\sim 34\%$; 2 signs $\sim 84\%$; 3 signs $\sim 98\%$.
12. Given recent research, the current cut-off numbers seem inadequate. People at the Construct-aware and the Unitive stage often produce as many high-end responses as seen in earlier stages. They really do look at the world from these more complex perspectives in a consistent and convincing way. It is assumed that in the future, the numbers will be revised again and perhaps the Bayes theorem argument left behind as the highest stages are becoming more common. Unfortunately, the sentence completion test and its cousins cannot measure stages much beyond the linguistically mediated realm precisely because sentence completion tests are language dependent. Other methods will have to be used or developed to measure ego-transcendent stages.

The previous scoring manual may be satisfactory for rating first and second tier protocols, but it is inadequate in the way it describes and adjudicates postconventional development. As a result, the likelihood that a conventional protocol is now being “mismeasured” as postconventional has increased considerably. It would seem that relying on the new postautonomous distinctions and more stringent requirements for assigning postconventional stages may be advantageous for projects that explore postconventional populations. Studies that investigate individuals in professional leadership roles, for instance, regularly contain a good proportion of postconventional protocols. Nineteen out of the 25 managers in the sample were rated postconventional regardless of their status (middle management to executives) and regardless of the size of the company (small, medium, and very large corporations). Studies with senior executive teams that are interested in playing a positive role in transforming their organizations have produced several high-end sentence completion tests.

Furthermore, such postconventional executives have been shown by multiple measurement criteria to be more effective at changing their organizations in positive directions than their conventional peers.

Given the many problems of the previous manual at the postconventional tier, it is justifiable to advocate for the new measuring categories and scoring rules as well as the use of the older manuals for dealing with projects that have predominantly postconventional subjects. It is also recommended to use the 36-item “professional” sentence completion test form because it is more relevant and interesting to professional test takers, and thus more likely to elicit authentic responses.

Conclusion

Even though it cannot be claimed that the Unitive ego stage denotes the achievement of ego transcendence as defined by transpersonal psychology, the revision of ego development theory at the postautonomous level is clearly an advance over previous models which do not allow for the possibility of development beyond the personal realm. The Construct-aware and the Unitive stages constitute real transformations in meaning making beyond the Autonomous stage while previous theories describe postautonomous meaning making poorly and provide insufficient evidence for what such development looks like. The interpretation of high-stage ego development presented here has proven to be robust because it was derived from and continues to be supported by empirical evidence.

The new scoring criteria uniquely characterize the two postautonomous ego stages and serve at the same time for measuring them. They allow raters to distinguish postautonomous responses from each other and from lower stage completions regardless of the stem. Their thematic content can also be used to ascertain that the whole protocol shows postautonomous characteristics, not just the individual completions.

In general, it is argued that for an analysis of how people create coherent meaning in their lives, theoretical consistency, verisimilitude and plausibility are more important than probabilistic considerations in the creation of theory and measuring tools. It will be interesting to compare postconventional stage scores derived from (a) interview-based assessments, (b) the previous manual alone and © combined with the new postautonomous categories and the more stringent ogive rules.

Unless the whole endeavor of understanding human beings is driven by insightful theory the “mismeasure of man” too readily results. If a considerable number of conventional people are rated at postconventional stages, we do not have an accurate and effective way to assess important differences among people. If, on the other hand, a person seems to embody a particular postconventional self-definition or speaks from its center of gravity by giving ample evidence of its presence, then we can place him or her at that stage with more justification.

It is also emphasized that technical decisions pertaining to measurement and manual construction are fundamentally arbitrary, that is, dependent on the instrument creators' experience and judgement. Thus, they await confirmation or disconfirmation from testing and observation in the field. There is little doubt that meaningful theory should lead measurement and not the other way around. Logical coherence and plausibility should weigh as much as statistical significance when we are trying to explain human beings.

It is not certain what impact this study will have on actual scoring practice. The modifications of ego development theory at the upper end are not needed in most projects using the sentence completion test because these rarely contain postautonomous protocols. The previous manual remains adequate and efficient for most research and assessment situations. On the other hand, for those interested in studying postconventional ego development, having a set of criteria by which to explore the characteristics of people at the highest stages may prove to be a valuable analytical tool.

Impact on Education

The study of exemplary individuals, those who are a step ahead of their fellow beings in insight, tolerance, and wisdom, is often inspirational. Based on sentence completion tests, postautonomous adults, even though rare, do live, work and play among us. As people who have developed a dynamic, fluid way of meaning making, they are perhaps especially well equipped to deal with the exigencies in training and education that face leaders in today's world. Mature insight into the process by which experience is reified in language may allow them to build bridges (or become the bridges) for and be mentors to those not yet aware or ready for this kind of understanding. Being free to move in and out of frames of reference, they can better appreciate the needs of diverse groups for unique identification, while promoting a collaborative focus on what connects us across geography, history, language, culture, ideology, race, development, and personal experience.

In an age where more and more adults return to learning throughout the lifespan, knowledge of the spectrum of different worldviews they may have is important for pedagogic reasons: First, institutions of higher learning need to know how to understand and support those with mature self-views since their needs are different from the younger college populations of the past. Second, the discipline of psychology ought to include teaching concepts of postconventional adult development to those who, in their professional and personal roles, are in a position to influence other adults' lives. In the organizational development sector, people with postconventional, more flexible self-views, long-term perspectives, and awareness of the constructed nature of knowledge have already been identified as more likely to lead others into the global economic and social order effectively and responsibly. Third, our knowledge of adult development influences what institutions and learning opportunities we create for adults. How well we support them, in turn, bears upon the future of society because of adults' omnipresent influence on children as parents, teachers, role models, and policy makers.

On the eve of the third millennium, it behooves anyone looking at a field of inquiry to anticipate at least some of the challenges awaiting those who toil in it. With the advent of the electronic information age and instant worldwide communication and commerce, people around the globe are exposed to the sights and sounds of other cultures and other languages as never before. The kind of conventional socialization described in earlier literature, in which children are initially exposed to one fairly coherent worldview, is now a rarity. As researchers point out, we no longer live in isolated cultures. Children everywhere in the world encounter other lifestyles, and other ways of being either personally by participating in pluralistic societies or by being targeted by global enterprise and communication channels.

All of this has created a formidable new challenge for the development of a sense of groundedness and orientation. Unlike earlier periods in history we now have to generate a sense of meaning out of many diverse, and often incompatible or contradictory beliefs and behaviors. No longer can we follow in the footsteps of our elders. Each generation finds itself creating its own assemblage of symbols and meanings, often chosen from many cultures and lifestyles and from tools, artifacts and memes that never existed before. It is truly a wonder how young people under these novel conditions actually do develop a coherent story about themselves, about human existence and about the meaning of life.

For some, the multitude of options might be destabilizing and disabling. For others, the new contingencies might call forth creative responses beyond our powers of imagination. The new multicultural, symbol-saturated, electronically interconnected reality may well provide opportunities for discovering new paths to expressing human nature.

Among the adults of our generation who have formed identities in the middle of the twentieth century, the current climate may support us in becoming more aware of the process of acculturation and the power of language in shaping reality. As each individual is challenged to orient himself or herself in this brave new world and to find a way to create a meaningful existence, so is psychology challenged to document and make sense of the as yet uncharted ways new generations will negotiate the basic human task of meaning making.

To summarize, this research has clarified and tested earlier hypotheses about how human beings differ in the ways they make sense of reality at the postconventional tier of development, and especially at its high end.

First, the reconceptualization of postconventional development as a step-wise deconstruction of the assumptions acquired in the first two tiers of development has been supported by the characterization of mature development in other contemporary development theories, both constructivist developmental and transpersonal. In addition, conceiving of the Construct-aware and the Unitive ego stages in the manner done here, may be a step towards an integration of Eastern and Western models of human growth.

Second, there is strong evidence from the interrater agreement studies that the empirically derived, thematic, stage-wide scoring criteria are useful and reliable for rating postautonomous sentence completion test protocols.

Beyond the above considerations, the new stage distinctions and classification categories for analyzing what constitutes mature insight and wisdom may be helpful for researching verbal material from other social science contexts. Thus, it is hoped that this study makes a substantive contribution to the field of positive adult development.

The conception of advanced ego development presented here, which was derived from actual sentence completion tests, is in excellent company. The rare postautonomous sentence completions—spontaneous as they were—give powerful empirical support to the notion that lifespan mental growth consists of a process of a sequential shedding of old thought habits, ego-attachments and illusions in favor of a growing embrace of life as it is. This idea is eloquently expressed by developmental theorists:

In fact, transforming our epistemologies, liberating ourselves from that in which we were embedded, making what was subject into object so that we can “have it” rather than “be had” by it—this is the most powerful way I know to conceptualize the growth of the mind. It is a way of conceptualizing the growth of the mind that is as faithful to the self-psychology of the West as to the “wisdom literature” of the East. The roshis and lamas speak to the growth of the mind in terms of our developing ability to relate to what we were formerly attached to.

The research indicates that full ego development in the personal realm may open the portal to ego-transcendence as described in the literature on human insight potential of both transpersonal psychology and the “received” schools of ancient knowledge. It is suggested that the ego can become transparent to itself and “ripen” towards ego-transcendence at the high end of ego development.

At the dawn of a new millennium, psychology as a discipline needs to have a framework of the overall trajectory of human development consonant with contemporary integral conceptions of consciousness. Having such a model may help us to transcend the modern legacy of fragmentation within and among disciplines. We can refocus our attention on consciousness and meaning making as central to human experience and create an integral vision of the human condition that embodies science, art and religion.

Addendum

There are many questions yet to be explored and researched in the field of mature ego development. These range from qualitative assessments of the function of ego stage in people’s work, love, and play at present and over the life span. They need to address differences and similarities among individual, age cohorts, and specific groups of people and the emergent global society.

What, for instance, is the relationship between high ego development and mental and physical health, resilience, wisdom, tolerance of ambiguity, equanimity, as well as creativity and spirituality in individual cases

and in specific groups of people? Are their characteristic cultural, gender, and race differences that persist beyond the Autonomous ego stage and into the transpersonal realm? What indicators are present in childhood that predict the long-term potential for mature ego development? If at all, how does mental performance and awareness change towards the end of life in people who score high at middle age?

To what degree do current social institutions and economic practices support or hinder development?

Appendices

The Study of Multi-Faceted Human Nature

Personality factors (traits)

- Learning style: visual, auditory, kinesthetic
- Jungian-based: extraversion-introversion, intuition-sensing, feeling-thinking, perceiving-judging
- Attitude towards life: optimistic-pessimistic, trusting-fearful
- Temperament: receptive, contemplative, responsive-reactive, outgoing, proactive
- Five factor model: Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to experience, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness

Performance

- Left brain: rational, symbol manipulation, linear/procedural, verbal
- Right brain: intuitive, holistic, pattern recognition, non-verbal
- Pattern recognition
- Intelligence
- Multiple intelligences: spatial/visual, body/kinesthetic, logical/mathematical, interpersonal, intrapersonal, naturalistic, musical
- Sternberg: analytical, practical, creative

Biological

- Physical-health: metabolism, stress tolerance, senses
- Mental health: neuroticism, substance use, stress tolerance, psychopathology
- Native intelligence (IQ): memory access, memory speed, perceptual sensibility, perceptual acuity, memory capacity

Group mind Contexts

- History/culture
- Collective Unconscious

Intuitive abilities

- Access to: primary process, premonition, clairvoyance, telepathy, dreaming/daydreaming, extrasensory perception

Practices/shifts

- Serious pastimes -> flow
- Meditation, yoga
- Relaxation - letting go
- Concentration - focusing
- Free association
- Play - mind games

Differentiation - Integration

- linear/analytic
- systemic
- unitive

Ego development

- preconventional
- conventional
- postconventional
- transcendent (+)

Scoring Categories for Ego Stages C9 and C10

Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ (C9): Construct-aware Stage

- **$\frac{5}{6},1$ (9v) Complex matrix of content (panoramic view; not linear lists)** Array of contrasting possibilities, reasons, responses given in order to approximate and express the complexity of one's insights, thoughts, feelings and observations (sometimes abstract, distanced or hyper-rational). [This is a stage specific manifestation of Rating Rule 2. Complexity may be signaled by the conscious use of dashes, semicolons, parentheses, underlines and quotation marks etc. to structure long "unwieldy" completions and to signal one's awareness of subtle distinctions. Rule: If all the responses above E8 in a protocol are from category 9v, it is rated at E8.]
- **$\frac{5}{6},2$ (9w) Exploration & evaluation of intrapsychic & interpersonal dynamics** Wide range of personal thought, feelings, concerns and deep insights into one's own and others' psychological functioning and interdependence; aware of the ambiguities, simultaneous benefits and costs, and double binds in human relationships; aware of the stages and process of identity-formation.
- **$\frac{5}{6},3$ (9x) Exploration and evaluation of habits of mind** Evidence of observing own thinking process and thought habits such as automatic judging, circular reasoning, infinite regress, defensive mind games; aware of existential and logical paradoxes; comments on various levels of own awareness or felt lack thereof; intellectual understanding of the nature of polar opposites as necessitating each other.
- **$\frac{5}{6},4$ (9y) Reference to constructed nature of reality** Specific reference to and questioning of underlying assumptions, multiple perceptions, frames of reference, paradigms and process of meaning making. Explicit

about multiple, multi-layered and changing meanings of words and definitions. Aware of constructed nature of self and reality. [Also comments on how sentence completion test stems and “measurements” frame and limit the respondent.]

Stage C10 (6): Unitive Stage

- **6,1 (10v) Wide range of thought on human relationships (self not as center)** with unique positive affect and gratitude for people as they are; appreciation of their shadow sides and struggles as mirrors of all humanity.
- **6,2 (10w) Expression of high tolerance, acceptance of self and world “as is”** openness to life, change, process, rhythm, flux, self-in-transformation; letting go of judging need; signs of non-attachment and embracing of polar opposites.
- **6,3 (10x) Non-trivial expression of universal connectedness** self as part of larger world, humankind, womanhood, history, manifestation of creative process.
- **6,4 (10y) Fundamental thoughts and feelings about the human condition** including but not limited to the wonder of being, creation/destruction, joy and suffering, life and death, sexuality; nature; global concerns, conscience, consciousness.
- **6,5 (10z) Unitive ability** Shifting focus effortlessly between near and far (geographically, historically, developmentally), the mundane and the sublime, the somber and the ridiculous, now and eternity, between different states of consciousness without attachment to any one view or position. [Sometimes playful light touch; illuminating metaphor: “seeing a world in a grain of sand.”]

Three Dimensions of Ego Development

1. Operative (behavioral) dimension

- **Issues addressed:** DOING (coping, needs & ends, purpose)
- **Questions:** How do people behave? What are the needs they act upon, and what ends do they move towards? How do they do to cope and master their lives?

2. Affective dimension

- **Issues addressed:** BEING (awareness, experience, affect)
- **Questions:** How do individuals feel about their lives? How do they express affect? How are events experienced and digested? What is felt as stress or as problematic? What are the favored defenses? What is the range of awareness and what remains hidden from consciousness?

3. Cognitive dimension

- **Issues addressed:** THINKING (conceptions, knowledge, interpretation)
- **Questions:** How do individuals structure experience, how do they explain things, make sense of their experience? What is the logic behind their perspectives on the self and the world? How do they know what they know and what questions do they ask, what do they focus on, and what remains hidden?

The Evolving Perspective on the Self: A Brief Overview

The First Tier or the Preconventional Stages

Stage 1 (E1) through Delta (E3) represent the child's normal development from birth to about age 12, as well as stages of arrested development in adults. Stage Delta (E3) and Delta/3 include the acquisition of primary and beginning concrete operations, respectively.

- **Stage 1 (E1)**, also called Presocial or Symbiotic, describes adults who are unaware of themselves as separate individuals. They may be nonverbal, driven by basic needs and fundamentally helpless with others.
- **Stage 2 (E2)**, or Impulsive, describes individuals who show signs of beginning use of language simultaneously with the ego as reflected in such statements as "I want" and "mine." They are concerned with safety and the gratification of basic needs. It is the first stage measured by the sentence completion test and shows the first-person perspective. The inability to understand fully the verbal stimuli of the test is a sign of this stage.
- **Stage Delta (E3)**, or the Self-protective stage, describes people who see the world only from the perspective of their own wants and needs. To get what they want, they need to control others and safeguard their interests. It is the first stage of purposeful social interaction. "Opportunists" see the world from an "I win/you lose" perspective. Power is used where useful: "Might makes right."
- **Stage Delta/3**, or the Rule-oriented stage, describes individuals who are discovering the second-person perspective. They have a vacillating point of view. Sometimes the question is: "How do I look to others?" and at other times: "How do they look to me?" Comparing is restricted to concrete and external aspects of self and others. Interest in being part of groups (greater power) and following rules.

The Second Tier Or The Conventional Stages 3 (E4), $\frac{3}{4}$ (E5) And 4 (E6)

Stages 3, $\frac{3}{4}$, and 4 (E4, E5, and E6) cover the ego stages of most people after age 12. Stage 3 (E4) represents concrete operations, and stage $\frac{3}{4}$ (E5) abstract operations. Stage 4 (E6) is considered the adult stage per se in modern Western cultures and comprises functioning at the formal operational level. For stages $\frac{3}{4}$ (E5) and 4 (E6), reality is defined as having closed boundaries, permanent objects, linear causality, and independent variables. Eighty percent of the average adult American population scores at these three conventional stages. Based on data since 1980, stage 3 (E4) has become less common with the women's movement having taken hold.

- **The Conformist Stage E4**, describes persons with an early adolescent frame of mind. They identify themselves mostly as members of familiar groups. The boundaries between self and others are confused. But unlike people at the Self-protective stage, there is real concern for the well-being of others. One takes responsibility for others. Dependency needs are high. Fear of rejection leads Conformists to be overly nice and to repress negative feelings. There is unquestioned acceptance of the Family and in-groups (such as peer groups, family values, club, church) and loyalty is important. The unfamiliar (out-groups) is rejected and easily maligned. External social status and material goods are important as indices of one's value. Simple shoulds and oughts are adhered to, but now include more socially desirable behavior. Experience is concrete, practical, and reactions immediate without much reflection.
- **The Self-Conscious Stage E5 ($\frac{3}{4}$)**, characterizes people who are able to step back and look at themselves as objects for the first time. They can take the third-person perspective and begin to observe themselves. Generally, however, the focus is directed outside the self, on others. Conventional morality and self-righteousness strong. Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ (E5) people often assert and express their newly discovered personhood albeit in traditional terms. They try to differentiate themselves from the previous familiar context.

Being able to stand outside oneself permits beginning self-reflection. $\frac{3}{4}$ (E5) persons begin to recognize that others have different selves and thoughts, and that they can look at you as an object as well.

Self-definition across Conventional Stages:

- **Stage E4 (3): Conformist Stage:** Concrete operations: several external features: vital statistics, rudimentary internal states, negative suppressed.
- **Stage E5 ($\frac{3}{4}$): Self-conscious Stage:** Abstract operations: clusters of external attributes, simple traits, beginning introspection; beginning sense of separate self-identity and unique personhood.
- **Stage E6 (4): Conscientious Stage:** Formal operations: self as system of roles and clusters of traits: prototype personality; individual self-agency; aware of recent past and future, and causality.

A third person perspective also allows for abstract operations and mental manipulation of abstract objects. Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ individuals (E5) can generate permutations or many solutions to a problem, known as “the yes-but” syndrome, but they cannot yet prioritize among variables. Beginning awareness of time as a linear progression and, therefore, beginning to see self as having enduring traits, i.e., an identifiable character or identity. Conventional shoulds and oughts and cultural norms are more successfully internalized. Belief in Authority and the Truth are strong. Self-aware persons are concerned with duty, responsibility, right action. Technicians and bureaucrats often inhabit this frame of mind with excellent results for society.

- **Stage 4 (E6),** or the Conscientious stage, adds the concept of linear time (sequentiality) as a conscious object to the third-person perspective and expands the meaningful social context to others within the same society with similar ideologies and aspirations. At stage 4 (E6) one starts to explore the nature of oneself in terms of traits through more ongoing introspection. Aware of self as having definite traits that distinguish one uniquely from others. One learns to understand oneself backwards (responsibility, guilt) and forwards in time (plans, dreams) within the roles (prototypes) and functions provided by one’s culture. Stage 4 (E6) individuals are interested in reasons, causes, goals, costs, consequences, and the effective use of time. Aware of others as individuals with unique personalities, and thus contract agreements and mutually beneficial arrangements. At stage 4 (E6), one may deeply believe in social progress and human perfectibility. This often translates into a genuine effort at making a difference in the world through action, and mobilizing others around one’s causes and beliefs. Clear sense of identity and being in charge of oneself. Life seen as a task to be mastered. Formal operations and abstract rationality are at their peak. There may be a conviction that the proper analytical, scientific methods will eventually lead to the discovery of how things really are, that is, to the discovery of the laws of everything and therefore the solutions to all problems. Formal Operational 4 (E6) persons represents “the Adult” as defined by Western industrialized society and as supported by modern institutions from education to jurisprudence. Because of the expanded view, the Conscientious person plans, prioritizes, and optimizes procedures to achieve goals. One needs society to function smoothly, in order to achieve one’s desires. Great need to improve.

The Individualist Stage $\frac{4}{5}$ (E7)

- **Realm:** self as unique entity
- **Time frame:** here and now
- **Cognition:** systematic operations, systems theory concepts perceived
- **Preoccupations:** celebrate one’s unique difference from others

- **Positive equilibration:** vivid individualism
- **Truth:** can never be found. Everything is relative. concentrate and relish experience in the present.
- **Perspective:** 4th person perspective -> Relativism: discovery of cultural conditioning and the possibility of self-deception.

Individualists (E7) realize that reality is not out there, separate from the viewer as previously felt, but connected to the person who experiences it. Increasing ability to see how things are related and influence each other in non-linear ways. Others admired for their individuality and creative solutions to living. Discovery of cultural and personal “assumptions” and own tendency towards defensive moves.

Expanding Relational Space and Time in Ego Development

Relational space (kinship with)

- Family of sentient beings
- Global village, humankind
- Diverse cultures of choice; like-‘spirited’ people
- Own society, culture: others with similar goals, values: like-“minded” people
- Own kin, family, clan, tribe, club, neighborhood, professional group
- Providing ones; Mother

Timeframe

- Time-space continuum
- One's whole life in historical time
- Self in linear time: defined by recent past, present and future
- Present
- Immediate needs; unaware of time
- Womb

Comparative Table of Ego Stages E8, C9, and C10

Stage Autonomous E8 (5)

- **Example from SCT:** I am - a well-balanced professional human being, definitely on the path of self-actualization and self-fulfillment
- **Focus:** Self-development, self-actualization: creating a meaningful, coherent, objective self-identity
- **Self-definition:** Autonomous, multiple roles; self-generated core-identity; aware of many defenses and expression of inner conflict. Sense of self-esteem, empowerment
- **Dominant Center of Awareness:** Rational mind and intellect; thought as mediated through language (symbolic codification, representation)
- **Range of Awareness:** Rational analysis with awareness of the mechanics of thought, symbolic codification, construction of meaning, contemplation of limitations of present way of knowing -> existential paradox.

- **Method of Knowing:** Reasoning, rational analysis aided by some intuition; one assesses, evaluate, judges, compare, measures, contrasts, and predicts
- **Goal:** To be the most one can be

Stage Construct-aware C9 (⁵/₆)

- **Example from SCT:** I am - sensitive, honest, striving to always love others, reflective, sometimes to the point of being unable to get out of endless loops, striving to take responsibility for myself (...)
- **Focus:** Exploring the habits and processes of mind and the way one makes sense of experience through cognition and language
- **Self-definition:** Complex matrix of self-identifications, at the same time questioning their adequacy. Description of self in stages (approximations) and critique of conventional labeling
- **Dominant Center of Awareness:** Rational mind plus intimations of transcendent awareness, and intuitive knowledge during peak moments
- **Range of Awareness:** Aware of the limits of symbolic codification and rational thought; aware of ego and conventional reality as constructs. Keenly aware of difference between map and territory
- **Method of Knowing:** To be aware of body/mind as system, aware of context dependency and personal interpretation of internal and external events
- **Goal:** To be aware

Stage Unitive C10 (6)

- **Example from SCT:** I am - alive, trundling along, making sense as best as I can, diversifying & expanding while consolidating & contracting
- **Focus:** Non-evaluating, integrative witnessing of ongoing process of experience
- **Self-definition:** Description of self as in constant flux and transformation; transcendent awareness; I am no(-)body, no(-)thing
- **Dominant Center of Awareness:** Metarational, postrepresentational, immediate, integrative awareness and direct experience of what it is
- **Range of Awareness:** Aware of perceptual flux and changing levels of awareness; life as is; aware of "illusion" of permanent, individual self and object world. Cognizant of witness-Self
- **Method of Knowing:** Contemplative, witnessing of continuous flux; subjective experience of non-symbolic mode of direct knowing and apperception; intellect and intuition are used but not overvalued.
- **Goal:** To be

Masterlist 55 SCT Stems

1. When a child will not join in group activities-
2. Raising a family-
3. When I am criticized-
4. A man's job-
5. Being with other people-

6. The thing I like about myself is-
7. My Mother and I-
8. What gets me into trouble is-
9. Education-
10. When people are helpless-
11. Women are lucky because-
12. A good father-
13. A girl has a right to-
14. When they talked about sex, I-
15. A wife should-
16. I feel sorry-
17. A man feels good when-
18. Rules are-
19. Crime and delinquency could be halted if-
20. Men are lucky because-
21. I just can't stand people who-
22. At times s/he worried about-
23. I am-
24. A woman feels good when-
25. My main problem is-
26. A husband has a right to-
27. The worst thing about being a woman/
28. A good mother-
29. When I am with a man or woman -
30. Sometimes s/he wished that-
31. My father-
32. If I can't get what I want, I-
33. Usually s/he felt that sex-
34. For a woman a career is-
35. My conscience bothers me if-
36. A woman/man should always-
37. Most men think that women-
38. When they avoided me-
39. If I had more money-
40. If my mother-

41. When I get mad-
 42. my husband and I will-
 43. A pregnant woman-
 44. When my mother spanked me-
 45. When I am nervous-
 46. When his wife asked him to help with the housework-
 47. A woman's body-
 48. When s/he thought of his/her mother-
 49. He (she) felt proud-
 50. If I were King (Queen)-
 51. A good boss-
 52. People who step out of line at work-
 53. Whenever s/he was with her/his mother, s/he-
 54. When I was younger-
 55. I am embarrassed when-
-

Appendix: Training and Scoring Agreement Form

Research Assistant Commitment

The prospective research assistant agrees to serve in this capacity for the lead researcher, provided they qualify following the completion of a training workshop focused on scoring the sentence completion instrument. Qualification is contingent upon the level of proficiency demonstrated in scoring the instrument using the standard manual alongside the newly developed high-end categories.

The training phase mandates attendance at three training sessions, each lasting four hours. During this period, the assistant must independently study the scoring manual and relevant theoretical articles distributed during the initial meeting (with the cost of materials, including the manual, noted as \$x). Furthermore, the assistant is required to complete assigned practice homework between training sessions to maximize their scoring proficiency.

The research phase requires the independent rating of approximately 36-item sentence completion protocols for an interrater reliability study. The assistant must maintain all required scoring records and execute the research tasks to the highest standard within the designated schedule. The assistant must also express a willingness to extend their work beyond the deadline if unforeseen, mutually negotiated circumstances arise. Upon selection post-training, the assistant will receive compensation at a rate of \$(x) per protocol, payable upon the completion of the assigned tasks.

Lead Researcher Commitment

The lead researcher commits to conducting an intensive workshop on scoring the sentence completion instrument and supplying handouts containing scoring clues and comprehensive instructions. The researcher will ensure a safe and comfortable environment for the training sessions and remain available upon request to

help participants master the scoring skills and understand the underlying theory outside of scheduled workshop hours.

The researcher agrees to adhere strictly to the established schedule, barring any mutually agreed-upon modifications. Following the workshop, the researcher will select three research assistants from those who demonstrate the highest proficiency in scoring the instrument. The researcher will provide compensation of \$(x) per protocol once the independent scoring task is finished, and will acknowledge the contributions of the assistants in the final research document, should they desire such recognition.

Scoring Hints and Guidelines

Before finalizing a stage assignment, raters are advised to double-check any unusual ratings or outliers—specifically, those scores that appear significantly higher or lower than the majority of responses within a given protocol. Raters should consult the scoring clues for the assigned stage to verify whether the salient indicators are indeed present.

Additionally, raters must evaluate whether the Total Weighted Score (TWS) falls within the expected normal range. If it does not, the underlying reasons must be investigated. For instance, a small number of very low scores can artificially depress the TWS, even if the protocol is generally high-scoring overall. Conversely, a highly consistent protocol featuring a narrow distribution of scores, where a large proportion of responses (50% or more) align with the target stage, will typically yield a higher TWS than the standard guidelines might suggest. Raters are instructed to rely on the overall weight of the evidence: the more frequently an individual's responses reflect a specific stage, the more confidently it can be assumed that this stage represents their true developmental center of gravity.

Raters must assign a final Total Protocol Rating (TPR) by synthesizing data from the ogive, the Total Weighted Score (TWS), and a holistic assessment of the entire protocol. To assign a rating at the highest developmental tiers, specific additional conditions must be satisfied. For the highest stage rating (e.g., Stage 6 or C10), protocols reaching this unitive level typically feature an abundance of responses at the preceding stage (E8) and often, though not necessarily always, contain numerous responses at the intermediate high stage ($\frac{5}{6}$ or C9). For the intermediate high stage rating (e.g., Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ or C9), the protocol must meet the baseline requirements for the E8 stage and must also include at least two categories distinct from the specific " $\frac{5}{6}$, 1 (9v)" category, or alternatively, include some responses that score at the highest stage (6 or C10). If a protocol's high-level responses are exclusively confined to the " $\frac{5}{6}$, 1 (9v)" category, the overall protocol should be capped and rated at the E8 stage.

Instructions for Rating Advanced Protocols

Raters are provided with an initial batch of 15 complete protocols (labeled B1-1 through B1-15), representing developmental stages ranging from the autonomous level (E6) through the highest unitive levels (C10), presented in a randomized order. To facilitate efficient use of the scoring manuals and to guarantee unbiased, out-of-context evaluations, the responses have been sorted by their corresponding item numbers from the master list. For example, for the sentence stem "When a child will not join in group activities—", raters must evaluate all 15 participant completions to this specific item together before moving on to the next item.

Each response must be matched as accurately as possible against the examples provided in the corresponding scoring manual. If a response is compound in nature, raters must apply the specific scoring rules governing compound responses and explicitly document their reasoning (e.g., noting the use of specific rules like R2 or R3). In instances where a response is omitted (which is rare in this dataset) or is too incoherent to interpret, raters are instructed to apply the designated rule for unscoreable or missing data (e.g., Rule R5). Raters are urged to maintain strict objectivity. Standard items typically require less than a minute to evaluate, while even the most complex completions should take no more than a few minutes. Crucially, scores at the highest developmental tiers (C9 or C10) should only be awarded when the response cannot be matched to any lower-stage examples, when the elements cannot be accounted for by standard scoring rules (such as Rule M), and when there is unambiguous evidence that the completion aligns with the theoretical criteria of the highest-stage categories.

The primary score must be recorded in the first designated column. If a rater experiences uncertainty and wishes to note alternative potential scores in a secondary column, they are still strictly required to select one of those alternatives as their definitive “best estimate” final score. In situations where no adequate manual matches exist, standard scoring rules fail to resolve the ambiguity, or a specific item manual is unavailable, raters must deduce a stage score based on the underlying developmental theory and append the category label “undecided” (denoted as “u”).

Once all individual item scores for the entire batch have been determined, they must be transcribed onto the individual protocol scoring sheets provided for each participant. Raters must meticulously double-check their data entry to ensure that the scores are recorded in the exact sequence in which the responses originally appeared on the participant’s protocol. This original sequence is indicated in a specific reference column. Upon completion of this step, every individual protocol must contain exactly 36 distinct scores corresponding to the 36 items.

Raters must then compute several quantitative metrics on the scoring form. This includes calculating the simple frequency distribution of scores, determining the Total Weighted Score (TWS) by multiplying the simple distribution frequencies by their respective stage weights and summing the results, calculating the cumulative distribution, and deriving the automatic ogive score in the designated cells. Finally, raters must read through the entire assembled protocol from start to finish. This holistic review is necessary to confirm that the overall text genuinely embodies the qualitative characteristics of the final assigned stage. Raters are reminded that higher developmental stages inherently demand a greater diversity of themes, elevated structural complexity, and deeper psychological insight across the protocol as a whole.

Corresponding Stage Numbers and Names Across Frameworks

The following table illustrates the alignment of developmental stages across different theoretical frameworks, demonstrating how various researchers have conceptualized the progression of human development.

Framework 1	Framework 2	Framework 3	Framework 4
Magenta	Impulsive	Impulsive	Impulsive
Red	Opportunist	Self-protective / Opportunist	Self-protective
	Rule-oriented**		
Amber	Diplomat	Conformist	Conformist
	Expert	Self-aware	Self-aware
Orange	Achiever	Conscientious	Conscientious
Green	Individualist	Pluralist / Individualist	Individualistic
Teal	Strategist	Autonomous	Autonomous
Turquoise	Alchemist	Magician	Integrated
		Construct-aware / Ego-aware	
Indigo	Ironist	Unitive	

Note: The Rule-oriented stage is no longer utilized in contemporary assessments because it is statistically very rare.

Stage Alignments with Additional Frameworks

This section details further alignments between developmental stages and an additional framework, highlighting the corresponding numerical designations and stage names.

Framework A	Framework B	Framework C	Framework D
2	E2	E2	Impulsive
			Beige
$\frac{2}{3}$	E3	E3	Self-protective
			Purple / Red
Delta/3			
3	E4	E4	Conformist
			Blue
$\frac{3}{4}$	E5	E5	Self-aware
4	E6	E6	Conscientious
			Orange
$\frac{4}{5}$	E7	E7	Individualistic
			Green
5	E8	E8	Autonomous
			Yellow
$\frac{5}{6}$	C9	E9	Integrated
			Turquoise
6	C10		

Ego Development: Nine Levels of Increasing Embrace

Introduction

Ego development theory serves as a model illustrating the various levels of human development, specifically focusing on the evolution of meaning-making in individuals. It outlines the most prevalent stages observed in contemporary Western society, encompassing preconventional, conventional, postconventional, and early post-postconventional ways of interpreting the world. While often depicted schematically to demonstrate fine-tuned differentiations and its place within broader models of consciousness, the theory should not be interpreted as a

simple hierarchy, a strictly linear progression, or a rigid staircase. It is merely one method of representing and displaying developmental models.

The stages of ego development parallel other action logic frameworks, and they can be compared as follows:

Table 1: Comparison of Ego Development Stages and Action Logics

Ego Development Stages	Action Logics	% of US Population
Post-postconventional, Transpersonal, Ego-transcendent		<1%
6 Unitive	Ironist	
$\frac{5}{6}$ Construct-aware	Alchemist	<2%
Postconventional		
5 Autonomous	Strategist	
$\frac{4}{5}$ Individualist	Individualist	10%
Conventional		
4 Conscientious	Achiever	30%
$\frac{3}{4}$ Self-conscious	Expert/technician	30%
3 Conformist	Diplomat	12%
Preconventional		
$\frac{2}{3}$ Self-defensive	Opportunist	10%
2 Impulsive	Impulsive	5%

Ego Development Theory and Stage Descriptions

Human development is frequently described as evolving in a spiral manner rather than in lockstep, with movement possible in multiple directions:

- **Up:** Transformation, vertical development.
- **Horizontal:** Expansion or transfer at the same stage (acquiring new skills or more knowledge), often referred to as “translating.”
- **Down:** Temporary or permanent regression.

The majority of growth in adults is horizontal expansion. Individuals learn new skills, methods, facts, and ways of organizing knowledge, but their fundamental stage or mental model of the world remains unchanged. In contrast, ego development theory details the sequence of how these mental models themselves evolve over

time. Each new level incorporates the previous ones as subsets. A new level represents both a novel, coherent logic and a component of a larger, more complex meaning system.

Furthermore, the theory describes a psychological system comprising three interrelated components:

1. **The Operative Component (Doing):** Examines what adults perceive as the purpose of life, the needs they act upon, and the ends they strive toward. It addresses behavioral dimensions such as coping, needs, ends, and purpose. It asks: How do people interact? What needs drive their actions? How do they cope and master their lives? What role do others play?
2. **The Affective Component (Being):** Deals with emotions and the experience of existing in the world. It encompasses awareness, experience, and affect. It asks: How do individuals feel about things? How do they manage affect? What is their range of awareness and selective perception? How are events experienced and processed? What are their preferred defenses?
3. **The Cognitive Component (Thinking):** Addresses how a person thinks about themselves and the world. It involves conceptions, knowledge, and interpretation. It asks: How does a person think? How do they structure experience, explain phenomena, and make sense of their lives? What logic underpins their perspectives on the self and the world?

It is crucial to recognize that each stage emerges from a synthesis of doing, being, and thinking, even though the term “logic” might imply an emphasis on cognition. Metaphorically, the theory provides an account of how individuals navigate human existence using common sense, increasingly complex maps, algorithms, and intuition.

Table 2: Three Main Dimensions of Each Stage

Dimension	Characteristics	Associated Stages
Knowledge	Notice more pieces of the puzzle; Discover patterns, rules, and laws; Predict, measure, and explain; See further ahead and back in time; Know more and do more.	Self-protective ($\frac{2}{3}$), Conformist (3), Self-conscious ($\frac{3}{4}$), Conscientious (4)
Wisdom	Understand more deeply; Recognize assumptions; See the whole dynamic system; See within, around, and beneath; Strip away illusions; Empty mind.	Individualist ($\frac{4}{5}$), Autonomous (5), Construct-aware ($\frac{5}{6}$), Unitive (6)

Alternating Stages of Differentiation and Integration

Human development can be viewed as a progression of different ways of making sense of reality. These stages alternate between emphasizing differentiation over integration and favoring integration over differentiation. This pattern is observable both overall and from stage to stage.

Individuals individuate by continuously renegotiating the balance between differentiation and integration—a dual trend towards autonomy and homonomy (the desire to be in harmony with a unit extending beyond the individual self, such as a family, nation, ideology, or ordered universe). This dual need is also known as separation and participation, mastery and relatedness, independence and connection, or care and justice.

Stages of differentiation (e.g., Self-protective, Self-conscious, Individualist, Construct-aware) occur when individuals emerge from a previously shared worldview. They tend to focus on their differences from the prior

stage, asserting their newly won independence while often expressing distress over the loss of connection. Stages of integration (e.g., Conformist, Conscientious, Autonomous, Unitive) represent a more balanced state where individuals are in harmony with a new community that aligns with their current cognitive, emotional, and transactional needs. The sequence progresses from identifying with those who are externally alike (Conformist), to the like-minded (Conscientious), to the like-principled (Autonomous), and finally to the like-spirited (Unitive), where spirit is perceived as radiant in all people.

An overall shift from differentiation to integration also characterizes the transition from conventional to postconventional stages. The initial tiers of development represent a movement away from symbiotic embeddedness, an overall trend of increasing differentiation culminating in the abstract, analytic functioning of the scientific ego stage (Conscientious). The postconventional stages show an overall trend of assimilation and integration towards a conscious sense of belongingness and unity.

In modern Western contexts, fully functional adults typically view reality as preexistent and external, composed of permanent, well-defined objects that can be analyzed and controlled. This perspective relies on a maximal separation between subject and object, thinker and thought, epitomizing the traditional scientific mindset concerned with control, measurement, and prediction. Most adults operate under the assumption that subject and object are distinct and that analyzing parts reveals the whole, often lacking insight into the arbitrariness of defining objects or the idea that naming and measuring pulls the named entity out of an unnameable reality. The acquisition of this rational mindset is often viewed as the goal of socialization.

Table 3: Comparison of Percentage Stage Distribution in Three Different Samples

Stage	535 Managers & Consultants (UK)	497 Managers & Supervisors (USA)	4510 Mixed Adult Population (USA)
Impulsive (2)	<1%	1.5%	0.5%
Self-protective ($\frac{2}{3}$)	0.4%	1.7%	8.2%
Conformist (3)	11.3%	21.1%	47.8%
Self-conscious ($\frac{3}{4}$)	36.5%	33.5%	34.8%
Conscientious (4)	29.7%	23.4%	5.0%
Individualist ($\frac{4}{5}$)	11.3%	13.5%	1.4%
Autonomous (5)	4.9%	5.6%	4.0%
Construct-aware & Unitive ($\frac{5}{6}$ & 6)	0.9%	<1%	<1%

Mapping the Expansion of Self-Awareness

Self-awareness expands in a regular pattern from ignorance to mature wisdom through increasingly complex perspectives on the self and others.

- **Infant State (Stage 1):** Symbiotic. Con-fused, autistic, preverbal.

- **Impulsive (Stage 2):** 1st person perspective. Rudimentary, physical self-labeling, basic dichotomies. Self-description in terms of own wishes; dichotomous thinking, self-serving.
- **Opportunist/Self-protective (Stage $\frac{2}{3}$):** 1st person perspective.
- **Diplomat/Conformist (Stage 3):** 2nd person perspective. Single visible external feature; beginning comparisons. Several external features; vital stats, membership self; rudimentary internal states; concrete operations.
- **Self-conscious (Stage $\frac{3}{4}$):** 3rd person perspective. Clusters of external attributes, simple traits, beginning introspection; beginning separate self-identity; abstract operations.
- **Conscientious (Stage 4):** Expanded 3rd person perspective. Self as a system of roles and clusters of traits; independent self, prototype personality; recent past and present, linear causality (Formal operations).
- **Individualist (Stage $\frac{4}{5}$):** 4th person perspective.
- **Autonomous (Stage 5):** 4th person perspective expanded.
- **Magician/Construct-aware (Stage $\frac{5}{6}$):** 5th to nth person perspective.
- **Ironist/Unitive (Stage 6):** Global/unitive perspective.

The Preconventional Stages

The first tier of action logics, from Impulsive to Self-protective, represents normal maturation from birth to approximately age 12, as well as stages of “arrested” development in adults. These preconventional stages are rarely encountered in professional adults, as they are typically traversed in childhood. They reside as subconscious memories and serve as fallback positions during extreme duress.

The Presocial or Symbiotic Stage (Stage 1)

- **Perspective on the self:** None
- **Cognitive:** Nominal actions
- **Self:** Con-fused, confounded, undifferentiated self
- **Other:** Not distinct, source of survival

In this initial stage, infants construct a stable world of objects, separating themselves out as objects in the process. The constitution of the self and outer reality are correlative and depend on language use. This stage can be subdivided into a presocial (autistic) phase and a symbiotic phase. Successful resolution of the challenges in these early periods is crucial for later adult adjustment, encompassing healthy ego, intellectual, psychosexual, social, and moral development. Strands of development that later become distinct are highly undifferentiated here. Adults at this level of undifferentiation are likely pre- or nonverbal and usually require institutionalization or complete dependence on caregivers.

The Impulsive Stage (Stage 2)

- **Cognitive:** Primary actions
- **Self:** Rudimentary, physical self-labeling (“me,” “mine”)

- **Differentiation:** Crude dichotomies
- **Perspective:** First person perspective
- **Other:** Fulfillment of needs on demand

This stage characterizes individuals showing early language use alongside an emerging ego, reflected in statements like “I want” and “mine.” They are focused on safety and the gratification of basic needs. Children at this stage are governed by impulses, asserting their growing sense of self through the word “no” and concepts of ownership. Magical thinking prevails, along with a sense of unlimited power that is only curbed by punishment. Punishments are not linked to behavior but are perceived as random, retaliatory, and imminent in things. Others are viewed primarily as sources of need gratification—good people give, mean ones do not. There is cognitive simplicity and verbal undifferentiation. The impulsive individual lacks an adequate conception of adult life complexities and readily appears confused, anxious, and overwhelmed.

Language Clues: Simple statements, repetitions of the prompt stem, responding to past tense stimuli with present tense, and an inability to understand or respond to longer, complex prompts (e.g., “crime and delinquency could be halted if...”). Things are categorized simply as good or bad, clean or dirty, nice or mean. Affects are expressed in bodily terms rather than as feelings. Repetitiveness is a conspicuous sign, with many responses containing identical or nearly identical simple completions to various prompts.

The Self-Protective or Opportunist Stage (Stage $\frac{2}{3}$)

- **Cognitive:** Preoperational actions
- **Self:** Single concrete features, minimal action-based self-description in terms of desire
- **Other:** Competing for goods, space, dominance, power
- **Differentiation:** Beginning sense of others as having their own wants and will to get

This stage is reminiscent of toddler behavior, where everything becomes a test of wills and tantrums result from thwarted desires or conflicting needs. Adults at this stage exhibit similar behaviors. They are generally wary of others’ intentions, assuming the worst, and view life as a zero-sum game or a war of wills. Their “I win, you lose” mentality causes friction and hurt feelings, and they are often perceived by others as manipulative and exploitative.

Individuals at this stage view the world solely from the perspective of their own needs and wants, lacking psychological insight into themselves or others. They believe the only way to achieve their desires is by controlling others and protecting themselves. They are also opportunistic, possessing a self-serving attitude, a keen eye for opportunities, and the energy to pursue what they want without reflection or delay.

Self-protective adults carefully maintain their fragile selves, which are synonymous with their will, ideas, and wishes. The self may be perceived as having two sides: an inner real self and an outer “false face” used for protection. They believe that if others knew their true desires, those others would have power over them. Consequently, they need to resist the will of others, test limits, and assert control. This stage marks the emerging awareness of others as separate people or “objects,” requiring the rudiments of conscious social interaction (“If I understand what others are after, I can better manipulate them to get what I want”).

Individuals at this level often inadvertently “get into trouble” by crossing boundaries. They try to anticipate trouble and avoid consequences. When they lose a test of will or overstep, they attribute the cause to external factors, becoming frustrated and displaying free-flowing anger and hostility. Blame is always placed on others, never on oneself. Their anger is projected outward, leading them to experience others as constantly angry and

the world as a hostile, dangerous place. Rules are recognized but followed only for immediate advantage or to avoid punishment. Cleverness and seizing opportunities are deemed necessary for survival. Self-respect is tied to the amount of control achieved in opposition to others. They often feel isolated, like the “odd person out,” but lack the skills to relate differently, creating a self-perpetuating dynamic of low trust and hyper-vigilance.

Morality is expedient; actions are only considered bad if one is caught and punished. When caught, they exhibit shamelessness and little remorse. They do not feel responsible for failures or trouble because they do not yet grasp linear causality (the connection between action and consequences). Blaming others serves as a protective mechanism. There is a heavy reliance on luck and magic for self-protection. (e.g., individuals in dangerous jobs who carry lucky objects and tend to be loners).

Self-protective people are not well-embedded in social networks and struggle to understand subtle human interactions not based on power. Relationships are volatile, and friendships easily rupture. Feelings are externalized and projected. There is little expression of or reflection on their own emotions, due to both a lack of insight and a need for self-protection. Showing weakness is considered dangerous (“The more others know about me, the more they can take advantage of me”). Consequently, they tend to express general hostility and a readiness for fight or flight.

- **Cognitive style:** Thinking is concrete and dichotomous, based on global, undifferentiated judgments and simple ideas (black or white).
 - **Preoccupations:** Themes of domination, gaining control and advantage, or deceiving others. Conversely, they constantly fear being dominated, controlled, or deceived.
 - **Internal dimension:** Psychology is defined by current actions or desires rather than psychological states or long-term goals.
 - **Decision-making style:** “This is your problem, not mine.”
 - **Organizational type:** Power and coercion.
 - **Defenses:** Use of blaming and distortion to minimize anxiety and maximize self-esteem. Coping styles are immature, commonly involving fantasy, acting out, and projection. All causality and significant psychological action are attributed to a constantly threatening external world.
 - **Depression:** Expressed as “There must be something wrong if I can’t get what I want.” They hate feeling controlled and constrained. Sadness is most likely expressed through aggression toward self or others.
 - **Sample character:** Individuals who are self-protective, bull-headed, possess tunnel vision, constantly blow up, and blame others for their circumstances.
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Developmental Stages of Ego

The Rule-Oriented Stage

This stage represents a cognitive shift from self-protective thinking to conscientious dependence, serving as a logical bridge for mental growth. It is considered statistically rare. At this stage, individuals alternate between different viewpoints, wondering how they appear to others and how others appear to them. They begin to recognize external differences in features or behaviors. This stage often describes adults who are discovering the second-person perspective, making simple external comparisons, and using concrete mental operations.

Individuals become highly focused on social conventions and rules due to an emerging need for acceptance and likability. The desire to look “right” and acceptable places a strong emphasis on external attractiveness and appearance. People at this stage exhibit more trust, as they realize that acceptance and protection can be achieved by following rules. The world is perceived as less hostile compared to the self-protective stage. There is a desire for respect, which translates to being “seen” by others. Respect is gained by adhering to group norms rather than just through power. Individuals also show respect by paying attention to others, acknowledging mutual presence and listening. The discovery of the second-person perspective allows for simple feedback, enabling individuals to ask others for their opinions without fear of negative consequences, marking a significant milestone in social interaction.

At this stage, superficial similarities with others are discovered and provide comfort, alleviating feelings of isolation. This new feeling is enjoyed in loose associations, such as clubs, where similar action interests are shared.

Language Clues: Individuals make simple factual statements, referring to concrete behavior and single features of appearance. They passively respond to stimuli, attempting to avoid trouble but often uncertain how to do so. They may feel they have done something wrong without being able to articulate how or why. Overall, their expressions often lack emotional depth.

The Conventional Stages

The Conformist, Self-Conscious, and Conscientious stages cover the developmental stages of most people after about the age of 12. Roughly 80% of adults populate these three stages, with most moving from the Self-Conscious to the Conscientious stage. In cognitive terms, the Conformist stage represents functioning at the concrete operational level, the Self-Conscious stage uses abstract operations, and the Conscientious stage relies on formal operations for meaning-making. At the Conscientious stage, individuals have a linear view of reality: objects have closed boundaries, causality is linear, and variables are treated as independent. The Conscientious stage is widely considered the adult stage in much of Western culture, supported and rewarded by society and institutions. It is a necessary precondition for democracy, as it requires a citizenry capable of rational deliberation and choice based on pertinent criteria to safeguard the whole while allowing changes in laws.

The Conformist Stage

This stage describes individuals with an early adolescent mindset. Their self-identity is defined by their relationship to a group, leading to blurred boundaries between oneself and the group (e.g., family, team, or nation). Being part of a larger entity provides protection and shared power, with loyalty and obedience as the price for inclusion. Conformist adults thrive on dependency and may feel responsible in situations where they are not. Self-worth is tied to the group's status. There is total acceptance of the in-group and blind rejection of deviance and out-groups, creating a “them against us” dynamic. Ambiguity and ambivalence are not recognized, as they threaten the Conformist's existence.

Language is impersonal, often overly positive, and full of platitudes due to the need for acceptance. Conformists avoid rocking the boat, being singled out, or taking initiatives outside the group's benefit. Acquiring material assets and status symbols is important for indicating success and providing satisfaction. To be liked, one must have a pleasing social personality, emphasizing neatness, outward appearance, and cleanliness. The self is defined by the expectations of those to whom one belongs. Conformists accept norms without questioning, dividing their cognitive world into simple categories based on external distinctions.

Conformists are bound to those with similar tastes, beliefs, and expectations, feeling threatened by differing demands, perspectives, diversity, and complexity. In-group values are introjected as strong “shoulds,” while differing values are denigrated. Negative feelings are split off and projected outward, experienced as “they hate me.” Anger and disagreeable feelings are suppressed, rarely reaching awareness. Blind conformism, fundamentalism, and prejudice can express this mindset. Aggression against the self and negative affect are often countered by demonstrations of overly positive feelings and enthusiasm.

In summary, the Conformist lacks a separate adult identity, defined instead by others. Self-other boundaries are blurry, resulting in relationships with a co-dependent quality.

Impulse Control and Character Development: Rules are partially internalized but obeyed without question. Shame is a common response to undesired consequences. Life is governed by rules of what can and cannot be done. Differing views are morally condemned. Sexual and aggressive feelings are denied or suppressed out of fear of rejection and abandonment.

Interpersonal Style: Conformists conform to the rules and norms of their desired group. In workplaces, they smooth discontent and ensure a pleasant atmosphere, valuing being nice and helpful. Relationships are viewed in terms of expected behaviors rather than deep feelings and motives.

Cognitive Style: Conformists focus on concrete, visible aspects of experience, using superlatives and conventional clichés taken seriously. References to inner feelings are stereotyped, predictable, and aligned with cultural expectations.

Conscious Preoccupation: Great value is placed on appearance, status symbols, material possessions, reputation, and prestige. They are concerned with social acceptance, adjusting to group norms, and caring deeply about others’ opinions. A sense of “shoulds” and “oughts” and the shame of unfulfilled expectations can be crushing.

Internal Dimension: Dependent on others’ acceptance, Conformists worry about what others think and feel. They express simple “acceptable” feeling states (e.g., sad, happy, nervous, upset) without differentiating subtler graduations.

Problem Solving: Emerging problems are generally denied, relabeled, or whitewashed.

Organizational Type: Conformists seek acceptance and protection by a larger entity, drawn to organizations with clearly defined identities and hierarchical structures.

Defenses: Main coping mechanisms are projection (imagining others think/feel what they do) and introjection (swallowing others’ definitions, norms, values, and opinions without questioning).

Counseling Style: Conformists like to give advice, telling others what to do, and tend to compare and evaluate others according to their own preferences.

Character of Depression: The most threatening experience is disapproval, desertion by significant others, rejection by the group, or disloyalty. The chief anxiety is the fear of being “not-me,” a loss of self as accepted by others.

Language Signs: Short, stereotypical phrases, love of clichés, exaggerated positive affect, concrete descriptions, and factual information.

The Self-Conscious Stage

This stage characterizes individuals able to step back and view themselves objectively from a distance, crossing a conceptual watershed by taking a third-person perspective. Individuals become capable of introspection and self-understanding, needing to differentiate themselves from their immediate family context and assert their newly discovered personhood. The third-person perspective allows operations with abstract objects and

concepts. Individuals excel at seeing alternatives, offering numerous solutions and permutations for problems. They become aware of general “traits” in others, leading to an interest in sharing more of their inner nature and describing differentiated traits, norms, and conventional virtues. The focus shifts from likeness to individual differences, asserting personal needs and wants previously suppressed for acceptance.

However, they still desire acceptance by others because they tend to want to be better than others and stand out. The group is needed, but they stand at its periphery. Individuals often feel they have “figured it all out,” knowing all the answers and what to believe. They feel righteous, often putting others in the wrong, with high moral standards and a strong sense of duty and responsibility. Compulsive and perfectionist tendencies are common, with a strong super-ego. Others are evaluated according to their own capabilities and standards, with severe criticism of differing thoughts as a form of intellectual aggression. A sense of superiority is evident. This stage is highly resistant and stable; individuals discredit counter-evidence or belittle others to maintain their beliefs.

In interpersonal situations, the “yes, but” syndrome and one-upmanship are common. On the positive side, they are adept at finding new solutions, better ideas, and more perfect procedures, seeing multiple possibilities and alternative solutions. However, they cannot yet prioritize among options or synthesize possibilities, not knowing when good is good enough.

Aggression, suppressed at the Conformist stage, reemerges, often as a hostile sense of humor or ridiculing others. While capable of looking inside, their defense is to be ultra-rational. They relish being movers and initiators, enjoying oppositional battles and feeling entitled to impose their views, appearing argumentative and opinionated.

Impulse Control: Societal shoulds and oughts are well internalized. Super-egos are strong and not available for inspection. Feelings of shame and guilt for transgressions are expressed simply or rationalized away.

Cognitive Style: Capable of abstract thought and operations, including multiple views, permutations, and careful comparison between pairs of items.

Internal Dimension: Psychology is understood in terms of stable moods and traits. They generate numerous solutions without prioritizing them, often hanging up the decision process.

Organizational Type: Engineering types, technocrats, bureaucrats, and professionals thrive here. Being in charge is a chief trait, with a clear-minded, pragmatic leadership style. They are necessary for running routine affairs and prosper in highly technological environments.

Chief Defenses: Intellectualization, rationalization, and explaining away what doesn't fit expectations. They often blame structures, tools, or others' incompetence for failures.

Counseling Style: As managers and consultants, they ask many questions, accumulate facts, and seek causes, which can be perceived as criticism and blaming. They offer advice and opinions without realizing they are not necessarily the clients'.

Main Anxiety: Having recently discovered their separate personhood, they fear losing their uniqueness, being reabsorbed into the mass, or losing their certainty and strong sense of self by opening up to others' views. This fear is counteracted by a strong front.

Language Clues: More complex syntax, beginning qualifications and conditions, contrast expressed in polar dimensions, passive interest in causality, beginning psychological vocabulary, references to the passing of time, consistent use of past tense, simple comparisons, and multiple options indicated.

The Conscientious Stage

This stage is the target for Western culture, with educational systems aiming to produce rationally competent and independent adults. Democracy relies on the capacity of independent-thinking voters to make reasoned choices.

Individuals add linear time (past and future selves) to the third-person perspective, expanding their meaningful social context to society and those with similar ideologies and aspirations. They associate with people who have made choices about their ideals and goals, belonging to diverse groups without feeling torn by competing loyalties.

They are interested in reasons, causes, goals, consequences, and the effective use of time, curious about what makes people “tick.” They seek truth about themselves through feedback and introspection, understanding themselves across time, describing past feelings, personal dreams, and future goals, with a future-oriented emphasis.

They believe in the perfectibility of humankind and the scientific method to uncover truth. Formal operations and abstract rationality peak. They believe proper scientific methods will reveal how things really are, including human nature. They work towards the betterment of the world, tolerating delays between actions and results, and recognizing the need for others to achieve goals.

Societal standards are internalized. They are aware of their ongoing growth and become truly introspective, concerned with living up to their beliefs. Guilt is a central emotion, and self-criticism can be severe when aggression is turned inward, leading to hypercritical, neurotic self-criticism due to single-minded, high-aiming plans.

Awareness of linear time allows observation of motivations across different periods. They seek root causes and reasons, believing truth about themselves can be found. They distinguish feelings from appearance and are motivated to figure things out.

Analyzing others and self-analysis become favorite pastimes. They cherish self-knowledge, possessing positive self-regard based on successes, independence, and self-authorship. They are less vulnerable to acceptance or exclusion.

Interpersonal relationships become intense and meaningful, with diverse and rich social contacts. Others are appreciated for different expertise, maintaining definite boundaries (“we agree to differ”). Increased self-differentiation does not mean egotistical behavior; others are valued independently of personal needs. Group membership is a contract to accomplish goals and partake in the enterprise’s governance. Loyalty is to a chosen belief system rather than individuals. They function well in different teams and contexts.

Time is the medium to accomplish things, with a preoccupation on responsibility, conscientiousness, and expediency. They have a driven quality to accomplish or improve the world. The mood is earnest conviction, seriousness, idealism, and enthusiasm oriented towards action. They change minds through rational arguments and evidence. Self-esteem depends on achieving set goals rather than external affirmation. The drive to succeed can lead to over-extension and exhaustion, as limits are difficult to acknowledge.

They love the hypothetical and theories, convinced society can be controlled and improved. Rationality, progressivism, positivism, and reductionism are strongholds. They believe rationality will triumph and are interested in analysis. Truth can be approached by applying the scientific method and refining inquiry methods. They can be skeptical of unproven things but believe universal laws can eventually be figured out and proven.

Impulse Control/Character Formation: Societal values and morality are internalized if they fit self-evaluated standards. They tend to be self-critical, feeling guilt for unintentional consequences. They are self-reliant, conscientious, efficient, and preoccupied with attaining goals and ideals.

Interpersonal Style: They have a sense of responsibility and obligation towards others while pursuing their own agendas. They see themselves as indispensable, contributing members of society, yet separate and responsible for their choices. They appreciate mutual expression of differentiated feelings and ideas.

Cognitive Style: They think in formal operations, appreciating conceptual complexity and closed systems. They are aware of contingencies, alternatives, contradictions, and inconsistencies. They are concerned with consequences, priorities, and planful actions, capable of revision and reorientation.

Conscious Preoccupations: Achievement of long-term personal goals, ideals, and values is important. The money motive and focus on individual success fit well with capitalism. They reflect on motivations, reasons for behavior, and contradictory traits.

Internal Dimension: Interested in feelings, moods, traits, and motivations, seeking to understand causes of behavior to achieve goals.

Decision Making: They move with conviction when taking responsibility for a problem, concerned with efficient and effective strategies. They are willing to take risks and fail to a degree earlier stages cannot.

Organizational Style: Alliances are task-related or problem-oriented, with relationships depending on the specific task and role.

Chief Defenses: Intellectualization, rationalization, and suppression of the negative pole and shadow side defend against doubt and criticism. They prefer concentrating on the positive and acting when opportunity arises.

Character of Depression: Depression often manifests as guilt for unfulfilled goals and ideals, loss of the ability to accomplish them, and fear of losing control and independence.

Fear: They fear the Conformist mindset's dependency and submission, viewing blind obedience as "bad-me." They must ensure they are not subsumed in others' goals. Fear of losing progress, control, and separateness is overcome with action and forward movement.

Counseling Style: They ask many questions, including inquiries about feelings and experiences, with a greater ability to listen and restate expressions without adding interpretation.

Language Clues: Recognition and expression of conceptual complexity, explicit references to causal relationships, consequences, and priorities. Terms related to time (efficiency, planning, goals, future) and implicit references to time lapse. Differentiated psychological vocabulary describes complex psychological beings. "I" statements are revealing, containing contrast, self-criticism, and ownership of responsibility.

The major limit of the conventional mindset is its acceptance of facts and the external world as real, blind to the constructed nature of beliefs, especially conventional science. Underlying assumptions are rarely questioned. Knowledge, measurement, and prediction are taken for granted as means to control nature, self, and society. This attitude changes dramatically with postconventional development.

The Postconventional Stages

The General Systems Stages

At the first postconventional level, adults realize that the meaning of things depends on one's relative position, personal perspective, and interpretation. While objects are permanent, their meaning is constructed. Variables are interdependent, causality is cyclical, and boundaries are open and flexible, depending on system definitions. This systems view allows individuals to look at and compare systems of thought or organizations with distance. A main concern is laying bare underlying assumptions and frameworks. The Individualist stage represents

systematic operations, while the Autonomous stage expands cognition to metasytematic operations, integrating different frameworks of the self into a coherent self-identity.

The Individualistic Stage

This stage describes what a person can “see” with a fourth-person perspective. Individuals realize things are not necessarily what they seem, as interpretation depends on the observer’s position. The concept of the participant observer, who influences what is observed, becomes a conscious preoccupation. Total detachment and objectivity are recognized as impossible.

The same object or event can have different meanings for different observers, contexts, or times. Individuals become interested in watching themselves try to make sense of themselves, marking a significant change in thought mode. Purely rational analysis is abandoned for a holistic, organismic approach, taking feelings and context into account. The process becomes as intriguing as the outcome. Relativistic or psychological approaches are favored over logical ones. The need to explain everything diminishes.

Individualists distrust conventional wisdom and hyper-rational tenets, distancing themselves from prior meaning-making. They reevaluate socially sanctioned role identities, redefining themselves uniquely based on personal experience. Realizing most prior meaning-making was socially conditioned breaks down scientific certainty and judgmental mindsets. They consciously scrutinize beliefs to test assumptions and relish novel mental freedom.

Since old identities are questioned, Individualists desire unique personal accomplishments independent of socially approved roles. They may withdraw from external affairs, turning inward to search for unique gifts or pursue burning questions. Given room, they provide creative input, novel problem-solving perspectives, and inspire others with their enthusiasm.

With the fourth-person perspective, paradoxes are recognized and enjoyed rather than explained away. Linear logic gives way to holistic understanding. There is no need to prove everything to live by it. A new, non-hostile humor directed towards the self emerges, based on the futility of framing things as right/wrong or provable/disprovable.

Individualists want to enjoy subjective experience, shifting from “doing” to “being and feeling.” They become present-oriented, noticing how feelings affect the body and vice versa, developing a new body/mind connection. This reflects a shift from intellectual to organismic or embodied awareness.

Individualists do not impose interpretations on others; they seek to respect and understand them. Individual differences are celebrated. In groups, room is made for all voices and opinions. This can lead to radical postmodernism, where it is claimed with absolute certainty that there is no position from which to judge, failing to recognize the inherent self-contradiction. Diversity training may focus so much on differences that common humanity is overlooked. Egalitarian experiences prepare the way for deeper appreciation and tolerance of difference and similarity.

Individualists may or may not have a communal bend; some focus on their own meaning-making. Regardless, they recognize the relativity of all positions, are less apt to judge, and may appear “amoral” in letting others be and do what they want.

The focus on causality and goals is replaced by a fascination with the immediate present, understanding how things unfold. The focus turns from outcomes to processes, relationships, and non-linear influences. They watch how they and others change in different contexts, with an existential sense of how each moment differs, infusing the present with salience and poignancy.

Individualist Stage (Continued)

Individuals at this stage often experience confusion arising from internal contradictions, frequently describing themselves as possessing multiple personalities or inner voices that resist synthesis into a unified whole. They might express this by saying, “Sometimes I act, feel, think one way, other times in another. There is struggle within myself, different voices competing for attention. And all seem real and important parts of me.” Some may refer to an “inner tribe,” asking themselves, “Who am I? What is going on?” Consequently, a primary source of anxiety involves the challenge of integrating these disparate aspects of the self. They may articulate fears such as, “I can be both my old rational self, and a new, different kind of person; I am afraid I am two or more personalities instead of one. I feel confused, split, ambivalent.” For these individuals, depression frequently revolves around these internal conflicts and a sense of despair regarding the possibility of ever discovering a true self. As they delve into their own feelings and motivations, they also become acutely aware of the human capacity for self-deception. The risks of defensive self-delusion and culturally biased distortions begin to be perceived as constant threats.

Conversely, this profound ability to connect with the self and engage in introspection fosters an enhanced capacity for empathy and a greater tolerance for diverse ideas, behaviors, and reactions. People at this stage are frequently admired, particularly by others at advanced developmental levels, for their energetic and uninhibited self-expression, spontaneity, and capacity to live authentically, free from restrictive societal norms. However, they may also be viewed with apprehension as unpredictable, or dismissed as impractical dreamers, especially within highly driven, achievement-oriented environments. Their interpersonal relationships are characterized by intensity and mutual fulfillment when based on synergy and personal choice. Yet, when placed in managerial roles, they can exhibit autocratic or highly idiosyncratic behaviors, leading others to perceive them as elusive, aloof, or unapproachable.

Language Clues: The syntax used by individuals at this stage features contingencies, sophisticated qualifications, and the juxtaposition of contrasting ideas. The conjunction “and” frequently replaces “or” and “but.” The use of phrases like “even though” or “despite” indicates advanced cognitive complexity. Their written expressions often include vivid personal disclosures, sometimes punctuated with exclamation marks, and employ a nuanced psychological vocabulary. A verbal rejection of cliché obligations in sentence completion exercises, such as responding with “How can I generalize?”, demonstrates an emerging awareness of cultural conditioning.

The Autonomous Stage (Strategist)

The Autonomous stage introduces an expanded fourth-person perspective, situating the individual's experiences within the broader context of specific worldviews and the entirety of a human lifespan. Equipped with this extended temporal horizon and broader social awareness, individuals at this stage can identify systemic patterns and long-term trends, a capacity that earns them recognition as strategic thinkers. Cognitively, they adopt a general systems perspective, enabling them to understand multiple, interconnected networks of relationships and processes.

Individuals at this stage recognize that they may exhibit conflicting traits or polarities across different times and contexts. However, unlike those at the preceding stage who might despair over their true identity, Autonomous individuals possess the ability to acknowledge and integrate these diverse facets of themselves, including previously compartmentalized sub-identities. A pivotal new capability is the realization of their own power to generate meaning and construct new narratives. This becomes possible because they understand that meaning

is fundamentally an interpretation applied to experience; humans are continuously constructing stories about their reality. Consequently, Autonomous individuals make a conscious commitment to actively forge a meaningful existence for themselves and others through self-determination and self-actualization, navigating constantly shifting contexts. They maintain a robust, autonomous sense of self that is both highly differentiated and well-integrated, which includes the capacity to perceive and accept paradoxes and to tolerate ambiguity.

Characteristics of the Autonomous Stage

- **Realm:** Society and individuals sharing similar convictions and principles.
- **Time Frame:** One's own history and lifetime.
- **Cognition:** Metasystematic operations; functioning as a general systems thinker.
- **Expanded Perspective:** The self is viewed as embedded within history and multiple cultural contexts.
- **Preoccupations:** Personal development, self-actualization, self-fulfillment, and underlying processes.
- **Positive Equilibration:** Achieves a well-balanced integration of body and mind; characterized as autonomous, tolerant, insightful, and growth-oriented, with high self-esteem and a focus on overarching principles.
- **Truth:** Viewed as something that can be approximated. Higher developmental stages are considered superior because more complex arguments hold greater validity than weaker ones. Advanced development is seen as more adequate for navigating an increasingly complex global environment, emphasizing qualitative differences.

Autonomous individuals become highly attuned to their own psychological well-being, exhibiting an emotional tone that is notably less cynical and distrustful than that of the preceding stage. Relativism evolves into a personal commitment and a sense of responsibility for creating one's own meaning. Deeply connected to their inner workings, they can rediscover and embrace parts of the self that were previously rejected for being too confusing or threatening. By acknowledging the shadow aspects of the self to a greater extent, they achieve a new level of integration and wholeness. While they acutely experience role conflicts and dilemmas, they accept these as inevitable and view ambivalent feelings as entirely natural. Unlike individuals at even more advanced stages, Autonomous persons strive diligently to maintain composure and present themselves as reasonable and mature. They feel a strong responsibility to balance conflicting needs and various sub-identities, generally projecting an image of equilibrium.

Experiences are embraced for their immediate qualities even more fully than in the previous stage. Distressing emotions become more manageable; they can be internally acknowledged and openly shared with others. Because Autonomous individuals utilize a logical framework capable of integrating psychologically paradoxical elements, they expend less energy on defensive mechanisms. This efficiency fosters greater tolerance and spontaneity compared to adults at conventional stages. Both the self and others are accepted as complex beings possessing a mixture of positive and negative traits. Interpersonal exchanges facilitate connection with aspects of the self or behaviors that might otherwise be ignored. Constructive feedback illuminates blind spots and defensive postures, reinforcing the belief that the caring presence of others is essential for reaching one's full potential. Consequently, others are deemed vital to personal well-being, as deep self-knowledge and wisdom are cultivated through dynamic, intimate interactions. Mutual interdependence is recognized as inevitable and is approached with a sense of awe and a profound awareness of responsibility toward others. This deep appreciation of people as mirrors of the self occasionally allows Autonomous individuals to experience non-possessive, unconditional love.

The primary fear at this stage is the failure to fulfill one's potential or to uphold deeply valued universal principles, such as justice, tolerance, and human dignity. Depression typically stems from a loss of courage, a diminished sense of agency, and guilt over not realizing one's unique human promise. When employing psychological defenses, healthy Autonomous individuals rely predominantly on mature mechanisms like suppression, altruism, humor, and anticipation. If they resort to less mature defenses, they demonstrate self-forgiveness and resilience, reasoning, "Right now I need to be like this, but I intend to act more maturely again when appropriate."

The internal processes at this stage are intricate and require careful observation. Despite their need for interpersonal connection, Autonomous individuals also require privacy and time for self-reflection. The self is perceived as a continuously unfolding entity subject to constant reappraisal, and observing this evolution provides significant satisfaction. Their life's work is dedicated to the pursuit of becoming the best version of themselves, making personal growth, self-actualization, and self-fulfillment their primary desires. They view others as actors in their own life dramas, finding these narratives equally fascinating. A powerful motivator is the desire to facilitate the growth of others, making this stage common among psychologists, coaches, consultants, and effective leaders. However, when their efforts to help others reach their potential meet resistance, they may experience impatience with the slow pace of others' development and frustration over a perceived unwillingness to grow. This tendency represents a central vulnerability of the stage.

Autonomous individuals are often the most steadfast believers that higher developmental stages are inherently better and should be actively promoted. They reason that increased differentiation and autonomy lead to a more objective, undistorted, and realistic self-identity, allowing one to claim an authentic and truthful self. Consequently, authenticity stands as a paramount value within their repertoire.

Many view life as an open-ended journey, rejecting the notion of a predetermined path applicable to everyone. They believe each person must forge their own lifestyle and bears the responsibility for their own self-fulfillment. They are deeply interested in psychological inquiries and strategies for resolving inner conflicts. Unlike those at conventional stages, they view seeking therapy, advice, or consultation not as a weakness, but as a vital necessity. They maintain faith in the human capacity to extract meaning from chaos and adversity, constructing personal significance without feeling compelled to impose it on others. They welcome alternative solutions to conflicts and deeply respect the autonomy of others. At times, they may find the mundane requirements of earning a living and other ordinary life constraints to be stifling, preferring to pursue their passions on their own terms. If their passion aligns with leading an organization to greatness, the pairing can be highly successful.

These individuals may experience genuine, principled anger and righteous indignation in response to global injustices. They are willing to oppose societal norms to express personal convictions or uphold their principles, though their anger rarely targets a specific victim. They live according to self-evaluated, internal standards, where "walking the talk" serves as a testament to their moral character and authenticity. Irreconcilable role conflicts are felt profoundly. Some emerge as charismatic moral leaders who, when defending a worthy cause, may disregard the negative repercussions for themselves. However, they can also become overly forceful in their convictions, particularly when driven by principled anger. If left unchecked, the combination of charisma and intense moral certainty can become a potent negative force.

An expanded awareness of their inner depths allows Autonomous individuals to utilize dreams, fantasy, and imagination much more freely than those at earlier stages. Their cognitive processes are unhindered, releasing profound creativity as their imagination breaks free from the constraints of strict logic and convention. They approach problem-solving by thinking outside the box. Furthermore, their acute awareness of human frailty as an intrinsic part of the human condition often manifests in existential humor, characterized by a lighter, more nuanced irony.

- **Impulse Control and Character Development:** Guided by self-evaluated, internalized standards. Behavior serves as an expression of moral principles. Demonstrates tolerance for multiple viewpoints and a deep concern for conflicting roles, duties, and principles.
- **Interpersonal Style:** Assumes responsibility for relationships while maintaining a strong desire for autonomy. Views relationships through the lens of inevitable mutual interdependence. Tolerates diverse approaches to conflict resolution and respects the autonomy of others. Employs non-hostile, existential humor.
- **Cognitive Level:** Features an expanded time frame and social context. Possesses the capacity to perceive and embrace paradox and contradiction, alongside a high tolerance for ambiguity. Exhibits a broad scope of thought and perceives the self as the regulator of a complex system with interdependent parts within a larger context.
- **Conscious Preoccupation:** Deeply concerned with individuality and self-fulfillment. Highly interested in the psychology of the self and the process of reconciling conflicting needs.
- **Chief Anxiety:** Fears failing to fulfill personal potential, neglecting cherished principles (e.g., justice, tolerance), and losing courage. Experiences impatience with the slow development of others and their perceived reluctance to grow.
- **Internal Dimension:** Seeks to understand the self through the lens of inner conflict and polarities. Strives to integrate various situational selves into a coherent, unified whole.
- **Defenses:** Primarily utilizes mature defenses such as suppression, altruism, humor, and anticipation. When employing less mature defenses, exhibits self-forgiveness and understanding, acknowledging temporary regressions while planning to return to mature behavior, stating, "Right now I need to be like this, but I will be able to act more maturely again later".
- **Representatives:** Often charismatic individuals willing to make personal sacrifices to defend and exemplify their deeply held moral principles.
- **Language Clues:** Employs complex, flexible syntax to discuss a wide array of topics and concerns. Strives to capture the complexity of life in verbal expressions, presenting a coherent exposition of their thoughts and identity. Utilizes a differentiated psychological vocabulary and grasps the concept of circular causality in human relationships. Frequently uses terms related to identity, growth, higher principles, and self-fulfillment.

The Unitive Stages

The highest levels of postconventional development encompass stages where individuals recognize that all objects and concepts are human-made constructs. This includes abstract notions such as the ego, three-dimensional space, and time, all of which are built upon successive layers of symbolic abstraction. They understand that even a commonplace concept like a "chair" is a massive simplification; no two mental representations of a chair are identical, nor are any two physical chairs exactly alike. Yet, the shared terminology functions effectively for communication. A defining characteristic of these advanced stages is the acute awareness of both the limitations and the extraordinary utility of language. While previous stages begin to deconstruct knowledge by recognizing the importance of interpretation and context, this advanced level perceives reality as an undifferentiated phenomenological continuum, a creative ground, or an underlying unity. A primary existential concern at these stages involves grappling with fundamental assumptions about human nature and the innate drive to impose order upon chaos. These final stages represent cross-paradigmatic and

transrational operations, as only a novel way of knowing can hierarchically transcend and integrate all preceding epistemologies.

The Construct-Aware Stage (Alchemist)

Individuals at the Construct-Aware stage recognize the overarching pattern of development that encompasses increasingly broad realms of experience and thought. They understand that the ego has served dual functions: as a central processing unit for stimuli and as the primary reference point for self-identity. Upon realizing this fundamental egocentricity, they begin to experience it as a limitation to further growth and comprehension. They question the ultimate value of constructing increasingly complex thought structures and integrations, recognizing the inherent absurdity and automatic boundaries of human map-making within the representational domain.

Unlike those at earlier stages, Construct-Aware individuals are highly conscious of the ego's vigilant and clever strategies for self-preservation. This marks the first developmental point where the ego becomes fully transparent to itself. They view definitive knowledge about the self or the universe as illusory and unattainable through sheer effort and rational thought, recognizing that all conscious cognition is constructed and therefore inherently separated from the underlying, cohesive, non-dual reality.

By directing their focus further inward, they deconstruct their own attempts at meaning-making, becoming acutely aware of the profound divisions and paradoxes embedded in rational thought. They independently arrive at the realization that the conceptual map is not the actual territory. The linguistic habit of dividing the world into polar opposites and attaching value judgments to them becomes fully conscious. Concepts such as good and evil, life and death, or beauty and ugliness are perceived as two sides of the same coin—mutually dependent and defining one another. Furthermore, they recognize that the incessant categorization of experiences as good or bad generates much of the tension and dissatisfaction prevalent in ordinary waking life. These individuals possess a dynamic, multifaceted understanding of human nature and the intricacies of social interaction. They actively confront their own deep-seated need for theories and explanations, seeking to uncover the limitations of the rational mind and to unlearn automatic, conditioned responses sustained by memory and continuous cultural reinforcement.

Characteristics of the Construct-Aware Stage

- **Realm:** Extends beyond one's own culture, encompassing a global and historical perspective.
- **Time Frame:** Reaches beyond the individual's lifetime.
- **Cognition:** Capable of perceiving unitive concepts; operates cross-paradigmatically.
- **Preoccupation:** Focused on inner conflicts regarding existential paradoxes and the intrinsic limitations of language and meaning-making.
- **Positive Equilibration:** Characterized by the acceptance of tension and paradox, a commitment to serving the self and others, and profound humility in the face of life's tasks.
- **Truth:** Acknowledges that regardless of the level of abstraction or cognitive insight achieved, the individual remains separated from the underlying non-dual reality.

Construct-Aware individuals closely monitor their own emotional and rational processing. They observe their automatic tendencies to judge, analyze, and reflect in the pursuit of creating increasingly accurate theories of life. They understand these intellectual endeavors as partial defense mechanisms designed to avoid confronting

the impermanence of the embodied self. Consequently, they see through not only cultural conditioning but also the fundamental predicament of existing within the confines of language.

Recognizing the filter of symbolic construction profoundly alters their relationship with language. They strive to remain conscious of the pseudo-reality generated by words, understanding that the quest for objective self-identification and rational explanations of the universe is ultimately futile—an artifact of the human desire to solidify that which is inherently fluid and immaterial. They recognize that the habit of language reinforces the ego's dominance whenever meaning is constructed through representation, regardless of the specific language, power dynamics, or cultural context. Simultaneously, they deeply appreciate the indispensable role language plays in human affairs, social interaction, and overall development.

As self-awareness deepens and reasoning becomes more sophisticated, these individuals gain increased access to intuition, bodily sensations, feelings, dreams, and archetypal or transpersonal material. These non-rational sources of knowledge become just as crucial as rational deliberation for interpreting experience and finding meaning. The ability to value and draw upon non-rational insights expands significantly throughout postconventional development.

Crucially, the consistent practice of inward observation often triggers spontaneous experiences of a direct mode of being, where the distinction between the knower and the known temporarily dissolves, and the personal sense of self vanishes. These occurrences, often described as peak moments, flow states, or bliss experiences, possess consistently positive qualities that encourage a yearning for further such encounters. However, the process of dismantling the conditional self can also be deeply unsettling, akin to the harrowing experiences sometimes encountered in alternative states of consciousness induced by intense meditation or other means.

Individuals at this stage frequently report functioning as a witness to their own internal experiences, observing the flow of thoughts and feelings without attempting to direct or control them. This witnessing provides moments of liberation from the ego's relentless drive for control and self-affirmation. Nevertheless, these experiences are transient; the moment the individual attempts to evaluate or judge the peak experience, the state is broken.

There is a natural reluctance to abandon familiar modes of functioning. People resist relinquishing the illusion of an enduring, separate identity that they have spent a lifetime defining and cultivating. Even when they comprehend that releasing attachment to the known alleviates familiar forms of suffering, deliberate attempts to let go often prove ineffective and generate intractable paradoxes. Becoming attached to the concept of non-attachment only strengthens the fetters. Similarly, taking pride in one's psychic abilities or ego-transcending journey merely reinforces the ego's dominance, illustrating how the ego can co-opt transpersonal experiences for its own aggrandizement.

A defining reality for Construct-Aware individuals is the scarcity of peers who share their developmental perspective. They may harbor fears that almost no one comprehends their complexity or sympathizes with their experiences, which in turn can induce feelings of guilt or hubris for perceiving themselves as "better" or more advanced than others. They acutely observe their own attachments and their reliance on increasingly elaborate self-theories to maintain a permanent identity. Conversely, they possess a profound appreciation for the necessity of others to make sense of life using the tools available to them. This fosters a deep tolerance for diverse life solutions, even as they clearly perceive the limitations of those solutions. Occasionally, they may experience envy toward the simplicity of earlier developmental stages, as their own reality is experienced as overwhelmingly complex. Yet, due to their advanced ego maturity, most achieve a dynamic and hopeful equilibrium amidst these fundamental conflicts. They pursue their chosen destinies with independence and courage, fully acknowledging their essential aloneness and existential despair. When integration fails, their depression centers on the fundamental isolation of humanity and the inability of rational thought to generate lasting meaning.

This is the first stage that interprets all experiences entirely through the lens of change and evolution. Consequently, they are even more sensitive than Autonomous individuals and possess a unique capacity to understand others in developmental terms. Those who engage in public or interpersonal work typically exhibit exceptionally refined interpersonal skills and a deep insight into complex personalities and relational dynamics. They listen with profound empathy and provide transformative, undistorted feedback.

Construct-Aware individuals have profound access to their own past methods of meaning-making, allowing them to tailor their interactions precisely to the developmental level of the recipient. For instance, they can effectively engage with individuals at self-protective stages by adopting a style that asserts superior insight through strength, meeting them on their own terms. As consultants or mentors, they adapt their approach to the client's needs, facilitating self-discovery through empathetic listening, strategically challenging ideas, and helping clients reframe experiences and construct new narratives. As counselors, they do not assume they can fully grasp the unique experience of another, yet they maintain a deep human affinity. They often harbor resentment toward the self-importance and subtle need for affirmation characteristic of the preceding Autonomous stage.

In fact, they may exhibit the least tolerance for the Autonomous stage's fervent drive to help others reach their maximum potential. They view the desire to change others as a fundamental flaw, reflecting an egocentric belief that one's own perspective is the valid measure of the world, and indicating a failure to live in the present moment. Because they are highly differentiated, they can be overly self-critical upon first recognizing their own ego attachments. However, with continued experience in the cycle of identification and release, they develop tolerance for their own vacillating complexity. They generally employ mature defense mechanisms—such as sublimation, non-hostile humor, and bracketing—while remaining highly insightful regarding their own vulnerabilities. They may consciously choose to utilize less mature behavioral styles or simply accept their raw, spontaneous responses when they occur. The conscious experience of non-ordinary states, where the sense of self and time dissolves, helps contextualize and diminish the ego's temptation to assume an exaggerated sense of power and responsibility.

These individuals can perceive the underlying structure of their own cognitive processes, compare them with those of others, and recognize the fundamental limitations of rational thought and language. While they often appear highly intelligent, they frequently experience impatience with their own cleverness, recognizing it as merely a cognitive tool. They are fascinated by the pervasive human need for meaning-making and understand the mechanics of how meaning is constructed through the segmentation and reification of the continuous flow of phenomena into complex theories. Consequently, they are deeply preoccupied with the boundaries of rationality and the challenge of living within the paradoxes of language.

In leadership roles, Construct-Aware individuals tend to establish novel organizations or work independently to make their optimal contribution to humanity. They embrace roles as catalysts or transformers but are quick to depart once they feel their transformative work is complete. They measure their success by their own dispensability—achieving their goal when the organization itself becomes self-organizing and inherently transformative.

- **Conscious Preoccupation:** Focused on the limitations of rational thought and language, and navigating the tension of existential paradoxes.
- **Counseling Style:** Highly adaptable; engages in mentoring and facilitates self-discovery through empathetic listening, strategic challenges, and reframing, all tailored to the client's specific developmental stage.
- **Depression:** Characterized by despair over humanity's essential aloneness and the ultimate failure of the rational enterprise to create enduring meaning.

- **Chief Anxiety:** The fear of being entirely misunderstood in their complexity, coupled with the fear that this very concern constitutes hubris.
- **Language Clues:** Communication is complex, vivid, authentic, and playful. It is often more direct and unpolished than that of the Autonomous stage, as there is significantly less desire to impress or present an idealized self. They articulate a vast matrix of topics, insights, and questions, cleverly woven into complex sentence structures. Responses may exhibit a stream-of-consciousness or “thought-in-progress” quality, reflecting attempts to relinquish conscious structuring. They frequently use vivid expressions regarding the constructed nature of reality, pose fundamental questions about meaning-making as a defense mechanism, and demonstrate a deep concern with epistemology and the limits of definition.

The Unitive Stage

Research into higher states of consciousness suggests the existence of stages beyond the rational, personal realm. While finer distinctions within this ego-transcendent domain are difficult to capture through standard assessment tools, the characteristics of the Unitive stage reflect a synthesis of these highest measurable levels of development.

The Unitive stage introduces a radically new paradigm for perceiving human existence and consciousness. The previous reliance on viewing reality exclusively through the lens of the self and the medium of language is fundamentally transformed into a universal or cosmic perspective. Individuals at this stage experience themselves and others as integral components of an ongoing humanity, deeply embedded in the creative ground and participating in the destiny of evolution. They successfully integrate the paradox of human existence: the simultaneous feelings of profound belongingness and distinct separateness are experienced without tension, viewed simply as shifting perceptions of the infinite possibilities of being.

At this level of integration, individuals perceive themselves and others across vast dimensions—geographical, social, cultural, historical, intellectual, and developmental. They effortlessly adopt multiple perspectives and shift their focus among various states of awareness. They feel deeply embedded in nature, viewing birth, growth, death, joy, and pain as natural, cyclical patterns within the flow of time. Rational awareness is no longer experienced as a limitation but as one of many phenomena that can move between the foreground and background of attention. They possess the ability to perceive the concrete, temporal aspects of an entity simultaneously with its eternal, symbolic significance. This unitive capacity allows them to recognize and cherish the essential humanity in all beings, feeling a profound sense of oneness with them. They respect the core essence of others and harbor no desire to change them. Crucially, from this perspective, higher developmental stages are not deemed superior to lower ones; all are recognized as necessary, interconnected components of a unified reality and an overarching evolutionary process.

Unitive thinkers accept themselves unconditionally and without the need for control. Regardless of the magnitude of their achievements, they recognize their efforts as merely a single drop in the vast ocean of human endeavor. Observers are frequently struck by the profound humility and grace these individuals exude. A defining characteristic of this transpersonal stage is a grounded simplicity that emerges on the far side of immense complexity.

Characteristics of the Unitive Stage

- **Realm:** The universe and the time/space continuum.
- **Time Frame:** Eternity.
- **Cognition:** Fully embraces unitive concepts.

- **Preoccupation:** Focused on pure being, maintaining a non-controlling consciousness, and witnessing the continuous flux of experience and mental states.
- **Perspective:** Highly multiperspectival; the center of identity shifts from the ego to a higher, transcendent Self.
- **Positive Equilibration:** Exhibits an accepting, unassuming presence; demonstrates a fully empathetic, non-interfering capacity to simply be with whatever arises.
- **Truth:** Perceived as immanent; truth is the experiential realization of interconnectedness and non-separateness, viewing existence as shifting states of awareness within a timeless spirit.

Despite their profound integration, individuals at this stage may sometimes be perceived by those at earlier stages as aloof or insufficiently engaged with the common pursuits and concerns of humanity. However, these critics often fail to recognize that Unitive adults function as powerful catalysts in the lives of others. By existing authentically and without apology, they challenge conventional perspectives and model a way of being that transcends evaluative, traditional notions of adulthood. They project a deep, ontological security that surpasses anything achievable through a rationally constructed self-identity. Unlike individuals at any other stage, they cultivate intense, non-demanding relationships with people across all developmental levels, ages, and backgrounds. By recognizing the inherent dignity in all manifestations of life, they possess a unique ability to make others feel entirely worthy and whole.

Unitive individuals operate from a completely internalized, transpersonal morality. Inner conflicts and competing external demands are accepted simply as aspects of existence that require witnessing rather than resolution or denial. They are no longer propelled by the desire to achieve specific states or to mold themselves into a particular ideal; instead, they easily relinquish the unattainable. While deeply concerned with global justice, creativity, and spontaneity, their non-attached, impersonal stance does not result in passivity. Rather, it enables them to take highly direct and powerful action when necessary.

Reality is frequently experienced as an undifferentiated phenomenological continuum or the unified ground of consciousness. Every thought, feeling, word, object, and theory is recognized as a human construct—an artificial boundary drawn where none truly exists. They understand the quest for meaning and connection as an essential facet of the human condition, feeling a deep interconnectedness with all sentient beings in their struggle to survive and comprehend their existence. This fosters boundless tolerance, compassion, and affiliation with all forms of life, recognizing that the simplest organism is, in its own way, as close to the ultimate truth as the most advanced philosopher. Peak experiences lose their extraordinary quality and become a familiar, integrated way of experiencing the world. The present moment is perceived as the intersection of past and future. This total openness allows them to align with truth and beauty, facilitating visionary experiences where reality is comprehended holistically and analogically, rather than solely through the rational mind.

They can effortlessly shift their focus, perceiving the entirety of a system simultaneously with its individual components. Operating within an expanded temporal framework that encompasses the entirety of Earth's history and future, they view life as a temporary, sometimes voluntary, separation from the creative ground, to which it will inevitably return. While conscious of their unique physical embodiment, they identify intimately with all living things. The perceived separation between self and other is understood as an illusion—a construct designed to satisfy the ego's demand for permanence and to defend against the fear of death.

Consequently, Unitive individuals transcend narrow ego boundaries. They maintain open boundaries, remaining attuned to whatever enters their awareness without becoming preoccupied by it. They engage in "witnessing" rather than mere observation, metabolizing experiences without the willful, conscious focus characteristic of earlier adult stages. They recognize that truth is immanent in the universe and can be apprehended through this open, receptive stance, though it remains forever beyond the grasp of pure rationality.

They possess an integrated sense of identity as active participants in cosmic evolution. They are aligned with their life's work, viewing it simultaneously as an expression of their unique individuality and as a contribution to shared humanity. Deeply invested in the fundamental dilemmas of the human condition, they advocate for justice, fairness, and universal benevolence. While they take responsibility for their own meaning-making, they do not view themselves as the absolute masters of their destiny in the way Autonomous or Construct-Aware individuals might. They recognize that the ways of being are infinite, with clues to this diversity found throughout human history, current cultural variations, and the potential for future evolutionary developments or alternative states of consciousness. Life is perceived as fulfilling a cosmic purpose, rendering it essentially simple. Thinking and doing are recognized merely as modes of existence, holding no intrinsic superiority over feeling, being, or even non-being—a concept that remains profoundly difficult for those operating exclusively within the personal realm to grasp. They embody the understanding that ultimate comprehension is itself an illusion.

In summary, Unitive adults maintain a beautifully balanced and integrated sense of both their individuality and their universal belonging, feeling themselves to be an active part of the universe's ongoing cycles of creation, destruction, and recreation.

- **Language Clues:** Unitive individuals utilize a vast, global array of topics and concerns, often weaving them into a single response. Their unitive capacity provides them with an expansive mental landscape. Their communication is kaleidoscopic, effortlessly bridging profound contrasts: the concrete and the practical, the theoretical and the philosophical, the personal and the global, the serious and the humorous, the mundane and the sublime. Their responses to assessments may feature highly unique, vivid expressions and creative metaphors that articulate both ordinary and non-ordinary experiences. Conversely, they may also provide strikingly simple responses. This simplicity is not indicative of a lower developmental stage; rather, straightforward spontaneity is recognized as an essential hallmark of wisdom and ego-transcendence. While Construct-Aware individuals possess the most complex and differentiated view of reality within the personal realm, Unitive adults operate entirely outside the desperate need for meaning-making that characterizes all earlier stages, recognizing the ultimate futility of shielding and bolstering the ego.

Summary

The developmental trajectory traces a path from the unconscious, undifferentiated state of infancy to the mature adult's conscious experience of profound embeddedness within the universe. This journey moves from the pre-rational to the meta-rational, and from pre-verbal unawareness to the dawn of post-symbolic wisdom. Immense freedom is attained when individuals recognize the fundamental interconnectedness of all phenomena and understand the constructed nature of boundaries, objects, self-identities, and the narratives woven about life and reality. Significant suffering is alleviated when automatic cognitive and emotional habits are unlearned—decoupled from the memories of the past and the desires for the future—and replaced by a mindful, non-evaluative, and unwavering attention to the reality of the present moment.

Construction of a Scoring Manual for the Sentence Stem “A Good Boss—”

Abstract

Ego development theory is the study of how an individual's processing of experience and meaning-making of the world develops. The tool used to measure ego development is a sentence completion test, and its scoring manual is the foundation for the high validity and reliability of the measurement tool. A modified version of the sentence completion test was constructed, and in order to continue the trend of strong psychometric properties, a scoring manual needs to be constructed for the new sentence stems found on the modified test. This project constructs a scoring manual for the sentence stem, “A good boss—”.

The first step in creating a scoring manual was to sort the data, which consisted of 836 responses to the sentence stem, into categories within the different stages of ego development. Next, any new categories that seemed to emerge during the sort process were defined, and all of the existing categories were organized into a logical sequence within each stage. The final step was to write the scoring manual and perform basic statistics on the frequency distribution of responses within each category.

The results of this project include the construction of a scoring manual for the sentence stem “A good boss—”, and a frequency distribution of the stem responses, which provides evidence that the sentence stem “A good boss—” has internal validity, as it seems to produce a similar distribution of response data as the assessment tool as a whole provides. This project enhances the reliability and validity of the modified sentence completion test and adds data and conclusions to the pool of research available for the study of ego development theory.

Introduction

The purpose of this project is to construct a scoring manual for the sentence stem “A good boss—”, which is a component of a projective measure of ego development. An introduction to this project would not be complete without a review of the concept of ego development, which will include an overview of the individual ego stages. This will be followed by a description of the original measure of ego development and its revised form. After a brief introduction of how these sentence completion tests are scored, the intent of this project will be discussed, including support for constructing an updated scoring manual for this sentence stem.

The Concept of Ego Development

Early psychoanalytic theorists believed that the ego was derived from and explained in terms of drives originating instinctually. Yet, other theorists separated from this view, contending that the ego endeavored to spontaneously develop. The concept of ego development follows a continuum of earlier, similar conceptions, including moral development, character development, interpersonal relatability, cognitive complexity, and interpersonal integration. These conceptions have the following in common, they all: (a) embody normal developmental sequences that include dimensions of individual differences within any age cohort; (b) encompass a holistic view of personality and view behavior in the realm of meaning-making and purpose; and (c) are concerned with the personality characteristics of impulse control, interpersonal mode, and conscious preoccupations.

Extracting from the common domain of psychology and partly from these earlier writers, a new version of ego development was constructed. A program to measure ego development was proposed and then the data was

used to construct stage-specific milestones, which embody the definition of ego development. These milestones represent the frame of reference through which a person makes meaning of the world and her or his experiences within it. This search for coherent meaning is defined as the “essence” of the ego, and the stability of the ego is tied into this “essence” in that the ego will selectively disregard the observations that are inconsistent with its current frame of reference. In other words, individuals will function at the level that is most egosyntonic for them and translate and respond to the world on a day-to-day basis from that frame of reference. Therefore, a projective test is a useful tool to help evoke the subject’s own frame of reference on the test material, and this is the theoretical foundation for the sentence completion test. The cornerstone of ego development theory is related to the idea that language not only reflects human experience, but it also organizes and filters it. This description of the nature and function of language is an important contribution to ego development theory, considering that the sentence completion test measures the ego stages of respondents based on their verbal responses. The overall strategy of the sentence completion test is to identify the qualitative differences in the successive stages of ego development and to map the qualitative data onto a quantitative scale. Before describing how ego development is measured by the sentence completion test, it is necessary to introduce the stages of ego development.

The labels given to the stages of ego development have been transformed over the years since the first version of the sentence completion test. A fundamental aspect of the concept of ego development is that there are several dimensions of a person that evolve during ego development, including character development, impulse control, cognitive style and conscious preoccupations, and interpersonal style, and these features are woven into the descriptions for each stage.

The first stage is the Symbiotic stage, and the newborn at this stage is constructing for her or himself a stable world of objects. Some psychoanalytic theorists connect ego development to this period alone. Because this stage is characterized as pre-verbal or nonverbal, it cannot be measured with the sentence completion test and therefore will not be discussed further.

Stage 2 is the Impulsive stage and is indicative of the simultaneous emergence of the ego and the use of language. Impulses govern people at this stage, and others are seen as a source of supply. Cognitive simplicity is reflected in the language clues of using simple statements, using simple dichotomies (things are good or bad, clean or dirty), and instead of being expressed as feelings, affects are described using bodily terms. Individuals who are at this stage may seem confused, anxious and overwhelmed.

The Opportunist occupies Stage $2\frac{2}{3}$, and this person is wary of other’s intentions and experiences friction due to an “I win, you lose” mentality. They perceive the world based on their own needs and wants and may be perceived by others as being exploitative and manipulative. Opportunists will attempt to avoid the consequences of their actions by placing blame on others. They are preoccupied with control and advantage, and their language reflects this with the use of words like “always” and “never”.

The Diplomat is at Stage 3, and this stage is characterized by a desire to belong and conform to the rules of the group. Individuals at this stage are concerned with appearances, social acceptance, and avoiding conflict. They tend to view the world in terms of stereotypes and clichés, and their language is often characterized by the use of platitudes and conventional phrases. They value loyalty and cooperation, but may struggle with independent thought and decision-making.

The Expert is at Stage $3\frac{3}{4}$, and this stage marks a shift towards greater self-awareness and a focus on individual skills and knowledge. Individuals at this stage are concerned with competence, efficiency, and doing things “right”. They value logic, reason, and objective facts, and may be critical of those who do not share their standards. Their language is often characterized by the use of technical jargon and a focus on details and procedures. They may struggle with ambiguity and multiple perspectives.

The Achiever is at Stage 4, and this stage is characterized by a focus on goals, results, and personal achievement. Individuals at this stage are self-directed, ambitious, and driven to succeed. They value planning, organization, and strategic thinking, and are able to balance multiple priorities and perspectives. Their language is often characterized by the use of action-oriented verbs and a focus on outcomes and consequences. They may struggle with delegating tasks and trusting others to meet their standards.

The Individualist is at Stage $\frac{4}{5}$, and this stage marks a shift towards greater introspection and a focus on personal growth and authenticity. Individuals at this stage are concerned with meaning, purpose, and self-actualization. They value creativity, intuition, and subjective experience, and are able to tolerate ambiguity and paradox. Their language is often characterized by the use of metaphors, symbols, and a focus on inner states and emotions. They may struggle with balancing their own needs with the needs of others and finding a sense of belonging.

The Strategist is at Stage 5, and this stage is characterized by a focus on systemic thinking, collaboration, and long-term vision. Individuals at this stage are able to see the big picture and understand the interconnectedness of complex systems. They value diversity, dialogue, and mutual learning, and are able to navigate conflict and ambiguity with grace and skill. Their language is often characterized by the use of inclusive pronouns and a focus on shared goals and values. They may struggle with the slow pace of change and the resistance of others to new ideas.

The Magician is at Stage $\frac{5}{6}$, and this stage marks a shift towards greater integration and a focus on transformation and transcendence. Individuals at this stage are able to hold multiple perspectives simultaneously and see the underlying unity of all things. They value wisdom, compassion, and spiritual growth, and are able to act with profound insight and intuition. Their language is often characterized by the use of paradox, poetry, and a focus on the ineffable and the transcendent. They may struggle with communicating their insights to others and finding a sense of grounding in the material world.

The Ironist is at Stage 6, and this stage is characterized by a focus on universal principles, unconditional love, and a deep sense of connection to all of humanity. Individuals at this stage are able to transcend their own ego and act with profound selflessness and compassion. They value truth, justice, and the well-being of all beings, and are able to inspire and uplift others with their presence and their words. Their language is often characterized by the use of simple, profound statements and a focus on the essential nature of reality. They may struggle with the suffering of the world and the limitations of human existence.

The Sentence Completion Test and Scoring Procedures

The sentence completion test is a projective measure of ego development that consists of a series of sentence stems that the respondent is asked to complete. The responses are then scored according to a detailed manual that provides examples of responses at each stage of ego development. The scoring process involves matching the respondent's completion with the examples in the manual and assigning a score based on the stage that best fits the response. The scores for all of the sentence stems are then combined to calculate a total protocol rating, which represents the respondent's overall level of ego development.

The purpose of this project is to increase the psychometric validity and reliability of the modified sentence completion test and enhance the study of ego development by constructing a scoring manual for the sentence stem "A good boss—".

Literature Review

It has been many years since the first publication of the sentence completion test, and since then, numerous studies have used this form of measurement in their empirical inquiries, volumes of books have been written about the concept and measure, countless evaluations of the measurement's validity and reliability have been conducted, and several revisions have been made to the test, its scoring manuals, and the labels for the stages of ego development. This literature review will provide a survey of the history of the test, the revisions and new forms that have been generated, the reliability and validity of the measurement tool, discussion of the concept of ego development as a "master trait", and the utilization of the test in peripheral areas of research.

History of the Sentence Completion Test

To understand how the concept and measurement of ego development were arrived at, it is necessary to begin with studies of the personality patterns of mothers and of women in general. A research group created an objective measure named the Family Problems scale, which included items concerning the problems of family life throughout the day. The purpose of this study was to administer the test items to several samples of women and search for clusters of items that might be related to personality patterns or traits. This study led to a large cluster of items that highlighted a characterization of women resembling the "authoritarian" personality. The group constructed a scale around this cluster, which they termed the Authoritarian Family Ideology. In determining which group of women was representative of this ideology, the researchers noted that a continuum was necessary to define the cluster and that authoritarianism was not the extreme, but the midpoint. Therefore, they came up with a milestone sequence, which represented qualitatively different levels along a developmental course. This milestone sequence was proposed to be the concept of ego development and introduced it not as one interesting personality trait among several others, but as the "master trait". The use of the term "master trait" has sparked some controversy in the field of trait and developmental psychology, and this debate will be examined later. A program of how to measure this concept of ego development was also described.

To test this new idea, the group constructed a sentence completion test, adopting the conception of I-levels for interpersonal maturity and integration as well as guidelines for scoring the test. The four initial stages and codes were as follows: Impulsive (I-2), Conformist (I-3), Conscientious (I-4), and Autonomous (I-5). Early raters of the measure indicated to the research group that an intermediate stage was needed between Impulsive and Conformist, and therefore, another stage was added, coded Delta, to occupy a level between these two stages. In the beginning, the researchers had sentence completions to begin with, but no scoring manual. To devise scoring manuals, the group first tried to imagine what kind of person would emerge in each stage, based on the milestones, which resulted in possible examples of responses for each stage. This list of possible responses was termed their exemplar manual. After this manual failed with newly collected responses, the researchers tried grouping examples into categories, and this was termed the categorized manual. The final manual that worked best in terms of being most useful for new sets of responses was a combination of both exemplar and categorized manuals, the rationalized category manual.

For microvalidation of the manual, the researchers finalized ground rules for scoring, and re-evaluated the final scoring manual with a large and heterogeneous sample set. This resulted in the revision and addition of stages of ego development. For example, the Opportunist (Delta) stage was renamed Self-Protective, which was more reflective of the expressions in the item responses, and another transition stage was introduced just after Self-Protective, coded Delta/3, because there seemed to be a need for compromise between the Self-Protective (Delta) stage and the next stage, Conformist (I-3). A later stage emerged above Autonomous, named Integrated (I-6), and two transition levels were added, one originally called Conscientious-Conformist (eventually changed

to Self-Aware, I-³/₄) and the other termed Individualistic (I-⁴/₅) for the transition between Conscientious and Autonomous.

The cornerstone of the method is classifying related but not necessarily linked answers into categories, treated as equivalent. Forming categories is an art that improves with practice, because there is constant feedback when the manual is next put to use. This statement provides insight into the creative methodology of constructing scoring manuals for sentence stems. For final confirmation to send the sentence completion test out for publication, the researchers settled upon 36 stems, finalized the unique scoring algorithm, and tested the scoring manual using a sealed sample and experienced raters. Data from this sample gave an interrater reliability of approximately .91 for rating the items and total protocol ratings, and the internal consistency (coefficient alpha) was .90. Training exercises administered to new, untrained raters proved that the written instructions in the scoring manual were complete.

The most distinctive and crucially valuable feature of the method of manual construction is the microvalidation of manual categories by repeated cycling, applying the manual to a new sample, “decoding” the ratings to see how well the parts of the manual are doing, and making minor changes before applying the manual again. By this method the descriptions of the several stages were shaped by the data, and the conception of ego development took shape.

Perhaps a limitation of this initial publication of the test and its scoring manual is that all of the item responses were obtained from women and adolescent girls. Prior to this manual being published, a prediction of future research needs led to a proposal of new versions for men and women, which subsequently became the original published forms of the test. As these forms were used in the field, problems began to emerge, which, in turn, provided the criteria for revising the test. These criteria which needed to be met included: (a) close comparability of forms for men and women (to keep the forms as equivalent as possible); (b) interesting and varied content (parallel stems may decrease interest and motivation of respondent); (c) first and second pages usable as abbreviated forms (a shorter form may be more attractive to users); (d) selection of some items originally composed for men and for which the original and only available manual was derived from male samples, for example “When I am criticized—” (this balances the use of stems and manuals devised for men and women); (e) selection of the most valid items; (f) avoidance of successions of items that suggest connected answers; (g) the first item on each page sufficiently structured so as to be relatively easy to complete (in hopes of preventing self-consciousness, factual reports, or objections); and (h) the last item on each page should be one that leaves a pleasant or bland aftertaste, that is, does not encourage hostile or self-derogatory completions.

Based on these criteria, new forms were devised for women, men, girls, and boys. With new forms of the test, it was a fundamental next step to revise the original scoring manuals and include samples from male and female subjects, considering the early scoring manuals only included responses from adolescent girls and women. Researchers who had used the earlier forms were requested to share their sample protocols in order to help with revising the scoring manuals. The researchers also took this opportunity to revise the coding for the stages of ego development.

In this revision of the scoring manual, several category titles within each stage were rewritten, more typical examples were chosen for category titles, and because exemplar categories had been used more successfully during the rating procedure, the majority of the descriptive titles were changed to exemplar category titles. Other changes in the format from the earlier version included a more condensed manual, the use of themes that appeared across stages for a given stem to help guide the rater to the pertinent area of the manual, and the “blurbs” for each stage were omitted. The resulting version of the scoring manual is the current published manual for the test.

Table I illustrates the codes assigned by the research teams, and also the corresponding numerical codes used in the representation of the ego development stages, which subsequently are the codes used in the scoring

manual for this project. It is important to note that the Delta and Delta/3 codes were subsumed into “ $\frac{2}{3}$ ” to keep the numerical codes consistent. While there was evidence of finer distinctions between the Delta and Delta/3 stages, these representations were combined because the earlier stages manifest themselves so infrequently with the sentence completion test. It is noted, however, that these earlier distinctions are important for research in the earlier, preconventional stages.

A new sentence completion test form and scoring manual were developed for use in the measure of ego development in children and youths. This was in response to questions raised about the use of the scoring manuals (devised from responses gathered mostly from adults) for rating the forms for boys and girls, as well as the minimum age at which those forms could be used. There is also an available appendix for using the test in translation to other languages. This seems to be a very resourceful tool in expanding the cross-cultural research on ego development. In fact, the test has been translated into 11 different languages in 19 different published studies.

Table I: Stages of Ego Development and Corresponding Codes

Ego Stage	Original Codes	Revised Codes	Current Codes
Impulsive	I-2	E2	2
Self-Protective	Delta; Delta/3	E3	$\frac{2}{3}$
Conformist	I-3	E4	3
Self-Aware	I- $\frac{3}{4}$	E5	$\frac{3}{4}$
Conscientious	I-4	E6	4
Individualistic	I- $\frac{4}{5}$	E7	$\frac{4}{5}$
Autonomous	I-5	E8	5
Integrated	I-6	E9	$\frac{5}{6}$; 6

Reliability and Validity of the Sentence Completion Test

A robust body of research with several hundred studies utilizing the test as a measurement tool supports the reliability and validity of the test. Two significant reviews describe the results of numerous studies concerning the reliability and validity of the test. Interrater reliability is high for this assessment when using the scoring manuals, with a Cronbach's alpha of .91. Similar results were consistently reported in research publications over a course of 20 years. The validity of ego development theory and measurement can be broken down into construct validity, discriminant validity, and predictive validity. There is considerable empirical support for the construct validity of ego development in regards to the three central tenets of the theory (unitary nature of the ego; the ego representing an integration of the personality characteristics of cognitive functioning, personal and interpersonal awareness, and character development; and the sequentiality of ego stages), as well as support for its relation to external criterion of alternative measures. Discriminant validity for the test indicated that the low correlations between ego development and verbal fluency and intelligence supported that ego development is distinct from those two variables, and it was also found that socioeconomic status and ego development are distinct. There was not enough empirical support to suggest further research into investigating the predictive

validity of the test. An earlier review of the reliability and validity of the test presents very similar findings. The results of the review of 20 years of research were summarized as indicating that ego development may be regarded as a complex, but unitary, construct, with the ego developing in a hierarchical, invariant, and sequential manner. It seems safe to conclude that the test is a reliable and valid tool for measuring ego development.

Ego Development as the Master Trait

Ego development theory and its original measurement tool seem to hold a solid position in the field of personality research. Yet, some ideas have met their share of criticism over the years, such as the use of the term "master trait". The conception of ego development is presented as the master trait in personality. It is contended that this frame provides the other, more specific, fragmented personality traits with their meaning, and it is around ego development that these other traits are organized. The indivisibility of the cognitive, affective and operant components of ego development is another reason given for saying no term less than ego development encompasses all of these phenomena.

Those that question the postulate of ego development as the master trait comment that the complexity of personality is being unjustly reduced to a single continuum and assuming that ego development holds a super-ordinate position in the overall collection of personality traits. It is argued that this leads one to think that all major personality factors could be seen as master traits, for they all condition the expression of the other traits. For example, some have wondered if the sentence completion test really is a measure of ego development or just a measure of differences in intelligence. It seems, though, that intelligence is a factor necessary but not sufficient for ego development.

A summary of 52 correlations between ego level scores and intelligence test scores only found a weighted Pearson correlation of 0.30, indicating that ego development and intelligence are conceptually and functionally distinct concepts. One might ask, then why do the two factors seem so related? It is necessary to be reliant on some kind of internal consistency in the measurement of ego development, and so the scoring and results will tend towards the most easily and reliably judged element, which seems to be the cognitive element. This is also similar to what happened with moral development, in that it was necessary to rely on stressing the cognitive and intellectual components of moral development during measurement. While agreeing that there is no proof of the indivisibility of ego development, there is also a caution against reducing the differences to intelligence only, for a formal notion of logic and cognitive structure will not suffice for an understanding of the contents and constituents of ego development, namely its "essence". There are also examples of individuals who score the same on intelligence tests but have very different levels of ego development, indicating an alternate possibility for another pacer aside from intelligence.

This debate stills begs the question of whether or not there are multiple lines of development, for if one does not believe that there could be a single master trait developing, one would have to research and define the other possible lines of development and discuss the correlations between them. Several lines of development have been mapped, but it is noted that the cognitive line of development seems to be a precursor to all other lines, including the self-line, for what one identifies with is determined by what one can be aware of. Other researchers explored this notion as well, describing cognitive development as affecting personality because what psychologically impacts an individual has to be known by her or him in some cognitive form. A case has been made that in fact the idea of lines of development may reflect an explanatory fiction, rather than an ontological reflection of human development.

In summary, if one is going to scorn the presentation of ego development as a "master trait," then it is necessary to approach the concept of multiple lines of development, which is currently a controversial one. In the study of personality development, are there master traits or are they all the same thing? The holistic and organismic view

of the concept of ego development is stood behind, and the significance of the proposal to the field is described as helping to go beyond the fragmentation of trait psychology and to look at personalities as meaningful wholes.

Relevant Research Areas for Ego Development

Research interest into adult development and organizational change in the workplace has been a catalyst for revisions of the names and stages of ego development as well as new forms of the test. Versions of stage names that are equivalent to the originally generated labels were introduced. A revised form of the test was used to measure organization transformation, and those revisions included decreasing the total number of stems and adding four stems that related directly to the work environment, resulting in a 24-item test.

The concept of ego development was advanced by showing evidence of emerging patterns at the later stages of ego development. One contribution to the concept of ego development was the replacement of the highest stage, Integrated, with two distinct stages, Construct-Aware and Unitive, and new scoring rules were developed for scoring these protocols. The test was also expanded and revised into a new form. This enhanced the original assessment tool in terms of allowing a better capture of professional subjects in organizational contexts. Studies on postautonomous ego development resulted in a modified test, which is the most finely tuned, cost-effective, and validated assessment tool to date for ego development in the field.

Versions of labels for the stage names originally proposed were introduced. The stage names were meant to be less pejorative and more semantically neutral, for example, "Diplomat" instead of "Conformist" which may have a negative undertone. Table II can be referenced to help distinguish the labels used for ego stages.

In closing, it seems useful to mention some of the other areas of interest in which the test has been used: successful organizational transformation; meaning-making in the management field; mature ego development and ego transcendence; transcendental meditation programs and postconventional self-development; optimal adult development and dynamics of growth; advanced ego development among adults; personality change in adulthood; differential patterns of gender-related personality traits; ego development and the transition from adolescence to adulthood; individual differences in personality; sex differences in the course of personality development; ego development in college; adolescent academic achievement; trait models of personality and the Five-Factor Model; counseling theory and model for treatment, including the Integral model; and coping and defense mechanisms.

Table II: Comparison of Labels Used for Ego Stages

Current Labels	Alternative Labels 1	Alternative Labels 2
Unitive	Ironist	Unitive
Construct-Aware	Alchemist/Magician	Magician
Autonomous	Strategist	Strategist
Individualistic	Individualist	Individualist
Conscientious	Achiever	Achiever
Self-Aware	Expert/Technician	Expert
Conformist	Diplomat	Diplomat
Self-Protective	Opportunist	Opportunist
Impulsive	Impulsive	Impulsive

Methodology

This section will outline the methodology utilized in constructing a scoring manual for the sentence completion stem, “A good boss—”. Sources used in determining this methodology included articles and chapters describing how the original scoring manuals for the test were constructed and revised, the original scoring manual for this stem and an updated version, publications on ego development and how it manifests at each stage, and also personal communication. Five sections delineating the course of construction will be described in detail below: (a) data collection, (b) sorting response items, © category definition and organization, (d) writing the manual, and (e) statistics.

Data Collection

The responses used for this data set came from two different sources, an original manual attempt and a database with thousands of collected responses. Responses for the sentence stems, which included “A good boss—”, were collected starting in 1982 and continued until 2000. When the manual attempt was updated in 2008, there were $n = 358$ responses for “A good boss—” included as examples in the manual. For this project, $n = 478$ additional responses to the sentence stem were incorporated into the manual, leading to $N = 836$ total items in the data set.

Sorting Response Items

In order to easily organize the scored response items, each response was entered into a spreadsheet exactly as it appeared in the item response list, preserving any grammatical errors. All of the available data collected about the respondent was included for each response (age, sex, numeric item score, item score [assigned ego stage], ID#, the total protocol rating, and the total weighted score). Each item was assigned a new identification number, beginning with letters to distinguish the new identification number from the original identification number assigned by the initial researcher who organized the data. The letters were followed with 4 numeric values corresponding to what order the items were entered into the file. This version of the file was termed the “Master” worksheet.

Once all of the available responses were entered into the worksheet, the worksheet was printed out, and each individual response was cut out. The responses were sorted based on their original item scores for ego stage, and utilizing the existing categories in the current version of the scoring manual, each response item was matched to a category title. During this categorical organization, themes and patterns that emerged within as well as between each ego stage were discerned and highlighted so they could be described during manual construction. If new categories seemed to emerge, they were assigned a numerical code (the existing categories were numbered, and the new categories followed in numerical order).

An attempt was made to classify every response into a single category utilizing the sequence of scoring rules from the scoring manual. Rule 1: Match the completion with one of the listed category titles. Rule 2: Where the combination of two or more elements in a compound response generates a more complex level of conception, rate the response one step higher than the highest element. There are two types of compound responses. One type is a pseudo-compound response, which could be a cliché or repetition, but either way it constitutes a similar thought or single banality in common speech. The other compound response is a true compound, which would contain two or more contrasting ideas or alternative perspectives on or aspects of a situation. Rule 3: Where the combination of ideas in a compound response does not generate a higher level of conceptual complexity, rate in the less frequent category or rate in the higher category.

If a simple response or compound response could not be scored using Rules 1-3, then scoring continued in sequence to Rule 4: In the case of a meaningful response, where there is no appropriate category and Rules 2 and 3 do not apply, use the general theory to arrive at a rating. Rule 5: Where the response is omitted or is too fragmentary to be meaningful, it is rated Stage 3 (Opportunist) by default. During this initial sort, “Unassigned” categories for each stage were used if the rating for an item was uncertain. Along with the rules, an additional rule was applied that pertained solely to scoring responses at category $\frac{5}{6}$, 1: Matrices (not merely lists) have to include 3 or more ideas from multiple perspectives, subject areas, and levels of analysis.

At this point, the numerical codes for the assigned category number for each response were added to the “Master” worksheet for each response, in a column titled “Category #”. An extra column was also added for comments about the category assignment (if uncertain about category, if response might need to be moved to a different stage, etc.). This “Master” worksheet was copied into a new worksheet within the same file, and the “sort” function was used to physically organize the items by ego development stage. This worksheet was entitled “Ego stage sort.” Following this step, one new worksheet was created for each stage, labeling each worksheet with its corresponding stage name. For each of these worksheets, the responses were sorted once again by category, using the numerical code for each category (the number “888” was used for items that were “Unassigned”).

Rewritten Content

After sorting the responses, the categories were organized within each developmental level and across all developmental stages.

Category Definition and Organization

In scoring the protocols, the most difficult distinction for raters to make is between responses that share similar content to the adjacent stages. Therefore, providing a cross-reference for a category within one stage that may share a theme with categories at adjacent stages will assist the rater in distinguishing between stages for a

single response. The original scoring manual for this stem has cross-references already in place, but it was necessary to confirm these and to determine if any new themes emerged across developmental stages that needed cross-referencing. A data table was created with the developmental stages across the top as the column headings, and within each column, the category title was listed. From this arrangement, any new themes were determined and confirmation was made that the cross-references from the original manual were still reflected and were the closest fit for efficient distinction purposes. If categories had similar content to adjacent stages, those category titles were given a cross-reference denoted by the stage number and category number for that adjacent stage. For example, if a category from Stage 3 had similar content to a category in Stage $\frac{3}{4}$, the cross-reference might be: ($\frac{3}{4}$, 12). This would direct raters to Stage $\frac{3}{4}$, category 12 to help them decide which stage the response best relates to. A brief description of the differing theoretical content between the similar categories was listed for many of the cross-references.

Based on communication with the framework developers, it would be helpful to determine if the categories within each stage follow some internal logic and then list these categories in the manual based on that internal logic. For organization purposes, the most common categories (based on frequency of responses) were listed at the beginning of the category sequence. After that, a determination was made as to whether or not the categories could be logically ordered. Utilizing the data table from the cross-references, it became evident that themes were emerging within and between the stages. These included themes of Relationships ®, Communication ©, Behavior (B), and Growth/Development (G). A column was then added to the data chart (entitled – “Internal Logic Category”), and an internal logic category was designated for each of the category titles within the stages. The categories were placed in the following order: (a) first, the most frequent categories overall (containing 10% or more of the responses within a category); (b) then categories grouped by internal logic category, and sorted from the most to least frequent; © and finally, those categories which were not included in the major themes (R, C, B, G) were designated as “Other” (O), and unless they contained 10% or more of the total responses for the stage, these categories were listed at the end of the stage. After determining the internal logic, all categories were renumbered within each stage, in numerical order.

Writing the Manual

After sorting the responses, assigning each response to a category, and organizing the categories, a draft of the scoring manual was written. The item scoring manual included a “blurb”, which is a short description including useful topics for the raters. The different types of responses that the stem “A good boss—” generates from responders across all developmental stages were described (based on the essence of each stage according to developmental theory). The blurb also described factors for the rater to keep in mind as they scored individual item responses, including any difficulties the rater may encounter when trying to distinguish the developmental stage of a response for this stem.

Following the blurb, each developmental level was listed in the following order: Impulsive, Opportunist, Diplomat, Expert, Achiever, Pluralist, Strategist, Magician, and Unitive. After listing the stage name, a short description was written about the general characteristics of this stage, any information relevant to adult development and meaning-making at this stage, and an explanation of the sequence logic for the categories.

Next, the categories were listed in numerical order (based on LC#), followed by example responses for each category. If a category title was exemplar (based on prototypic responses) it began with the numerical code, followed by a dash and a lowercase letter. For category titles that were descriptive in nature, they started with the numerical code, used a capital letter for the first word and described the included responses. Category titles were immediately followed by cross-references, if applicable, and asterisks were applied for the common category titles- using one asterisk for a category that included 10% or more of the responses in that

developmental stage. Previous research also utilized asterisks to denote popular responses, although their asterisks represented different distribution percentages, for example, they used one asterisk to denote categories that included at least 2% of the responses and two asterisks to denote categories that comprised about 5% or more of the sample set. For this project, the sample set was not large enough to incorporate 2% and 5% for the cutoff levels.

The examples of responses that follow the category title were taken verbatim from actual protocol responses and typed in italics. The responses from the updated version of the scoring manual were included and differentiated by bold type font from the items in the project data set (in regular font). All items from the data set were included under their respective categories, because listing more responses, as opposed to fewer responses, will help the rater to make a more informed decision. The exception was omitting repeated, identical responses within a category.

Statistics

Within the spreadsheet file, basic statistics were performed for each developmental level. The responses for each category were counted, and a percentage was determined for each category, based on how many responses fall into this category compared to the total number of responses for that developmental stage. These percentages were also used in determining the sequence of the category titles within a developmental stage (highest frequency categories listed first). An additional distribution graph was constructed which compared the range of responses among the developmental stages for “A good boss—” and a range of scores from a mixed sample set, showing the distribution of developmental stages within a general adult population.

Results

Item 12

A Good Boss—

How one views self in relation to other people can be explored through a variety of sentence stems, and with the stem, “A good boss—”, it is possible to understand how an individual may view a relationship with someone in a supervisory or leadership position. Researchers first compiled data from this stem in early studies, and since then, it seems to have added a valuable dimension of work relationships to the study of development. This scoring manual was recently updated, affirming, “‘A good boss—’ has proven to be one of the most liked stems by professionals because everyone can relate to it and unlike ‘a good father,’ it does not have a personal (and overly Freudian) ring”. It is also described how it is likely that most adults have had experience with bosses or may even desire to become a boss themselves.

The varieties of completions for this stem exhibit a wide distribution among the developmental stages, ranging from Opportunist (Stage $\frac{2}{3}$) to Unitive (Stage 6). The topics of the responses include: social interactions, benefits of interpersonal relationships, conventional and differentiated traits of a good boss, communication, the atmosphere created at work, growth and development (of the individual and/or the company), efficiency and effectiveness, what behaviors a good boss might engage in, as well as many others.

One factor to keep in mind while scoring is that the quality of personal relationships with others seems to develop from dependency to allowing for a degree of autonomy and independence and even further toward mutuality and interdependence as one moves to the later stages. Also, it seems that the meaning of work evolves through the stages from a banal activity, to a means of achieving one’s individual goals, onward to a more encompassing medium for growth, development and expression of one’s beliefs and values, and finally as

part of the global realm of existence. Additionally, researchers caution that we may get more “canned or rehearsed” completions even at the later stages, for people may provide quotes from leadership books and gurus. It is stated, “It is therefore important to be alert to ‘espoused’ theory and do get a sense of how much the respondent actually lives the experience of a boss.”

In order to assist the rater in traversing the scoring manual, categories have been arranged in a certain order within each stage. Categories marked with an asterisk contain 10% or more of the responses within the stage, and these items are listed first among the stage categories. The remainder of the categories are grouped by overall theme (Relationships, Communication, Behavior, and Growth/Development), and then sorted based on which theme is most dominant for that stage. Categories not included in the four major themes for this stem are designated as “Other”, and unless they contain 10% or more of the responses for that stage, “Other” categories are listed last. To help distinguish responses across adjacent stages, cross-references to similar categories in other stages are listed in parentheses next to category titles. Some cross-references also include a brief reason for distinction, if available. Item responses in this scoring manual include items from the updated version of the scoring manual. Those responses can be differentiated with their bold type font from the items in the project data set (in regular font).

Themes:

Relationships (Stage 2 – Stage 5): The topic of relationship between boss and employee is first noticeable from Impulsive with “looks after me”, then Opportunist, when a good boss “stays out of my way”, and evolves to “gets on well with his staff” at Diplomat, “knows each person individually” at Expert, and to “knows his people and can relate to them” (Achiever). At later stages, interpersonal relationships have an essence of being valuable in their own right and being mutually interdependent (Pluralist and Strategist).

Communication (Stage 3 – Stage $\frac{4}{5}$): This theme spans from Diplomat to Pluralist, in which it emerges as a theme of how a boss communicates with her/his staff. In the earlier stages, a good boss listens and talks to the employees, but later listens and understands, takes all factors into account, and becomes more receptive and engaging, allowing for input from employees.

Behavior (Stage 3 – Stage 5): The behavior of a good boss is another theme within this stem, emerging at Diplomat and persisting through Strategist. At earlier stages, behavior seems to have a more individual connection, for example, a good boss is helpful (Diplomat), or delegates (Expert), and can even begin to engage in contrasting behaviors at Achiever. At later stages, behavior seems to have a more encompassing impact on general systems, and psychological causation comes into play (Pluralist and Strategist).

Growth/Development (Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ – Stage 5): Emerging in the middle of the conventional stages at Expert, a good boss facilitates growth by making life easier and being reliable when you need him/her. At Achiever, a good boss will motivate employees and support them in their efforts to learn and experiment, and even continues to learn her/himself. This develops into a good boss fostering growth and tolerating human nature and mistakes (Pluralist) and even further to a concern for autonomy (Strategist).

Stage 2 / Impulsive

No responses in the data set were assigned a rating at this stage. Some of the characteristics of responses at this stage might be a sense of being dependent (“neediness”), simple statements, and hostility if one cannot get what one wants immediately. Previous item manuals based on data for “A good mother—” and “My father—” sentence stems were used to hypothesize on possible reactions to supervision relationships at this Stage.

1. – is good, nice *is sweet, nice is a dead one looks after me (dependent)*

Stage $\frac{2}{3}$ / Opportunist

At this stage, adults may seem egocentric and preoccupied with their own immediate wants and needs. It is possible that they might be opportunistic and aggressive at going after what they want, or be self-protective in the presence of a perceived threat. Others are seen as competitors for goods, attention, and power. Needs rules impulses at this stage, and rules may be seen as a loss of freedom. Language at this level includes simple dichotomies (good/bad, right/wrong). Because the first four categories each contained 10% or more of the total stage responses, the categories for this stage have been listed in order of most to least frequent categories.

1. *– stays out of my way *let's me do it my way gives you your head let's me have it my way should mind his own business lets me get on with it keeps out of my way!*
2. *– likes me *understands understands me*
3. *– doesn't snoop on us *never gives out on me*
4. *Hostile tone *is like me... ha! ha! ha! is just a boss , so what*
5. – let's you have a good time
6. – is easy to get around

Stage 3 / Diplomat

The Diplomat has moved from a “me against them” to an “us against them” mentality, and norms rules impulses. Socially accepted behavior and a respect for the rules (obedience and loyalty) dominate behavior at this stage as the Diplomat seeks status and membership into a group. Appearances are also salient, and negative feelings and expressions are avoided. Responses may have an exaggerated positive affect and may include clichés and stereotypical phrases. The order of responses in this stage is most frequent categories, followed by “Relationships”, “Communication”, and “Other” themed categories, respectively.

1. *– listens, cares, talks to his people ($\frac{3}{4}$,8, $\frac{3}{4}$,10 - takes care of [3] vs. cares about [$\frac{3}{4}$]; $\frac{3}{4}$,16 - listens [3] vs. communicates [$\frac{3}{4}$]) *Listens Cares for his staff Takes good care of his staff Cares for the people in his care Sticks up for his people Is your friend always listens to his people one who listens takes time to listen listens to their subordinates listens to his/her employees listens to employees listens to her co-workers*
2. *– is hard to find ($\frac{3}{4}$,7 - hard to find [3] vs. hard to describe [$\frac{3}{4}$]) *not often is hard to come by wished I had one is rare is next to impossible to find like a good wife, hard to find is hard to find is someone I haven't met yet. is hard to come by I don't know... is rare Unusual.*
3. *– is understanding, kind, helpful, friendly *Is understanding Is patient helps me do things right is kind and understanding is there when you need him (?). is one I get support from is kind. is kind to his her employees*
4. – is mine, – is what I want to be *I have one is what I have is what I am going to be <-> John Tynan - the two go together like Bogart and Bacall*
5. – gets on well with his staff (beginning social interaction) *has a happy staff*
6. – is a teacher, leader *is un bon maitre is the one that teaches you is a good teacher*
7. – is important *is the best is critical*

8. – is great! (2,1) simple idealization *is wonderful is fantastic*

9. Unassigned: (assigned to Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ due to Scoring Rule 5) *is probably a good father too Once told me, "Debby, not everything matters," as if my conscientious attention to detail were a flaw, I disagree - everything matters! Everything!*

Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ / Expert

A focus on likeness at the Diplomat stage has turned into a focus on individual differences, as Experts begin to assert more of their own needs and wants that were suppressed for the sake of the group in the earlier stage. An awareness of general traits in others emerges, and an emphasis on expertise, procedure, high moral standards, and efficiency surfaces. Experts may feel that they have it all figured out and are entitled to impose their views on others, which may come across in responses as "shoulds," qualifications and conditions, and use of psychological vocabulary and explanations. Unlike individuals at later stages, Experts cannot prioritize among options or synthesize/weigh out several possibilities. Craft logic begins to rule norms, experts in the field may be quoted, and clichéd responses may surface. Categories in this stage are sorted beginning with the most frequent categories, and then "Behavior", "Relationships", and "Communication" themed categories, respectively.

1. *– is a blessing *is worth his weight in gold is an asset is a god send god bless him! is a boon is a great asset. a rare find Is a gift Is a rare gift Is a rare and valuable commodity. is a joy forever is a wonderful opportunity; one to be treasured. is a bonus, but you can help any boss to become - well, almost any! is one of the blessings of life is hard to find! (Really, a lot of it can be due to your working relationships.) is sometimes hard to find and worth cultivating to be treasured and nurtured and valued as they are a rare breed.*
2. *Is defined by what he does not do (action-oriented) (4,9) *can keep people in tow without using the whip should not be a bully does not favor some over others should never play favorites should not go home when the staff is still working is behind the scenes stays in the background is hardly visible is one who does not remind you that he is the boss does not lie to his people is invisible Is one who encourages and helps you with your work if under pressure, but always remains the authoritative figure. I have seen bosses who sink to below employee level - it does not work. is not to be a boss puts safety ahead of production is honest with his subordinates and does not pretend to be someone other than what you see.*
3. – is effective *gets the most from his team gets results is efficient gets things done succeeds makes for an efficient running of the company should be on top of things is great for business will most likely have good employees manages well encourages his/her staff to work as effectively as possible Delivers results has the skills to handle people and his area of responsibility Pays you well then expects you to earn it.*
4. is not... (single negative attribute) (4,19) *a tyrant, dictatorial selfish, egotistical money-grabbing verbally abusive inflexible hard-nosed, hard-shelled exploitative stand-offish arrogant conceited insensitive sexist, bigoted, discriminatory impatient ruthless*
5. – is responsible, reliable (4,12) *can be relied on can be trusted takes his job seriously is usually available to staff has an open door is honest and trustworthy walks the talk (cliché) is there for his people in a crisis is never a phony can be trusted is one who has a great deal of common sense and is in touch with reality*
6. – should be fair *should be fair and pleasant should be fair and nice to work for is just Is egalitarian treats his staff with equality never displays favoritism is one you can trust is consistent recognizes and rewards good*

performance without undue disrespect.

7. – is hard to describe (3,2) *has many good qualities wished I knew what makes him good is many different things is hard to train. is not something I relate to, I don't have a "boss" is I am not at all sure about the notion of a boss - but a "good" boss, well, I'll fill you in ... But everyone I have finally worked for the past 20 years, have done some things very well, and some things very badly ... should have many outstanding qualities*
8. – is appreciative, patient (single positive conventional trait) (4,18 - conventional [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. differentiated [4]) *is an appreciative one is one who is patient, and young has a compassionate heart is a caring, intelligent one is a sympathetic one is one who teaches.*
9. – delegates one who delegates responsibility assigns work well should delegate physically demanding work assignments fairly can manage people is someone who delegates appropriately
10. – is one who appreciates his people (3,1 - cares for [3] vs. cares about [$\frac{3}{4}$]; 4,13 makes you feel he/she is interested [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. qualified, genuine interest in what you do [4]) *is one who values what I do one who can make each and every of his staff feel useful is one who supports my efforts supports those in his care listens well to your ideas wants you to grow let's you learn new things cares about his subordinates cares about their employees Is one who cares about his staff. supports his/her subordinates treats his people with respect and dignity.*
11. – is respected, looked up to wins respect from his employees commands respect is one I hold in high regard is my role model is my hero is what I hope to be one day sets a good example is someone from whom you can learn. is a role model, one that you wish to be in the future. earns the respect of his workforce. (is) someone who cares and someone you have respect for.
12. Affects how work is experienced (4,10, 4,15 - keeping staff happy/content [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. motivating, bringing out the best in staff [4]) *makes work a great deal more pleasant makes the job interesting and worthwhile make work more enjoyable can make a job more satisfying makes for a good and happy employee makes a job easier makes work a lot better Makes almost any job bearable. is half the job makes work a real pleasure. I know, because I have one.*
13. – knows his staff members well (4,11 - treating people individually [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. treating people as individuals [4]) *takes an interest in his staff individually is sensitive to everyone's need listens carefully to his employees takes an interest in the needs of his staff knows each person individually puts himself in the place of each of his employees. Is sensitive to employees. understand all faces of the job has a basic idea of what his employee do. Is willing to listen*
14. – makes life easier is a great help in daily work is easy to work with makes all the difference can make all the difference in how one feels about one's job and even oneself
15. – makes a good, happy employee determines the level of an employee's contentment and satisfaction in the job can make or mar the feelings of his staff is fulfillment to a good employee
16. – communicates with his staff (unelaborated) (3,1 – listens [3] vs. communicates [$\frac{3}{4}$]; 4,16 – communication (unelaborated) [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. elaboration on quality of communication [4]) *should communicate with his people should be in constant exchange talks as well as listens to his employees listens as well as talks is a good listener Knows how to communicate. Should be a good listener. lets his expectations be known Gives feedback. is one who takes time to hear what those around him are trying to say*

Stage 4 / Achiever

Whereas the Expert seemed to rely on authority or received knowledge, the Achiever seems skeptical. System effectiveness rules craft logic, and Achievers might obtain effectiveness and truth through knowledge, the mutual expression of ideas, and the scientific method. With an expanded perspective, Achievers add a dimension of linear time to their concerns and seem very goal-oriented and action-driven. Achieving goals, planning for the future, and evaluating oneself in order to improve are some of the preoccupations at this stage. Achievers express complexities in the form of contingencies, contradictions, and inconsistencies. The most frequent categories are listed first, then "Behavior", "Relationships", "Growth/Development", and "Communication" themed categories, are listed, respectively.

1. *Mentioning several positive qualities (list of 2 or more) ($\frac{4}{5}, 8$) *is competent and considerate is savvy and communicates easily gets the job done and treat people fairly is fair, interesting and motivational is one who understands his employees, is patient and tolerant is a person who both leads and treats his staff fairly should be firm, gentle, considerate and interested in his staff is one who is considerate and cares about the well-being of those who work for him cares a lot about other people and does his/her best to help others do the best they can & be as happy as they can is fair, helpful, challenging. is a coach, a leader, a person who brings out the best in others. is fairminded [sic], does not have favorites and keeps professional and personal separate. is fair and does not show favoritism in his or her relations with subordinates. Also is willing to listen and understand his or her workers. provides encouragement + support + challenges. not just a good manager, but is a good leader too is clear in purpose, strong in moral values, cares for others and has inestimable patience one who encourages and enables others to achieve and is available when needed is a source of inspiration and a good listener is one who listens, understand, is interested, provides direction, helps me to develop and stretch myself - and is hard to find is usually a good people manager and is well respected by all. someone who makes you believe you can do it; who doesn't mind you asking for help when you need it; who believes that it's necessary to make mistakes in order to learn; and who gives constructive feedback. is truthful and gives credit where it is appropriate, behaves fairly and is there to support you. one that consults, involves and gives credit where it's due for responsibilities taken. someone who encourages, listens supports and above all else gives feedback - both good and bad. is a good leader who listens to his workers, provides for differing opinions and is open to change. has high integrity, is trustworthy, listens and is supportive. supports, encourages, lets you take risks, and learn from your mistakes. cares about me as a person, recognizes my talent and uses it, and considers me as a valuable asset to the organization. gives room - does not ask for opinion if the decision is already made - is fair listens, trusts, challenges, supports and encourages. is one who supports you and is consistent in his/her actions. is open, honest and communicates directly with me. is willing to learn and brings out the spirit in his/her people challenges, supports, and confronts. is a pleasure to work with, helps you grow, and is open to new ideas and activities. is thoughtful, understanding, responsible and firm - leader is a good communicator, cares about people and motivates with positive reinforcement is understanding, helpful, and a teacher willing to let subordinates have a substantial involvement in how things are done in the department. is sympathetic, intelligent, creative + can be trusted is someone who listens, challenges, coaches and has a sense of humor. gives good instructions and is fair. is consistent [sic], approachable and highly focused. listens, encourages and leaves you alone supports and back his or her employees, and is considerate of their needs, while enabling them to succeed. Clear, with strong vision, has time, listens and shares thinking. Is one who communicates well and looks out for your interests. Listens, is patient, understanding, and progressive. Is caring, knowledgeable, and never forgets that people work with them, not for them. is supportive, provides general guidance, provides you with the tools you need, and recognizes your accomplishments. Lets his employees do the work - Serves as a mentor - Stands up for his*

people support you when you need it and challenges you to always improve communicates and sets goals and mentors if at all possible is approachable, respectful, listens and makes decisions, accountable. is a leader, mentor, educator who will help the "group" or "team" succeed to a common goal communicates expectations + is consistent is a mentor & facilitator listens, is clear in his intentions, and isn't afraid to lead is one who listens, understand and develops. is someone who will listen, guide and support me. is a good listener, coach and mentor. listens to employees, peers, customers; recognizes and rewards positive contributions; tracks and develops subordinates,; acts as a mentor and a leader one who listens, builds rapport easily, gives feedback with sensitivity and supports your learning and development. Challenges, believes in, encourages, guides, has fun with and learn from her employees. is one with vision and objective short term strategies and goals. treats people fairly, has integrity, is competent, lives by values, manages and leads, is emotionally mature, trustworthy. is someone who listens, who motivates others to be their best, and who can inspire other to a common cause. is open, outward looking, challenging and competent. Is a leader and a teacher. one who listens and guides. He can always be trusted Is a good leader and a manager. is a good leader and a role model is a mentor and a coach Is one that can be fair, and makes their job easier. is one who inspires, respects others. Who challenges and who leads the way through example encourages and motivates others, treats everyone with respect and then get out of their way so they can get the job done. is someone who is collaborative, listens, is a leader, is consistent and has a healthy sense of humor is a person who exhibits leadership, builds trust and who helps their people to grow and do a good job ever better.

2. *— supports people to develop, learn, improve, experiment ($\frac{4}{5}, 1$) allows workers time to develop provides opportunities for learning is coaching people to become their best does his best to keep staff happy and engaged encourages learning and being self-directive give people credit for improvements rewards initiative and learning allows learning through mistakes sees failure as part of development sees you trying and failing rather than not trying at all allows others to show they can behave responsibly supports you in your endeavors to grow + improve. gives employees space in which to grow and shows belief in their ability to do so gives me flexible boundaries in which I can learn, be creative, contribute, and grow professionally. gets either behind or alongside me. can be the difference in a very successful or only mediocre career facilitates the development of her subordinates supports their employees in being leaders. allows their employees to develop with their strong leadership. helps me fulfill "our" dreams is one who delegates authority and responsibility to subordinates, under controlled circumstances, and gives them the opportunity to fail. is helps those around them achieve far more than they ever dreamt possible. can make a significant difference in one's development. gives employees the opportunity to succeed is crucial to my success in terms of learning and in having sponsorship and support. Carries water for his/her troops. Someone who is a good developer of people Helps a person grow and reach their potential. creates an environment for being creative and inovative (sic) is one who challenges his employees to think someone who provides encouragement and support but basically lets you get on with it trusts you and your decisions and is there to guide and support you if necessary. is a supportive listener who enables the individual to work to the best of their ability while encouraging development + growth. "coaches" and stand behind you. They work to develop you to your potential. Should have vision, should encourage and support his/her employees to take risks, to grow. lets me complete my work and helps when asked. allows you a lot of leeway to accomplish your tasks. is my luck. He could help me realize my personal goal. Without such a good boss, however, I would also do my best to perform better at work. But if I am not able to make it, I quit. Facilitates the growth and development of the people she is responsible for, knowing that one person learning helps another learn but it all depends. is supportive and challenging while giving as much freedom to get on with the job as possible. Gives me space to achieve my potential and support when I need it provides overall direction and allows the individual exercise maximum judgment & innovations

3. Balancing job requirements and employee needs (simply stated) makes life enjoyable, he should be kind and understanding and also have the ability to get more work done is as conscious of his staff's needs as those of the organization understand his/her employees and still aims to make a profit in his business can achieve good results while not forgetting the priority that should be given to the needs of people who work for him has to be human and has to take care of other issues in his employees, not only production output. should be loving, understanding, but firm, to help good work done. Balances concerns for cost of production and quality of product, with employee well-being. is a task master, but tolerant of other issues that may be occurring in and outside of work. A high level of devolved responsibility is extended. values the experience for himself as well as for his employees. is not only knowledgeable of subject matter but is adept at working with individuals and personal issues. is well organized fair and has the best interests of the company in mind. who can reconcile individual goals with group goals recognizes the talents and human resources, and commits support to them in order to meet the needs and goals of the group. is someone who drives charge forward but carries staff along with her/him. A good motivator and leader. considers both the group's best interest as well as the individual's best interest is concerned with what is good for me as an individual as well as what is good for the group, company balances and nurtures both organizational and employee growth + development needs. a good optimizer of business needs and people needs - simultaneously knows what to do & how to do it at a high level + gives leadership & support to staff. is one who is able to achieve his/her objectives, in a manner which leaves the subordinates feeling they were responsible for the results. contributes to organizational goals and individual goals of his subordinates, he may also encourage the development of socially beneficial goals of both. has the best interests of his/her employees in mind . I think this means that the personal/professional growth of employees is good both for the people involved and the product/organization one who is clear about the organizations [requirements] as he/she sees them + supports my idiosyncratic contribution. One who makes demands I can meet in my way Is supportive, values and recognises the strengths of individuals within an organisation and has a vision for the organizations and the individual. encourages their employees to utilize their full potential to maximize productivity. A boss also needs to be a role model of integrity, honesty, fairness and openness. keeps the larger picture in mind is able to integrate and balance the demands of the product/client with the nurturing and valuing of staff. acts as a filter between you and upper management. - gives you as much responsibility as you can handle. has a good overall knowledge of the goals of the group and a sufficient understanding of each of the individual pieces to efficiently assign, prioritize, and focus the work to be done. Is somebody with the qualities and the charisma to guide and lead a group of people successfully to the point of reaching the group goals.
4. Mentioning of at least 2 contrasting behaviors can be friendly with his staff, yet obtain the best results is a person who is understanding but is firm in getting the work done steers things rather than directs them influences by example rather than by pushing others one who delegates constructively and does not rule by fear nurtures commitment to learning and performance rather than demand obedience and obeisance. should be goal-oriented instead of means-oriented. He or she should give subordinates more autonomy to their jobs. is someone who listens well and encourages, but knows when to challenge. is a facilitator, not a dictator. is greatly loved and a little feared. is reasonable, fair and understanding, yet firm and decisive Is one that gives you both space and support when you need it. Provides a structured framework but allows for flexibility. Works with people not over them. Is strict but not too strict, understanding of employees needs and treats all employees equally. listens to the NO's as well as the YES's knows when to demand, suggest, and listen, sets practical priorities. Knows team's goals, direction, status knows how to listen. knows how to lead, not just supervise people below him (or her). provides meaningful guidance + then stays out of the way. teaches you and learns from you is vision oriented, demanding - but fair. a coach and mentor who commands respect not through status but by being firm and fair but above allow through inspiration

simultaneously offers subordinates independence and guidance is challenging of your behavior and supportive of your hopes is a mentor of individual - guiding but not "doing." is a coach and facilitator and does not beat people up for results or take credit for my work. is not a boss but a coach who empowers his people to do their personal and organizational best by teaching them correct principles.

5. – *Listens, then acts. is one who listens and lets the individual grow. Listens and acts in the interests of his employees. will listen and then make decisions is one who listens and hears. Listens and encourages. actively listens, and understands will listen as well as give direction Listens and teaches. listens and capitalizes on the strength of subordinates. listens, assesses, then leads. openly seeks input, then makes a decision and communicates and reinforces it Listens and asks questions in order to provide appropriate direction and support. is willing to listen to his/her employees' opinions + provides a means of deflecting unnecessary work.*
6. – *is decisive, organized, has business skills has to be able to make decisions can choose wisely can prioritize obligations and responsibilities is not a slave to pressure meets deadlines and plans well knows how to plan projects and execute his role makes timely decisions takes all factors into account knows how to use a balanced score card Understands how to fit the skills of an employee to the job. is consistent in his application of policies to all his subordinates*
7. – *has experience is well educated and informed should have some formal qualifications in management is trained and informed in his field knows what his position is like from experience is not a novice with lots of textbook ideas and no experience has been seasoned through hard times is knowledgeable in his/her field and has good leadership qualities. understands and has done the job you are doing*
8. – *tries his best, tries to improve himself ($\frac{4}{5}$, 7 – tries to improve [4] vs. has no illusion about himself [$\frac{4}{5}$]) tries his best to execute his role well and effectively has a difficult job with many demands to fulfill and tries to fill them keeps up with the trends in his industry and works on himself too is trying to learn his craft and manage himself as well as others Gains respect from the workforce/employee knowing that there is one who is both good at his job and one who can be trusted and reliable. does himself out of a job is constantly open to new and improved ways of working but has consistent values and can inspire others. is capable of holding his frustration, tension + sometimes his rages - is clear about his expectations + is prepared to be a committed role model*
9. – *does not ... (behaviors qualified) ($\frac{3}{4}$, 2) assume that things will always go smoothly systematically underestimate the time it takes to get things done well push his agenda beyond reason make snap judgments of people and situation generalize to the whole team when specific individuals are at fault claim sole credit for things he has not accomplished alone is one who does not need to exercise his power. would not expect others to do what he or she would not do.*
10. – *affects the atmosphere at work ($\frac{3}{4}$, 12 - keeping staff happy/content [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. motivating, bringing out the best in staff [4]) is vital for a happy and efficient team of worker is essential for a good working atmosphere makes for a good office climate is a great mood enhancer should provide an atmosphere of ease and a learning experience. creates a working environment that not only brings out the best in his/her employees but also cultivates an atmosphere that allows them to personal grow.*
11. *Has differentiated relationship to individuals ($\frac{3}{4}$, 13, $\frac{4}{5}$, 4 - treating people individually [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. treating people as individuals [4] vs. understanding of individual differences/perspectives [$\frac{4}{5}$]) works with each one of his staff and supports them when needed can take interest in his/her staff, and always stands behind*

them is one who tries to understand his staff as individuals should know how to adjust to the level of his employees understands how each contributor is different and adjusts should treat his employees as people, not just machines communicates with people and informs them each of their progress is one who delegates and shows appreciation for work well done gives constructive feedback and monitors progress recognizes his staff at every level and communicates with them on a person to person level is someone who shows respect for others and is respected by them as a boss and as a person. treats his/her employees as he/she would wish to be treated if the roles were reversed. recognizes the value of all employees and tries to ensure they are fully utilized Provides direction when asked but otherwise has a "hands-off" policy of supervision due to his trust in his workers' abilities and professionalism. is someone who trusts you and has faith in your decisions, but helps you learn when things go wrong. encourages his employees to be successful and rewards them when they perform well. is an enabler. Allows work to be done efficiently between different people knows his/her people and their capabilities is a person who helps each person in the team to do their job well and realize their personal ambitions and potential. likely to see in me what I don't knows the skills of their employees and also allows those skills to be utilized and expanded. One who assesses the abilities and personalities of his subordinates and, within his own leadership style, manages and directs the individuals accordingly (for "his," read "his/her"!) understand how an individual fits into the goals of the organization. fully uses + develops the potential of his people, guides them + insures they know what is expected of them + treat them fairly

12. – is accessible ($\frac{3}{4}, 5$) is a rare man and should be someone you could confide in and not be afraid of has an open door policy and welcomes input is someone who have no fear of, someone you can discuss work issues with openly is always open to discuss things with his staff and answer their concerns is open to listen to his people, but also knows how to set boundaries is one of the finest guides you can have. If he is willing to listen to you and give ideas and advice, that is the best kind to have around. [long run-on sentence] is the person with whom you talk through your weaknesses as well as your strengths. is generous with himself has to be open to ideas and criticisms (is) - always available; never in the way - someone who gives you space to reason for yourself. Lets you know where he stands and is available to discuss issues with you. is easy to approach with problems and offers solutions
13. – is interested in what you do (qualified) ($\frac{3}{4}, 10, \frac{4}{5}, 2$ - makes you feel he/she is interested [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. qualified, genuine interest in what you do [4] vs. mutuality/collaboration [$\frac{4}{5}$]) is one who makes you feel he is interested in everything you do and say (work wise) is a person who knows how to treat his staff, who takes an interest in what his staff feels about certain things. He should be ready to help them in a crisis is important to the happy running of the Department if staff is to see he is fair to everyone is appreciative when you show responsibility and a good attitude is one who has a general interest in the development of his/her employees. knows his people and can relate to them finds pleasure and fulfillment in the accomplishments of others Must have a high sense of integrity. He must have as a first objective to help his staff making their works and achieve their objectives. is interested in people and can support, challenge and direct staff with openness and integrity. is a coach who helps the subordinate achieve their best, from realizing what that is to how to accomplish it
14. – is also a colleague. shares the burden Is a working member of a team. treats employees as equals. works as a team member not afraid to take a leadership role when necessary. works with his or her subordinates, giving them respect and support and feeling no need to dominate them.
15. – motivates ($\frac{3}{4}, 12$ - keeping staff happy/content [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. motivating, bringing out the best in staff [4]) enables you is inspirational, inspires is charismatic empowers his staff finds ways to make your feel uplifted

encourages risk taking and responsibility leads while channeling energies believes in your potential and shows it can be one of the things that motivates a worker the most. always encourages one who enables is enabling is an enabler of my excellence leads by example and always encourages his/her people to excel. is a team player whose enthusiasm is contagious. is one who motivates people to excel knows how to allow his/her employees to feel personal satisfaction from their work.

16. – communicates with his staff (emphasis on quality) ($\frac{3}{4}, 16$ - communication (unelaborated) [$\frac{3}{4}$] vs. elaboration on quality of communication [4]) *should be able to talk to his employees and not at them should above all be a good communicator of his vision is an effective communicator, establishes clear expectations, and can show some personal understanding Gives clear expectations and provides routine feedback on how I'm meeting his expectations knows what you are doing without getting in the way. "how to make recommendations without a club. Clearly states expectations and defines roles. can give you good feedback as well as constructive criticism is someone who communicates well and gives the right amount of supervision tells me exactly what my responsibilities are, gives me the wherewithal, delegates, encourages, supports, lead the way ahead. will periodically review your work and provide constructive criticism & recognizes the strengths. is able to be understanding, tactful, and to react to the problem at hand. They should delegate both responsibility/ authority. But most of all be a good communicator. provides a clear description of product wanted, timeframe product is desired, is fundamentally aware of approximate effort required to produce product and is willing to set priorities if the becomes a premium*
17. – is hard to be (beginning recognition of difficulty of role) ($\frac{4}{5}, 6$) *can be trying and exhausting as there is no right way to be is someone who knows himself does not have illusions about his abilities tries hard to fulfill a difficult role never stops learning and adapting requires self-knowledge and openness to feedback to improve is something I strive hard to be but find hard to accomplish is only human does not come with a certificate has a big juggling act is a difficult thing to become is a wise person Is one you seldom notice but one you know is real Has to be many things if he/she is to stay good. Importantly they must ?, create learning ? and remain courageous when the right thing to do is hard or out of the ordinary.*
18. One or more positive differentiated trait ($\frac{3}{4}, 8$) *is conscientious is compassionate and fair enthusiastic and knowledgeable goal-oriented sees the big picture is thoughtful and helpful is consistent, fair and goal focused is flexible, fair, sympathetic & helpful. approachable and even-handed Is honest, trustworthy, organized, educated and fun. Is visionary, capable and honest. Is fair, approachable, pleasant, and a team player.*
19. – is not ... (attributes qualified) ($\frac{3}{4}, 4$) *a tyrant when things don't go his way peremptory even under stress self-serving while pretending to not to be just goal—oriented without regard for people's feelings gratuitously abusive bogged down by minutiae is not necessarily a good friend. is not intimidated or afraid of those smarter than he/she.*
20. – savvy in business matters and people *is not only a good manager, but also has good people skills. has a good mix of people skills + technical knowledge deals capably with people and is technically proficient*
21. Awareness of past understanding *is not as rare as I used to think. Usually he or she is thoughtful and most of all, courteous now that I am one myself, the role seems much more challenging than anticipated and my ideas of the role have changed since I became one*

Stage $\frac{4}{5}$ / Pluralist

At this stage, Pluralists begin taking multiple perspectives into account (“everything is relative”), and this relativism rules the single system logic that may have emerged from the scientific method in the last stage. A more holistic, body/mind connection, being, feeling, here and now essence has been transformed from the causality, goals, action, and future-oriented drive from the Achiever stage. Interpersonal relationships are seen as mutually rewarding, and there is an awareness and tolerance for individual differences. There is discussion of how interpretation plays into meaning-making, as interpretation depends on the position of the observer. Context has become more important than content, and the Pluralist sees her/himself as self-in-relation, interacting with a larger system. Categories are organized in this stage with the most frequent categories first, followed by “Relationships” and “Growth/Development” themed categories, respectively.

1. *— fosters an environment conducive to help can grow (4,2) *leads others by creating the conditions where each individual person will express his own talents to the best of his ability creates the space for people to give their best and develop on their own accord. leads others by creating the conditions where each individual person will express his own talents to the best of his ability*
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Stage 5 / Strategist

An expanded perspective allows individuals at the Strategist stage to understand their experiences within the context of their entire lifetime and their constructed worldview. While individuals at the previous stage can perceive this complexity, they are unable to take charge of it. In contrast, Strategists recognize complex, long-term trends and systemic patterns, enabling them to navigate these intricacies and assume leadership. Interpersonal relationships are viewed as interdependent, and core principles such as acceptance, justice, tolerance, and dignity for all take precedence over relativism. Strategists also acknowledge the need for autonomy in others and are deeply concerned with self-fulfillment and psychological causation. The responses for this stage are categorized and presented in order of their frequency.

1. Complex Psychological Causation and Mutual Influence

A good boss affects the morale of his staff and if they are happy this gratifies the boss and so the whole operation benefits. Such a person is someone who causes the right things to happen. This is one with whom I can have an intimate, gamefree relationship and above all I can trust, whilst for others maybe needs to be approachable and fair. A good boss is someone who can remain open, develop good relationships based on trust and respect and who will bring out the best in her/his subordinates, peers and superiors. This individual isn't really a “boss” at all, but rather a coach, a mentor, a friend, a parent, a sage - and all in a nice way.

A good boss listens to, solicits input from, and communicates information to his/her employees as well as keeping empathy, human, and a feeling of worthiness and teamwork in the workplace. A good “boss” is what I once was and what I hope to be again. Or, a good boss is able to nurture and direct his people in fair and effective ways, and is on to learning from his employees. This is one who with an ethic of service to his team questioningly seeks ways to add value to their work. A good boss has integrity, principles and love; and helps direct reports achieve their fullest on behalf of the enterprise.

This person is provocative and challenging, helps you to hold to what you believe in and see the wider issues whilst giving you room to be the best you can. A good boss has integrity, is straight with you, and both

challenges you to do your best and collaborates with you to get the best out of you. This individual knows and treats employees and coworkers with a sense of balance between job's needs, the boss's needs, the employees' needs and all their place in the firmament. A good boss believes in what she does, believes it serves a purpose, and empowers the folks who work for her.

A good boss is not too attached to his/her own agenda, but can deal with personal relationships, strategic goals, firm decision-making and analysis in a holistic and flexible way. This person leads by example and is the first to wade in. She is attentive in order to recognize and call on other's individual strengths and help them find ways to compensate for weaknesses, take personal responsibility. A good boss takes the time to listen, teach by example, is not afraid to challenge the status quo, and acts with a vision of quality first.

A good boss is a wonderful thing to have. It can be inspiring and enriching. It also helps having work be an extension of the self rather than just a necessary evil. This individual can recognize the daily routine and also more broad changes in and out of the office and work to motivate people within those changes; should be adaptable and open to change but not so adaptable that the office's mission is completely obscured. A good boss is one who can nurture and unfold his staff for the benefit of themselves and the organization that employs them.

This person stands her ground, gives positive affirming feedback whenever possible, constantly challenges and supports employees to develop their capabilities and skills, and always has her eye on the long-term vision of the organization. A good boss is able to balance company and staff priorities, whilst finding a way through the chaos to create a climate in which work is rewarding and successful. This is very rare! A good boss does not pretend to be the boss, yet still relates to his or her team as fellow human beings.

A good boss has a clear sense of self and a vision of a future state- both which are compatible with colleagues, co-workers and with the organization - and which are conveyed to others through example, not words. It is hard to generalize. I think one who ?? his staff and creates enthusiasm for common purpose (both individual and business growth) and drive to put together. A good boss works for the good of his company by way of its component parts - the people that make up that company, and within the environment in which the company is set.

2. Concern for Autonomy in Others Without Relinquishing the Role as Leader

A good boss keeps lines of communication open, and provides directions for activities without impinging on the employees' own abilities and desire to direct his own activities. This person has a clear vision and purpose for the company but offers it without enforcing it upon his people. A good boss knows what needs to be done, gets it done, and still is able to see where changes are needed and makes improvements-all with everyone's endorsement and contributions.

This individual is willing and has the skills to work others on a vision of how things could and should ideally be, to work with and support others in achieving these goals. A good boss respects his employees, has earned their trust, and demonstrates his confidence in them frequently allowing maximum opportunity for growth. This is someone who is wise enough to know when to move in and help and when to let go and leave others to learn for themselves.

A good boss knows how to listen to her/his employees and how to visualize progress and communicate it to her/his employees and integrate his visions with their needs. This person should be "tough" and "sensitive" at the same time - he should push his subordinates, be tough and aggressive to achieve the necessary goals within limits, yet at the same time he has to maintain an underlying sensitivity to be aware of the needs, desires and

incentives of the employees. A good boss keeps lines of communication open, and provides direction for activities without impinging on the employees own abilities and desire to direct their own activities.

This individual empowers his/her subordinates to stretch themselves to do their best work and to have input and some control in their work and organization, while not relinquishing his/her own leadership position. A good boss is someone who is able to accept the creativity and independence of other people and to motivate and support them to develop themselves to their highest potential. This person provides guidance when necessary but permits his/her employees the opportunity to make own decisions and to maintain responsibility in their assigned work.

A good boss is a divine one - rare, but when you find one you only need a little at a time to get the full benefit of the riches within. This individual provides just enough structure and specificity to give a blueprint for success, provides enough latitude so when people accomplish things they know they did it themselves, and provides enough blessings and support so people can put their whole selves into their work without fear of reprisal. A good boss is one that gives me operational headroom and mutual respect, recognizes my commitment and runs interference in my career pursuits. He/she also acts as a coach, mentor, medic, wailing wall and leader.

Stage $5/6$ / Magician

While the Strategist still endeavors to appear reasonable and mature, their sense of self remains anchored around a “separate self.” The Magician stage marks the beginning of recognizing this “separate self” as the central processing unit, noticing its clever attempts at self-preservation by projecting maturity to others. At this stage, the distinction between the “knower” and the “known” begins to blur, accompanied by increased access to feelings, dreams, bodily states, and intuitions. The constructed nature of reality and the complex matrices of existence become evident, which can also lead to anxiety and frustration. Magicians appreciate the need of others to make sense of life within their own capacities, possessing insight into the complex dynamics of people’s lives through a long-term, whole-integrated focus. There remains a hope for the Magician to unlearn the automatic responses of language habits and the ingrained habits of mind and heart. The categories in this stage are organized according to established frameworks for this developmental level.

1. Complex Matrix of Content

This category involves a panoramic view rather than linear lists. It includes an array of contrasting possibilities, reasons, and responses provided in an attempt to approximate and express the complexity of one’s insights, thoughts, feelings, and observations, which can sometimes appear abstract, distanced, or hyper-rational.

A good boss is one who is learning day by day and moment by moment, who encourages this kind of learning in others, who can also adapt to unique people and situations, and who fosters the inner and outer development and those she or he leads. This person can measure vision, action and strategy against one another and include those beneath him in the formulation of all, sometimes as a follower. They can see the patterns unfolding over time, see now as a sacred gate to possible futures while honoring seeing the system as an aspect of the largest system. Overcome the stagnation in success.

A good boss is one who exercises leadership by mobilizing others to solve difficult issues, being mindful of how best to position him/herself with the right balance of challenge and support to further the contribution and development of the people working for and with him/her. This individual may utilize technology and total integrity, usually hires people more skilled than him/herself, surfs the economic/cultural waves, and trusts

his/her intuition when wise to do so. A good boss genuinely respects and values the people who he/she “bosses” and supports their development, creativity and initiative in ways that are appropriate to each individual, within the context of the organization and larger purposes of existence.

This person has leadership qualities of vision and direction-setting coupled with skills in planning, doing and communicating; as well as a sense of responsibility for and the talent to support the development of diverse individuals and teams. A good boss responds to the needs of his people and balances this with the business needs he/she has taken on; she/he engenders an atmosphere of trust and comradeship, and an understanding of what has to be achieved; he/she gets the right balance between hierarchy, collaboration and autonomy; she/he has an eye out for the future and the meaning of the work in a wider context, and assists his/her team/s to connect to these things also.

A good boss understands that the responsibilities of a work provider range from time structuring to a carer and nurturer of the souls; he is these and he holds the boundaries; he listens, and helps remove blockages to growth. This individual cares about his/her employees by listening to their ideas, concerns and assists in their development to grow within a role, then within the organization, and finally their body, mind and soul. A good boss is able to unleash the potential and abilities of staff by creating a situation in which they choose willingly to live of their best, having a clear understanding of goals, roles and their unique combination, within a supportive, challenging and ultimately liberating environment.

2. Exploration and Evaluation of Intrapsychic and Interpersonal Dynamics (Habits of Heart)

This category encompasses a wide range of personal thoughts, feelings, concerns, and deep insights into one's own and others' psychological functioning and interdependence. It reflects an awareness of the ambiguities, simultaneous benefits and costs, and double binds inherent in human relationships, as well as an understanding of the stages and processes of identity formation.

A good boss sees the brilliance, capability and potential in her employees, while confronting them with careful and growthful truths about their actual performance, all the while holding to the la. A good boss is made, not born, they say... so if we are to be of service, are we ourselves not the first “organization” that we must master? A good boss is a gift to be enjoyed, savored and an opportunity to learn, although such a gift may also be a limitation to anyone who aspires to run their own business, be their own boss, or author their own life.

This person embodies many characteristics that positively influence his ability to manage his subordinates, or manage with his subordinates, but an exceptional boss “challenges” his subordinates to develop their talents and weaknesses, and openly appreciates their value to the organization individually and as a team. A good boss recognizes and capitalizes on opportunities to coach and transform others, knows when to clown, when to threaten punitive action, when to be open, expresses both doubt and certainty and invites feedback and input on her own behavior goals.

A good boss listens; puts subordinates at ease, laughs and gives perspective (the “bigger picture”) to help subordinates shape the details of his work. He worries most about the quality, motivation and development of his staff rather than the details of what they are doing. This is someone who is generous about revealing aspects of themselves (including insecurities, emotions, formative life events) as part of really getting to know their teams very well. Combine this with a high achiever with an ability to reward and create an environment of enjoyment and possibilities and you have the sort of role model that I would seek to emulate and learn from. They...

A good boss is one who seeks his/her employees as capable individuals, who treats them with respect, who appreciates good work and rewards it, who understands that cooperation and prosperity are intertwined. This individual symbolizes energy and movement in positive directions, and inspires others to learn and grow by providing them with freedom, challenge and love.

3. Exploration and Evaluation of Habits of Mind

This category shows evidence of observing one's own thinking processes and thought habits, such as automatic judging, circular reasoning, infinite regress, and defensive mind games. It includes an awareness of existential and logical paradoxes, commentary on various levels of one's own awareness or the felt lack thereof, and an intellectual understanding of the nature of polar opposites as necessitating each other.

A good boss is probably not the phrase I would use: 'A boss is B' sounds simplistic and foolish. A good leader is someone who has vision and is utterly present; who engenders respect yet is also vulnerable; who leads apparently effortlessly by their own commitment and open struggle.

4. Reference to Constructed Nature of Reality

This category involves specific references to and questioning of underlying assumptions, multiple perceptions, frames of reference, paradigms, and the process of meaning-making. It is explicit about the multiple, multi-layered, and changing meanings of words and definitions, demonstrating an awareness of the constructed nature of self and reality.

A good boss is a judgment from a point of view (i.e. what is good?); at this moment I feel myself a "good boss" if I can be/act in the spirit of Lao Tsu, wherein a 'good' leader has such finely honed sensitivity, and is so invisible that he seems to do nothing special, yet accomplishes goals in a way that "People say 'we did it!'" A good boss is a term that takes on new "bells and whistles" during this period of heightened technological and economic dominance; however, the primary concern for addressing the complex interplay of purposefulness and relatedness have remained similar since the time of the Greeks, Romans, Indians and Chinese.

A good boss is in the eye of the beholder, where the eye may be more than one "eye" (the subordinate, the peer, the boss him/herself, the superior, etc.) It remains relative until it is fixed in time and space by one or more than one. I don't like to judge or take too strong a position: It always depends where I am in my own evolution. Some say you need a "bad" boss to appreciate a "good" one - . If I were to say "ideally" (with my present state of consciousness) - a "good" boss would be like a good coach, friend, etc.: somebody who takes you where you are [continued on back of page] and puts you consciously or unconsciously on a learning curve, so that you become aware, accept it for yourself, have strategies of action and, finally, take action in the areas of development, tasks, achievement, leadership, etc. (here again, I said as short as I could - there are many things to say).

A good boss is an odd phrase; it may contain a fundamental epistemological flaw. "A good boss" - is most often defined by someone who "doesn't have one" rarely found from that frame of reference, and probably somewhat invisible if she or he (the boss) is really good. "A good boss" is a relative judgment - it varies in time, situation and observer. Lao Tsu says that empties hearts and fills bellies, but he wants running a cardiac surgery unit. A good boss is always a subjective assessment. A good boss is rare as hen's teeth. (Whatever we mean by good?) A good boss is a contradiction in terms.

Stage 6 / Unitive

Unitive individuals experience a profound sense of belongingness to the creative ground. Unlike the preceding stage, consciousness is no longer felt as a burden. At the Unitive stage, individuals let go of the unattainable and recognize that complete understanding is an ultimate illusion. Responses at this stage tend to convey a greater sense of peace and acceptance compared to the often tormented responses of Magicians. Completions to the sentence stem can be remarkably simple or take the form of an all-encompassing kaleidoscope response that eloquently bridges numerous paradoxes and levels, sometimes manifesting as a creative metaphor. Unitive individuals are capable of cherishing human connections with those who are vastly different from them, feeling a sense of oneness. Elements of the fundamental dilemma of the human condition frequently surface in Unitive responses. The categories in this stage are organized according to established frameworks for the Unitive level.

1. Wide Range of Thought on Human Relationships

This category reflects a perspective where the self is not the center. It includes unique positive affect and gratitude for people exactly as they are, alongside an appreciation of their shadow sides and struggles as mirrors reflecting all of humanity.

2. Expression of High Tolerance and Acceptance

This category demonstrates an acceptance of the self and the world “as is.” It shows an openness to life, change, process, rhythm, flux, and self-in-transformation. There is a letting go of the need to judge, accompanied by signs of non-attachment and the embracing of polar opposites.

3. Non-Trivial Expression of Universal Connectedness

This category involves expressions of the self as part of a larger world, humankind, history, or the manifestation of the creative process.

A good boss is each and all of her employees and employers. A good boss is someone who is honest with everyone in an ongoing routine way regarding praise as well as criticism, who sees and conveys the big picture of what's going on and how the parts fit together, who conveys a sense of meaning and purpose to the work, and, at the same time, sees people in the context of their whole lives rather than just their work roles. (Tall order!)

4. Fundamental Thoughts and Feelings About the Human Condition

This category encompasses thoughts on the wonder of being, creation and destruction, joy and suffering, life and death, sexuality, nature, global concerns, conscience, and consciousness.

A good boss is maybe whoever arises in the moment to create the conditions for the next step forward, who sees what needs to happen most deeply and offers the courage to manifest it. A good boss does not fear to lay bare his or her own soul while reaching for an awareness of others. A good boss can be a ‘boss’ if he needs to, or a coach, leader, shaman, or disappear. A good boss is a boss God, that is, uses authority without presence of self but rather Self and the resulting Wisdom and Compassion and Flow enriches the field and otherwise becomes invisible as each person tends to translate experience in a healthier manner.

5. Unitive Ability

This category highlights the ability to shift focus effortlessly between near and far (geographically, historically, developmentally), the mundane and the sublime, the somber and the ridiculous, and now and eternity. This shifting occurs between different states of consciousness without attachment to any single view or position. It often features a playful, light touch or illuminating metaphors, akin to “seeing a world in a grain of sand.”

A good boss is someone who knows how to balance authority and freedom, who is able to embody and/or give voice to the deeper mission of the organization, while seeing it in the context of society, and can do this in service of a deeper Reality. A good boss is a clown, is a leader, a decider, a guide, an evoker, a motivator, a foil, a mistake-maker and visionary for her employees and company, sees what might be or experiments to find what might be. A good boss makes rules, a good manager sets standards, a good executive creates systems, but a good leader simply “is.”

Discussion

When the initial scoring manual for this sentence stem was constructed, there were no existing categories available to assist in sorting the data. It appears that other sentence stems from similar assessment tools, along with the underlying theory of ego development, were utilized to predict potential categories. The manual also incorporated descriptions from research literature on supervision and management to suggest what characteristics might define a good boss. The task of creating a scoring manual from scratch for a new assessment tool designed to measure a novel theoretical concept is a formidable undertaking. The current project involved creating a scoring manual based on pre-existing attempts and templates, which offered a less complicated task, though it was not without its challenges. This discussion explores the process of creating the scoring manual, the inherent biases in the scoring process, the personal growth and development experienced during the project, and the limitations and future directions of this research.

Process of Creating the Scoring Manual

A fundamental step before engaging in this task was to become thoroughly familiar with the concept of ego development. Several sources were referenced, including original manuals, manual revisions, and literature detailing later stage distinctions. This preparation provided an opportunity to calibrate responses to specific stages and then utilize established scoring rules to further assign responses to categories within each stage. Examples of sample responses are provided to illustrate the scoring methods and observed trends, adhering to the scientific practice of clearly marking the chosen stage and category and providing a rationale for the choice.

The procedure for rating single stem responses begins with foundational ground rules: Every response must be rated as a whole, focusing on the level of meaning—what the person intended to say. Deep-level inferences about intent are inappropriate; responses should be taken at face value. Snap judgments are to be avoided, but excessive rumination does not improve rating accuracy.

With these ground rules established, the first step in sorting responses was to apply the rule of matching the completion with one of the listed category titles. For instance, if a category title was “-is respected, looked up to,” a response such as “earns the respect of his workforce” would be a match. Cross-references were checked when necessary. Attempts were made to satisfy this matching rule for every response in the data set. If a match was unavailable or the response was compound, subsequent scoring rules were employed.

When the combination of two or more elements in a compound response generated a more complex level of conception, the response was rated one step higher than its highest element. For example, a response combining elements of listening, understanding, providing direction, and helping with development might generate a more complex conception than any single element alone, warranting a higher stage rating.

If a compound response did not generate a more complex concept, it was rated in the less frequent category or the higher category. For instance, a response combining the delegation of authority with supporting people to develop might not generate a higher level of conceptual complexity than the individual elements, so it would be rated in the higher of the applicable categories.

Many responses did not provide an exact match to a category title and could not be rated using the rules for compound responses. In these cases, the general theory of ego development was used to arrive at a rating. This was particularly common at the later stages, where responses are often unique and complex, making it difficult to find matches to exemplar category titles. Guidance from research on postconventional development and scoring was heavily relied upon for applying theory to responses in the later stages.

The postconventional “systems” stages included responses indicating a shift to a more systems-centered perspective, compared to the individual perspectives of earlier stages. Responses might reflect a new ability to take multiple perspectives and tolerate human nature and mistakes. For example, a response stating that interpretations of a “good boss” depend on the individuals and situations concerned embodies the perspective that interpretation depends on the observer’s position. This response would be rated based on general theory rather than an exact category match.

For the postconventional “unitary” stages, responses reflected a recognition of the constructed nature of reality and a realization of a nondual universe. Research distinguishing separate stages at this level was referenced to categorize responses. A response demonstrating a perspective at multiple levels of depth—from the boss to the employees, to the individual, within the context of the organization and the larger purposes of existence—would be categorized under a complex matrix of content, distinguishing it from linear lists found at earlier stages.

If ego development theoretical concepts could not assist in rating a response, a default rating was considered as a last resort for responses that were omitted or too fragmentary to be meaningful. Responses that were difficult to place, such as those that seemed to avoid answering the stem or were too fragmentary, were assigned this default rating.

During the sorting process, new patterns and categories emerged within stage responses. Titles for these new categories were chosen to best represent the included items. It is crucial to perform microvalidation on these new categories to determine their robustness with an increased sample set. No categories were established without the presence of a cluster of items; the creation of the scoring manual was driven entirely by the response data.

Overall Trends

Themes characteristic of responses for this sentence stem, such as relationships, communication, behavior, and growth/development, were useful for examining overall trends related to ego development. Two primary trends materialized: a movement from preconventional to postconventional functioning, and a shift in the frame of reference from integration to differentiation.

The trend of integration and differentiation manifests as two patterns throughout ego development. One pattern involves experiencing differentiation during alternating stages, as individuals focus on their differences from the previous stage. These stages of differentiation may also involve experiencing tension. Conversely, the

alternating stages experience less tension and seem more balanced because the frame of reference involves identifying with others who are externally alike, like-minded, like-principled, or like-spirited.

These trends are evident in the context of interpersonal relationships, which change throughout ego development, with their salience holding different meanings at each stage. In the preconventional stages, where symbiotic interactions and impulsivity occur, relationships are viewed as a source of supply. This source can be of a dependent nature or viewed as fulfilling a need or posing a threat. The pattern of integration to differentiation is visible as individuals move from symbiotic needs to differentiating from those relationships.

As the transition is made from preconventional to conventional stages, reasoning becomes more logical, and achieving independence becomes a primary goal. Interpersonal relationships and acceptance are important, and individuals begin to differentiate by distancing themselves from the group while aligning with experts. Relationships are valued if they are productive, effective, and encompass moral standards. The frame of reference develops from concrete to abstract, and finally to formal operational functioning, which is the target stage for most adults in the Western world. At this stage, relationships thrive if they are supportive, like-minded, and assist in reaching goals. The vast majority of the adult population scores at these preconventional and conventional stages.

The shift to a postconventional frame of reference involves a transition from logical to holistic reasoning. At the initial postconventional "systems" stages, individuals realize that meaning depends on the observer's position, and the ability to take multiple perspectives becomes a tool for making sense of the world. Context becomes more important than content. Differentiation occurs as individuals recognize that their interpretations are unique. A good boss is seen as being aware of these multiple perspectives and their role in relationships. The trend continues as individuals integrate conflicting perspectives into a like-principled framework where systems are interdependent.

Finally, in the postconventional "unitary" stages, the separate sense of self becomes an object of awareness, and the idea that everything is a human-made construct is recognized. Individuals may experience tension with this new metasystematic view of reality as they differentiate from the previous stage. As integration occurs at the final stage, individuals become more simple and succinct, experiencing a non-dual existence as part of the creative ground. Responses at this level break through conventional definitions, reflecting a universal connectedness with others.

Throughout the spectrum of ego development, individuals vacillate between integration and differentiation from one stage to the next. They evolve from an integrated, symbiotic existence in early stages, to a differentiated, independent human in conventional stages, and finally to a postconventional stage where they are once again integrated into a new sense of oneness and belongingness.

Statistics

The final sorting of all responses into categories allowed for statistical analysis. The number of responses within each category was tallied, including additional items from updated manuals to increase the sample size. Duplicate responses were included for statistical purposes but omitted in the final scoring manual. The percentage of total responses for each stage contained within specific categories was calculated to identify the most frequent categories.

It is important to note that as more data is collected, the frequency status of categories may shift. The statistical analysis also determined the distribution of total responses among the different ego development stages. For a sentence stem to be useful in measuring ego development, it must elicit responses across the range of stages.

The distribution of responses spanned from the earliest to the most advanced stages, with a peak at the stage representing formal operational functioning, which contained 43.8% of the total responses in the data set. This pattern of distribution is similar to that reported for a mixed adult population, although slightly shifted. The comparison data represents total protocol rating scores from complete sentence completion tests, not just a single stem. This similarity provides evidence of internal validity for the sentence stem, as it produces a data distribution comparable to the assessment tool as a whole. Further validity and reliability results were beyond the scope of the project.

Table: Raw Data for Distribution Graph

Stage	Responses (%)	Mixed Adult Sample TPR Scores (%)
Opportunist	0.1	4.3
Diplomat	7.9	11.3
Expert	20.9	36.5
Achiever	43.8	29.7
Pluralist	17.6	11.3
Strategist	4.8	4.9
Magician	3.7	1.5
Unitive	1.2	0.5

Bias in Scoring Responses

The scoring manuals used in this framework are empirically validated measures that rely on response data to craft the scoring guidelines. However, scoring bias can still impact the validity and reliability of the scoring process. The framework developers highlight potential sources of bias that raters might encounter during scoring. These sources of bias, which can stem from the responses themselves or be intrinsic to the rater, are examined below.

One characteristic of responses that appeared to be more of a distraction than a true scoring bias was the presence of typing errors. The responses in the dataset had already been transcribed by another individual, and some typing errors may have originated during that transcription. These responses were subsequently re-typed into a spreadsheet, potentially introducing further typing errors. There did not appear to be any instances where the rating of a response was questioned due to a typing or spelling error. In some cases, as noted by the framework developers, spelling errors originating in the written responses may influence a rater to score the response at an earlier stage.

The framework developers contend that bias regarding word choice should be avoided because it is not the specific words chosen that determine the developmental stage, but rather the evidence of the thought behind those words. They emphasize that the entire response is the only safe index of the subject's meaning, and raters must operate solely within the level of discourse of meanings. During the initial sorting of responses, a negative reaction was experienced when the pronoun "he" was used in a completion. A perspective on gender role stereotypes created an assumption that anyone using "he" in response to a good boss was discriminating

against women's capability to be good bosses. Consequently, it was assumed that someone using "he" instead of "she" might fit into an earlier developmental stage. This bias was inappropriate for the scoring process. Fortunately, this observation was made early in the scoring process, and that awareness helped mitigate bias when scoring responses containing this pronoun.

The framework developers also caution against questioning the truthfulness of a response. A fundamental ground rule for scoring is that deep-level inferences about the person's true meaning behind a response are inappropriate. During the early stages of the scoring process, a significant amount of time was spent focusing on an item response that did not exactly match a category title, attempting to decipher what the person was truly trying to say or what they really meant by their answer. For example, process notes indicate questioning whether responders who gave the answers "is a leader" and "is a teacher" were referring to the same meaning, or whether "leader" and "teacher" meant "responsible" to these responders, and should therefore be rated higher at Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ under the category "– is responsible". This type of rumination not only consumed a considerable amount of time but was also unnecessary, as raters are not supposed to attempt to figure out the hidden meaning behind a response.

Attempting to understand the factual nature of a response also raises the concern that a given sentence stem completion might merely reflect a transitory "state" of the respondent, rather than an enduring personality trait. This is a valid apprehension, as the potential to access a non-ordinary, transpersonal realm is always available, even though the state itself is transitory and fleeting. It is possible that a person has experienced a state that influences how they respond to a sentence stem.

For instance, an individual might have experienced a peak moment that corresponds to one of the sentence stems in such a way that the provided response scores at one of the later stages. However, another sentence stem, such as "A good boss—", might provoke a memory of an unpleasant experience of abuse by a previous boss, causing the person to respond in a manner resembling an Impulsive or Opportunist sentence completion. These two responses would capture transitory states experienced by the respondent. The state can also be experienced in real-time while the respondent is completing the test. For example, a person might have just come from work to a counseling session and is taking the test, but just before leaving work, they had an argument with their boss. This event could completely alter their frame of reference regarding what a good boss would be, compared to the frame of reference they held the day before.

The framework developers explain that the factual status of any response cannot be known, indicating the difficulty of determining whether a respondent's completion reflects a state or a trait. Traits, unlike states, are stable positions or preferred stances from which an individual consistently processes experiences. The measurement of this developmental framework is based on the notion that an individual will function at some core level. When rating a total protocol, the intent is to estimate that core level of functioning, or center of gravity. While some sentence stem completions may capture transitory states, the use of multiple sentence stems, combined with a sophisticated scoring system, appears to buffer out potential outlier effects and provides a depiction of the individual's stable continuum of functioning.

Other indications of bias based on response characteristics include allowing the number of words used (response length) or the respondent's age to predict the developmental level. At first glance, it might seem that the number of words used and the assigned stage are positively correlated. However, this relationship may stem from the possibility that it often takes more words to describe more complex thoughts and relationships. This highlights why proper use of the scoring manual is crucial, as it provides rules for raters to follow to avoid making such assumptions. The age of the respondent was removed from the sorted responses, so it did not appear to influence the scoring of the completions.

Finally, regarding sources of bias arising from intrinsic aspects of the response, an "end of the rainbow" effect may occur when scoring responses at later stages. In this scenario, a rater might incorrectly assume that

sentence completions conveying a sense of peace, contentment, or self-satisfaction should be scored at a later stage, as development through a sequence of stages is sometimes viewed as an increasing capacity to solve problems. However, within this developmental framework, the sequence seems more reflective of coping with increasingly profound problems. Therefore, responses at later stages may be fraught with questioning, feelings of torment, and tension arising from the awareness of significant, global, and universal conflicts that are not easily resolved.

There also appeared to be sources of bias resulting from the rater's own qualities, such as personal problems, salient interests, and the rater's own developmental level. As previously described, a salient issue that originated bias was the perspective on gender role stereotypes. Another source of bias stemmed from personal experience, specifically the rater's personal relationships with bosses. During parts of the scoring process, it became apparent that comparisons were being made between the responses in the dataset and personal experiences with "good" and "bad" bosses. An individual's perspective on what defines "A good boss—" seems to be shaped by their own concept of a good boss, based on unique life experiences. It is a challenging task to avoid using those experiences as a frame of reference during the scoring process.

Finally, it is important to consider the extent to which the rater's own developmental level might have enhanced or hindered the scoring process. When categorizing responses in the later developmental stages, it became increasingly difficult to distinguish whether a response was more appropriate for one stage or the next. It was insightful to observe the frame of reference from which the scoring was conducted. The distinction between the conventional Stage 4 and the postconventional Stage $4\frac{1}{2}$ was very evident. However, distinguishing between the later stages was a more difficult task, requiring responses to be shifted back and forth between stages numerous times. This difficulty might indicate that the rater's developmental level resides within the range of those specific stages. It would have been interesting to measure the rater's developmental level prior to this experience, identify ways to control for limitations or bias associated with their frame of reference, and determine if their developmental stage changed throughout the process by measuring it again at the project's conclusion.

It is understandable that the framework developers point out that the rater's developmental level may affect the rating process, especially for later-level protocols. However, they contend that through experience (such as scoring and understanding the underlying theory) and the use of a self-training program, the range of scoring effectiveness can be extended to later stages. This appeared to be the case in this project; when difficulties arose in distinguishing between later developmental stages, resources providing useful insight were consulted. Scoring sentence stem responses and placing each into a category relies on the rater's discretion, and different raters may score the same response in a different category or even at a different stage. With later-stage responses, there is even more room for interpretation, which is considered a natural part of the scoring process, as scoring inherently involves interpreting from one's own frame of reference.

Personal Growth

This project, as a whole, promoted personal growth and development through humility and gentle self-inquiry. Experiencing and overcoming roadblocks was necessary, and these barriers surfaced at various times, not just when working with later-stage responses. These included instances where it was necessary to relinquish the idea of understanding every aspect of the theory to make the "correct" choice regarding item placement. Working from a framework that demanded perfection in sorting the items proved to be a barrier to the overall process.

Once the humility of the task was embraced, it became possible to appreciate the glimpse into the responders' worlds and understand that it is unrealistic to expect one "right" score for every response (especially for later-stage responses). Another individual might make a different judgment on the scoring of these items, operating

from their own frame of reference. The intricate scoring process constructed in the initial scoring manual helps correct for some of these potential differences in scoring and has resulted in high interrater reliability. Once the personal stake in correctly scoring all items was withdrawn and trust was placed back into the scoring process, the project began to progress again.

A gentle self-inquiry was also interwoven throughout the project. An awareness developed that the rater's position within their own frame of reference, their perspective-taking, and the context of their lifetime experiences impacted the construction of this scoring manual. Certain assumptions were made based on salient life issues, as well as the impact of past, current, and hoped-for future relationships with "bosses" on the interpretation of responses to "A good boss—". Meaning is a constructed concept; it is an interpretation brought to an experience from the observer's position. The position as a witness to the responses shared for this stem is a unique perspective, and interpretation was brought forth from personal experience. This will differ for each individual undertaking such a task. While deep inferences about the meaning behind responses are inappropriate, and each rater approaches the task from a different frame of reference, a judgment must still be made to assign a score to each response item. It seems crucial for raters to be aware of how their unique experiences may influence those assignments.

Limitations and Future Directions

To increase the reliability of the scoring process and minimize bias introduced from personal experience, certain steps could be taken to strengthen the construction of a scoring manual. Although the final dataset included 836 responses for the sentence stem "A good boss—", collecting and adding more responses would strengthen the manual's reliability. Interrater reliability has been shown to be excellent, partly because the scoring manuals are empirically derived from data collected from the sentence stems. Having more responses allows emerging patterns and themes to develop more fully. Even with the current dataset, new categories seemed to emerge as similar items clustered together with responses from earlier datasets. Therefore, the size of the dataset may be a limitation, as a larger number of responses would help strengthen the resulting manual.

Another limitation was the rater's initial ability to rate the items. The framework developers stress the importance of the self-training process for new raters, providing training exercises in the scoring manual. Completing these self-training exercises before starting the data sort section could have saved considerable time. While knowledge of the underlying theory provided a useful foundation, the experience of sorting through hundreds of responses seemed critical for building scoring capability. Completing the self-training prior to the start of the project could have enhanced the process.

Determining the interrater reliability of this scoring manual would be an invaluable tool to enhance its effectiveness. This microvalidation step could involve a new set of response items to the stem and several different raters. Each rater could use the draft scoring manual and compare scores to generate a measure of interrater reliability. It would also be useful for the raters to track their reasons for assigning a specific score and their certainty in that decision. If a newly established category does not hold up during the microvalidation process (e.g., it is too narrow, confusing, or better subsumed by another category), this could indicate that the category is not useful and should be omitted or revised. If low certainty causes a rating discrepancy, the group of raters could discuss a new rating. Scoring insights, categories, and cross-references that work well for the group could be retained, while those not confirmed by the new data could be altered or omitted.

Conclusion

The reliability of the empirically derived scoring manuals is a major strength of this measurement tool, with decades of research reporting consistently high interrater reliability. It is necessary to continue generating reliable scoring manuals for each sentence stem, including new additions like "A good boss—". This project

enhanced the psychometric properties of the measurement tool by utilizing data to construct a scoring manual for this stem, which future raters can use. Previous attempts had been made to create a scoring manual for “A good boss—”, and this project helped validate those existing categories while adding five new possible categories. Studying the distribution of responses for this stem also internally validated the scoring device and the construct of measurement.

Regarding the study of this developmental framework and its benefit to the counseling field, sorting responses into different stages and categorizing within each stage tests the original concept and the reliability of the scoring manuals. The responses included in this scoring manual can be utilized in future research to further define and understand manifestations of development in sentence stem completions, particularly in the ongoing study of later developmental stages. Even the relatively few responses added to the scoring manual for the later stages will contribute to the current scarcity of postautonomous response data for sentence stem completions. This experience also positively influenced personal and professional growth, increasing awareness of how one’s developmental stage can influence their perspective on how others translate life from their own centers of gravity.

This project has hopefully enhanced the foundation for establishing a scoring manual for the sentence stem “A good boss—”, strengthened the psychometric properties of the measurement tool, increased the data available for study, and promoted the use of this developmental theory as a sound construct with a valid and reliable measurement tool.

Statistics Chart

Number of Responses	Percentage of Total Responses	Internal Logic Category
Stage $\frac{2}{3}$		
– stays out of my way	7	43.75
– likes me	3	18.75
– doesn't snoop on us	2	12.50
Hostile tone	2	12.50
– let's you have a good time	1	6.25
– is easy to get around	1	6.25
Total	16	100
Stage 3		
– listens, cares, talks to his people ($\frac{3}{4}$, 12)	20	30.30
– is hard to find	17	25.76
– is understanding, kind, helpful, friendly	9	13.64
– is mine, – is what I want to be	6	9.09
– gets on well with his staff (beginning social interaction)	2	3.03
– is a teacher, leader	4	6.06
– is important	3	4.55
– is great! (2, 1) simple idealization	3	4.55
Unassigned: (assigned to Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ due to Rule 5)	2	3.03
Total	66	100
Stage $\frac{3}{4}$		
– is a blessing	19	10.92
Is defined by what he does not do (action-oriented)	18	10.34
– is effective	15	8.62
is not... (single negative attribute)	14	8.05

Number of Responses	Percentage of Total Responses	Internal Logic Category
– is responsible, reliable	12	6.90
– should be fair	10	5.75
– is hard to describe	8	4.60
– is appreciative, patient, (single positive conventional trait)	7	4.02
– delegates	6	3.45
– is one who appreciates his people	13	7.47
– is respected, looked up to	12	6.90
Affects how work is experienced	10	5.75
– knows his staff members well	10	5.75
– makes life easier	5	2.87
– makes a good, happy employee	4	2.30
– communicates with his staff (unelaborated)	11	6.32
Total	163	100
Stage 4		
Mentioning several positive qualities (list of 2 or more)	77	21.15
– supports people to develop, learn, improve, experiment	47	12.91
Balancing job requirements and employee needs (simply stated)	30	8.24
Mentioning of at least 2 contrasting behaviors	27	7.42
– Listens, then acts.	13	3.57
– is decisive, organized, has business skills	12	3.30
– has experience	9	2.47
– tries his best, tries to improve himself	9	2.47
– does not ... (behaviors qualified)	8	2.20
– affects the atmosphere at work	7	1.92

Number of Responses	Percentage of Total Responses	Internal Logic Category
Has differentiated relationship to individuals	24	6.59
– is accessible	13	3.57
– is interested in what you do (qualified)	11	3.02
– is also a colleague.	6	1.65
– motivates	18	4.95
– communicates with his staff (emphasis on quality)	12	3.30
– is hard to be (beginning recognition of difficulty of role)	15	4.12
One or more positive differentiated trait	12	3.30
– is not ... (attributes qualified)	8	2.20
– savvy in business matters and people	4	1.10
Awareness of past understanding	2	0.55
Total	364	100
Stage $\frac{4}{5}$		
– fosters an environment conducive to help can grow	46	31.51
– is genuinely interested in what others think and value	26	17.81
Interpersonal relationships are valuable in their own right	22	15.07
Growing awareness of individual differences with a capacity to empathize	6	4.11
Tolerance for human nature and mistakes	10	6.85
– is a complex person (unique insight)	14	9.59
– has no illusion about himself	12	8.22
Multiple answers/interpretations in a single response	10	6.85
Total	146	100
Stage 5		
Complex psychological causation, mutual influence	24	60.00

Number of Responses	Percentage of Total Responses	Internal Logic Category
– Concern for autonomy in others without relinquishing the role as leader	16	40.00
Total	40	100
Stage $\frac{5}{6}$		
Category $\frac{5}{6},1$: Complex matrix	10	32.26
Category $\frac{5}{6},2$: Habits of heart	10	32.26
Category $\frac{5}{6},3$: Habits of mind	1	3.23
Category $\frac{5}{6},4$: Recognition of constructed nature of reality	10	32.26
Total	31	100
Stage 6		
Category 6,3: Universal connectedness	2	20.00
Category 6,4: Fundamental thoughts and feelings about the human condition	5	50.00
Category 6,5: Unitive thought and unique encompassing metaphor	3	30.00
Total	10	100

Note: The abbreviations used in the Internal Logic Category column represent themes within the developmental stage: (B) Behavior; ® Relationships; © Communication; (G) Growth; and (O) Other.

The Construct-Aware Stage of Ego Development and its Relationship to the Fool Archetype

This essay addresses the use of laughter as a tool to lighten up our own lives and the lives of those around us. While fools and jesters can come from any stage, it is a late-stage discovery to recognize the poison of taking ourselves too seriously and its antidote: light-heartedness and delight. We often take ourselves and our mandate to raise collective consciousness very seriously. That is why we exchange ideas and work with each other. We have much important knowledge to share. And while that is as it should be, it is important to remember the fool in all of us and to engage in our work with a deeper level of awareness.

Ego development theory proposes that it is a characteristic of maturity to discover that not knowing is the highest form of knowing. The concept of the fool is about the capacity to recognize the folly of trying to explain and map everything. It is about truly seeing how thoroughly we tend to confuse our maps and theories with the territory.

Some may bristle at this notion of being a fool, especially if they cherish their identification as an expert in constructive developmental theory. The question asked in ancient Rome: Who is not a fool? Moreover, it has been said that foolery walks about the orb like the sun, it shines everywhere. Finally, we quip: "Anyone who does not wish to see a fool, should smash his mirror."

We are all fools when we so avidly strive to gain greater insight to master our lives, reach nirvana and hope to leave traces of our greatness. As a group we tend to believe that if only everyone else could collaborate and see the world through our color-tinted glasses, then we could be saved from our self-induced global calamity both as individuals and as a species and create the longed-for better world.

The longer we have lived and the more we think we understand about existence, the more we need reminding of the teaching that says: "Understanding is the ultimate illusion."

There is a relationship between the capacity to see through the function and games of the ego and the archetype of the fool. Both show an increasing affinity for mirth and laughter. Both tend to point to all that is pretentious, self-important or takes itself too seriously.

Since time immemorial, all cultures, groups and individuals have told stories about where they come from, and who they are in relation to nature and the universe. They have explanations about why they exist and where they are headed in life and after death. From myths to grand theories of everything, storytelling seems to be a universal human characteristic.

Based on observations, the Construct-Aware stage in ego development theory is the first in which some people begin to explore our astounding world-wide impulse to explain everything under the sun and the concomitant capacity to fool ourselves about what it means to know. It's liberating to be able to take life more lightly and to laugh at ego's sincere and relentless efforts to cement its illusive supremacy.

What is Ego?

First, what is meant by ego? As defined in ego development theory, ego underlies the universal drive to explain everything and make us feel safe, important, and to belong. Ego represents the striving of human beings to understand themselves and the world they live in. It is the tireless organizer, interpreter, and synthesizer of experience. Its task is to turn experience into a coherent narrative about the world. How does it do that? It does so by telling a culturally influenced story about who we are, why we are here and for what purpose.

Overall, the ego labors mightily to create and maintain meaning and vigorously defends against dissonant information and its deep, unspeakable sense of helplessness. Indeed, when we are not able to tell a good story about ourselves and our tribe, we feel anxiety and despair. Ego is invested in the denial of death, and in upholding the illusion of our immortality. Therefore, facing and embracing our finitude is part of late-stage realization.

It is at the Construct-Aware stage that one becomes aware of ego's narrative function and its cleverness at fooling us into thinking we can know and understand. Few people begin to question the function of ego and our need for myths, stories, and theorizing. Even rarer among ordinary adults, some individuals learn to look kindly at ego's tireless striving for security and preeminence while seeing through its hopeless efforts.

Construct-Aware individuals are the first who potentially realize the illusion of "knowing" and the futility of trying to make ever better maps of reality. Other names for the Construct-Aware stage are Magician, Alchemist, Fool,

and Jester. It is these latter two aspects of the Construct-Aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$, that will be explored further here.

The Role of Language and Culture

Overall, human development moves from the newborn's unconscious union with mother to a conscious union with everyone and everything. As we grow up we construct meaning by learning the vocabulary, memes, grammar and the scripts available to us from our languages and cultures. Languages divide lived experience into separate objects with distinct boundaries and evaluative attributes. We are so totally immersed in a sea of language that we hardly notice the way it lures us into a false sense of knowledge and how it molds us into very particular notions of what is real and important.

The idea of a separate self in Western cultures is just one result of this phenomenon. It is ironic that all of us have to communicate via symbols. Ironical also that concepts such as "purpose" and "soul" as well as "ego" are symbolic abstractions that do not exist outside of language and our agreed upon definitions. Yet we treat them almost always as if they were palpable, real things. We could choose to remain silent in the face of this paradox or to speak out and laugh at our dilemma while remaining conscious of the trap of speaking.

In this context, the focus will mainly be on aspects of the penultimate stage in ego development theory, the Construct-Aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$. The stage has several expressions: The cognitively-focused Construct-Aware and the more meaning-focused Ego-Aware. A third, more action-oriented form pertains to individuals who bravely hold up the mirror to society and intervene in real time to debunk all forms of accepted dogma, non-sense, and pretense. The third form is the closest to the fool archetype.

The job of wise individuals and jesters has been to expose the blind spots of society and to unmask any emperor with new clothes since time immemorial. They often do so at the risk of their own lives as their message is rarely welcome. Gifted fools, however, can come from any stage, and yet it is at stage $\frac{5}{6}$, that one first fully realizes there is nothing to gain or lose by pretending to know. We are just here, now, alive, on this tiny blue pebble hurtling through a vast mysterious universe. Existence cannot be explained without recourse to storytelling.

The first, the Construct-aware form of stage $\frac{5}{6}$ understands the human need to create ever more comprehensive explanations of reality despite knowing that lived experience cannot be captured in words.

We think we are taking hold of reality when we concoct a plausible theory about it. Far from it. Our lived experience is always dynamic, moment to moment, and seamless comprised of myriad fleeting sensory impressions, feelings, and thoughts. The maps of reality we construct can never depict the undivided whole, the actual lived territory. They are, at best, temporary, and useful approximations that serve us as guidelines.

Moreover, we trust science and technology as well as highly developed human minds that we can and will eventually be able to explain the cosmos. Constructive adult development theory buys into this conception by asserting that meaning is made and that we can explain what it takes to become a mature and highly evolved human being.

Most developmental theories judge the complexity of thought as the best indicator of advanced understanding. They make great efforts to help people grow bigger minds, handle more complexity, wield greater influence, and have a more lasting and far-reaching impact. Most assume that cognitive agility and a second-tier perspective are vital for solving our increasingly complex, deep-rooted, and global problems.

Most adult development theories do not, however, point out the fundamental limitations of symbolic mental activity that includes our penchant for storytelling and theory making. Who or what is behind meaning making

remains undefined. Why we are striving for meaning and growth is taken as a given or explained away by other abstract concepts, such as, for instance, the idea of progress via the evolutionary impulse.

Ego development theory alone postulates that it is ego's task to construct meaning and to form a coherent narrative about existence to counter uncertainty.

Based on the evidence of more than 4500 sentence completions tests, nine different self-stories were identified, nine different ways of defining what is real and important in the Western world. These ways develop sequentially and represent increasing levels of individuation and integration. While complex reasoning is an aspect of later-stage meaning making, it is not sufficient by itself for becoming a mature adult. By mature, it means a wise, discerning, and compassionate human being: One who is aware of being held captive by language. One who accepts being mortal, and, thus, participates in the universal processes of growth and demise.

A Brief Refresher of Ego Development Theory

Let us now briefly recapitulate the overall trajectory of ego development. A clear pattern of a developmental sequence was first seen in the stories women told about themselves by analyzing thousands of sentence completions. Ego development theory and its measurement still derives from empirical evidence, not from mere theorizing.

By analyzing thousands of additional sentence completion tests, it was possible to suggest the logical underpinnings of increasing perspectives and expand the stage sequence at the upper end. These hypotheses were validated both statistically and qualitatively. Since then, some additional 360,000 pieces of evidence have been accumulated. So far these support the current distinctions, but, for lack of evidence, do not allow for speculation about further stages.

The arc representation is chosen for this summary. Details about arrested adult development and the first three ego stages: The Self-Centric stage $\frac{2}{3}$, the Group-Centric stage 3 and the Skill-Centric Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ will not be offered.

The first half of this arc image shows the movement from an unconscious unity of the infant at birth to an ever more accurate, unique, and separate self-identity at the Self-Governing Stage 4. At the apex of the arc, separation is at its most developed (modern science) and the boundary between "me and not me," between "this" and "that" is most clearly-delineated. Stage 4 represents the ideal adult in most modern western societies. Its achievement and expression are encouraged, supported by our social institutions, and rewarded. At Stage 4, people tend to have the most definite idea of who they are, and what they want, and how to achieve their goals including making the world a better place. They rely on rational analysis and technology. They trust that humans can figure out solutions to all problems, if not now, certainly in the future. While they may know some of their personal traits, preferences, and behavior patterns, they do not yet fully recognize their historical, geographic, cultural, and linguistic conditioning.

The discovery of having been socialized into specific set of beliefs about what is real, is an aspect of the next, the Self-Inquiring stage $\frac{4}{5}$. It is the first stage that can take a perspective on its own acculturation and assumptions. Individuals are now aware that other people have their own perspectives and unique programming to deal with and their own way of telling their stories. While there is one reality, there are as many perspectives on it as there are people. Moreover, rational linear analysis is often rejected in favor of free-spirited self-expression. One realizes that life and the world is much stranger and less predictable than one believed up to now. Great uncertainty to who one really is outside of conditioned responses is part of the confusion and challenge of Stage $\frac{4}{5}$. At the same time, self-questioning creates a sense of freedom, and the open road.

At the next level, the Self-Actualizing stage 5, people gain a more integrated way to feel good, powerful, and certain about themselves. Rational analysis is an important part of meaning making yet supported by access to intuition, dreams, creativity, and other inner and outer resources. The person understands the interdependence of people and systems. That includes recognizing that we are inevitably influenced by the environment and that we shape it in turn. Many at Stage 5 can appreciate their own and others' developmental journeys and, thus, relate to themselves and others in more skillful and appreciative ways. Many also feel empowered, masterful, and proud of their understanding as they indeed know a lot more about themselves, human nature, and the world than people at any stage before. Pride about how much one knows is one of the shadows of this stage along with its inner certainty and sense of importance. "If only everyone were second-tier then the world could be saved."

The Construct-Aware stage $\frac{5}{6}$ is the first in the sequence to begin to understand the process of meaning making and identity formation. It recognizes the moment to moment construction of a self, and its ongoing deconstruction and reconstruction. While Stage 5 can discern patterns of evolution in nature, people, and society, it still trusts that more knowledge and control over the vagaries of life are attainable and will give us a way out of the current global catastrophe.

Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ constitutes a radically new perspective. It can look at the whole paradigm of constructive developmental theory, compare it to other psychological theories and see both their similarities and differences, their benefits and limitations. It is thus a stage of differentiation from the previously held view of reality and meaning making. Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ embraces the fundamental uncertainty about knowing and shows a greater and greater capacity to see through our human yearning for meaning and wholeness.

People at this form of Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ often experience great existential tension as there is now really no ground to stand on, no single reality to observe from multiple perspectives. Instead, there are multiple realities created by humans in different cultures and languages. All theories are seen for what they are: ego's attempts to create order, certainty, and predictability. While there can be tremendous suffering associated with seeing through the games our minds play, the pain can be appreciated and indeed embraced as a portal to deeper connection and fuller being.

In contrast, some individuals become aware of ego's function and how it does its work. Ego-Aware is a name used for this aspect of Stage $\frac{5}{6}$. Ego is always trying to make us feel secure, important, and enduring. It executes its charge with exquisite finesse. This includes a tendency to adopt any ideology that; a) resonates with our own ideals and yearnings, b) gives us a sense of power and belonging, and c) promises us a sense of immortality.

Ego tries to usurp even the loftiest spiritual notions to feel good about itself. This tendency has been famously diagnosed as spiritual materialism.

Research has shown just how readily the ego will appropriate any content to see itself as a hero and make itself feel more potent and indispensable. The suffering here can be intense as no attempt at overcoming ego's workings (shenanigans) will achieve its goal of ego-transcendence and self-liberation. The more one strives for greater insight and seeks detachment from ego, the more attached one is to whatever one is seeking.

It is a Construct-Aware capacity to see through ego's efforts at safeguarding our illusion of knowing. Immersed as we are in language, humans everywhere participate in confusing discursive knowing with understanding. It takes courage to acknowledge that we are all prone to fool ourselves in myriad ways about our achievements, including in terms of development and spiritual attainment. It requires great grit to believe in the value of simply being alive and not to despair in the face of fundamental doubt about ever knowing and understanding.

As it is often said, we are all bozos on the same bus. Once we get this joke, we can become more light-hearted, and see ego's striving for control in a more benevolent light because it can do no other. Fooling us and misdirecting our attention is ego's task. It makes us feel secure, permanent, and important. It creates for us a pretend world in which we can reach heaven and in which we don't really have to die. And yet, there is no escaping the tragedy and randomness of life and our inevitable death.

To summarize, mature integration as a human being entails an increasing capacity to notice ego's workings. At the same time, we can lighten-up and experience the simple and childlike joy of being alive. We can delight in the senses and our inner world – moment to moment as well as appreciate the lives and struggles of humanity.

One of the surprising insights of late stage maturity is realizing what a hoot ego's efforts are. It is folly to wish experience to be different than it is. And yet many idealists feel it is its own madness to see life as it is, and not as we wish it to be, and as we think it should be. It is natural that we want to feel that we are here for a higher purpose, that our lives mean something beyond simple existence.

Perhaps most important of all, immersed as we are in language, humans automatically participate in the delusion that symbol-mediated knowing is true understanding.

In this essay, the possibility has been opened that all of us are fools, prone to fall into the typical and very human trap of self-delusion. We are fooling ourselves especially when we believe that we know, and thereby that we can predict and control. We can learn to take ourselves less seriously and laugh at ego's folly while appreciating its hapless and important task. Embracing the inseparableness of laughter and tears, of life and death, is part of the unmasking process of Fool-Ling. It is suggested that the ability to laugh whole-heartedly and with compassion at the human condition is an indicator of ego maturity and a mark of the wise fool.

To sum up, the Construct-Aware stage is the first stage in the sequence of ego development stages that sees through the function of the ego to make us feel safe, important, and permanent. We inevitably use language to describe experience and then make maps and tell stories about it.

Fools are Everywhere!

Treatises about the fool character and its brethren and sisters serve as a rich resource of information.

Throughout the ages and across the globe their role and special license was to tell the unvarnished truth.

Much has been written about the ubiquity and ancient recognition of the function of the fool as an archetype. He is the forerunner to the hero's quest to explore the unknown and deal with the demons awaiting us. Its closest ally is the wise fool, the kind we may encounter in seasoned elders and well-grounded late-stage meaning makers.

Human fools and jesters look at the human condition from a radically honest, and yet often deeply caring and imaginative perspective. Their function is to reveal and poke fun at the limitation of people, systems, and society. Historically and culturally, fools have played an essential role in holding up the mirror to power, vanity, and entitlement.

Like fools, the statistically rare, integrated individuals at stage $5\frac{5}{6}$ are marginal to society. As outsiders, they can observe the human drama while accepting that they are players in it. Because they have a perspective on meaning making itself, they can observe the clever games ego plays and how we can delude ourselves.

In academia, taking oneself seriously is almost a requirement. Jestors are rarely welcome. When they debunk established pet theories, they are likely expelled and hung out to dry. In times past, they were even burnt at the stake for challenging the powers that be. The quintessential caricature of the learned man who is stuck in his head elicits ridicule by exaggerating his knowledge and his pedantic self-importance. Academic pretense can be

found everywhere. You recognize it by all the neologisms, fancy multi-syllabic words presented with an aura of authority. Most of us tend to think something is deep and must be true if we don't really understand it. We don't want to appear ignorant and admit we are unable to get it whatever the "it" is.

It is pointed out that: It is often considered that to be taken seriously one had to be serious, that humor is frivolous, and not suited to weighty matters. Yet earnestness implies rigidity while humor tends towards fluidity and as such is surely a better means of dealing with serious matters, since it is well equipped to take the complexities and contradictions of life in its stride.

Shared Characteristics

So, what do mature Construct-Aware meaning makers and wise fools and jesters have in common?

They expose and laugh at all that is pretentious, inauthentic, and unpoetic.

- They unmask intellectual arrogance, expose mental rigidity, and uncover (defrock) spiritual ego inflation.
- They expose and poke fun at sacred cows, and pompous behavior of any kind especially in authorities.
- They deliver the truth raw without embellishing or softening it to please.
- They are spontaneous and often irreverent towards the established order.
- While they challenge the conventional mores and beliefs of society, they generally do not try to overthrow them as would rebels.
- They shake people out of deep-rooted patterns of thought and behavior and remind us of our human frailties and limitations.
- Like very young children, they embrace innocence, are joyful, imaginative and can play on the world stage with abandon.
- At the same time, wise fools are always also laughing at their own suffering, confusion, and the reality of our shared human lot.

Wise fools and jesters are an affirmation of all that is uncertain in the universe, the random and unknown factors of existence. That makes them a threat to those who want to believe we know where humanity is headed, to those who trust that all has been mapped out and already settled and that whatever mysteries remain will be unlocked in due time.

How do wise fools and mature humans hold up the mirror?

- They present a different angle or perspective on reality and offer a wider view of experience than people who swim with the mainstream.
- They use self-deprecating humor, puns, and wordplay to diffuse tense situation and soften the blow of their critical observations.
- They can voice disagreement by profusely agreeing with an absurd notion, so that the perpetrator sees the absurdity for him or herself.
- In scholarly contexts, they may use reason in such a way that the fallacy of a belief becomes evident. This requires that proponents of a theory are open to having their ideas and certainties challenged.
- They can create space by exaggerating the absurd that is taken for normal and thus create laughter as the only healthy response.

Both wise humans and fools can turn the world on its head by making people see the ultimate insignificance of many of the things they hold dear by pointing to unwarranted beliefs and delusions as well as misperceptions and illusions.

We all benefit from practicing being OK with what is, especially with not being perfect and recognizing the function of the ego's to fool us into feeling in control of life. Getting over ourselves is a great gift to humanity. We are all fallible and mortal human beings. Let's unlearn conditioned self-criticism, perfectionism, thinking we know, and wishing things to be different than they are.

Humor and laughter are wonderful remedies for pointing to folly and self-importance wherever they show up. While trying our best, let's learn to smile kindly at our foibles and clay feet. The very laughter gives us angel wings, the antidote to taking ourselves too seriously.

Description of the Development of Nine Action Logics in the Leadership Development Framework

Metaphorically speaking, the framework provides us with one possible account of how individuals navigate the straits of human existence by using navigational lore, common sense, increasingly complex maps, algorithms, and intuition.

The Preconventional Stages

Infant, Stage 1

The pre-social or symbiotic stage, Stage 1:

- **Perspective on the self:** none
- **Cognitive:** 1a; nominal actions
- **Self:** Con-fused, confounded, undifferentiated self
- **Other:** not distinct, source of survival

Impulsive, Stage 2

Impulsive Action Logic, Stage 2:

- **First person perspective**
- **Cognitive:** 2a Primary actions
- **Self:** rudimentary, physical self-labeling "me, mine"
- **Differentiation:** crude dichotomies
- **Other:** fulfillment of needs on demand

Opportunist, Stage $\frac{2}{3}$

Opportunist Action Logic, or stage $\frac{2}{3}$:

- **Cognitive:** 2b preoperational actions
- **Self:** single concrete features, minimal action-based self-description in terms of desire
- **Other:** competing for goods, space, dominance, power
- **Differentiation:** Beginning sense of others as having their own wants and will to get.

The Conventional Stages

Diplomat, Stage 3

Diplomat Action Logic, Stage 3:

- **Cognitive:** 3b concrete operations
- **Self:** several external features; vital statistics given; rudimentary internal states, negative avoided or suppressed
- **Two types of other:**
 1. own family, tribe, group, nation: provides identity, values and protection. Boundaries between self and in-group confused; over-identified
 2. every one who is different, or not part of my group belongs to the out-group (threat: them vs. us)

Rule-Oriented ($\Delta/3$) not in the framework The Rule-oriented stage, $\Delta/3$: (subsumed under Diplomat in the framework)

- **Second person perspective**
- **Cognitive:** 3a primary actions
- **Self:** single external features; beginning comparisons, one variable at a time
- **Other:** Sees me also and notices how I am and what I do; beginning recognition that if I want something from other I have to make myself appealing.

The Diplomat stage 3 describes persons with an early adolescent frame of mind. Their self-identity is defined by their relationship to a group. This leads to confused boundaries between oneself and the group (whether family, team or nation). Being part of this larger entity allows one to be protected and share in its power. The price for protection is loyalty and obedience.

Expert, Stage $\frac{3}{4}$

The Expert or Technician Action Logic; stage $\frac{3}{4}$:

- **Cognition:** 4a abstract operations; beginning ability to take a 3rd person perspective or to look at oneself objectively

- **Self:** Separate self differentiated from others; sense of specialness. Identity = clusters of external attributes, conventional traits, “self-conscious” in the sense of readily feeling uneasy.
- **Other:** others too are seen as separate persons who are different from me. Need for constant comparison & measuring. Do others measure up to my ideas and standards?

They want to be accepted by others because of their difference. They also tend to want to be better than others, stand out from the crowd. The group is needed, but one stands at its periphery threatening to leave, without ever quite leaving. Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ persons often feel they have “figured it all out.” They know all the answers. They know what to believe. They feel righteous and often put others in the wrong (resistance). They have high moral standards and a strong sense of what should be. They are concerned with fulfilling their responsibilities and duties. They often display compulsive and perfectionist tendencies. The super-ego is very strong.

In interpersonal situation the “yes, but” syndrome is very common. One-upmanship - that is, listening to the other and then adding one’s own opinion to remain on top - is typical. On the plus side, Experts are very adept at finding new and different solutions, better ideas, more perfect procedures. Adolescents as well as adults with this action logic see multiple possibilities and alternative solutions.

Achiever, Stage 4

The Achiever action logic or Stage 4:

- **Realm:** Self in society, others with similar goals and aspirations
- **Time frame:** Self as it is (traits), self as it should be (goals, ideals)
- **Cognition:** 4b, formal operations; clear separation of subject and object, knower and known.
- **Preoccupations:** Reasons, causes, goals, achievement, effectiveness, contracts and agreements.
- **Positive equilibration:** rational, analytical determined, conscientious, fair; successful; competent with high self-esteem
- **Truth:** Can be found through appropriate scientific methods if not now > later.

The Achiever action logic is the target stage for Western culture. Our educational systems are intended to produce adults with the mental capacity of the Achiever stage, that is, rationally competent and independent adults. Democracy as a form of government is based on the capacity of its independent-thinking voters to make reasoned and informed choices.

Achievers add linear time (consciously thinking of their past and future selves) as concern to the third person perspective. Persons at this action logic are interested in reasons, causes, goals, consequences and the effective use of time. They are curious what makes themselves and others “tick” in more than a “why” way.

Achievers generally believe in the perfectibility of humankind and in the scientific method to “uncover” truth. Formal operations and abstract rationality are at their peak. People believe that the proper scientific methods of investigation and procedures will eventually lead to the discovery of how things really are, including human nature.

The mood of the stage is earnest conviction, seriousness, idealism and enthusiasm usually oriented towards action.

Given their cognitive capacity, Achievers are in love with the hypothetical, with theories at the espoused level. Achievers are convinced that society can be controlled and improved. They have the frame of mind where

formal operations are at their peak and rationality, progressivism, positivism and reductionism have their strongholds.

Achievers can become skeptical. Achiever researchers are known for their intellectual skepticism towards things that are not yet proven. However, they do believe that the laws of the universe can be figured out eventually and proved.

The Postconventional Stages

a) The General Systems Stages

At the first postconventional level people come to realize that the meaning of things depend on one's relative position in regard to them, that is, on one's personal perspective & interpretation of them. Although the objects themselves are seen as permanent, their meaning is seen as constructed.

With the 4th person perspective, individuals realize that things are not always what they were thought to be. Paradoxes (rather than contradictions) do exist. Thus, Individualists may come to enjoy paradoxes and contradictions and no longer try to explain them away "to heck with it! Everything is relative." Linear, intellectual logic gives way to a more holistic understanding of things.

Individualists often replace the focus on causality (past) and goals (future) of the Achiever with a fascination with the immediate present. They need to understand and watch how things unfold. Their focus turns from outcomes and deliverables to an interest in the processes, relationships and non-linear influences among variables.

But they may also be feared as unpredictable or dismissed as dreamers and non-doers, especially in an Achiever environment. Their relationships with others are intense and mutually rewarding when there is synergy and choice. When they have to manage others as part of a job, they can be autocratic or idiosyncratic to such a degree, that others find them "impossible to nail down" or "aloof and unapproachable."

The Individualist, Stage $\frac{4}{5}$

The Individualistic action logic, or Stage $\frac{4}{5}$:

- **4th person perspective**
- **Relativism:** discovery of personal and cultural conditioning and defensive self-deception
- **Cognition:** 5a, systems theory concepts perceived
- **Positive equilibration:** vivid individualism; concentrate and relish experience in the here and now
- **Truth:** can never be found. Everything is relative; there is no place to stand or judge from deconstructive postmodernism.

Individualists distrust conventional wisdom and the hyper-rational tenets of the Achiever action logic. They need to distance themselves from all that went before. In this case, one must reevaluate the self-adopted, yet sanctioned role identities of society and redefine oneself uniquely and independently of them based on one's own experience and conclusions. When one fully realizes that most prior meaning making was socially and culturally conditioned, scientific certainty and the judgmental frame of mind break down. Moreover, Individualists learn to consciously scrutinize their beliefs in order to test their assumptions or to relish the novel mental freedom such a maneuver allows.

Since one's old identities are no longer accepted without questioning, Individualists are preoccupied with a desire for unique personal accomplishments independent of any socially sanctioned roles.

The Strategist, Stage 5

Strategist Action Logic or Stage 5:

- **Expanded 4th person perspective:** Self is embedded in history and multiple cultural contexts.
- **Realm:** Society and others with similar convictions and principles
- **Time frame:** own "history, lifetime"
- **Cognition:** 5b, metasystematic operations; General systems thinker
- **Preoccupations:** own development, self-actualization, self-fulfillment; processes
- **Positive equilibration:** well-balanced body/mind integration; autonomous, tolerant, insightful, growth-oriented; high self-esteem; overarching principles
- **Truth:** can be approximated; higher development is better since more complex arguments carry more weight than feeble ones. Higher is more adequate for functioning in an ever more complex global theatre. There are qualitative differences!

The Strategist action logic represents an enlarged fourth person perspective which places the individual's experience into the context of particular societies and within the totality of a person's lifetime. With the expanded time frame and wider social networks, Strategists can perceive systemic patterns or long-term trends and are often valued for that "strategic" capacity. Cognitively they have a general systems view of reality, that is they can comprehend multiple interconnected systems of relationships and processes.

The greatest fear of Strategists is to feel that they have not fulfilled their potential, or to have failed to observe those universal principles they value deeply (justice, tolerance, dignity of all people). Depression is often based on loss of courage, loss of self-agency and guilt for not having fulfilled one's unique human promise. When using defenses, Strategists use mostly mature ones: suppression, altruism, humor, anticipation. When they use less mature defenses, they are able to forgive themselves and move on. "Right now I need to be like this, but I intend to act more maturely again later."

Many Strategists see life as an open-ended journey. They believe that there is no predetermined way to follow for all human beings. Each individual has to find and create his/her own life style and is responsible for his or her self-fulfillment.

Strategists are interested in psychological questions and how to come to terms with inner conflict. Unlike people at the conventional stages, seeking therapy, advice, or consulting from others, is not seen as a weakness, but welcomed as an opportunity. Strategists have faith in their own and other people's capacity to make meaning out of messes and difficulties.

Strategists may genuinely feel principled anger and righteous indignation towards the injustices of the world. They will stand up against society to express their personal convictions or to uphold their principles. Their anger does not usually seek a victim. They live their personal conviction according to self-evaluated, internal standards. "To walk the talk" becomes an expression of one's moral character and authenticity. Irreconcilable role conflicts are felt deeply. Some Strategists become charismatic moral leaders. When they defend what they believe to be a worthy cause, they often disregard negative consequences for themselves. But they may also be overly forceful with their convictions especially when they are fueled by principled anger. The combination of charisma and moral conviction can be a powerful negative force if not kept in check.

b) The Unitive Stages or Action Logics

At the second level of postconventional stages people come to realize that all objects are human-made constructs, including such abstract constructs as the ego, three-dimensional space and time. All are based on layers upon layers of symbolic abstraction.

At the previous systems stage level, the conventional belief into a permanent object world began to be deconstructed as interpretation and context-dependence are recognized as crucial to any knowledge endeavor. At this new level of differentiation, reality is now understood as the undifferentiated phenomenological continuum or chaos, the creative ground, “das All,” or whatever other terms human beings have created to express this awareness of an underlying unity. To deal with the fundamental assumptions about human nature and one’s need to make order out of the chaos is one of the main existential concerns of men and women at these two highest stages of ego development. The final action logics in the framework represent cross-paradigmatic and transrational operations as only the creation of a new way of knowing can hierarchically supersede and integrate all previous knowledge and epistemologies.

The Magician, Stage $\frac{5}{6}$

- **Realm:** Beyond own culture
- **Time frame:** beyond own lifetime; global-historical perspective
- **Cognition:** 6a, unitive concepts perceived; cross-paradigmatic
- **Preoccupation:** inner conflict around existential paradoxes and intrinsic problems of language and meaning making.
- **Positive equilibration:** Acceptance of tension and paradox, committed to service of self and others; humility in face of task
- **Truth:** No matter what level of abstraction and what level of cognitive insight one gains, one is always separated from the underlying nondifferentiated continuum.

Construct-aware Magicians start to pay attention to their emotional and rational processing behavior. They pay attention to the automatic judgment habit as well as the habits of mind such as our endless analyzing and reflecting in order to create ever more accurate theories of life and nature. All of these endeavors are understood as partial defenses against knowing the impermanence of the embodied self. Thus, at the Construct-aware stage not just cultural conditioning is seen through, but the predicament of living in language.

When people see through the filter of the symbolic construction and mapping of reality, their disposition towards the language habit can change profoundly. In general, Magicians try to remain aware of the pseudo-reality created by words. They realize that the pursuit of objective self-identification and rational, objective explanations of the universe are futile—artifacts of our need to make permanent and substantive that which is in flux and immaterial. To reiterate a crucial point, the language habit works to support the ego’s supremacy whenever we make meaning through representations regardless of the specific tongue, power base, or cultural or personal context. At the same time, Magicians appreciate the vital function language plays in human affairs, in social interaction and development.

It is a fact of Magician life that there are few other people like them. They may fear that almost nobody understands them in their complexity and sympathizes with their experience, and fearing this, they feel culpable of hubris, of feeling “better” than others. They also observe their own self-attachment and their need for a permanent self-identity by means of ever bigger self-theories. On the other hand, they truly appreciate others’

need to make sense of their lives within their own means. They therefore have a much deeper toleration for other's solution to life's conditions without being blind to the possible shortcomings and limitations of such solutions.

Sometimes Magicians express a sense of envy at the simplicity of earlier periods because their own world is experienced as so complex. However, given their ego maturity, most are capable of arriving at a dynamic and hopeful balance within these fundamental conflicts: They fulfill their perceived or chosen destiny independently and courageously in full realization of their basic despair and aloneness. When they cannot integrate this awareness, their depression is about man's essential aloneness and inability to create lasting meaning through the rational enterprise.

As leaders, Magicians tend to build their own novel organizations or work alone doing what they perceive to be their best contribution to humanity. They like to take on the roles of catalysts or transformers, but readily leave when they feel their transformational work is done. They feel successful when they have made themselves dispensable, that is, if the organization itself has become transformative and self-reorganizing.

The Ironist, Stage 6

The Unitive stage 6 or The Ironist Action Logic:

- **Multiperspectival; center no longer in the ego, but the higher Self**
- **Realm:** universe > time/space continuum
- **Time frame:** eternity
- **Cognition:** Unitive concepts embraced
- **Preoccupation:** Being, non-controlling consciousness; witnessing of flux of experience and states of mind
- **Positive equilibration:** Accepting, unassuming presence; fully empathetic, non-interfering ability to be with whatever is.
- **Truth:** immanent; experiential truth of interconnectedness and nonseparateness, existence as changing states of awareness within timeless spirit.

The Ironist action logic presents an entirely new way of perceiving human existence and consciousness. The previous way of viewing reality solely from the self's perspective and through the medium of language is transformed. The new paradigm has a universal or cosmic perspective. Ironist individuals experience themselves and others as part of ongoing humanity, embedded in the creative ground, fulfilling the destiny of evolution. The two sides of the Pascalian paradox are integrated: feelings of belongingness and feelings of one's separateness and uniqueness are experienced without undue tension as changing perceptions of many possibilities of being. At this level of integration, adults can look at themselves and at other beings in terms of the passing of ages, of near and far in geographical, social, cultural, historical, intellectual and developmental dimensions. They can take multiple points of view and shift focus effortlessly among many states of awareness. They feel embedded in nature - birth, growth and death, joy and pain - are seen as natural occurrences, - patterns of change in the flux of time.

On the other hand, Individuals at the Ironist stage may be perceived as "aloof", as not enough engaged in the goals, pursuits, concerns of common humanity especially from the perspective of Experts and Achievers, even Strategists may feel that way.

What is not evident to these critics is that Ironists often act as catalysts in shaping others' lives. In being what they are without excuses, they challenge others' perspectives, and demonstrate a way of being human that is

different from the evaluative, conventional ideas about what it means to be an adult. They manifest a deeper security about being, than is possible with a rationally generated self-identity.

In contrast to all other stages, Ironists seems to have intense, non-demanding relationships with people regardless of their development, age, gender, or any other identifications. Because they see the dignity in all manifestations of life, they can make others feel worthy and whole.

Ironists have a completely internalized transpersonal or interindividual morality. Inner conflicts and conflicting external demands simply are part of being and need not be resolved or denied, only witnessed. Ironists are no longer driven by desires to be one way or another, to achieve one state or another. Instead they can let go of the unattainable. Concerned with global justice, spontaneity, existence & creativity. Rather than passivity, the non-attached, impersonal stance allows for greater and more direct and powerful action where action is needed.

Ironists can shift focus without effort and behold the whole simultaneously with its constituting variables. They operate within an expanded time frame which includes all of earth's history and its future. Life is seen as a form of temporary and sometimes voluntary separation (Bodhisattva vow) from the creative ground to which it will eventually return. Though the Ironist is aware of him or herself as such a separate and unique embodiment, he or she identifies more and more with all other living beings. The separation of self from others is experienced as an illusion, an invention to safeguard the ego's need for permanence and self-importance and to defend against the fear of its death.

Abstract

The developmental model is a variation of prior ego development frameworks that defines developmental levels in terms of three parameters: object of awareness (concrete, subtle, or metaware), individual versus collective focus, and active/passive orientation. Like prior frameworks, it uses a sentence completion test (SCT) assessment. Prior frameworks rely on exemplar-based scoring that is closely tied into the specific sentence stems. In contrast, the scoring system of this model is based on language properties that do not depend on the sentence stem. Thus, it is the first such assessment to be able to freely incorporate alternative sentence stems without the labor-intensive process of discovering the full range of specific responses. Though the theory and assessment methodology easily allow for using alternative sentence stems, the validity of using alternative stems needs to be shown. This paper reports on internal consistency studies of several "specialty protocols" which are SCT surveys with 6 to 10 of the original 36 stems replaced by stems focused on a particular specialty area. Results show strong reliability scores, via the Cronbach's alpha statistic, for six specialty inventories, on: leadership and organizations, love, education, psychological reflection, climate change, and a children's SCT.

Introduction and Background

Motivations. The developmental model is a variation of prior ego development frameworks that defines developmental levels in terms of three "parameters" (or "drivers"): object of awareness (concrete, subtle, or metaware), individual versus collective focus, and active/passive orientation. It uses a variation of the sentence completion test (SCT) that began with early ego development research and was updated by subsequent researchers. The prior frameworks rely on exemplar-based scoring that is closely tied into the specific sentence stems. In contrast, the scoring system of this model is based on language properties that do not depend on the sentence stem. Thus, it is the first such assessment to be able to freely incorporate alternative sentence stems

without the labor-intensive process of discovering the full range of specific responses. Though the theory and assessment methodology easily allow for using alternative sentence stems, the psychometric validity of each use of alternative stems still needs to be shown. This paper reports on internal consistency studies of several “specialty protocols” which are SCT surveys with 6 to 10 of the original 36 stems that are replaced by stems focused on a particular specialty area. It will also summarize research on the validity of SCTs of varying length, another dimension of survey variability.

Prior Research

Validity of the SCT and the scoring system. The SCT for ego development is a robust assessment instrument. Prior studies conclude that findings of over 350 empirical studies generally support critical assumptions underlying the ego development construct. Previous overviews of the history of research on the SCT cover inter-rater reliability, internal consistency, test-retest reliability, face validity, construct validity, incremental validity, clinical utility, external validity, and predictive validity. A summary of those findings is also included in related literature on the developmental model. This paper is interested in two issues: the primary one being the robustness of the SCT model to variations in sentence stems, and secondarily, its robustness to reducing the number of sentence stems. Next, prior research on these two questions is summarized.

Variations in SCT stems. Historically, within the lineage of ego development research (and several other developmental models), stages of human development have been identified by interviewing or observing samples of people, recording their responses, and organizing these responses into categories. Researchers then sequenced these categories of responses from the earliest to the latest level of maturity. These categories could then be used to identify where a person might fall in their developmental journey through life. This is the method used by other SCT projects and is outlined in prior research on the construction of and validity measures of one new sentence stem, “A good Boss”.

As to variations in the choice of sentence stems (“test items”), several observations can be made. Early researchers adapted the sentence items numerous times before settling on a final version. There is nothing particularly special about the stems used initially. Though they were carefully chosen and vetted; many were drawn from the experience of prior researchers, and the entire set evolved over the years before settling into the current standard form. Others have used alternate forms tailored to men, women, or youth.

Sentence starters can be inadequate for a variety of reasons, e.g., they may be vague and thus understood in very different ways; they may coerce an overly limited developmental range of responses; or they may introduce biases of various types. Thus, new stems must be pilot tested for clarity and psychometric validity. But assuming that this due-diligence work is done to ensure that questions are adequate, overall prior research suggests that the strong psychometric properties of the SCT are robust to changes in the choice of sentence stems. However, the general question of stem flexibility has not been addressed until this study. Rather, specific sets of stems have been tested in the past.

Ego development (meaning-making complexity) is a holistic capacity spanning all life-contexts (though individuals may exhibit maturity different than their “center of gravity” in any given context). The stems are meant to probe across a variety of contexts, and triangulate toward an overall measurement. Prior researchers note that people tend to respond optimally to a task in domains in which they are highly motivated. To tap this motivation, the SCT stems were devised to address ordinary everyday experiences shared across a wide spectrum of people.

The framing of a holistic span of life contexts includes subjective, intersubjective, and objective (I/we/it) contexts. The span of stems is described in a related way: looking at item content, the stems can be classed as first person (My father –, When they talked about sex, I –), third person (Sometimes she wished that –, Usually he felt that sex –), and common noun or impersonal (A good father –, Being with other people –).

Some stems seem to be sensitive to particular transitions along the developmental spectrum, and this is another reason for having an adequate diversity of stems. For example, some stems are related to impulse control which comes online at the second person perspective, and increases gradually or levels off for later levels. Therefore, sentences sensitive to impulse control are also sensitive to the transition from pre-conventional to conventional levels. Abstract and formal thinking begins at the third person perspective, and increases gradually or levels off after that, so it would be expected that certain stems are more sensitive to transitions in this part of the spectrum. In general, it would be expected that, to a weak but statistically significant degree, certain sentence stems are better at signaling changes in specific levels. Prior item response theory analysis shows which stems do in fact load for higher versus lower levels (i.e., “item difficulty”). However, in general, the data indicate that all of the stems are of comparable difficulty, and that every stem elicits responses from across the developmental spectrum, as is intended by the SCT design.

Prior research reports on variations of the assessment that have evolved into other instruments. Researchers modified the original protocol to omit a number of gender-based items and include work and leadership-related stems. One variation is also shorter (24 items) and includes six new stems not in the original assessment. It is reported that the responses to the new stems correlate better with an individual’s overall profile rating than responses to the former stems did, thus improving the overall reliability of the measure.

Additional adjustments were made to stems to derive a General protocol (or “inventory”), the standard set used in research and consulting before branching out into “specialty protocols.” As described below, modifications were to ensure that the stem collection had an equal representation from the “four quadrants” of I/we/it/its as explained later.

Variations in SCT Length. As to the length of the SCT: Prior studies compared the split-half versions of the assessment (18 items each). They conclude these results provide empirical justification for those users of the SCT who have the need for shorter, interchangeable, and reliable forms of the test. Other researchers, experimenting with a 12-item short form, found that inter-rater reliability was at least as good as reported initially; and the internal consistency was quite adequate. Analyses of other data indicate that the short forms are representative samples of the full assessment. It is further stated that the data show that an abbreviated form is a reasonably reliable, feasible, and useful instrument for large-scale research and is a representative sample of the larger instrument, which probably gives substantially the same results. Basic psychometric theory predicts that more evidence will result in better accuracy, so for individually-based assessments, done for coaching or consulting purposes, the full set of items is still recommended, but for research or group-statistical assessments, it would appear that shorter forms are quite valid. New research related to inventory length, analyzed for the current data, is summarized later.

The Matrix

The Matrix is a new model that describes the stages of human perspectives from birth to the latest levels of human development investigated by research. One of the innovations of this model is the use of parameters for describing developmental stages. These are underlying attributes that lead to development. The Matrix shows

the sequence of patterning of the parameters of human consciousness across 12 levels (or 6 person perspectives). These parameters are arrived at by asking 3 fundamental questions.

The General Protocol: Stems and Quadrants

Above was mentioned the notion that the holistic triangulation of contexts needed to measure one’s general “center of gravity” should include subjective, objective, and intersubjective (I/we/it) contexts. This notion has been extended to use a four-quadrant model: I/we/it/its, where the objective domain has been split into individual and collective objects (matching the subjective domain’s split between individual “I” and collective “we”). Thus, the protocols are designed to have a relative balance of stems representing each of the four quadrants. The quadrant categorization of stems is approximate, and is not expected to have a strong influence on the nature of completions – i.e., subjects can respond to any of the stems in ways that emphasize any of the quadrants. (Preliminary research is inconclusive regarding whether stems categorized in a given quadrant tend to elicit responses from that quadrant – more research is needed.)

In a recent revision, 9 of the original stems were changed to new ones to achieve a relative balance among the quadrants. Adjustments were also made because some of the original stems seemed outdated versus 21st-century western cultural norms. Table 1 shows the results. Of the 36 items, there are 8 stems associated with each of the four quadrants, plus 4 stems that are mixed-quadrant.

Table 1. General Inventory: Showing New vs. Prior Sentence Stems

Order	Old Protocol	New General Protocol	Quadrant
1	Raising a family	Raising a family	LL
2	When I am criticized	When I am criticized	UL
3	Change is	Change is	UR
4	A man's job	These days, work	UR
5	Being with other people	Being with other people	LL
6	The thing I like about myself is	The thing I like about myself is	UL
7	My mother and I	My co-workers and I	LL
8	What gets me into trouble is	What gets me into trouble is	UR/UL
9	Education	Education	LR
10	When people are helpless	When people are helpless	LL
11	Women are lucky because	What I like to do best is	UR
12	A good boss	A good boss	UR
13	A girl has a right to	We could make the world a better place if	LR
14	The past	The past	LR
15	When they talked about sex, I	Privacy	UL
16	I feel sorry	I feel sorry	UL
17	When they avoided me	When they avoided me	LL
18	Rules are	Rules	LR
19	Crime and delinquency could be halted if	Crime and delinquency could be halted if	LR
20	Men are lucky because	Business and society	LR
21	I just can't stand people who	I just can't stand people who	UL
22	At times s/he worried about	At times I worry about	UR
23	I am	I am	UL
24	If I had more money	If I had more money	UR
25	My main problem is	My main problem is	UL

Order	Old Protocol	New General Protocol	Quadrant
26	When I get mad	When I get mad	UR/UL
27	People who step out of line at work	People who step out of line	LL, LR
28	A husband has a right to	A partner has the right to	LL
29	If my mother	If my mother	LL
30	If I were in charge	If I were in charge	LR
31	My father	My father	LL
32	If I can't get what I want	If I can't get what I want	UR
33	When I am nervous	When I am nervous	UL
34	For a woman career is	Technology	LR
35	My conscience bothers me if	My conscience bothers me if	UR
36	Sometimes s/he wished that	Sometimes I wished that	UL, UR, LL, LR

Specialty Inventories: Description

As mentioned, the model allows for efficient introduction and experimentation with new sentence starters. A number of “specialty protocols” have been developed. The first six of these, which replace 6 of the General protocol stems with theme-specific stems, have been validated for internal consistency: leadership, love, education, climate change, psychological reflection, and a children’s version of the SCT. Reliability analysis results are in the Results section later.

These specialty inventories were developed separately and at different times. With each specialty inventory, a consultant who specialized in that domain was involved. The consultant helped design 6 stems targeted at that domain, and in deciding which of the 6 General inventory stems should be replaced. Through this process, the goal of having adequate stem representation among the four quadrants was maintained. Sometimes stems were spot-tested on a small number of subjects to check for potential problems (such as common misunderstandings), before the final set was decided upon.

Why create specialty protocols? The person perspectives that people take on these different areas are being tested. For example, what is a first, second, third, fourth, fifth, sixth person perspective on leadership; on love; on education; on climate change? For example, on the Love inventory, researchers were able to categorize the specific ways that people at each person perspective understood the topics of love. In the climate change area, this might be helpful in planning, policy decisions, or communications that are meaningful to various audiences.

Specialty inventories are created for several reasons:

- Quantitatively, they allow a researcher or leader to gauge meaning-making (developmental) levels for a specific theme, for specific populations or sub-populations;

- Qualitatively, they allow for research into the concepts and themes by which individuals understand some domain, e.g., climate change;
- Finally, they allow for the wording of an assessment to appear more familiar or comfortable for given test-taking audiences. For example, if one is assessing employees in an organizational transformation research project, one may want to remove questions about parents or personal relationships which may strike the subjects as too intrusive.

Table 2 shows the new stems designed for each of the six specialty inventories validated below: leadership, love, education, psychological reflection, climate change, and a child inventory which is given orally. In addition, work is currently underway with domain experts to design additional specialty protocols in these areas: relationships, religious beliefs, spirituality, money, hope, dementia, ethics, and parenting.

Table 2. New stems for the specialty inventories.

Inventory	New stem
Leadership	A good organization
Leadership	These days progress means
Leadership	Working with other people
Leadership	We could make organizations better if
Leadership	When developing strategies...
Leadership	These days, a career
Leadership	A good leader
Love	Love changes when
Love	Loving other people
Love	Love
Love	Business, society, and love
Love	When I am in love
Love	My main problem with love is
Education	These days, teaching
Education	My students and I
Education	A good educator
Education	Education and society
Education	Students who step out of line
Education	A teacher has the right to
Climate change	The environment
Climate change	Climate change is
Climate change	Regarding climate change, I
Climate change	My biggest concern about climate change
Climate change	People who deny climate change
Climate change	Actually, climate change...
Psychological	My friends and I

Inventory	New stem
Psychological	A healthy person
Psychological	Sex
Psychological	Psychology and society
Psychological	An intimate partner has the right to
Children's	My family
Children's	Grandparents
Children's	These days, school
Children's	My parents and I
Children's	A good child
Children's	When they didn't let me join in
Children's	Bullying could be stopped if
Children's	Children and parents are lucky when
Children's	Children who step out of line
Children's	A parent has the right to
Children's	A child has the right to

The six validated specialty inventories came about as follows:

- The Leadership/organizational/business inventory was initiated by consultants who work with the developmental model – with the goal of including sufficient stems addressing leadership and organizational issues.
- The Love inventory was pioneered by a specialist whose focus is the area of personal and spiritual manifestations of Love, and who wanted to create a Love inventory.
- The Education inventory was initiated by a college professor who teaches courses on educational theory, sustainability, and developmental theory.
- The Climate Change inventory was initiated by a researcher in the area of Climate Change, who used the new Climate Change inventory in a dissertation study.
- The psychological reflection inventory was initiated by psychotherapists. It removes stems added to the General protocol about work and society, to maintain a focus on psychological/therapeutic themes.
- The children's inventory was co-created by educators and researchers. It is meant to be administered orally to children from preschool age through Junior High, approximately.

Method: Reliability assessment

As mentioned above, unlike prior models, the theory and scoring method allows for easy substitution of new stems. However, for any new protocol, one must establish that the new stems, each and as a whole protocol, maintain psychometric validity. The reliability of the SCT is assessed using the standard Cronbach's Alpha measure of internal consistency. A commonly accepted rule of thumb for describing internal consistency is as follows:

Table 3. Cronbach's Alpha Interpretation.

Cronbach's alpha	Internal consistency
$\alpha \geq 0.9$	Excellent
$0.9 > \alpha \geq 0.8$	Good
$0.8 > \alpha \geq 0.7$	Acceptable
$0.7 > \alpha \geq 0.6$	Questionable
$0.6 > \alpha \geq 0.5$	Poor
$0.5 > \alpha$	Unacceptable

Statisticians determined that a sample of 20 surveys was sufficient to validate the reliability (internal consistency) of any new protocol. Later the reliability metrics for each of six new inventories (protocols) that have been designed and tested will be given. But first, the reliability of the General Protocol, upon which the specialty protocols are based, is reported.

Following inventory design, the specialist recruited 20 or more volunteers to take the assessment. Diversity of backgrounds and demographic characteristics was intended, but not strictly monitored. Surveys were scored by a certified scorer using the standard scoring manual/method. Then statisticians ran the internal consistency statistics on the data set. In all cases, as reported below, the first version of the new inventory was satisfactory – i.e., there were no outlier stems that needed to be re-designed.

In the results for each inventory, the Cronbach's alpha is shown for the inventory as a whole, for the inventory without the new stems, and for only the new stems. Note that Cronbach's alpha values are naturally higher when there are more stems, and values for different numbers of stems are not directly comparable. That is, the internal consistency for 6 stems is always lower, but this does not necessarily mean that the items are worse than the other items. One would have to compare Cronbach's alpha values between the same number of items for a direct comparison.

There are two additional types of psychometric analysis possible with each new inventory. One removes each item in turn, and checks the Cronbach's alpha of the remaining set of 35 stems – repeated for each of 9 new stems. This analysis was decided to be used only when the overall reliability score is low, to check on outlier stems, but it has not been needed thus far. In addition, statistician reports include a Spearman correlation dendrogram that can be used to reveal hierarchical clustering patterns, i.e., similarities or correlations, between stems. These reveal in general that there are no outlier stems, and these analyses have not yet been used for deeper interpretations, so they are not included in this paper.

Results

The General Inventory Table 4 shows results of assessing the internal consistency of the new (now standard in the assessment) General protocol. It was validated versus the prior “old” protocol. 940 surveys based on the old protocol were compared with 351 based on the new protocol.

Table 4. Cronbach’s Alpha for New (General) vs Old protocol.

	Old (N=940)	New (N=351)
All 36 stems	0.98	0.97
Common stems	0.97	0.96
Changed stems	0.91	0.89

In a test of removing each item and checking the Cronbach’s alpha of the remaining set of 35 stems, repeated for each of 9 new stems, the resulting value varied from 0.9688 to 0.9692.

In related research, item response theory is used to assess overall reliability of the test, and look for item outliers. These results reiterate the high reliability scores for the full inventory, and the acceptability of each individual item, as indicated above. (However, the analysis does show that the “I am” stem stands out as being the least correlated with other items.)

Conclusion. The overall internal consistency of both the old and new general protocols as measured by the Cronbach’s alpha statistic was excellent (0.98 and 0.97, respectively). The internal consistency of the changed stems in the new protocol was good and only slightly smaller than the internal consistency of the changed stems in the old protocol ($\alpha = 0.89$ vs. 0.91). Through the method of deleting each new stem one at a time, it is confirmed that each new stem does not effect the overall consistency of the protocol.

Specialty Inventories: Reliability Next, reliability analysis of the six new (“specialty”) inventories is described: leadership, love, education, psychological reflection, climate change, and a children’s inventory. For the children’s inventory, 53 children, age range 4-13 enrolled in a progressive elementary school, gave verbal answers to in-person prompts; recordings of their answers were transcribed. The data is shown in Table 5.

Table 5. Cronbach’s alpha internal consistency values for specialty protocols.

Domain	Leadership	Love	Education	Climate Change	Psych	Children
N in study	32	20	20	32	17	53
New stems (of 36)	6	6	6	6	5	11
α All 36 stems	0.97	0.95	0.95	0.96	0.92	0.88
α General prot. stems only	0.96	0.94	0.94	0.95	0.90	0.85
α New stems only	0.85	0.82	0.83	0.82	0.80	0.63

Conclusions: For the five specialty inventories excluding Children’s:

- the overall internal consistency was excellent (α 0.95 to 0.97).

- the internal consistency for the new stems as a group was good (α 0.80 to 0.85).
- For the Children's inventory:
- the overall internal consistency was good (α 0.88).
- the internal consistency for the new stems as a group was questionable (α 0.63).

Overall, these results not only show evidence about the reliability of the particular specialty inventories, but it also shows evidence that the SCT is quite robust to the addition of new stems, assuming they are well-written. It also gives evidence that even a short test containing only six specialty stems would be a psychometrically reliable instrument.

The Children's protocol is a special case. First, there were almost twice as many new stems as the other specialty inventories. Second, the assessment was done face to face and verbally. Third, the pre-existing (general protocol) stems by themselves show a much lower alpha (though still "good") vs. the other protocols, indicating that there was probably much more variation in the children's responses than in adults'. Thus, though the alpha of the new stems by themselves was unacceptably low, it is not clear whether this was because of the nature of the stems or the nature of the subject population.

Inventory size analysis Above, prior research suggesting that the SCT worked well with shorter versions was summarized. Here, inventory length variation with the assessment particularly is evaluated.

A shorter, 16-stem, inventory. Given the strong results on the reliability of the SCT mentioned above, it was decided to experiment with a shorter inventory containing 16 stems. This gives an inventory that subjects can take in half the time, which is important for some applications.

16 stems were selected from the General inventory which had previously gotten a high Cronbach's alpha. Sentence starters were chosen that would point to each of the four quadrants. The stems were: 1, 2, 5, 6, 8, 18, 19, 20, 21, 23, 25, 27, 28, 30, 34, 35 (from Table 1). The Cronbach's alpha for the 16-item inventory (0.98) is in the "excellent" range.

Cronbach's-Mesbah analysis. Related research includes additional analysis related to test length, which is summarized next. A Cronbachs-Mesbah curve illustrating the Cronbachs-alpha score for successively fewer test stems (with the worst correlated items removed first) shows that for a half-item test the reliability is still excellent (.95); and that even with 10 stems, the SCT has very good reliability (.92); and that even at 5 stems the reliability is quite good (.85).

From a purely statistical perspective, the SCT doesn't need so many items (assuming this pattern was also true of the variations of the SCT – though item-level data for those is not available). However, from a qualitative research agenda, and for coaching and debrief purposes, a full set of 36 responses is important for identifying themes and patterns in the detailed reports and coaching sessions given for individualized SCT assessments. Thus, for the purposes of sharing qualitative information, and not just a final statistical score, the longer inventory is preferable.

Conclusions

Over the past 4 years, experimentation with the efficient and effective adaptability of the SCT Inventory has occurred. Beginning with the alteration of the General Inventory, it was learned that up to 9 stems could be changed all at once in a 36 item inventory, and still have very high internal consistency. This prompted experimentation with other uses of this process and the idea of the specialty inventories was born.

The resultant findings indicate that the model allows for efficient introduction and experimentation with variations on the SCT, including new sentence starters and length variations. Researchers have developed and evaluated “specialty protocols” in these domains: leadership, love, education, climate change, psychological reflection, and a children’s version of the SCT. Most of the specialty protocols replace 6 of the General protocol stems with theme-specific stems. However, generally there is an indication that up to 9 stems can be changed as depicted by research on the new General inventory. Experimentation with variations on this theme is ongoing.

Results for internal consistency studies have been shown for (1) the General Protocol, (2) Six specialty protocols, and (3) a shorter 16-item inventory. It has been shown that for all of these inventories there is excellent internal consistency (excluding the special case of the Children’s study).

The research not only gives evidence about the reliability of the particular specialty inventories, but also shows evidence that the SCT is quite robust to the addition of new stems, assuming they are well-written.

The research also shows that the assessment (and the SCT in general) is psychometrically valid for much shorter inventories, as low as 10 and even 5 items for certain applications.

These statistical results give an underlying confidence that these variations on the regular inventory are internally consistent.

Once this assurance is established, qualitative research is done that allows for extracting meaning from what the test takers actually say. For example, qualitative research has been done on the Love inventory. All the Love stem scores at each developmental level were selected and categories were created out of their responses. The resultant understanding points to the perspectives people take on Love at each developmental level. As well, the evolutionary trajectory on the test takers’ views on love can be seen. The addition of the qualitative research can support curriculum development, policy development, planning, and particular interests of various audiences.

Future Research

Based on the research on adapting the General inventory in length and specialty, there is further research aspired to.

1. Work is currently underway with domain experts to design additional specialty protocols in these areas: relationships, beliefs related to a specific religious tradition, spirituality, money, hope, dementia, ethics, and parenting.
 2. Since it can be seen that there is a variation from 5 to 9 stem changes and still maintain internal consistency, experimentation with variations of these numbers for other specialty inventories will occur.
 3. Since the 5-9 stems isolated from the general inventory still have a “good” internal consistency, looking into using only the specialty stems to indicate the developmental perspectives that people take on the specialty only will be explored. This would involve much shorter inventories for people to take which might bring a research advantage, if there is enough material to do qualitative research.
 4. Once the quantitative research is complete, qualitative research yields more useful and practical day-to-day value for clients. Thus, serious qualitative research on all specialty inventories will continue to perfect the relationship between the quantitative and qualitative interface for the benefits of services to others. As well, how to develop curriculum, planning, policy, and service to each specialty area and the audiences that resonate with them will be looked into.
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On the Construction of a Scoring Manual for a Sentence Completion Test Item

Abstract

The Integral Sentence Completion Test was developed in 1999 as a revision of an earlier measure created in 1970, which was subsequently revised in 1985 and 1996. The instrument measures ego development by providing 36 sentence stems and asking respondents to complete them with whatever comes to mind. Because the test is semi-projective, scoring requires training and familiarity with both the instrument and the concept of ego development.

The original developers created a scoring system with specific rules and manuals containing sample responses for each of the 36 stems. The manual was updated with each significant revision of the test. The current developer is adapting the previous manual to reflect recent changes. The purpose of this project is to provide a scoring manual for the sentence stem “People who step out of line at work—”, which is one of the newly added stems.

The first step involved reviewing the history of ego development theory and its measurement tools. Following the theoretical review, 627 responses provided by the current developer were analyzed and categorized to create the manual. After the manual’s creation, an analysis of the findings was conducted and discussed.

Chapter I: Introduction

The purpose of this project is to provide a scoring manual for the sentence stem “People who step out of line at work—”, which is part of a widely used measure of ego development. This document consists of five chapters. Chapter one provides a history of ego development theory and the measurement instrument. Chapter two offers an overview of the theory, the measure, and a brief primer on constructing and scoring the test. Chapter three highlights the methods used in constructing the manual, and chapter four presents the finished scoring manual. A discussion of discoveries and problems encountered is the topic of chapter five.

History of the Concept of Ego Development

In the late 1800s, when psychoanalysis was emerging, ego development was not considered measurable. Early theorists viewed the ego as derived from and explained by instinctual drives. It was seen as something that simply “was,” rather than something that could develop and change over a lifetime. In the early 1900s, alternative views emerged suggesting the ego was not controlled by instinct, but rather had a drive to develop and could master instincts. Throughout life, the ego could change and grow as it learned to master various instinctive drives.

Later theorists refined these ideas, developing the concept of the “self system.” A major function of this system was to avoid anxiety through “anxiety gating.” It was proposed that individuals selectively ignore things that are not part of their frame of reference. The search for meaning in experiences was seen as the core of ego functioning. The ego develops and maintains stability by selective inattention—ignoring things that do not fit its current state.

A central theoretical issue in ego development is whether it is best characterized as a gradual evolutionary process or as a set of discrete stages with distinct jumps. Influential theorists working with children noticed that they tended to give the same wrong answers to various questions as other children of similar ages, regardless

of background. This led to the theory that children have their own way of making cognitive sense of the world, and that humans develop cognitively in a stepwise fashion through four distinct stages: sensorimotor, preoperational, concrete operational, and formal operational.

Following this revolutionary theory, many proposed similar stepwise developmental patterns for different aspects of human cognitive and psychological functioning, including moral reasoning, character development, interpersonal relatability, cognitive complexity, and interpersonal integration.

The framework developers built upon these ideas, looking at the development of the whole ego rather than separate aspects. The ego is viewed as a holistic construct representing the fundamental structural unity of personality organization. It involves the integrative processes used in dealing with diverse intrapersonal and interpersonal experiences, and the consequent frame of reference subjectively imposed on those experiences to create meaning. It is considered a “master trait” that subsumes other developmental domains such as intellectual conceptualizations, moral development, and interpersonal understanding.

Like previous theorists, the framework developers proposed that humans go through a series of stages. Initial research suggested seven distinct ego levels and four transitional levels. Later collaboration and research on the highest proposed level (the integrated level) revealed that it was actually two distinct stages: Construct Aware and Unitive, leading to the levels used today.

Ego Development Measurement

Early pioneers developed a measure consisting of 36 incomplete sentence stems with instructions to “Please complete the following sentences.” The rationale was that this method allowed people to project their core level of ego functioning into the incomplete sentences. The test was first published in 1970 and revised in 1985 and 1996. In the late 1990s, the test was revised again to create the integral version discussed here.

Development of the Scoring Manual

When the original test was devised in 1970, a scoring manual was also created. This first edition established five scoring rules that became standard procedure for raters. When the test was revised in 1985, a new manual was produced to reflect the changes. When the integral version was created in the late 1990s, a new manual was needed. While there is no official complete manual for the integral version yet, various stems have been studied and categorized, creating a patchwork of individual documents.

Purpose of Research

During the late 1990s revision, new stems were added. In 1978, a researcher investigated adding stems related to the workplace, including “a good boss...” and “people who step out of line at work.” Although data has been collected and these stems are being used, they have not been properly categorized for a manual. The purpose of this project is to create a useable scoring manual for the item “people who step out of line at work” by categorizing provided data.

Chapter II: Literature Review

Early Theoretical Work

The pioneering framework viewed ego development across four domains: character development, cognitive style, interpersonal style, and conscious preoccupations. Character development refers to impulse control and moral judgment. Cognitive style is the level of complexity in cognition. Interpersonal style refers to attitudes

towards others and relationships. Conscious preoccupations refer to the things that dominate thoughts and behaviors (e.g., conformity, responsibility, independence).

Ego development involves the progressive redefinition and reorganization of these four factors. Based on research, seven distinct ego levels and four transitional levels were proposed, each assigned an alphanumeric identifier and a descriptive label. These labels evolved over time:

Evolution of Ego Stage Naming (1978 to 1996)

- I-1 - Presocial Stage -> E-1 - Infancy
- I-1 - Symbiotic Stage -> E-2 - Impulsive
- I-2 - Impulsive -> E-3 - Self Protective
- Δ - Self protective -> E-4 - Conformist
- Δ/3 - Transition from self protective to conformist -> E-5 - Self-Aware
- I-3 - Conformist -> E-6 - Conscientious
- I- $\frac{3}{4}$ - Transition from conformist to conscientious -> E-7 - Individualistic
- I-4 - Conscientious -> E-8 - Autonomous
- I- $\frac{4}{5}$ - Transition from conscientious to autonomous -> E-9 - Integrated
- I-5 - Autonomous
- I-6 - Integrated

Expanded Theoretical Work

Later work expanded the concept of ego development to involve three interrelated components: operative, affective, and cognitive. The operative component looks at life purpose, needs acted upon, and goals. The affective component deals with emotions and the experience of being in the world. The cognitive component addresses how a person thinks about themselves and the world.

Individuals slowly change throughout their lifetimes in all three components. Research into the highest proposed stage (Integrated) revealed it was actually two distinct stages, resulting in nine stages of ego development called “action logics.” These are divided into four broad tiers: preconventional, conventional, postconventional, and transcendent.

First Tier Action Logics (Preconventional)

Characterized by impulsive, reactive, concrete cognition and affect.

- **1 – Infant State:** The self is undifferentiated from the world. Infants learn to construct a stable world of objects and separate themselves. Cognition is pre-verbal. Rarely seen in adulthood except in institutionalized, completely dependent individuals.
- **2 – Impulsive:** The individual sees themselves as separate but hasn’t mastered impulses. Language is simplistic and ego-centric (first-person perspective). The world is black and white (people are nice or mean). Moral development is virtually non-existent; morality is based on whether they get caught. Adults in this stage struggle with life’s complexities.
- **$\frac{2}{3}$ – Self-Protective:** The world is seen in terms of personal needs and wants. A “me against the world” mentality prevails, constantly trying to assert will over others. Adults in this stage tend to be manipulative

and exploitive.

Second Tier Action Logics (Conventional)

Characterized by linear, logical, preventative thinking. Most Western adults operate at this tier.

- **3 – Conformist:** Individuals see themselves as part of a group, basing identity on the group and bound by “oughts” and “shoulds.” They have a fierce desire to be liked and accepted, conforming to group rules. They view outsiders negatively (“us against them” thinking).
- **$\frac{3}{4}$ – Self-conscious:** A transitional stage. The person can step back and look at themselves from a distance, beginning to differentiate from the group, though conformist mentality remains. Cognition is more complex, moving beyond “self” and “other” to a third-person perspective (working with abstract objects/concepts). Characterized by inner conflict between conformity and individuality, often resulting in intellectual aggressiveness and insisting they know the right answers.
- **4 – Conscientious:** People take a longer view, seeing themselves in light of past and future. They are long-term goal-oriented with a deeper sense of responsibility and morality. Thinking is “rational,” and they pride themselves on self-reflection and criticism. They are intellectually curious, believing anything can be answered with enough intellectual rigor. Most Western adults fall into this stage.

Third Tier Action Logics (Postconventional)

Characterized by creative, systems-oriented thinking and a fourth-person perspective (understanding that meaning is determined by perspective and interpretation).

- **$\frac{4}{5}$ – Individualist:** A transitional stage. Self-reflection deepens, and tolerance increases. They understand reality depends on the observer’s position (fourth-person perspective). They view the rational, “everything can be figured out” attitude of the previous stage with disdain, yet feel uncomfortable with their new relativistic outlook.
- **5 – Autonomous:** A systems approach is taken, seeing complexities and interconnectedness. The fourth-person view is fully established. They handle conflicting needs and duties in changing contexts and integrate conflicting polarities within themselves. The central drive is self-actualization, authenticity, and autonomy.
- **$\frac{5}{6}$ – Construct Aware:** A transitional stage moving into a fifth-person view. The function of the ego as a central processing center comes to light. They see through the ego and its lifelong protective patterns, realizing the “self” is a series of constructs. They want to move beyond the ego but still desire to protect it, causing struggle. Less than 2% of Westerners are in this stage.

Transcendent Tier

Characterized by a fifth-person perspective. Individuals see themselves as individuals and as part of a whole. Extremely rare in Western society (less than 1%).

- **6 – Unitive:** The transition to the fifth-person view is complete. They take a “witness view,” observing their ego honestly without needing to protect it. They see themselves as part of all humanity and view people at earlier levels without judgment.

Business Application and Renaming

In the late 1990s, the framework was adapted for the business world to understand how managers and leaders interpret events and act in situations. The stages were relabeled with descriptive terms to reflect their essence and reach a wider audience:

Further Evolution of Ego Stage Naming

- 1 - Infant State -> (Not used)
- 2 - Impulsive -> Impulsive
- $\frac{2}{3}$ - Self-Protective -> Opportunist
- 3 - Conformist -> Diplomat
- $\frac{3}{4}$ - Self-conscious -> Expert
- 4 - Conscientious -> Achiever
- $\frac{4}{5}$ - Individualist -> Individualist
- 5 - Autonomous -> Strategist
- $\frac{5}{6}$ - Construct Aware -> Magician
- 6 - Unitive -> Ironist

Development of the Measurement Instrument

The original test grew out of research on attitudes towards family life. An objective test designed to map personality based on psychoanalytic theories yielded unexpected results, leading to the idea of an Authoritarian Family Ideology (AFI) continuum. Further study revealed that authoritarianism was a mid-point, not an extreme, leading to the conceptualization of traits as a milestone sequence—the birth of ego development theory.

A semi-projective sentence completion test was devised, initially for women, then modified for men. It was later revised to be appropriate for both genders, allowing for abbreviated versions. A form for adolescents was also created. The integral version was later developed to better capture professional subjects in organizational contexts, maintaining original stems and adding new ones.

Development of the Scoring Manual

The first manual was categorized by examining protocols, evaluating the range of responses for each stem, finding common themes, and determining which themes indicated which levels. The manual was divided into sections for each stem, with subsections for each ego level listing categories and example responses.

A five-rule system was devised for rating responses and dealing with “compound responses” (responses with two or more ideas). Compound responses are divided into:

- **Pseudo-compounds – clichés:** Responses adding little meaning (e.g., “treats her husband with love and understanding”).
- **Pseudo-compounds – repetitious:** Responses offering ideas too close in meaning (e.g., “I am sometimes too shy and self-conscious”).
- **True compounds:** Responses presenting true alternative or contrasting views (e.g., “felt uneasy, but joined in, and tried to change the subject”).

The five scoring rules are:

1. Match the completion with one of the listed category titles.
2. Where the combination of elements in a compound response generates a more complex level of conception, rate the response one step higher than the highest element.
3. Where the combination does not generate a higher level of conceptual complexity, rate in the less frequent category or the higher category.
4. For meaningful responses with no appropriate category where Rules 2 and 3 don't apply, use general theory to rate.
5. Omitted or fragmentary responses are rated at the Conformist/Diplomat level.

Validity and Reliability

Studies have shown the instrument is reliable and valid, and the underlying theory is sound. Interrater reliability for personally trained raters was .86, and for self-trained raters ranged from .89 to .92. Test-retest reliability ranged from .44 to .76 for total protocol ratings and .64 to .91 for item sum scores. Split-half reliability ranged from .85 to .90 (no time interval) and .68 (one-week interval). Internal consistency ranged from .80 to .89.

Construct validity studies showed weak correlation with IQ, suggesting ego development is a separate construct. Convergent validity studies found predicted links between ego stages and behaviors (e.g., delinquency and street fighting correlated with earlier stages). Predictive validity studies on specific behaviors (helping, responsibility, conformity) were largely inconclusive.

Other studies found lower mean scores for phone interviews versus written tests, though another study found no significant difference. Research on faking the test showed it is easy to fake an earlier level but extremely difficult to fake a later level; attempts to fake a later level often resulted in lower scores. The theory has been applied to psychiatry, marriage and family, multicultural studies, spirituality, business, and counseling.

Chapter III: Methodology

Labeling System Used

The manual uses a combination of numeric and descriptive labels:

- 2: Impulsive
- $\frac{2}{3}$: Opportunist
- 3: Diplomat
- $\frac{3}{4}$: Expert
- 4: Achiever
- $\frac{4}{5}$: Pluralist (Note: changed from Individualist)
- 5: Strategist
- $\frac{5}{6}$: Magician
- 6: Unitive (Note: changed from Ironist) Level 1 (Infancy) is not used as it never appears in the test.

Participants

Data consisted of 628 completed responses collected over several years from individuals of various ages, socioeconomic levels, and educational backgrounds. 446 responses included item scores, total protocol ratings, weighted scores, and subject IDs. 181 responses came from a preliminary draft manual without demographic data.

Demographic Information (N = 627)

- **Gender:** Female (218), Male (216), Not reported (193)
- **Age:** 18 or below (1), 20's (29), 30's (102), 40's (130), 50's (51), 60 or above (3), Not reported (311)

Item Rating Data (N = 627)

- 2 (Impulsive): 3
- $\frac{2}{3}$ (Opportunist): 21
- 3 (Diplomat): 40
- $\frac{3}{4}$ (Expert): 145
- 4 (Achiever): 224
- $\frac{4}{5}$ (Pluralist): 109
- 5 (Autonomous/Strategist): 48
- $\frac{5}{6}$ (Magician): 36
- 6 (Unitive): 1

Procedure

Organization of Data

The 446 responses were entered into a spreadsheet exactly as they appeared, preserving original spelling, grammar, punctuation, and subject IDs. The 181 draft responses were added later.

Category Creation

Initial analysis revealed four broad themes: cause, solution, effect, and assessment. Responses were assigned to these themes using intuition and grammatical clues (e.g., “cause” used “because”; “solution” used “should”; “effect” used transitive verbs; “assessment” used linking verbs). This was difficult as later-stage responses often blended themes.

Responses were grouped by theme and further divided into categories without looking at item scores to maintain objectivity. After establishing categories, item scores were evaluated. If scores clustered around a rating, the category was assigned to that level. If scores were split, the category was re-evaluated for different shades of meaning (e.g., “should be reprimanded” split into “should be reprimanded” at the Diplomat level and “should be corrected appropriately” at the Expert level).

Uncategorized data was grouped by item score to establish categories at each level. Complex, unique responses at later levels were difficult to categorize. Remaining uncategorized data was evaluated as compound or unique non-compound answers and left “unassigned” at the end of their respective ego levels.

The results were checked against the preliminary draft manual. Similar categories were merged, and discrepancies were evaluated and resolved by either adopting the draft's categories or redistributing data.

Manual Construction

The manual was constructed using three ground rules: (1) rate every response except omissions; (2) stick to the level of meaning; (3) write in simple, intelligible English.

A description of each ego level and expected answers was written. Categories were numbered and named, and authentic example responses from the data set were selected to illustrate the category without redundancy.

Categories were cross-referenced across ego levels to aid raters with difficult responses. Cross-references are noted in parentheses. For example:

- Level $\frac{2}{3}$, category 3: should be punished (3-1; $\frac{3}{4}$ -6; 4-6)
- Level 3, category 1: should be reprimanded ($\frac{2}{3}$ -3; $\frac{3}{4}$ -6; 4-6)
- Level $\frac{3}{4}$, category 6: should be corrected appropriately ($\frac{2}{3}$ -3; 3-1; 4-6)
- Level 4, category 6: should be corrected in a respectful manner ($\frac{2}{3}$ -3; 3-1; $\frac{3}{4}$ -6) Many later-level categories were unique and left without cross-references.

Statistical Analysis

A preliminary statistical analysis was conducted on the distribution of item scores and aspects such as theme, perspective, degree of certainty, and beliefs about truth.

Chapter IV: Results

ITEM 27 People who step out of line at work -

The framework developer noted that this item was created in 1978 to replace family-oriented stems.

The prompt "When a child won't join in group activities" is often viewed as inappropriate or irrelevant by professionals in the business sector. Both this prompt and its replacement test the respondent's attitude toward deviance, control, discipline, and their relationship to rules.

The original prompt regarding a child not joining group activities is considered easier to answer than other prompts in the protocol. The reasoning provided is that it does not make the respondent feel self-conscious and is more structured. Furthermore, the content of the response provides a better clue to the ego level than many other prompts. This makes the prompt easier to rate because its structure suggests broad themes. The themes identified for the original prompt are (a) why the child acts that way, (b) what to do about it, and © the long or short-term results.

A similar situation was found with the replacement prompt, "people who step out of line at work..." This prompt suggests four broad themes, three of which are equivalent to the themes found in the original prompt. The themes are: cause, solution, effect, and assessment. Not all of these themes are present at all levels, and when they appear across multiple levels, they manifest differently. The themes are discussed in detail below.

Themes:

Cause: This theme is observed at all levels except the Diplomat and Unitive stages. At the earliest stages, causes are very concrete and simple (e.g., “have a pain”). In the conventional tier, causes are stated in broad terms (e.g., the employee has problems or the employee is ignorant). At later levels, causes become more complex, and the possibility of multiple causes is contemplated.

Solution: This theme first appears at the Opportunist stage. At this stage, solutions most often focus on punitive measures against the employee (e.g., “should be punished” or “should be dealt with”). Solutions become increasingly complex at later stages. Respondents at later levels recognize that the solution should involve a fair dialogue between the employee and management. At the Pluralist level and beyond, respondents see the possibility that the employee may be pointing to a larger problem within the organization, and therefore, the solution might include global changes to the organization rather than simple negative sanctions against the individual.

Effect: This theme first appears in the Opportunist stage and is seen in every subsequent stage except the Unitive stage. At the earlier levels, the effect is more immediate, concrete, and negative toward the employee (e.g., “get in trouble” or “go to the back of the line”). As the stages progress, effects become more complex, long-term, and potentially beneficial in some way.

Assessment: The theme of assessment appears at all levels. Assessments can be negative or positive, and they can involve an assessment of just the employee or of the entire system. At earlier stages, assessments are simple and black-and-white. They also tend to focus on the employee (e.g., “are bad” or “annoy me”). As the stages progress, assessments become more complex and less black-and-white. At the very latest stages, assessments often involve a component of self-reflection.

Arrangement of Manual

Before presenting the stages and categories, it is necessary to explain the arrangement of this manual. Some data and categories were derived from an earlier draft of the manual for this prompt. In cases where categories from the earlier draft were merged with newly identified categories, the new category name is stated first, followed by the earlier draft's category name in parentheses.

Manual

Stage 2 / Impulsive

The data set of 446 responses did not include responses from the Impulsive level. Below are the categories as listed in the preliminary draft of the manual for this prompt. It was noted about responses at this level: “The impulsive person interprets deviance as a sign of badness or that the person is sick. The complexity of the stem may also be difficult for people at the Impulsive stage to comprehend.”

1. are bad

- aren't very good
- are no good

2. are sick

- have a pain

Stage $\frac{2}{3}$ / Opportunist (Self-protective)

The Opportunist views this situation in terms of punishment and rewards. They view the employee's behavior as deviant and therefore focus on the punishments the employee might receive. Opportunists also exhibit an element of self-protection, which causes some of their answers to be very self-centered (e.g., "annoy me").

1. Bad motives

- are trouble makers
- want to be the boss
- want attention
- hate the work
- are rebels

2. are on some other line (vague)

3. should be punished

- Must be stopped
- should be walked on'
- must be fired

4. get in trouble (ask for trouble)

- Get yelled at
- Might get caught
- never do it again.
- can get caught
- get into trouble
- catch trouble

5. get me into trouble

6. annoy me

- Irritate me

7. are stupid

- are crazy
- are idiots
- are fools

8. Inappropriate affect

- are fun
- show them!
- are a laugh

Stage 3 / Diplomat (Conformist)

Answers at this level focus on the group. The employee is often seen as an outsider because his/her actions do not conform to the rules of the group. Those testing at this level often feel that the employee deserves to be punished for their actions. They also feel that an employee who steps out of line is a detriment rather than an asset to the team.

1. should be reprimanded

- Must be disciplined
- should be disciplined
- should be chastised
- should be set right

2. need help (unelaborated)

3. suffer immediate and concrete consequences

- Must go to the back of the line and start all over again!??!
- Will have to wait longer for their lunch
- get what they deserve
- need to start over
- often lose their job

4. cause problems for the group (upset things)

- Are destructive
- Are not around enough
- Bring the company a bad name
- hurt the team
- make life difficult for everyone else
- often upset the whole department

5. Don't fit in/are unpopular (combination of 'are unpopular,' 'are the young ones,' 'are annoying,' and 'don't belong here')

- nobody likes
- don't get invited to the party (concrete event)
- are new
- are foreigners
- are a nuisance
- are annoying

6. are rare

- are rare
- are few and far between
- does not happen often here

Unassigned Non-Compounds

- Find something else to do
- Are often punished
- Should be reminded
- Should receive a big wet kiss on the forehead assuming that's not what they were looking for in the first place
- Really have to work at it because of our culture
- Ought to step back in line

Stage $\frac{3}{4}$ / Specialist – Expert (Self-aware)

At this stage, many answers are still group-focused but show a tentativeness that is not seen at earlier levels. The use of qualifiers such as “may,” “usually,” or “often” begins to appear. There is also an inkling of sympathy toward the employee. The employee may have a good reason for his/her behavior, or the employee should be talked to or counseled rather than just punished. Also at this level, respondents begin to see the possibility of several different outcomes (e.g., the employee may or may not be punished).

1. has problems (may have a problem)

- tend to be discouraged
- Doesn't separate business and personal issues
- often have non-work issues.
- may have something bothering them
- are unhappy with a co-worker
- are not properly motivated
- have a difficult time
- may be lonely
- may not be up to it

2. usually have a reason (may have a point/reason)

- usually have a reason
- usually have a reason for doing so.
- usually do so for a reason
- Do so for a reason
- may have a reason

3. usually have a good reason

- may have a good reason to do so.
- May well have a good reason for their action.
- May very well have a good reason.
- will usually have a really good reason for doing so.

- may have a good reason for doing so.
- Are usually doing it for a good reason
- may be doing so for good reason.
- usually have a good reason

4. should be handled/dealt with

- Have to be handled individually.
- need careful handling.
- need to be dealt with by management
- Should be dealt with by the boss
- should be dealt with

5. should be given more than one chance

- should be given a second chance
- Should be warned and disciplined if they continue.
- should be given 3 chances
- should be given fair warning

6. should be corrected appropriately

- should be reprimanding [sic] and “punished” accordingly.
- Need to be disciplined appropriately
- should be reprimanded in a rational manner.
- need to be confronted
- have a meeting with the supervisor of co-worker alone and after the incident and discuss the issue and the cause and what can be done to prevent the issue from continuing whether it be up to or outside the control of that person.
- should reap the natural consequences of their actions.
- should be confronted
- should be straightened out
- should be reined back in
- ought to be appropriately reprimanded

7. should be informed

- need to be immediately told
- Have to be told.
- should be pulled aside and spoken to.
- Should be spoken to.
- should be made aware of their actions.
- need to be told so and the matter discussed.
- Need to have a talk with a supervisor

- should be addressed
- should be told that they have done so
- need to be told of the consequences
- should be told so

8. should be reminded of the rules

- need to be reminded of our code of conduct.
- should be reminded of the rules.
- should be told of the proper rules

9. should be held accountable

- should be held accountable

10. need counseling/special attention

- need counseling
- Should be counseled
- should be counseled immediately
- need counseling + guidance a few times.
- need to be counseled.
- may need professional help
- need co-workers who can set boundaries.

11. need to be heard/understood

- need to be understood so you can find out what is bothering them.
- probably need listening to.
- probably need to be heard.
- need to be listened to and understood.
- need understanding

12. should be asked why

- should be spoken to to understand why they behave that way
- need to be talked to, to find out whats [sic] going on.
- Should be asked why, not [sic]
- should be asked why.

13. are usually reprimanded

- usually receive negative sanctions
- generally get told off
- will be taken care of one way or another.
- get slammed unmercifully.
- are quickly put back in their place

- are usually corrected
- are sometimes reprimanded
- can be punished

14. suffer consequences

- will receive less rewards.
- are generally not promoted
- do not get bonuses
- don't get much support
- become unpopular in the team
- are not selected for foreman

15. usually get off easy

- Can usually get away with it indefinitely!
- aren't usually held accountable.
- are usually given several chances.
- are rarely dealt with.
- sometime get away with it
- are sometimes promoted anyway
- are tolerated and even promoted
- are often left alone

16. bring consequences on themselves

- bring consequences upon them.
- will usually have it come back to them ten times more.
- eventually hurt themselves.
- are hurting themselves.

17. affect others (concern with influence on others)

- disrupt the work flow and often cause additional work for others
- affect everyone
- often waste the time of those who are trying to do their job.
- make others' jobs more difficult
- are letting the team down.
- should not be allowed to bring the whole workforce down
- make it difficult for others to follow the rules

18. might be right/justified

- may be justified in what they are doing.
- Might well be right

- are sometimes right
- could be on to something

19. feel justified

- usually think that the company is not treating them fairly.
- feel that the rules don't apply to them.

20. do so out of ignorance

- Probably didn't know the line existed.
- May not have been told where the lines are
- have misunderstood something

21. can be useful

- Are useful to have if they contribute something valuable.
- can be useful.

22. better know what they are doing

- better have a damn good reason for doing it.
- best know what they are doing.

23. simple negative judgment

- aren't being fair.
- frustrate me

24. simple positive judgment (are interesting)

- aren't all bad.
- make a difference
- more power to them
- make me wonder about things
- keep every one on their toes

25. Simple dichotomies (black and white, either/or)

- are promoted or fired
- can be fun or awkward

26. What do you mean?

Unassigned Compounds:

- are rare in my department, but I make sure the action is addressed immediately
- usually do not know where the lines are so I help them by working with them.
- are definitely OK, but we should find out why.
- at not get a slap on their wrist + are told to get back in line. Mostly everyone just talks about them.
- need to be told directly, not just gossiped about.

- sometimes have good reasons others will need a firm word to insure their actions will not be repeated.
- should not always be punished right away but they should not repeat the same offense.
- need to be reprimanded and the situation needs to be addressed honestly, or it will reoccur and get worse.
- imitate me. They know what they are doing, and in cases are just trying it out.

Unassigned Non-Compounds:

- Should be tackled about the issues.
- do so without concern about implications of consequences.
- Are generally trying to improve things.
- May see the lines differently.
- may need to.
- often do so because they are trying to be heard
- should step in if the situation warrants it.
- should understand that they have done so + understand the implications of their action.
- they, along with other people, should decide whether their behavior or the line itself needs to change.
- are inevitable but few and far between
- should never have been required to be in that line in the first place.
- were obviously in the wrong queue.
- have to deal with it themselves.
- I tolerate, then say something about it.
- the squeaky wheel gets the grease
- are asked to explain themselves
- need immediate feedback

Stage 4 / Achiever (Conscientious)

Responses at this level are more analytical than at earlier levels. Respondents begin to question the motivations and causes for the “out of line” behavior of the employee. Solutions become more elaborate and begin to take into account the rights of the employee. At this level, many responses encourage a gentler approach to reprimands that will benefit both the managers and the employee. There is also a beginning recognition of the role that the passage of time plays in all situations in life. The behavior of the employee, the causes of that behavior, and the solution to that behavior are looked at over time rather than at one point in time (e.g., pattern vs. one-time event). Views of the employee also begin to change at this level. Some responses view the behavior of the employee as potentially good, brave, or forward-looking.

1. may have various reasons

- could be doing for many reasons.
- may have reasons for doing so.
- it's probably a lot of things that caused the issue.
- do it for a whole variety of reasons.

- will do so for a multitude of reasons.
- do so for a number of (good) reasons
- the reasons for their behavior have many causes

2. specific reason

- probably have their own agenda
- are for whatever reason not as (coerced)/(motivated) to stay “in line” as those who do
- are usually trying to make a point.
- are often doing so to rebel against unduly restrictive rules and regulations of their employers.
- usually are testing (trying) the limits.

3. may have a deeper psychological/developmental issue

- are probably have difficulty accepting some event/occurrence.
- often are troubled some other are of their life.
- are distressed and need to discharge feelings to get beyond
- are generally people who have a propensity to step out of line at school, at home and just about anywhere.
- often have poor people skills.
- may have deeper problems or issues that need to be worked out.
- Usually have personal problems as well
- are fighting something within themselves.
- Are typically having other problems in their lives.
- usually have some problem with may not be immediately apparent
- may feel shut in by over-restrictive rules
- are usually insecure and it's their way of expression themselves
- may be anxious or emotionally upset about something

4. go through a temporary phase

- may go through a phase
- may learn to deal with dissatisfaction and boredom in more constructive ways
- often come around in their own good time to seeing a better solution
- do so as part of their learning and development

5. may respond to the faults in the set up

- are probably expressing that there is something wrong with the set up
- usually do so because of the uselessness or boringness of work

6. should be corrected in a respectful manner

- Should be first praised for their good qualities at work and their problem solve with them to bring them back in line.

- need to be taken aside to discuss what they have done in a positive and caring manner in order to get the message through about at the same time they do not feel bad about whatever they may have done.
- deserve to be recognized for their unconventional behaviour and developed to take risks responsibly.
- are to be noticed, encouraged but checked if they go too far.
- should be made aware of this in a discrete manner
- should be spoken to nicely but firmly
- should be told in a diplomatic way that their behavior is unacceptable
- should be approached with respect and firmness
- should be treated first with understanding, then admonished and held accountable
- should be gradually and firmly brought back
- should be gently reminded of their responsibility towards their work mates

7. should be given the benefit of the doubt

- Should be given the benefit of the doubt; everyone makes mistakes or poor judgments
- need to be corrected, but given the benefit of the doubt, and allowed to make appropriate correcting.
- are given many chances to correct their behavior and become successful with our company.

8. should be allowed to discuss their side

- Need to be pulled aside privately, addressed in a matter-of-fact way about the incident, offered some solutions, given a chance to explain and then should commit to "watching their steps."
- and are disobedient, rebellious, bloodyminded, and obstreperous usually have some sort of grievance which needs sorting out and you need to give them an opportunity to open up and discuss their [?]
- should be confronted about their behavior, but should be given the opportunity to explain their actions.
- should be talked too [sic] to find out why and if there is something to be learned from either side
- should be given a chance to explain their actions
- can talk to me and we can assess if we can work together in transforming our organisation.
- should have their point of view respected
- ought to be able to explain why
- deserve to be heard
- need to be listened to for their reasons

9. need help, counseling, feedback, coaching (more elaborate)

- Need help, for the comfort of themselves and others
- perhaps need careful understanding and help
- they are lucky if they have a mentor or colleague who can help them adjust
- it is good to have people on staff who are specialized in helping them
- need to be worked with to help identify what the behavior was and why it was inappropriate
- may need careful counseling to find out what is bothering them
- should be counseled as to how better to express their dissention while still being respectful of others.

- need feedback on “what the line” means, why it’s there and [] as to what they can do about it.
- need feedback to get back on track. If the problem is chronic, then they should be separated / moved.
- should be coached about appropriate behavior
- should be coached, advised be given a chance to restore themselves, rather than be castigated, disciplined or punished
- may need a coach to work on their issues
- good coaching can do a great deal to help them improve

10. pattern vs one time event

- frequency and degree is a consideration.
- Should be encouraged not to do so by discussions with them. However, if they continue to do so their influence should be restricted or they should be dismissed.
- should be coned and if it doesn’t work then they should be dealt with is stronger methods.
- should be told that they have done so, initially in an advisory manner but if repeated in a more formal and forceful way
- can be forgiven for a “one-off” occurrence but must be disciplined if their behaviour is excessive.
- should be given a very stern warning and dismissed if they do not begin to conform.
- are spoken to privately at first, and then reported if it’s serious.
- must be punished accordingly, but only if it is common practice and not a onceonly misstep
- should not be told off the first time, but if it happens regularly, this should be dealt with
- should be reprimanded. If constantly out of line other options exist.
- if not constant, some flexibility on the side of the manger is useful

11. should be listened to/understood

- should be listened to before judging them.
- need to be understood and dealt with accordingly, with firmness and compassion.
- shall have an opportunity to be listened to about what’s bothering them.
- should be listened to
- should be listened to so we understand why they did what they did.
- may need listening to and may need challenging
- should be listened to before any reaction occurs.
- should be listened to and taken seriously

12. should be evaluated/investigated

- should be evaluated on their explanations as to why they stepped of line as it may or may not be justified
- should be “investigated” to see why, if they are really out of line, then helped to understand the difficulty.
- should not necessarily be punished. The source for their action should be determined and investigated in order to resolve the problems upon which their behavior is based.

- the root cause of their behavior should be carefully investigated
- should have their reasons for doing so investigated

13. several possible solutions

- should be sacked, ignored or promoted
- have a greater chance these days of retribution. If serious enough, transgression will trigger formal procedures, starting with counseling + warnings. Alcohol during office hours is frowned upon more and more.

14. should be spoken to (more elaborate)

- need to be told what the expectations are of them and what the consequences will be but they are usually not.
- should have the opportunity of being told is expected of them and the consequences of what will happen if the expectations are not met.
- should have guidelines and expectations restated to them in order for the person(s) to understand the consequences if they step out of line again.
- should be spoken with to understand if their alignments are in congruence to the organization
- should be told so they can understand and work with the consequences.
- know it, but are counselled in a private, supportive “opportunity to grow” way
- should promptly be brought in for discussion of the situation, allowed to participate in the solution and held accountable for their future behavior.
- should be told what they are doing wrong immediately in order for them to know where the boundaries are and/or them to improve. Depending on the severity, appropriate action may be needed.

15. responsibility for success/change placed on employee

- should be aware of how far they can step.
- are rarely noticed by me because people should sit their own boundaries and values.
- need the style to carry it through.
- need to readdress what their goals are in relationship to the job as a whole
- should realize the potential outcome(s) and work for change instead
- need to be aware of what they are getting themselves into.
- ought to be aware of their privilege to work

16. need to be told how they affect the organization

- need to be steered in the right direction and shown the effect their behavior has on everyone surrounding them.
- need to be shown how their actions have a negative impact throughout the entire organization. This way they can move towards being more productive team players.
- need to be told clearly and honestly how their action affects their position
- should be informed of how it effects other people's and their effectiveness.[sic]
- need to know how their actions affect others and why it is “out of line”.

- need to understand the effect it has on the group
- need to understand the consequences of their actions on others.
- should be made aware of the impact their actions have on the people around them.
- should be made to understand that it is unfair to others
- should be checked because someone else may suffer for it
- should be reprimanded as it causes dissent in the group if someone does as they please

17. suffer various consequences

- often end up regretting it
- usually end up losing effectiveness if they have been crude or offensive.
- inevitably provoke some consequence sooner or later, but this is not always a bad thing.
- do not often benefit from their actions
- usually regret it
- will probably cause more trouble for themselves than they intended
- must accept the consequences

18. are judged by others

- Are unacceptable and not understood by others who pass judgment on them
- are annoyances to the people they work for + should be prepared to seek alternative employment.
- annoy me if they are not pulling their weight
- are perceived as trouble makers and watched more carefully

19. either or

- are either very smart or very dumb
- often show their immaturity or they're pointing to something that is distressing them among other things.
- are taking risks they believe are appropriate or just acting out; who can tell?
- are counselled or reprimanded.
- Are one of two things: 1. Troublemakers who won't follow the rules; 2. Standing up for themselves.
- if right should be supported, if wrong may need further questioning
- are either rebellious or may have a valid reason for doing so

20. have something to say

- have an important story to tell.
- May have something valuable to say
- may have more to say than their actions indicate.
- Probably have something interesting to say.
- may be saying ????????

21. can be an asset to the organization

- often ask the question "why" and that's good for others and for the organization.

- can sometimes have something different and useful to contribute.
- are just starting new lines
- are no longer in line and may be offering a valuable perspective
- are an important part of the mix.
- may be very valuable and it would be worthwhile to find out why they do it
- may be the ones who will take the business forward.

22. misc. positive assessment (beginning recognition of individuality as positive)

- can be the most creative people, if managed well.
- May be innovators
- are probably the most interesting.
- are probably creative
- often deserve credit
- aren't necessarily wrong
- are brave
- get things done
- should be praised!
- Are perhaps being creative.
- probably have something more important to do.
- are usually more worthwhile than people who don't
- are often brave and to be admired
- may aid progress
- how some backbone
- are individuals
- are creative

23. are unaware

- may be in the wrong line who will help them to know?
- often do so without realizing they have gone too far. And can soon be guided back if it is important
- may not be aware of the lines.
- do not realize that they are out of line. Usually, there is no line.

24. are unfair, selfish, uncommitted

- are unfair to their co-workers
- are not being fair to the rest of the team
- do not take into consideration the needs of others
- tend to only see their own situation
- should show more solidarity and commitment

- need more purpose and show loyalty to the company

25. **Are not always punished**

- sometimes get away with it.
- are not always reprimanded or held accountable
- are often not dealt with in a timely fashion
- may not be questioned till the damage is done

26. **individual commentary**

- Don't bother me at all if they step out of line with me I can usually jolly people along.
- initially frustrate me, often though I am able to ask the questions "Why did that happen? What was behind their behavior?"
- may make me irritated, but I also understand what it means to feel bound by constraints and stupid rules
- make me see why I am careful about my behavior.
- help us understand how others see and respond to our actions

Unassigned Compounds

- may genuinely not be aware of how their actions or words are affecting other people and need to be confronted in a calm and positive manner.
- Should be encouraged to understand the impact of their behavior on others – and if they persist they should be disciplined
- Do so for a good reason which should be understood before reacting to in any way.
- have a reason for doing it, w
- often believe they have valid reasons to step out of line. They should be listened to however, boundaries must be set + communicated and consequences must be made known of behavior ignorance
- need to be understood. This type of behavior is usually caused by a misunderstanding of a given situation
- need to be understood, because they may be right!
- must have a good reason. We should listen to such people there aren't many of them.
- need to be understood. They usually have a reason, and sometimes it is important and changes the situation.
- have reasons for their actions that should be heard and accepted before action is taken.
- are the risk-takers and need to be recognized and valued they may help the organization move forward.
- Are in the minority and in my experience are demonstrating the view to try something different.
- should be given an opportunity to air their issues and then be given coaching as needed to help them get back in line. If nothing works, they should suffer the consequences of their behaviors.
- must first work hard to discover the line, but if they do manage to find it + cross it then it is bad news
- are at risk of being slapped down if it's out of order and need a [?]/understanding as to why they do step out of line.

- probably have a reason and efforts should be made to get to the root problem / issue.
- drive me crazy! There's ways of doing things & getting you point across without unprofessional
- can be useful to improve understanding if they make mistakes they deserve another chance but if they deliberately break rules they have to go.
- must first work hard to discover the line, but if they do manage to find it + cross it then it is bad news (R3)

Unassigned Non-Compounds

- do not consider the big picture impact of what will happen if they do something or behave a certain way.
- need to be confronted and redirected.
- do so at times because they are not heard any other way.
- should first be explained as to why.
- Are taking risks.
- make a manager's job interesting.
- Are best characterized in a variety of comic strips
- only do so if they abuse the trust of confidence, of colleagues or fail to respect them as individuals.
- take risks
- may not be given the opportunity to move to jobs that are a better fit
- should be asked to step back in again and try and behave fairly in the future

Stage $\frac{4}{5}$ / Pluralist (Individualistic)

The analytical answers that began at the previous level become more elaborate here. Not only are causes for the employee's behavior considered, but the Pluralist sees the possibility that there may be many complex causes for the behavior and that the employee's own psychology may play a large role in that causation. Solutions at this level become more elaborate and more cautious. Many Pluralists who suggest a solution do so by stating that it is important to fully analyze all aspects of the situation before taking action. They also emphasize the importance of getting the employee's viewpoint before going forward with a plan.

At this level, the possible merits of the employee's behavior are also recognized. A Pluralist sees an "out of line" employee as a possible agent of change or a chance for the organization to learn something new.

1. May have complex motives

- Are bothered by something, rationally or irrationally
- are often seeking attention because they feel unappreciated or slighted in some way, or they could have low impulse control
- Can be acting out of their own issues, the issues of the workplace, or both.
- are not necessarily reluctant to the rules. They may express some demotivation.
- often have a reason for doing so, which, if uncovered, can lead to insight
- are usually reacting to personal stuff that got triggered by the work situation.
- may do so for many different reasons, some positive, some negative

2. three or more plausible reasons

- may do so because they are incompetent, or, on the contrary, too much qualified, or merely because they are in a wrong mood this day.
- may be making a mistake, changing their commitment at work, or are concerned with a problem or breakdown in some other domain which has overcome their capacity to maintain their behavioral commitment at work.
- sometimes do so for legitimate reasons and do so productively to work toward changing a system
- may be extremely creative, may not have the maturity to accept or even understand the social paradigm at work, and then there are those for whom “stepping out of line” is not relevant.
- can be acting out of their own issues, the issues at work, or other reasons

3. fair dialog encouraged - both sides get their say

- need careful and directive management so their behavior can be better utilized for themselves and the organization, but it ain't easy.
- should be approached and questioned about what their reasons may be – assumptions should not be made.
- what line? We need to work together to establish what we are up to and what standards we agree to.
- are redirected or challenged to justify and explain their divergence from the group and how it might affect us all positively
- should be talked to in order to understand their motivation. It's not necessarily bad.
- should have an opportunity for dialogue w/ their supervisors, to understand the real issues/motives and to work towards resolution.
- need to tell me what they think the line is and why and then listen to my reaction.
- need talking to and dealing with unless they have a valuable perspective that should be listened to.

4. solution depends on the situation

- I talk with to find out the situation. If for some reason discipline is needed, it is given. If not, I ask if they have learned from the experience and go on.
- (?) I don't mean to fence-sit, but it really depends on the situation. If they are endangering the safety of themselves or others, then obviously this cannot be allowed.
- unless it is for a good reason or to make a creative contribution, are a problem to be managed, hopefully, for their and the organization's benefit. Otherwise goodbye.
- should be given praise or criticism depending on different situations.
- deserve to be asked to step back in if they are willing to share their insights, if not, it depends on the severity of their dissidence

5. full analysis necessary before taking action

- need to be examined individually to see both what the stepping out of lines to them and also what it means for the organization; appropriate action can follow such an analysis.
- do so for a reason conscious or otherwise which must be understood before a genuine solution can be found.

- are usually considered as “problem employees” BUT what’s important is to understand what the circumstances were that caused them to step out of line before a label is put on them
- generally know whether they are being constructive or destructive; either way I like to explore their motives.

6. solution should bring out the best in the employee

- need counseling immediate, private and oriented toward performance outcomes rather than toward behaviors
- can often become valuable team members if given the necessary attention and guidance.
- Are very often the ones who are more likely to succeed and should be carefully trained and encouraged.
- Should be positively challenged so it doesn’t damage their self-esteem. And encouraged to take responsibility for learning from the experience

7. complex/specific consequences

- Will usually face the consequences of their actions they will hear from those who feel compelled to offer an opinion about them.
- Are often trodden on despite / because of (?) sometimes having valuable insights into the issue
- usually get negatively labeled if they do not return quickly to their “normal” predictable behavior.
- usually are very quickly brought back into line by either their peers, subordinates or superiors.
- don’t always understand that you reap what you sew. If you cut corners or talk badly about people behind their back >it will eventually be exposed.

8. offer new perspective/move the org forward

- can sometimes be on to something, depending on what their point is; lines are linear after all!
- might actually have something to offer that would “forward the action.”
- sometimes lead the way.
- are probably breaking new ground. This can be a good thing!
- are part of the whole and are probably expressing some aspect of the overall situation which has not been given attention.
- are to be regarded with great curiosity what is it that we can learn from them?
- present an opportunity to discover new lines of thought and new things about myself
- provide insights and perspective that benefit the culture.
- give management its greatest opportunity to move forward.

9. may be offering constructive criticism

- often have something to say, often can represent a problem that affects many but others won’t discuss.
- are helpful if they contribute constructive criticism about work and how it is done.

10. are change agents (positive regard for individuality)

- Might deserve praise if they are bucking the status quo in order to bring about needed change.
- are necessary within degrees to ensure that we do not become a ‘clone’ factory.
- make life uncomfortable, but are sometimes good catalysts for change

- providing it is done in a constructive way, should be applauded - stepping out of line implies challenging the system. If organizations do not evolve, they will dissolve.
- may need control, but need to be listened to because they may be positive agents for change.
- are often those with a real grasp of what needs to be done. And ? who aren't who seek to destroy rather than contribute should be sacked.
- may play a vital role in creating a adaptive company
- are very often creative and feel the need to express this
- should not be censured for they may be generating new ideas
- may well be frustrated innovators
- should be respected because they have the courage to follow their own drummer

11. either/or – specific and elaborate

- Are not looking at the big picture, or are, and want to change things.
- Are either courageous, imaginative risk-takers or fools
- Are probably very courageous or very stupid unless they have a very good reason
- Are heroes or villains depending on the circumstances.
- can be great if creative, but annoying if lazy, truculent or selfish
- may be either constructive or destructive ... creative or trouble ... it all depends.
- may well be justified in voicing things we need to attend to, or may be self-serving.
- are usually a nuisance but just sometimes are ground-breakers.
- can be total pains or bright sparks it depends.
- are probably showing initiative but some are just blowers.
- can be total pains or bright sparks – it depends on their motives and expression

12. are non-conformists/system is too rigid

- Most likely have some other – perhaps more interesting – idea about what they really should be doing.
- are often taking risks which are usually for reasons of principle and challenge the system
- are probably doing many of the right things, but the “system” is rarely flexible enough to accommodate them.
- maybe have something to their inability or unwillingness to conform
- May have realized that the line is not going where they want it to.

13. recognition of multiple perspectives

- Do so for all sorts of reasons, some of which may be valid and some of which will have no validity from my perspective.
- are not thinking in a line-oriented way. But their managers may be “in-line” thinkers. And that causes problems for both parties.
- is a phrase that irritates me, it usually heralds a period if getting one party to see another's point of view.
- will usually behave rationally from their perspective.

14. questioning the question

- not an easy one to answer. The question assumes too much & explaining how my work situation is on this scale would take too long. Other answers often intentional, sometimes not.
- have reasons + should be listened to; I don't know that there is any "line."
- it depends on what "step out of line" means.

15. positive assessment (more elaborate)

- Are sometimes people with the most creativity and self-awareness.
- are often more interesting than those who don't.
- are sometimes delightful to be with.
- are probably more creative and courageous than those who stay in line.
- Sometimes surprise me with their courage [sic] and creativity

16. Individualized nuanced response

- No longer exist because it's just me and my husband, and we are peers so there's no line to step out of; if a client breaks an agreement with me I'll ask him why and find out if there's something wrong, or if I feel he is acting outside the spirit of what we are doing together I'll explore it privately with him and find out what's wrong; if it means we are no longer creating together in a way that supports our mutual well-being and neither of us or anyone who helps us can see a way to correct it I'll end the contract
- irritate me and I take that irritation as a challenge to my capacity to remain open

17. Caution against conventional interpretation

- are generally regarded as trying to get attention, which may not be so
- are not necessarily non-conformist or out to cause trouble

Unassigned Compounds:

- are often the most creative ones. If they're productive and successful enough, they can get away with it.
- Are frustrating but usually reacting to "systems" pressures from the world around them.
- are non conformist to the rule and regulations which frustrates those that maintain the status quo.
- usually do so for a reason. I think it's important to check out how they are feeling about their work and what precipitated the problem + it's important to set limits, but also important to understand why a limit is not observed.
- should have the opportunity to talk with their supervisor about the situation and, depending upon the circumstances, should be given another chance, reprimanded, or in rare instances, fired; however, in my role as supervisor I tend to give people the benefit of the doubt, probably beyond what is justified, before I reprimand.
- may have good reason depending on the situation and each instance should be treated separately to determine if warranted and what if any sanctions should be imposed.
- should be asked to justify the breach, and, failing some just cause or good reason for the "misconduct" which may justify it, should be dealt with to correct the problem or eradicate [sic] it if it's a one time occurrence they may not be a problem, but ongoing misconduct cannot be allowed to go unchecked.
- need more time and understanding, careful handling, and can be good feedback agents.

- may speak for others, who are perhaps less courageous. They are a “pain in the asse” (!), they disturb the status quo, and are potentially ejected from the system. How interesting, that their replacement often also “steps out of line at work”?
- May have a good reason to do so. I try to find out why. Maybe they have a good reason that could ultimately lead to better approach.
- may be right to do so, there is no reason to assume the line is drawn in the right place.
- are acting out their unhappiness in other areas of life too; the effects of their actions are deeper than I can see and more far reaching than I can ever know or understand.
- are often using that situation to act out inner psychological issues which may or may not be related to the workplace; either way inquiry and trust rather than punishment may help transform the behavior.

Unassigned Non-Compounds:

- may be brave, stupid, (born) and probably I admire them.
- irritate me and I take that irritation as a challenge to my capacity to remain open.
- Have to balance their needs for self-expression with the risks to their job and career.
- usually deserve recognition for offering up some discretionary potential
- are taking a risk and should be respected for it so long as they are fully aware of their objectives to do so.
- may vry [sic]well do so if the result is good/creative
- it is important for the organization to be able to accept a reasonable amount of diversity.
- may well be justified in voicing things we all need to attend to, or may be selfserving

Stage 5 / Strategist (Autonomous)

Responses at this level are beginning to recognize the complexity of people and situations. They realize that things are rarely as simple as they look on the outside. Answers at this level speak of the far-reaching causes and effects of current situations. The Autonomous person is also beginning to see that the line is something that can be played with and changed to better meet the needs of the organization.

1. complex causes at various levels (alternative constructions, reasons and feelings)

- are either instigating trouble, very bored, or trying to do something to “make a difference.”
- are often demonstrating that something is wrong in their work situation, personal life, interpersonal relations or that their goals and values about work are different than other people’s.
- may be acting from a variety of motivations, some due to unresolved issues of their own, others due to genuine inadequacies in the work environment.
- usually do so for their won very good reasons: they may or may not be valid, obvious or susceptible to something .
- may have very different reasons: inability to cope, intentional reframing, temporary problems, etc.
- may be doing so as the only was to draw attention to a concern either with themselves or the system the find themselves in.
- may be experiencing incongruity between their value systems and their workplace “reality” and struggling to find a more acceptable balance

- may be signaling a real problem with the structure of their jobs or even the organization as a whole; or they may simply be a disciplinary problem

2. are valuable to any learning or forward looking organization)

- should be handled as valuable contributors to the organization, their motivation should be determined perhaps they have value to contribute through the instance though they have not previously been provided that opportunity.
- Maybe signaling a problem with the organizational system interpersonal or personal problems or a combination of all these.
- should be celebrated! They are the precious rebels every organization needs to illuminate underlying problems and opportunities for change.
- Can cause considerable inconvenience or even disruption, but they can often initiate a valuable questioning of the values, priorities, and procedures
- provide a creative tension which if honored can bring enormous benefit to the organization
- need to be encouraged and motivated to do so such that the output can be harnessed into a creative and positive force.
- may carry the sign of a forthcoming change in the way the organization functions.
- should be prized because they are the ones who show us what we take for granted

3. complex outcomes

- at the [medical center], when it occurs, leadership steps in and tries to help the person see where they violated their performance agreement and the problem is renegotiated on a win win basis so it, hopefully, will not happen again.
- Are allowed to do so for a time – until I am clear whether this is a creative & inspiring act or a selfish demand.
- are subject to a range of responses ranging from tolerated/ignored to being dealt with with extreme prejudice! HP has fewer guidelines/models for dealing with this than for rewarding/praise we can be too nice and occasionally too criminal.
- Something needs to be adjusted, and the decision of what gets adjusted must be approached with an open mind and a fair heart.

4. The “line” is determined by society and can be improved/changed (beginning notion of the line as constructed)

- are sometimes wrongly punished for their creativity, and rarely helped if they are having problems.
- are usually punished individually even though in many cases, it was the underlying system or expectations that were out of line
- are very brave or very foolish, depending on your point of view (and depending on what you mean by “step out of line”)
- may need the reasons “why” considered very carefully they may have a point which might alter the line.
- Again, it relates to my view on rules and systems they are man-made, to be changed, improved, and transformed by men/women
- may need to be brought into line or the line requires adjustment to reflect current conditions

5. speculation and self reflection (introspective reaction with self-critical elements)

- it makes us more aware of the lines that are being stepped out of and sometimes that's quite a gift
- I often find myself intrigued and delighted and wonder what trouble, change, or reaction will occur as a result.
- provide an invitation and an opportunity to question my own understanding of "line" and work" as used here - I have often felt compelled to step out of line.
- can really get me exercised till I realize that they are just doing what they know how to do in a system that may not allow for individual self-expression – when I see that I calm right down.
- at first blush, can get me into a self-righteous mode. Then I think about their point of view and situation and may actually commiserate.

6. may speak the truth for all of us who don't dare

- frequently are voicing what many others feel but haven't the personal integrity to express.

7. Balance of rights and responsibilities of all :

- are often those who succeed, some rightly so, some because they know the "politics" and some because that's one way the company manages its perceived problems [sic]
- should be respected and understood but this should be done with due regard for the rights and needs of others
- are sometimes torn between doing what they feel to be right and necessary and conforming for the sake of peace and performance

8. Are being authentic and self-expressive

- may be trying to give expression to their true selves instead of doing what the company sees as their ideal employee.
- should be allowed to "do their own thing" within the widest constraints a good organization can permit
- maybe displaying genuine individuality, but on the other hand, they may be taking us all for a ride.

Unassigned Compounds:

- should be disciplined and made aware of the effect they have on all of us on staff, that said, I realize how easy it is to get into a punitive mode myself to eliminate tension
- usually do so for reason, conscious or unconscious – so searching for that provides the clues to moving them forward and the group
- Could indicate problems with the place of work or the organization, or they could have personal problems, but generally they should not be allowed to adversely affect other employees.
- may be in a hurry, may need to say something, may have a problem at home but whatever else, they are certainly a source of knowledge / information / learning to the organization.
- may well be struggling in many facets of their life, could have the potential for creative contributions and should be listened to. We may learn much about [back of page] the things which don't normally get talked about by understanding them.
- are often true innovators, the visionary leaders. They need to have their ideas and energy constructively managed.

- are OK. I try to understand their motivations and be responsive to their needs hopefully, in the short or long run my actions will encourage them to give more willingly.
- May be marching to a different drummer and it is important to find out what is going on with them before making any kind of judgments

Unassigned Non-Compounds:

- sometimes brave, sometimes foolish, often right, but always interesting.
- probably have something interesting and useful to say that we are afraid to hear.
- May be justified in doing so but will find less resistance if nonviolent methods are used.

Stage $\frac{5}{6}$ / Magician (Construct-aware)

Responses at this level take a very wide view of the situation and fully recognize the existence of various perspectives. Also, the Magician is beginning to recognize the constructed nature of reality – this view is also reflected in the responses to this prompt. Responses at this level do not take the “line” for granted. In fact, the Magician recognizes that the line is just a construct of society (a figment of our collective imagination, if you will). As a construct, the line is not important in and of itself. Instead, it is our response to the line that is the focus of the Magician. Answers at this level recognize that the employee has several possible complex responses to the line. They also recognize that the solution to the situation needs to account for the views of all people involved and also account for the fact that the line is just a construct. The solutions suggested here are holistic and far-reaching.

Magicians not only recognize the “line” as a construct, but they are also beginning to see the constructed nature of the ego itself. As a result, we see many complex, self-reflective answers at this level.

1. complex matrix

- may have a problem or may be in a system that is dysfunctional, or may simply be in a role that is a poor fit for them, or have a boss with “a problem.”
- might not be aware of their tasks/responsibilities, might not be motivated, might have other priorities, might be rebels ... etc.. (guess that, because I am a French speaker, I don't understand this one as well as the others.)
- may well be leading, living their values, being creative or possibly needing the standard [?] held + help to learn something about themselves.
- doing it for lots of different reasons, doing the best they can, to be noticed, being immature, etc...
- may have something really important to teach everyone else, or they may simply be bloody-minded (gits?) who have never learned to cooperate or live creatively alongside other people and they may be neither of these things!
- are often those who care more for the integrity, content, purpose and value of the work itself, than for political nicety and self-promotion. They are vital to a healthy organisation which seeks continuous improvement by recognising and learning from mistakes.
- should be encouraged and rewarded for their courage, providing that their motives for doing so were consistent with our core values, mission and the customers wishes.
- should be dealt with in a manner which analyzes the reasons for their behavior, demonstrates to them, implicitly or explicitly, why their behavior was deemed inappropriate (if it was, and, if necessary, offers

alternative, more appropriate ways to behave.

- do so in one of several ways:; They sometimes create positive energy by constructive change that moves the organization forward. They can also create negative energy by destructive behavior that saps organizational strength. It takes the wisdom of many to tell the difference between the two.
- are often bringing something to the attention of other people (or the “convention”) that is important to know; i.e. if someone defies the accepted chain of command maybe both the chain of command + that person’s role need to be examined.
- may be signalling a real problem with the structure of their jobs or even the organization as a whole; or they may simply be a disciplinary problem.
- will perturb that human system, potentially opening an opportunity to learn something about the values most dominant in it – if the perturbers are sufficiently aware and interested and thrill seeking to make the inquiry.
- are reacting to a feeling of oppression or marginalization which may or may not meet the appropriate validity claims, although the situation warrants investigation nonetheless to discern what may or may not need to be done, and by or to whom.

2. habits of heart

- puzzle me. They may be the only ones willing to tell the truth, or they may be feeling squashed by the organization with their creativity or individual talents curtailed. Or they may be incapable of collaborative activity, or etc. I’d need more data.
- can usually be helped back into line very quickly if one finds the right “buttons,” but my “lines” are very “wide” as pointless constraints stifle [sic] development.
- a kaleidoscope of reactions occur including anxiousness and expectancy, uncertainty and appreciation, dread and relief, hope and belief in the potential of what can unfold in the dialogue we create
- may be seeing something I don’t, and possibly acting in a responsible and purposeful way for reasons I should try to understand, or alternatively they may motivated by factors that would not command my (or even their own) respect
- people who step out of line at work – well, frankly I admire their courage to push at the boundaries, to question the way things are done, to at least try something different because in the trying is the opportunity for growth of self, others, the organization, the society
- feel some need to do this - some prompting from fear which could be something I need to understand and act on, or at least have compassion with - while also setting healthy boundaries around the behaviors that are not acceptable

3. Habits of mind

4. recognition of constructed nature of reality

- Sometimes are only that – out of line – and other times can help, by how and when they step, to redefine a more workable + appropriate line.
- may know the line exists and may want to move it; may know the line exists and have trouble working with it; may not know the line exists; may see a different line.
- can do it because they are mad or geniuses the mad ones do not see the line and eventually trip over it; the geniuses play with the line and will eventually redraw it.
- may be starting a new line, prefer dancing to staying in line, or hope to go to the bathroom.

- what line? oh yes, the illusion that has been created by calling it “stepping out of line.”
- present an opportunity to examine the line, their values in stepping out of line, commitments, possibility,
- ... are probably making a profound statement of reaction to how thin the 'line' is

Unassigned Compounds:

- take a risk, for better or worse: they stand to draw attention to themselves thereby either fulfilling their better interests or ensuring the annoyance of those who pay their salary. If they keep their job they can be made happier or after they get fired, they can still move on to a happier situation
-

Discussion and Analysis

Statistical Analysis

As part of the research and categorization process, a statistical analysis of the data was completed. Previous research found that the total protocol rating (TPR) for most Westerners fell within the conventional tier, as shown in the table below.

Tier	Stage	Percentage
Transcendent		
	Unitive	1%
Postconventional		
Systems Thinking		
Creative		
	Magician	
	Strategist	
	Pluralist	14%
Conventional		
Linear Thinking		
Preventative		
	Achiever	
	Expert	
	Diplomat	75%
Preconventional		
Reactive		
	Opportunist	
	Impulsive	10%

An analysis of total protocol ratings was not possible due to problems with the data set (described below). However, an analysis on the distribution of the item scores was conducted. The table below shows that for the stem “people who step out of line at work...”, the majority of the ratings fell within the conventional tier, as expected.

Tier	Stage	Percentage
Transcendent		
	Unitive	0.2%
Postconventional		
Systems Thinking		
Creative		
	Magician	
	Strategist	
	Pluralist	30.3%
Conventional		
Linear Thinking		
Preventative		
	Achiever	
	Expert	
	Diplomat	65.1%
Preconventional		
Reactive		
	Opportunist	
	Impulsive	4.5%

The most significant difference between previous findings and the current research is that over 30% of the responses in the current data set fell within the postconventional tier. In contrast, previous findings showed that only about 14% in that data set achieved a TPR within the postconventional tier.

Some may argue that comparing item scores to total protocol ratings is like comparing “apples and oranges,” as they are different metrics. However, such a comparison is useful for validation purposes. If an individual stem is a valid measure of the level of ego development, one would expect ratings for that particular stem to fall out in a similar pattern as that of TPRs. Although the discrepancy found is of little significance, a larger discrepancy might indicate a lack of validity or reliability of that individual stem or the fact that the sample size was too small for proper analysis. Further research on this topic is warranted.

The distribution of the item scores was also analyzed. The mean, median, and mode score for the stem was the Achiever stage, indicating a normal distribution and a relatively trustworthy data set.

The Emergence of Categories

In composing the scoring manual, an interesting trend was found in many of the categories. It seems that some categories emerge in simple terms at earlier stages and get more and more developed and complex in later stages. Below are some excerpts from the scoring manual that serve as an illustration of this emergence.

Level $\frac{2}{3}$ - Category 3

- should be punished
- Must be stopped
- should be walked on
- must be fired

Level 3 - Category 1

- should be reprimanded
- Must be disciplined
- should be discipline
- should be chastised

Level $\frac{3}{4}$ - Category 6

- should be corrected appropriately
- should be reprimanding [sic] and “punished” accordingly.
- Need to be disciplined appropriately
- should be reprimanded in a rational manner.

Level 4 - Category 6

- should be corrected in a respectful manner
- Should be first praised for their good qualities at work and their problem solve with them to bring them back in line.
- need to be taken aside to discuss what they have done in a positive and caring manner in order to get the message through about at the same time they do not feel bad about whatever they may have done.
- deserve to be recognized for their unconventional behaviour and developed to take risks responsibly.

In looking at the above progression, one can see that although all responses are in essence saying that the employee needs to receive some kind of punishment or correction, the point of view expands a bit more at each stage. At $\frac{2}{3}$, responses are somewhat harsh – almost visceral. The employee must be punished severely. At the Diplomat stage, the employee needs discipline, but there is an emergence of the idea that there should be a purpose in the punishment – to get the employee back into conformity with the group. At the Expert level, we see that respondents are realizing that there is a right way and a wrong way to go about punishing an employee. Therefore, care must be taken to ensure that the employee is punished appropriately. Finally, in the Achiever stage, we see the emergence of an expanded third-person perspective that is concerned about the

wellbeing of the employee, and therefore, recognizes the need to respect the feelings and rights of the employee. The above progression is an excellent example of how perspectives continually expand to include more and more people as individuals move through the stages.

Applications to the Field of Counseling

In the course of completing this research, it was found that ego development theory in general, and the sentence completion test in particular, are being used in various arenas. The arena of particular interest is counseling. Several articles have been written in relation to the use of ego development theory in counseling.

One approach looks at the formula that states behavior is a function of the person and the environment. It suggests that clinicians need to assess both the environment and the person. The framework chosen to assess the "person" is the ego development framework. Using these stages of development, it is suggested that the choice of therapeutic intervention should be chosen based on the client's level of ego development. For example, clients at the very earliest stages are more motivated by rewards and punishments and would therefore benefit from a more behavioral approach, while clients at the later stages would benefit from a more self-directed type of therapy focusing on self-development. The importance of assessing a client's level of ego development is stressed in order to tailor interventions so the client receives the maximum benefit from that intervention. It is also stressed that being at an earlier level of development does not necessarily indicate poor mental health. Therefore, one goal of therapy may be to help the person live successfully at the stage of ego development at which they now function.

There are several different theoretical orientations into which ego development theory could fit, but the counseling theory that makes the most use of ego development theory is the Integral model of the self (the self-system). The integral self-system is a comprehensive model of the self that embraces the relevant research and theoretical understandings of how our self-sense evolves and accounts for much of our experience of the world.

The metaphor of the ladder and climber is used to illustrate ego development. The ladder represents the various stages that one moves through as they develop, and the climber is the ego itself. As the ego moves from one stage to the next, its views and perspectives change, just as a climber on a ladder gains a different vantage point each time he moves up one rung. A complete treatment of the topic of Integral counseling is beyond the scope of this research; however, Integral theory is based on the premise of "meeting a client where they are" based on their level of ego development.

Limitations of the Study

Problems with the Data Set

As mentioned earlier, the data for this research was provided by other researchers. There was no access to the original protocols, which means there was a dependence on other researchers for accuracy in demographic data and responses. One significant piece of demographic data that was not provided was the native language of respondents. It is assumed that most respondents were native English speakers, but at least one of the responses indicated another language as seen in the following: "...might not be aware of their tasks/responsibilities, might not be motivated, might have other priorities, might be rebels ... etc.. (guess that, because I am a French speaker, I don't understand this one as well as the others.)" It is unknown how many other responders were not native English speakers, nor how the language barrier may have skewed ratings on this stem. Verbal fluency does play some role in the scoring process. Generally, answers to protocols get longer

and more complex at later levels. It is possible that non-native speakers of English could have been placed in an earlier stage because they lacked the skill to successfully communicate complex ideas in English.

A second limitation stemming from the lack of access to the original protocols is possible spelling and grammatical errors which could affect the ratings on this stem. Twelve responses to this stem were flagged as possible grammatical errors. Grammatical errors pose two separate problems. Firstly, it is unknown whether the grammatical errors were in the original or were errors in data entry. Secondly, although the grammatical/spelling errors often do not interfere with the interpretation of the responses, there are some cases where they clearly do. In the response, "...imitate me. They know what they are doing, and in cases are just trying it out," there is a temptation to say that the respondent meant "irritate me," but there is no evidence for such an assumption except intuitive sense. Due to the uncertainty, this response was left uncategorized. Similarly, the response, "should be reminded," if taken at face value, appears to be an incomplete thought (i.e., it poses the question, "reminded of what?"). However, this response could be taken as a typographical error. Perhaps the original answer was "should be reprimanded." Because there is no way to know for sure, this response was left uncategorized.

Another shortcoming in the data was the fact that the data pulled from a draft of the scoring manual had no identifying information. There were 34 responses in that data that were identical to responses in the data set provided in chart form. It is possible that these duplicates came from the same participant. However, it is equally possible that some of the duplicates came from other participants. This is particularly possible with common responses such as, "should be spoken to" or "should be asked why." Because of the uncertainty of the origin of duplicate responses, they were only counted once when tallying the total number of responses.

A final limitation in the data is a simple one. There is very little data for the extreme ends of the ego development scale. Out of the 628 responses, only three were rated as level 2 and only one was rated at level 6. This is an understandable limitation since those from the Western world tend to clump at the conventional tier; however, the lack of data made categorizing items in the preconventional, postconventional, and transcendent tiers more difficult.

Problems with the Ratings

As mentioned above, the data was provided, and the item ratings were also provided. An attempt was made to stay true to the ratings provided to maintain the integrity of the data, but there were times when there was strong disagreement with a rating. In these cases, after careful consideration and discussion, the rating was changed. In all, 20 of the 627 responses were reclassified. Below is a list of responses that were reassigned, showing the response, the original rating, and the new rating.

Response	Original Rating	Final Rating
should be disciplined	2.5	3
have misunderstood something	3	3.5
irritate me.	3	2.5
need to be listened to and understood.	3	3.5
often have non-work issues.	3	3.5
must go to the back of the line and start all over again!??!	3.5	3
are letting the team down.	4	3.5
Do so for a reason	4	3.5
make others' jobs more difficult	4	3.5
may have a good reason to do so.	4	3.5
May very well have a good reason.	4	3.5
May well have a good reason for their action.	4	3.5
must be stopped.	4	2.5
need to be counseled.	4	3.5
need to be told so and the matter discussed.	4	3.5
will usually have a really good reason for doing so.	4	3.5
Are perhaps being creative.	4.5	4
have an important story to tell.	4.5	4
should be made aware of the impact their actions have on the people around them.	4.5	4
No longer exist because it's just me and my husband, and we are peers so there's no line to step out of; if a client breaks an agreement with me I'll ask him why and find out if there's something wrong, or if I feel he is acting outside the spirit of what we are doing together I'll explore it privately with him and find out what's wrong; if it means we are no longer creating together in a way that supports our mutual well-being and neither of us or anyone who helps us can see a way to correct it I'll end the contract	5.5	4.5

A related rating issue stems from the 34 duplicate responses that were mentioned above. There were five instances where item scores for items in one data set did not match the item score in the same response in the primary data set. The table below shows those instances. The first column shows the item scores as given in

the primary data, the second column shows the scores as reported in the other data set, and the final column indicates the score chosen.

Response	Primary data item score	Other Data item score	Final item score
never do it again.	3	2.5	2.5
should receive a big wet kiss on the forehead – assuming that's not what they were looking for in the first place	3	3.5	3
can be acting out of their own issues, the issues at work, or other reasons	5	4.5	4.5
it is important for the organization to be able to accept a reasonable amount of diversity.	4	4.5	4.5
may be signaling a real problem with the structure of their jobs or even the organization as a whole; or they may simply be a disciplinary problem	5.5	5	5

As can be seen, in all cases except one, deference was given to the other data set. In the one instance where there was disagreement, rule five was applied and, by default, the response was rated at the Diplomat level.

The Categorization of Humorous Responses

Some limitations stem from the categorization process itself. Although an attempt was made to look only at the surface meaning inherent in the responses, there were times it was difficult to remain objective. This was particularly true when a response was found humorous. Humor is somewhat subjective and makes responses difficult to categorize. Questions asked when dealing with humorous responses include:

- What is the quality of the humor (i.e., is the humor “mean-spirited” or “lighthearted”)?
- Was the humor used as an illustrative tool or used simply to avoid responding to the stem?
- Did the respondent intend the response to be humorous?

The answers to these questions are also somewhat subjective; however, thinking about these aspects of humor helped in scoring humorous responses. Below is a list of select responses that were found humorous along with the rating of the responses and the category in which they were placed. A discussion of the thought process regarding these responses follows:

Response	Score	Category Name	Category #
are idiots	2.5		
are stupid	7		
Will have to wait longer for their lunch.	3	suffer immediate and concrete consequences	3
should receive a big wet kiss on the forehead assuming that's not what they were looking for in the first place.	3	Uncategorized	Rule 5
were obviously in the wrong queue.	3.5	Uncategorized	Rule 4
Are best characterized in a variety of comic strips	4	Uncategorized	Rule 4
may be starting a new line, prefer dancing to staying in line, or hope to go to the bathroom.	5.5	Recognition of the constructed nature of reality	4

In terms of quality, statements deemed “mean-spirited” tended to be placed in earlier stages while light-hearted responses were placed in later stages. For example, “are idiots” is a response that was found “mean-spirited,” while “were obviously in the wrong queue,” appears to be more “light-hearted” and is scored accordingly.

It is incredibly difficult and scientifically questionable to guess at the intentions of the respondents, but the question of why various respondents may have chosen to use humor was still considered. It seems that some humor was useful in illustrating a point while other humorous responses offered no useable opinion. Humor that was used illustratively was placed in later stages than humor that did not appear to be used illustratively. A response that used humor as an illustration is, “may be starting a new line, prefer dancing to staying in line, or hope to go to the bathroom.” It seems that the respondent was playing on the meanings of “line” to illustrate that the “line” is just a construct. Conversely, a response like, “should receive a big wet kiss on the forehead, assuming that's not what they were looking for in the first place,” did not seem to illustrate anything. As such, rule five of the scoring rules was applied and it was placed by default in the Diplomat stage.

The third question regarding the use of humor also forces a guess at the intentions of the respondent. Humor that appeared to be intentional was given a higher rating than humor that appeared unintentional. For example, “...will have to wait longer for their lunch,” is a response that was found humorous, but feels was not intentional. Therefore, the response was taken literally and placed in the Diplomat stage. Conversely, the response “are best characterized in a variety of comic strips,” appears to be more intentional and therefore was rated at the Achiever level.

Future Study

Further Statistical Analysis

In the course of the research, a preliminary statistical analysis on the themes apparent in the responses was begun in an attempt to discover trends in thought patterns across the ego levels. The four categories identified

(cause, solution, effect, and assessment) were taken and an attempt was made to place each response into one of the four categories. The process and its highly intuitive nature are described in detail elsewhere.

Due to the limitations of time and the fact that a great deal of intuition was required in spite of grammatical cues, a full statistically sound analysis could not be completed. The table below gives the preliminary findings. Note that the theme with the highest percentage of answers is bolded at each level.

Level	Cause	Solution	Effect	Assessment
Impulsive	33.3%	0.0%	0.0%	66.7%
Opportunist	20.0%	16.0%	24.0%	40.0%
Diplomat	0.0%	47.2%	25.0%	27.8%
Expert	16.7%	40.4%	22.4%	20.5%
Achiever	16.2%	48.6%	7.4%	27.8%
Pluralist	11.0%	31.2%	4.6%	53.2%
Autonomous	28.6%	26.5%	14.3%	30.6%
Magician	21.9%	15.6%	3.1%	59.4%
Unitive	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	100.0%
Total	15.9%	38.4%	12.6%	33.0%

It is interesting to note that “assessment” was the most common theme at the preconventional, postconventional, and transcendent tiers (i.e., Opportunist and above and Pluralist and below) while “solution” was the most common theme in the conventional tier (Diplomat, Expert, and Achiever). These trends seem to support the theory that those in the conventional tier are critical thinkers, analyzers, and “get it done” kind of people. It also supports the theory that those in the postconventional and transcendent tiers are more thoughtful and inward-looking and are less concerned with causes and outcomes. The fact that “assessment” was the most common category at the preconventional stages might be indicative of the fact that those at the preconventional levels are self-focused, which would suggest that they lack the ability to look beyond themselves and their own opinions.

The above analysis was found to be useful in understanding the worldviews of individuals at each ego level. It is hoped that similar analyses could be done for other aspects of the data such as perspective, degree of certainty, and beliefs about truth. Ego development theory postulates that as we move through the ego levels, our perspective broadens. At the Opportunist level we are self-focused, while at the Unitive level, our perspective has broadened to the point where we see the interconnectedness of all people and things. The following progression in the data has been hypothesized based on ego development theory (note the bold uppercase X’s in this chart and subsequent charts indicate primary occurrences and lower case x’s indicate secondary occurrences):

Level	Self (1st)	Other (2nd)	Group (3rd)	Systems (4th)	Universal (5th)
Impulsive	X				
Opportunist	X				
Diplomat	x	X			
Expert		x	X		
Achiever		x	X		
Pluralist		x	X		
Autonomous		x	X		
Magician				X	
Ironist				x	X

Trends in degree of certainty (i.e., how sure is the responder that their answer is the “correct” answer) and beliefs about truth (i.e., can we know truth absolutely or not and is it even a relevant question) were also hypothesized. As with the above hypothesis, these ideas were based on what is known about the process of ego development. Below are the expected trends for “degree of certainty” and “beliefs about truth.”

Level	100%	75%	50%	25%	irrelevant
Impulsive	X				
Opportunist	X				
Diplomat	X				
Expert		x	X		
Achiever		X	x		
Pluralist			X		
Autonomous			X	x	
Magician			X	x	
Ironist				X	

Level	black & white	black & white with some grey	all grey	grey with some black & white	non-dual
Impulsive					
Opportunist	X				
Diplomat	X	x			
Expert	x	X			
Achiever	X	x			
Pluralist		X			
Autonomous	x				
Magician		X	X		
Ironist		x	X		

It is hoped that others in the field who are interested in ego development theory and the sentence completion test would test the above hypotheses using, not just the data from the stem that is the focus of this research, but other data from other stems as well. Such a process would be useful for validating the stems and the theory of ego development.

Extensive Field Testing and Revisions

Now that the manual has been constructed, to complete the process it will be necessary to validate the manual. A validation process was planned, but time constraints prevented completion of this process. It is suggested that the manual be distributed to as many raters as possible for field testing. Along with the manual, they could be given a brief survey to complete which will determine their satisfaction with the newly created item manual. The survey could consist of five to ten questions using a Likert scale. Once surveys and comments have been received, further revisions could be made to the manual.

Throughout the validation process, new data could be added to the data already collected to make the data set stronger. It would be particularly helpful to gather new data for the extreme ends of the ego level scale (i.e., levels two and six).

Causes for Movement from One Ego Level to the Next

During the course of researching the subject of ego development, one question that came up was, "what causes movement from one level to the next?" Some sources looked at that question. Some suggest that a change in career or religion could play a part in ego development. In a related study, it is stated that although several factors could contribute to ego development in adults, only two receive clear endorsement: life experiences and cognitive development. They go on to say that even while considering these two factors, ego development is still not fully explainable. One study of twins separated at birth was undertaken to determine whether there was a genetic component to ego development and found that heredity may in fact play a role in ego development.

The causes for movement from one ego level to another, especially in adulthood, is a subject that may never be exhausted. Researchers have barely begun to unravel that mystery and it is hoped that more study will be done

on this topic in the future.

Closing Remarks

Researching and writing this material was a deeply personal experience. Interest in this subject was sparked when given the opportunity to take the sentence completion test. Taking the test and then going over the results with one of the raters gave tremendous insight into oneself and views of the world. It explained some nagging questions and issues that had been plaguing.

After that experience, further looking into ego development theory began. There was the added advantage of studying under a professional who has worked closely with the framework developers and is very familiar with ego development theory and the Integral model of counseling. Students were always encouraged to try and “ballpark” the ego level of the clients seen in order to determine where they are coming from. By knowing where clients are coming from, one is free to “meet them where they are.” When these concepts were first learned, it was difficult to conceptualize exactly how to “ballpark” a client’s level of ego development and how it would make one a more effective counselor. However, throughout the process of writing this material, skills and insights into ego development have been gained that have allowed for effectively applying ego-development theory to work as a counselor. It is believed it has made one not only a better counselor, but a more fully developed person.

It is hoped that some of those who read this will be inspired to study ego development theory further. Study of ego development theory could encourage professional and personal growth. Additionally, as more people study and write about ego development theory, the base of knowledge on the topic will expand and further validate the theory and the measurement thereof.